
ANIME ANYWAY
TRANSLATIONS
CLASSROOM OF THE ELITE
4
YEAR 3
衣笠彰梧
KINUGASA SHOUGO
TOMOSESHUNSAKU
トモセシュンサク


Classroom of the Elite: Year 3
Shōgo Kinugasa
Tomoseshunsaku
4


"That definitely brings up a lot of things I want to dig into, but can I ask a fundamental question first?"
"What is it?"
"Nanase-chan, at the end of the day... Are you Ayanokōji-senpai's ally? Or are you his enemy?"


Kushida Kikyō
Ibuki Mio


Shiina Hiyori


A1
A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O
1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15
N
W
E
S
UNINHABITED
ISLAND MAP



A Note to Readers

From the Translation Team

❖

We're passionate fans just like you, and we work on these projects in our free time out of love for the story and characters. However, we strongly encourage you to purchase the official releases if and when they become available in your region to support the author and the publisher.

Important Notes: This is Version **v0** release. Please make sure you have the latest version from our website for the best reading experience. While our releases undergo thorough checks, we occasionally update them to correct rare errors if any or make small improvements. You can always find the latest version at: animeanyway.com

Found any typos or formatting issues? Report them on our website here.

Feel free to share and upload this translation as long as you credits us. We'd also appreciate it if you include our website link with the translation. Thank you again and we hope you enjoy this volume!

Disclaimer: This is a fan translation for fans, by fans.

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Editor's Foreword

This volume has been carefully translated with the intention of striking a balance between faithfulness to the Japanese text and readability in English. Throughout the process, specialized edits were employed to transition from literal translation into prose that feels like a novel, while preserving the context, tone, and detail of the original.

Japanese prose often conveys meaning through compression and implication. Actions may be presented as short, sequential clauses; spatial relationships may be assumed rather than stated; and emotional nuance is frequently embedded in neutral declarative phrasing. When translated directly into English, these qualities can result in prose that feels flat, mechanically sequential, or difficult to visualize.

The edits in this volume aim to bridge that gap, not by embellishing, but by restructuring and clarifying what the original already implies.

Take for example the line:
Raw (Y3V2): **金田はどこか決意を持った態度を残し、この場を後にした。**
Literal Translation: "Kaneda left the room, his demeanor carrying a trace of some quiet resolve."
Final Translation: "With a faint but unmistakable air of resolve, his footsteps faded into the hush of the library as he turned and left."

Here, the literal version captures the essence, but it feels plain. In the final phrasing, imagery and rhythm are expanded to highlight the quiet atmosphere and Kaneda's resolve without adding meaning that isn't there. This way, the line reads more naturally in English prose, while still carrying the weight of the original.

Another instance is:
Raw (Y3V2): **高育の図書室はとても広いため、本を探すのと同じくらい人を探すのも難しい。**

Literal Translation: “The Kōiku library is so spacious that finding a person here is just as difficult as finding a book.”
Final Translation: “The school’s library was vast, its towering shelves and wide aisles making it just as tricky to find a person as it was to locate a specific book.”

The literal translation is clear, but a little blunt. By expanding with light descriptive elements like “towering shelves,” and “wide aisles” the English version paints the same idea in a way that flows like a scene in a novel, enhancing the atmosphere while keeping true to the intent of the Japanese.

Raw (Y3V4): **午前11時。客船の上層階にある完全プライベートプール。**
Literal Translation: It was 11 a.m. A completely private pool located on the upper deck of the passenger ship.
Final Translation: It was eleven in the morning. High above the decks of the passenger ship, where the sea breeze softened against glass walls and the sunlight spilled cleanly across the water, lay a completely secluded private pool.

The raw Japanese simply states the time and location. The edited version adds atmosphere and visual detail, turning a bare scene-setting line into a more immersive opening. While not literal, it preserves the intent of introducing a secluded setting and reads more naturally in English prose.

Other supporting edits were employed for environmental anchoring, internal monologue smoothening, and dialogue flow & turn-taking. Across the volume, these edits serve a single purpose: to recreate the intended experience of the original text for an English reader. No motivations, scenes, or outcomes were invented in a way that changes the plot details. Where Japanese relied on implication, English was given structure; where motion was compressed, rhythm was restored; and where silence carried meaning, restraint was preserved. It is our

hope that this approach maintains the tension, clarity, and atmosphere of the original while allowing the prose to move naturally in English.

And with that— Welcome to the fourth installment of the Year 3 Arc of Classroom of the Elite (Yōkoso Jitsuryoku Shijō Shugi no Kyōshitsu e). We hope you enjoy reading this volume as much as we enjoyed bringing it to you.

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Prologue: Ibuki Mio's Monologue

❖

I always had a feeling that someday it would come to this, that sooner or later, I wouldn't be able to keep up with this school's system.

I sucked at studying.

I wasn't exactly good at working with other people either.

The only thing I could say I was good at... was fighting.

That's why somewhere deep down, I had already sensed it, that when the time came, I'd be the one sacrificed.

Ryūen, obviously, and even Shiina and Katsuragi, were indispensable to the class.

But unlike them, I'd always been standing on the edge of the cliff.

That was why I thought I'd be fine even if I got expelled.

That was what I'd believed all this time— that I could walk away without a single regret.

At least, that was what I thought...

But now, I realized there was still one thing left undone.

If I was getting expelled anyway, then before I disappeared, I wanted to land at least one solid punch on Ayanokōji, no matter what.

Staring at his infuriating back, I steeled my resolve.

A surprise attack?

Feints before the real hit?

Yeah, I already knew none of that crap would work on this guy.

So I'd do it properly.

Straight on. Fair and square.

I surged forward and closed the distance between us.

Ayanokōji turned around. That same unreadable expression on his face.

I grabbed him by the collar and drew back my fist.

"I'll accept the expulsion," I spat. "So let me hit you once before I go."

It was a completely absurd demand.

A total Hail Mary.

I'd fully expected him to refuse, tell me he had no reason to indulge me, and the second he did, I was ready to swing anyway.

But the response I got was the last thing I expected.

"I'm the one who decided to have you expelled, after all," Ayanokōji said evenly. "I suppose I can grant you at least that much."

Hearing that, the corner of my mouth curled upward ever so slightly.

"You've got some nerve," I muttered. "Fine, then. Don't expect me to hold back."

I won't hold back.

If he thought he could underestimate a woman's strength, he was dead wrong.

I was going to knock out one or two of his teeth for sure.

Then, putting every last ounce of strength into it, I unleashed the most dead-serious, super-ultra straight punch of my entire life.

Chapter 1: Token Collection Special Exam

❖

Mashima-sensei's voice rang across the shoreline with quiet finality.

"Effective immediately, we will now commence the Uninhabited Island Special Exam."

The students, already exhausted from the survival game, were still struggling to process what they had just heard. Yet Mashima-sensei showed no intention of waiting for anyone to catch up. As though brushing aside the confusion spreading through the crowd, he continued his explanation without hesitation.

Just when everyone thought the island exam was finally over, another special exam was suddenly set into motion.

So the Survival Game conducted earlier was merely the prelude, and this was the second phase?

Of course, there was always the possibility that this next phase was only the midpoint of an even larger ordeal waiting beyond it. But considering the condition some students were already in, pushing them through three consecutive stages would be unrealistic.

Either way, the situation was harsh.

Meanwhile, the sun was already beginning to sink toward the horizon. It was close to five in the evening.

The third-years had weathered countless special exams by now and developed a tolerance for the school's unpredictability. Even so, they couldn't hide their confusion. This was different from anything they'd faced before.

“Damn, they’re seriously going to start another special exam right now?” Hashimoto muttered beside me with a strained half-laugh. “Yamamura and Shiraishi are already hanging by a thread.”

His tone carried a trace of sympathy, but the school showed no sign of reconsidering.

“The special exam commencing now,” Mashima-sensei continued, “will consist of ten groups, each containing sixteen students. Every group will be assigned one adult supervisor who will provide instructions as necessary. You are expected to obey your supervisor at all times. As you are already aware, due to the number of students expelled thus far, some groups will inevitably begin with fewer members than others. However, adjustments have been made to ensure that disparities in group size will not create any advantages or disadvantages.”

Sixteen students per group.

If that was the base structure, then this was unlikely to be a straightforward class-versus-class exam.

As though confirming that very suspicion, Mashima-sensei’s next words peeled back another layer of the situation.

“The bottled drinks you were instructed to take upon disembarking may have struck some of you as unusual. Those bottles are the key to determining your groups.”

At once, students began glancing down at the plastic bottles in their hands.

“There are five different label colors,” he explained. “Red, blue, green, yellow, and purple. Enough had been prepared for each class, with adjustments and guidance carried out to ensure everyone received one.”

I lowered my gaze to the mineral water bottle I’d been carrying since leaving the ship, which bore a blue label.

Hashimoto, standing beside me, held purple.

At the very least, it confirmed one thing: the two of us wouldn't end up in the same group.

However, there were only five colors. That alone wasn't enough to divide everyone into ten separate groups.

Which meant there had to be another layer hidden somewhere in the selection process.

Removing the label would only create litter. On an island like this, a stray gust of wind could easily carry it straight into the ocean. The school wouldn't use something so careless.

If they wanted a cleaner, simpler way to add another randomizer, there was an obvious answer.

The cap.

Without a word, I twisted the bottle open, removed the cap, and checked the underside.

A second later, Hashimoto noticed what I was doing and quietly checked his own as well.

"There's nothing on my cap," I said quietly. "What about yours?"

"Mine's marked," Hashimoto replied immediately. "One black line."

Right on cue, Mashima-sensei resumed speaking over the microphone.

"I would like everyone to remove the caps from your bottles and examine the underside carefully."

Around us, the sound of twisting plastic caps spread through the crowd in uneven bursts.

"There are two types of caps prepared for this exam," he continued. "Plain caps with no markings, and caps marked with a single black line. Students carrying red labels with unmarked caps will belong to Group 1, and students carrying red labels with marked caps will belong to Group 2. That will determine your assigned groups."

He proceeded through the remaining combinations without pause.

Blue labels corresponded to Groups 3 and 4. Green to 5 and 6. Yellow to 7 and 8. And purple to 9 and 10.

It was also explained that Group 10 alone would begin with fewer than sixteen members.

Hashimoto glanced at his purple label again.

"So I got stuck in the smaller Group 10, huh? And you're Group 3…" He slowly scanned the students surrounding us. "Still, there's no way in hell to tell who ended up where from here."

Even if someone managed to identify the color of another student's bottle label from a distance, spotting the tiny black line hidden beneath a bottle cap was another matter entirely. Until everyone physically gathered with their assigned groups, nobody could know for certain who their teammates would be.

Which was probably intentional.

If group assignments had been too easy to identify, students might've attempted to exchange bottles beforehand. The school had clearly accounted for that possibility from the start.

Still, the identities of our future teammates were something we would inevitably learn soon enough. Speculating now was pointless. More important was understanding the rules of the exam itself.

In fact, Mashima-sensei and the others were already proceeding to the next stage without wasting time.

"Now then, I will explain the details of this special exam. To assist your understanding, documents summarizing the rules and structure will now be distributed. Read through them carefully."

After a brief pause, teachers moved through the students, handing out the materials one by one.

The multi-page document was bundled together with detailed maps of the island. Small card rings had been fastened through the corners, likely to prevent them from being blown away by the wind.

As the documents reached my hands, Mashima-sensei resumed speaking.

"You will divide into your assigned groups and undertake various challenges throughout the island. Based on your results, you will earn rewards known as 'tokens.' Collecting these tokens will form the core objective of the exam. In addition, one student from each class has already been selected by their homeroom teacher to serve as class leader. Although the results of the Survival Game Special Exam have caused provisional changes in class rankings, those standings will remain unofficial until the end of the month. Therefore, for the purposes of this exam, the current class designations will remain unchanged."

He paused briefly before reading out the names.

"For Class A: Horikita Suzune. For Class B: Ryūen Kakeru. For Class C: Ayanokōji Kiyotaka. And for Class D: Ichinose Honami. These students will serve as the leaders for their respective classes."

As his voice echoed across the shore, I lowered my gaze to the documents in my hands.

TOKEN COLLECTION SPECIAL EXAM

Overview

❖

During the course of the four-day, three-night examination, students are required to travel across the island while undertaking various challenges, collect tokens, and ultimately reach the designated goal.

Token multipliers and Private Point rewards will be distributed according to the order in which groups reach the goal.

Note: A group's finishing rank is determined the moment a majority of its members successfully reach the goal

The groups containing each class leader will determine their class's outcome based on the total number of tokens accumulated.

Group Ranking — Tokens & Rewards

GROUP RANK	TOKEN MULTIPLIER	PRIVATE POINT REWARD
1st Place	100%	100,000 Points
2nd Place	95%	80,000 Points
3rd Place	90%	50,000 Points
4th Place	85%	30,000 Points
5th Place	80%	20,000 Points
6th Place or Lower	75%	10,000 Points
Disqualified Group	70%	No additional reward

Token Holding — Class Point Results

TOKEN HOLDING RANK	RESULT
1st Place	Class Points +100
2nd Place	Class Points +50
3rd Place	Class Points +20
4th–9th Place	No Change
Last Place	Class Points -50

What mattered most was not simply collecting tokens, but balancing two objectives simultaneously: gathering as many as possible while also reaching the goal quickly enough to preserve a high multiplier.

Neither alone would be enough.

Mashima-sensei broke the brief silence, resuming his explanation.

"As for the private point rewards granted upon reaching the goal, if a group finishes in first place, every student within that group will individually receive 100,000 private points. The second reward, the token multiplier, is tied both to your group's ranking by token possession and to the individual rewards I will explain shortly. If a group finishes in third place, the total number of tokens used in calculations will be reduced to 90%. Groups ranked 6th or lower will receive only 75%." He paused briefly before adding, "Any fractional values produced after the multiplier is applied will be rounded upward."

In other words, even if a group accumulated 1,000 tokens through relentless effort over four exhausting days, a poor finishing rank would steadily erode the value of everything they had gathered.

The exact conditions for what constituted "reaching the goal" remained unclear for now, but one thing was already obvious. Finishing near the top was non-negotiable.

"Up to this point, the rules may have sounded favorable to the students, however, this special exam also contains several major penalties. And... some of them are unavoidable."

I lowered my eyes to the next page of the booklet. The penalties he referred to had already been printed there in orderly text.

PENALTY LIST

❂ Lowest Token Holder Expulsion

At the conclusion of the exam, the single student across the entire year with the **fewest tokens** will be **expelled**.

- If multiple students are tied, the one with the **lowest Overall Ability Assessment (OAA) score as of June 1st** is selected.
- If still tied, earlier monthly OAA records are referenced in order.

❂ Reaching Zero Tokens

If a student's token count ever reaches **zero** during the exam, that student is **expelled immediately**.

- If the student holds a **Protection Point**, they instead withdraw from the exam and wait aboard the ship.
- This penalty applies only to the *first* student whose token count reaches zero.

❂ Failure to Reach the Goal

Each student who fails to reach the goal by the end of the exam triggers two consequences:

- Their class loses **5 Class Points**.
- Their token multiplier is reduced to **70%**, regardless of the group's finishing rank.

❂ Delayed Goal Completion Penalty

Once a majority of a group has reached the goal and its ranking is finalized, every student who still has not arrived keeps costing their class **1 Class Point every 30 minutes** until they reach the goal.

❂ Leaving the Supervisor's Area

For every hour a student remains outside the area where their assigned supervisor is stationed, that student loses **1 token**.

- Returning to the designated area **resets the timer**.

The penalties laid out before us were severe.

Unlike ordinary punishments for breaking rules, these weren't pitfalls students could simply avoid through caution or obedience. Some could potentially be worked around, but others were built into the structure of the exam itself, unavoidable by design.

Compared to the Survival Game Special Exam, this was a clear step deeper into dangerous territory.

"So this is finally the real deal, huh?" Hashimoto muttered beside me under his breath.

"It seems so," I replied quietly.

Considering that Horikita had most likely shouldered the penalty from the Survival Game Exam, the only student confirmed to still possess a Protection Point was Kōenji. Other classes might still have some in reserve, but intentionally reducing your own tokens to zero just to burn that single expulsion slot would only benefit rival classes more than your allies. No one would willingly make that sacrifice.

With the safety net already stripped away following their recent defeat, Class A's position in particular had become especially unforgiving.

Mashima-sensei gave the students a moment to absorb the weight of the penalties before resuming his explanation.

"Next, I will explain the details regarding tokens themselves… as well as the individual rewards."

❂ Token Classifications (Front-side and Back-side)

• Tokens are divided into two distinct classifications: **Front-side** and **Back-side**.

• Tokens earned through verified individual achievements are classified as **Front-side**. Tokens acquired through all other methods are classified as **Back-side**.

• Victory rewards based on token possession will account for the **aggregate total**, regardless of whether they are Front-side or Back-side.

• Individual rewards will strictly account for **Front-side tokens only**.

❂ Token Transfer Protocols

• Tokens are fully transferable between students. To initiate a transfer, a specific interface operation must be performed, followed by **physical contact** between both parties' smartwatches.

• There are **no restrictions** on the quantity of tokens transferred, the frequency of transfers, or the intended recipient.

• Any token utilized in a transfer will **permanently** convert into a **Back-side** token and cannot be reverted back to Front-side.

• A student's token count becomes **finalized the exact moment they reach the goal**. Beyond this point, any further transfers involving that student are **prohibited**.

❂ Token Expenditure

• Expending **1 Token** permits **5 minutes of communication** with any student of your choice.

• Expending **1 Token** permits a **location check** to view the current coordinates of any student of your choice.

The ability to freely transfer tokens at any time seemed likely to play a major role in avoiding certain penalties.

A student close to reaching zero could be rescued by allies before expulsion was triggered. Likewise, someone at risk of falling to the bottom of the rankings could potentially be saved by pooling resources.

At the same time, there was an obvious tradeoff.

The moment a token was transferred, it lost its front-side status and became a back-side token permanently, making it ineligible for pursuing individual rewards.

❂ Individual Rewards

• **Special Reward:** The class of the student who accumulates the highest number of **Front-side tokens** will be awarded **100 Class Points**. Additionally, that student will receive **500,000 Private Points**. *(In the event of a tie for the top position, the rewards will be divided equally among the qualifying students.)*

• **General Reward (All Students):** Every student will receive **1,000 Private Points** multiplied by their total number of **Front-side tokens** in possession.

The section regarding the Special Reward was impossible to ignore.

100 Class Points.

That alone was significant enough to rival the rewards of an entire special exam victory. But there was an important catch. If multiple students tied for the highest number of front-side tokens, the reward would simply be divided amongst them.

In any case, gathering even a single additional token as an individual carried clear advantages for every student involved.

By now, the entire structure of the exam had finally come into view, and a measured tension began settling over the crowd.

If a group cooperated efficiently, gathered large numbers of tokens, and secured a top finish, then naturally every member of that group stood to gain a huge amount of Private Points. That was the straightforward benefit.

But the problem was what happened inside the group itself.

If a student from a rival class happened to accumulate an overwhelming number of front-side tokens while working alongside you, they could seize the Special Award for their class instead. And that would effectively create a massive class point gap in favor of a rival class.

After that, the explanation shifted toward the new functions added to the smartwatches.

“By entering the six-digit passcode assigned to your device,” Mashima-sensei explained, “you may confirm your current token count as well as transfer tokens to others. We will now have everyone operate the system as part of the explanation.”

He paused briefly.

“However, there is one important precaution. Every student has been provided with at least two tokens at the start of the exam, but the number distributed differs from student to student. Your starting token count is therefore valuable information. I strongly recommend you avoid revealing it to others.”

So the starting conditions weren’t equal after all.

The smartwatch displays themselves were designed with privacy in mind. Unless someone deliberately stood directly behind another person, or pressed in unnaturally close from the side, stealing a glance at the screen was nearly impossible.

Even so, the students took no chances. Shielding the screens with their bodies, they cautiously entered passcodes to confirm the initial token counts.

I too entered my passcode and the screen lit up.

11 Tokens: Front-Side

At first glance, it seemed relatively high.

But there was no baseline yet beyond "two or more." Without additional comparisons, there was no reliable way to judge where the number actually stood.

In addition, send and receive buttons for transfers were displayed side-by-side. It seemed token transfers required both parties to activate the appropriate commands before physically touching their smartwatches together.

Without speaking, I extended my arm slightly toward Hashimoto, showing him my screen.

His eyes widened slightly in surprise as he compared it to his own before turning his watch toward me in return.

9 Tokens

Close to mine, but slightly lower.

It was hard to believe the distribution was based directly on OAA scores or academic performance. More likely, they were related to the previous exam, not necessarily contribution itself, but survival duration.

Yamamura and Shiraishi had endured until the very end of the Survival Game, exhausting themselves more thoroughly than anyone else.

Meanwhile, students eliminated early had probably recovered completely by now, entering this exam in a far better condition.

Seen that way, the uneven token distribution made sense. A form of insurance. A balancing measure intended to offset the physical disparity between students.

Still, it wasn't something to celebrate unconditionally.

Even if others could eventually make educated guesses regarding who had started with a larger number of tokens, concealing that information whenever possible was still the smarter choice.

"And finally," Mashima-sensei continued, "although everyone is currently present, some students may unexpectedly fall ill during the course of the exam. In such cases, the procedures involved are extremely delicate. Be certain to carefully review the relevant section in your documents."

At those words, I lowered my gaze toward the final page.

❂ Conditions That Make Continuing the Exam Impossible

- If a student suffers a sudden illness or serious injury severe enough to prevent them from continuing, they may, in principle, report the situation verbally to a supervisor and request a judgment on whether they are allowed to proceed.
- If no supervisor is nearby and direct contact is impossible, the student may instead use the emergency request function on their smartwatch.
- However, the moment a student is officially declared retired from the exam, their token count becomes finalized.
- As a relief measure, any student may transfer tokens to a retired participant regardless of distance.
- In addition, a group containing a retired student may still receive an official ranking, but only if every remaining member of that group successfully reaches the goal.
- Feigning illness, or intentionally concealing a serious injury or medical condition in order to continue participating, is strictly prohibited.
- If a student is uncertain whether their condition qualifies, they are instructed to consult the school for judgment.
- If a violation is discovered, an expulsion penalty will be imposed.

In an island exam like this, health issues and injuries were practically inevitable.

Because the exam was fundamentally built around maintaining group numbers, the school likely had zero tolerance for students concealing their true condition.

If being grouped together with students from other classes puts you at a disadvantage, then naturally people would want to hide any signs of poor health.

This rule existed specifically to prevent that from happening.

And since faking illness would not work either, it effectively prevented someone like Kōenji from casually abandoning the exam whenever he pleased.

“Man, these rules are brutal,” Hashimoto muttered. “So even if you get sick and retire, they still won’t show any mercy, huh?”

The relief measures certainly existed. But if a student lacking either ability or social value retired early, there was a very real possibility their class would simply abandon them.

On the other hand, someone like Ichinose would almost certainly be saved without hesitation. Her classmates would willingly gather tokens from across the island just to keep her safe.

In any case, token possession itself remained hidden behind layers of secrecy. Whether they were front-side or back-side, no third party had any reliable way to verify the total unless the owner chose to reveal it. The entire system was effectively a black box.

Just tracking the token counts within the group won't be straightforward, let alone knowing the token counts outside the group.

Additionally, it seems students could spend tokens to contact one another, but every use would naturally reduce the maximum number of tokens they could finish the exam with. Unless it was an emergency, unnecessary communication had to be avoided.

After that, the explanation shifted to supplies: food, tents, and other necessities.

Students would each be given a designated backpack and permitted to pack whatever items they wanted from the prepared stock.

However, no explanation was given regarding what would happen if supplies ran short during the three nights on the island. Because of that, it was probably wiser to carry extra provisions even if it meant adding more weight.

That naturally made girls with less muscle mass more likely to be at a disadvantage.

Still, it was hard to believe the school hadn’t already considered that issue. There was a good chance some kind of support measure existed behind the scenes.

"Now then, after a 10-minute break, you will assemble according to your assigned groups. That concludes the explanation."

With that, the briefing finally came to an end.

I turned toward Hashimoto.

"I need you to relay a message to the rest of the class," I said.

Hashimoto looked over at me.

"Sure thing, just say the word," he replied.

"The first thing I want you to tell them is this: whether they share their token counts with classmates is their own decision. But right now, they should think very carefully before doing it."

"...Careful about sharing?" Hashimoto tilted his head slightly. "I mean, personally I'm all for keeping secrets, but wouldn't sharing help avoid risks?"

"It would, if you could be absolutely certain every single person was prepared to go down together for the sake of the class."

I paused.

"But classmates are still, ultimately, other people. If it comes down to choosing between themselves and someone else, the answer becomes obvious."

Especially in my class, more than half the students were highly capable and deeply confident in their own abilities.

And because they carried such a strong determination to graduate from Class A, careless information sharing carried risks of its own.

The students assigned to each mixed group were now being forced to make a difficult choice:

Would they constantly share information about their token counts with their classmates... or keep everything hidden?

If a class managed token information thoroughly, then students running low could be supported collectively, reducing the risk of expulsions across the board. There was a clear advantage to that approach.

Of course, doing so would make it nearly impossible for any individual to monopolize tokens and chase the massive personal rewards tied to them.

Still, if the alternative was sacrificing classmates, plenty of students would consider that a fair trade.

The problem was that even perfect cooperation didn't guarantee safety.

Suppose three or four students worked together and distributed tokens evenly among themselves. If that balance still resulted in someone ending up at the bottom overall, then expulsion remained unavoidable.

In the end, the deciding factor would become OAA rankings.

And if the group tried compensating for that by funneling extra tokens toward the student with the lowest OAA, then naturally the student with the second-lowest OAA would become the next person in danger.

No matter how carefully people joined hands, trust and moral hazard would always exist side by side.

It started with whether people could genuinely accept the policy established from the beginning. Even within a single group, resentment and distrust could easily grow through complaints like, "He's holding more than he claims," or "She's not helping nearly as much as expected." On top of that, there was no telling where information might leak.

Students who accumulated large numbers of tokens would eventually attract attention beyond their own groups as well. The more successful someone became, the more they would inevitably be treated as a potential savior by people desperate for help.

On the other hand, refusing to share token counts entirely was also a perfectly reasonable option.

But complete secrecy created its own dangers.

If nobody shared anything, then classmates approaching the expulsion threshold could not be rescued in time during emergencies.

Worse, students willing to lie and manipulate others into offering assistance would gain a clear advantage. Paranoia inside the class would deepen further, slowly poisoning internal trust and eventually causing losses.

In the end, the most rational students would probably settle somewhere in the middle. They would avoid revealing exact numbers, respond vaguely like “I don’t really have room to spare,” and only contribute the bare minimum whenever a classmate truly faced immediate danger.

“So basically,” Hashimoto said, “don’t trust your classmates too much.”

“That’s right.”

The fact that Hashimoto understood immediately probably meant he’d already been thinking along similar lines himself.

After that, I gave him a few more requests to pass along.

He accepted every one of them without complaint, nodding firmly each time.

“Leave it to me for now.”

Hashimoto answered with easy confidence, then immediately broke into a run across the sand.

Almost as if trading places with him, Shiraishi and Nishikawa began walking toward me at an unhurried pace.

“Just now, the loyal dog Hachikō, or rather, the loyal dog Hashimoto Masayoshi, seemed to run energetically across the sandy beach. He looked like a child unable to contain his joy at being asked to run an errand.”

And alongside them was the usual oddball Morishita.

“You look more energetic than expected, Ayanokōji Kiyotaka,” she said as she walked up. “Weren't you starting to feel a mixture of heart-pounding anticipation and anxiety from wanting to see me so badly?"

“Not even remotely,” I replied. “More importantly, considering you retired on the second day, you seem pretty energetic yourself.”

“Quite, quite,” Morishita declared proudly without the slightest shame. “Life aboard the ship was unexpectedly wonderful. I spent private points like running water, eating delicious food, drinking, and playing around. Honestly, I would’ve liked to continue that elegant lifestyle for a while longer.”

She spoke without the slightest attempt to hide a single thing.

“That certainly sounds like a meaningful use of your time,” I said dryly. “Did anything unusual happen aboard the ship?”

Expecting little of value from Morishita, I directed the question toward Nishikawa instead, since she had also been eliminated early.

“The third-years who retired were basically given free time until the Survival Game Special Exam ended,” Nishikawa explained. “But it sounded like the first-years and second-years were doing separate special exams of their own. Though I haven’t heard anything about the results, so I don’t really know the details. Sorry.”

So rather than getting an early summer vacation, it seemed they had been placed in a similar environment.

“The first-years must have it rough too,” Shiraishi murmured. “They’re probably struggling with the contrast compared to the luxury cruise ship.”

She sounded genuinely concerned, but Morishita immediately went “tsk, tsk” and wagged a finger.

“You’re still far too naïve, Shiraishi Asuka. A real softie. Our juniors, especially the first-years, should absolutely suffer on the island just like we did. We’ve been struggling ever since our own first year, and yet they get pampered? Very cheeky.”

Coming from someone who’d barely suffered at all this year, Morishita’s venom carried remarkably little self-awareness.

“I happened to run into Yamamura Miki earlier,” she continued. “And wow, she absolutely reeked of sweat and dirt.”

“Don’t say things like that, even as a joke,” I replied. “Yamamura staying until the end helped the class a lot. Same goes for Shiraishi here.”

I looked toward Shiraishi.

“How’s your condition?”

“To be honest,” she answered with a faint smile, “it’s a little difficult. But I can’t afford to complain. Our class managed to take second place, and we’ve finally closed the distance with the classes above us.”

In the Survival Game Special Exam, Ichinose’s class had finished first, Ryūen’s class third, while Horikita’s class had fallen to last place. As a result, the gap in Class Points between the upper and lower classes had narrowed significantly.

Although our class had temporarily dropped into provisional Class D after the reshuffling, the difference between us and Ryūen’s class was still minimal.

Depending on the outcome of the special exam about to begin, every class still had a realistic chance of ending up anywhere between A and D.

“We actually came over because we wanted to compare our initial token counts.”

Saying that, Shiraishi swiftly operated her smartwatch and turned the display toward me.

The tokens displayed there were 12. Nishikawa, who showed hers in tandem, had 2, a massive difference.

“What about Morishita?”

“Fufu, I am a believer in secrecy.”

“Earlier, I was allowed to confirm Morishita-san’s token count,” Shiraishi said calmly. “She had five.”

It seemed the believer in secrecy had thoroughly shared her information.

“Well, for someone operating at my level, five tokens is more than sufficient. Though in the unlikely event of an emergency, I fully intend to exploit Ayanokōji Kiyotaka, so please earn plenty on my behalf.”

At the moment, Shiraishi held the highest confirmed count with twelve. I had eleven. Nishikawa had two, and Morishita five, huh.

“Hashimoto had nine,” I said. “It’s probably safe to assume the longer someone remained active in the Survival Game Special Exam, the larger the advantage they received in starting tokens.”

Class rankings, movements during the exam, roles, and contribution levels may also have had an effect.

At the very least, those kinds of factors were clearly connected to the initial token distribution.

How meaningful that initial token handicap would prove to be might become one of the major keys to the entire test.

Shiraishi considered that silently before speaking again.

“Since everyone begins with at least two tokens, would it be reasonable to assume the penalty involving the first student reduced to zero tokens is unlikely to happen easily?”

“Not necessarily,” I replied. “As long as unrestricted token transfers exist, the system is constantly providing students with ways to adjust their situation.”

I looked back toward Shiraishi.

“If the very first task carried the possibility of losing multiple tokens, then students would need to receive additional tokens from others before even attempting it.”

It was an intentionally extreme scenario.

Realistically, the exam probably wouldn’t escalate that far that quickly. But with Morishita casually nodding along beside us, it wasn’t a bad lie to leave hanging in the air.

A little tension would do her good.

“Are you sure it's okay not to go and support everyone in the class?” Shiraishi asked quietly.

“I’ve already asked Hashimoto to relay several things,” I replied. “Besides, no matter how thoroughly we organize things, nobody is truly safe from the zero-token expulsion penalty until they’ve secured a stable number of tokens for themselves. Since the groups have been separated, this is something they’ll have to overcome on their own.”

There were limits to how much protection could be offered from the outside.

If someone allowed their tokens to fall to zero so easily, then receiving an expulsion notice would simply be the consequence of that failure.

There was another possible approach, of course.

The class could gather from the start, pool its surplus tokens, and redistribute them to students like Nishikawa, who possessed only the minimum amount.

On paper, that would strengthen the weakest members of the class. But even that strategy came with drawbacks.

Protecting weaker students too aggressively would lower the overall ceiling of the class's earning potential. The more tokens were redistributed defensively, the harder it became for stronger students to maximize gains elsewhere.

And in an exam structured entirely around token acquisition, lowering the class's offensive potential too much could become fatal in its own way.

If the class intended to win, then students ultimately needed to gather tokens through their own ability.

This was not an exam where every single person could be protected with absolute certainty. A certain amount of risk had to be accepted.

"By the way," Nishikawa asked, "what group did you end up in, Ayanokōji-kun? I'm in Group One. Honestly, I was hoping I'd end up with Asuka if possible, though~"

It seemed Shiraishi had been assigned to Group Two instead, so that wish had not been granted.

"So you wish to know my group?" Morishita folded her arms with unnecessary pride, "truly, what a secretly perverted man you are! It's Group Three. Three."

"I don't remember asking in the slightest…" I muttered. "Wait. Don't tell me we're actually in the same group…"

"Eh!? Seriously!? We're together!?"

Morishita abruptly covered her mouth with both hands in exaggerated shock.

Though notably, her eyes remained completely unchanged.

“This is going to be an exhausting special exam…”

Just imagining how loud things were likely to become over the next few days was enough to leave me slightly depressed already.

Part 1

With the explanations finally concluded, Morishita and I made our way to our group's designated gathering spot.

Since Group 3's standby area happened to be right nearby, we ended up being the first ones to arrive.

"Allow me to make one thing clear in advance," Morishita said, turning to me with the composed severity of someone delivering an official warning. "During the exam, please refrain from acting overly familiar with me. If there were even the slightest misunderstanding that you were my boyfriend, it would seriously ruin my future school life."

"You don't have to worry about that."

"I wonder about that," she replied without missing a beat. "They say that even when a man denies it, his lower half remains quite energetic. Though I admit, I don't fully understand the biological mechanisms behind it."

"You really have a knack for speaking confidently about things you know nothing about."

"Flattery won't raise my affection rating for you, you know."

Isn't anyone else going to show up?

Just as I was silently hoping for a distraction, the sound of footsteps shifting through the sand reached my ears.

"Let's do our best, Ayanokōji." The voice belonged to Yoshida Kenta, who had come up from behind.

Sanada followed shortly after, and with their arrival, the Class C members assigned to our group had gathered. Looking over them, they were the academically inclined sort, students who might not stand out in any dramatic way, but who could be counted on to handle most situations steadily and without unnecessary trouble.

“Ugh, Morishita, seriously?” Yoshida groaned.

“It seems you simply cannot hide your joy, Kobayashi Kenta.”

“It's Yoshida,” he corrected at once. “*Yoshida.*”

“...Ugh. Ayanokōji. Don't tell me I'm stuck with you.” The voice that cut in from the side was thick with undisguised disgust. It belonged to another participant: Class B’s Ibuki Mio.

Almost at the same moment, another figure began moving toward us: Katsuragi Kōhei, his expression stiff and guarded.

“To think I'd be placed in the same group as you,” he said, stopping nearby. “It looks like this is going to be a tough battle.”

“I could say the same,” I replied.

Katsuragi wasn’t the type to be easily swayed by emotion. If he ended up on the opposing side in a special exam like this, he wouldn’t make things easy for anyone.

That said, because this exam also required mutual cooperation within the same group, he could just as easily be considered a highly dependable ally, making it difficult to definitively weigh his presence.

The rest of the Class B students had yet to make an appearance. Before they did, however, a student from Class A approached.

“Oh, I'm with you, Ibuki-san!” Kushida’s voice came brightly from behind her. “I look forward to working together.”

She stepped close to Ibuki and, with a gentle little pat, placed a hand on her shoulder. Her smile was flawless, almost angelic.

To anyone watching from the outside, it would have looked like nothing more than a girl warmly greeting a friend. Whether that was truly the case, however, was another matter.

“Ugh, Kushida... This is the absolute worst.”

Ibuki looked just as thoroughly disgusted with her as she had been with me, but Kushida, naturally, didn't allow a single facial muscle to twitch.

In the meantime, students from the other classes continued to arrive one after another.

When, at last, all sixteen participants had gathered, I looked over the group once more and took a moment to mentally review the lineup.

> **Group 3 Participants**
>
> **CLASS D:** Sumida Makoto, Moriyama Susumu, Minamikata Kozue, Amikura Mako
>
> **CLASS C:** Ayanokōji Kiyotaka, Yoshida Kenta, Sanada Kōsei, Morishita Ai
>
> **CLASS B:** Sonoda Masashi, Katsuragi Kōhei, Ibuki Mio, Morofuji Rika
>
> **CLASS A:** Ike Kanji, Kushida Kikyō, Shinohara Satsuki, Wang Mei-Yu

There were a few loudmouths in the mix, but my initial impression was that this was a solid, well-balanced group.

I immediately began constructing the logic needed to secure a win, and more importantly, how to avoid a loss.

The important factors were the number of tokens, the multipliers, and avoiding penalties. There were still unknowns, such as the goals system that affected those multipliers, but one thing was already certain: these sixteen people were both allies and enemies. By analyzing their individual abilities and relationships, I began narrowing down the optimal way to maneuver from here.

As I ran through these calculations, I noticed the four Class A students watching me closely.

As their former classmate, I figured I should probably offer them a standard, polite greeting. Though, knowing Ike and the others, there was a fair chance they would just hurl abuse at me the second I opened my mouth.

While I was idly considering that possibility, Ike Kanji and Shinohara Satsuki exchanged a glance. Then after a brief, hushed conversation, they took the initiative and approached me, both wearing visibly nervous expressions.

They were walking extremely close to one another, close enough that their shoulders nearly lined up. From that alone, it was easy to see that their relationship was still going well.

Statistically, the probability of a couple ending up in the same group was just under eight percent. It wasn't a particularly surprising outcome in itself, but the two of them likely interpreted it as some stroke of baseless romantic destiny.

Behind them, Kushida and Mii-chan were watching me as well. Kushida, smile firmly in place, gave me a small, casual wave. Mii-chan, meanwhile, looked somewhat nervous, but still lowered her head in a polite bow.

“I never imagined I'd end up in the same group as you, Ayanokōji.”

Ike was the first to speak. His tone was surprisingly composed. Even as I considered how best to match his demeanor, he kept going.

“When I first saw your face, I thought about giving you a piece of my mind. But since we're stuck in the same group, we might as well try to get along. I'll lend a hand where I can.”

“I feel the same way as Kanji,” Shinohara added. “It doesn't seem like this exam is just a straightforward battle, and I think I properly understand just how capable you actually are, Ayanokōji-kun. I'll cooperate however I can, so I look forward to working with you.”

It was an unexpectedly amicable greeting from my former classmates. Given the circumstances, they should have harbored overwhelmingly negative feelings toward me. Yet, their smiles were genuine, lacking any trace of deception, and they seemed to be treating me as normally as possible.

In this exam, we were simultaneously allies and enemies. That was precisely why they wanted to keep the peace and approach the situation cordially. Maneuvering to avoid making unnecessary enemies was the tactically correct decision, but I was genuinely surprised to see such sound judgment coming from these two. It felt as though I was witnessing a genuine sign of growth.

Considering they were addressing the very person who had betrayed their class, their soft expressions and mild demeanor were practically impeccable. Ike and Shinohara had likely mustered a great deal of courage just to initiate this contact.

I let my gaze slip away from the two of them.

Then, without stopping, I passed by and moved toward Kushida and Mii-chan, who had been standing just behind them, quietly watching how things were unfolding.

”I'm sure there are plenty of difficulties that come with working alongside a traitor,” I said, directing my first words to Mii-chan. “But I look forward to working with you until the exam concludes.”

“Eh?” She blinked, visibly caught off guard. “Ah, y-yes. The pleasure is mine...”

Though she was flustered, her reply was polite, almost overly so. After receiving it, I shifted my eyes to Kushida, who stood beside her.

“It would be a great help if I could rely on you as an ally, too.”

“That’s what I should be saying,” Kushida answered with a gentle smile. “I only hope someone like me can be useful.”

Her voice was soft, her expression perfectly composed. Only her eyes gave the faintest glimpse of something closer to her true feelings.

“I rate your communication skills particularly highly, Kushida,” I said. “With students from all four classes mixed together, managing the group won’t be easy.”

“Of course, I'll do everything in my power to help. It would be wonderful if everyone in the group could achieve a good result, wouldn't it?” Ever mindful of the prying eyes around us, Kushida delivered a flawlessly safe response.

“That will be sufficient.”

With those brief greetings out of the way, I turned my back on them and began walking over to where the Class C students were gathered.

“Hey, wait, hold on a second?”

“Um, Ayanokōji-kun...?”

Ike and Shinohara called after me, their voices carrying the same bewilderment their faces showed. Neither of them seemed to understand what had just happened. They had approached me, offered a greeting, extended something close to goodwill, and I had walked past them as though it had never reached me.

I gave them only the briefest glance.

Then I continued on.

Perhaps realizing just how unnatural this behavior was, Ike raised his voice.

“Wait a minute, you're just gonna ignore us?!”

The irritation in him finally began to show. He had been the one to take the first step, forcing down whatever resentment still lingered inside him and choosing to speak to me before Kushida or Mii-chan did.

“That's honestly really messed up,” Shinohara said, her tone losing some of its earlier composure. “I mean, seriously… Did we do something to you?”

“No, nothing,” I answered. “I simply judged that you weren't worth greeting.”

“Excuse me?!”

Showered with such unexpectedly merciless words, their expressions predictably, and rather amusingly, twisted with fresh anger.

Even Kushida likely couldn't have imagined I would say something so harshly blunt.

But their reaction was a perfectly natural one. Anyone would be furious if they choked down their negative feelings to politely greet someone, only to receive an unreserved insult in return.

“Well then,” I said, already turning away. “I’ll see you later.”

Even as I took my leave, I aimed those parting words entirely at Kushida and Mii-chan, completely ignoring the other two.

“Ayanokōji!” Ike shouted after me, his restraint finally breaking. “What the hell is your problem?! That attitude is way out of line!”

Though he finally let his suppressed emotions explode, Ike didn't attempt to chase after me.

Ignoring his shouting, I resumed my walk toward the area where Yoshida and the others had gathered. Along the way, I noticed a girl standing between us, frozen as though the commotion had caught her attention and then left her unsure of what to do. She was looking directly at me as our eyes met.

“...A-Ah, s-sorry! I'm sorry...!” Morofuji stammered, shrinking back almost at once. “F-For being in the way...”

Her apology came out in broken fragments. Before I could say anything, she hurriedly moved aside and fled, her behavior suspiciously restless.

There had been no particular reason for her to apologize. Yet the look on her face had gone beyond ordinary wariness. She seemed frightened, unnaturally so.

Morofuji had once been among the students involved in the bullying of Karuizawa. Perhaps what happened back then still lingered in her memory and influenced the way she saw me now.

As I watched her flee back toward the Class B students, Yoshida approached from the other side and called out to me.

“Did something happen with Morofuji?”

“No,” I replied. “Nothing in particular.”

“I see. More importantly…” Yoshida glanced past me. “Are you sure that’s okay? Ike and Shinohara have been glaring at you this whole time.”

He must have overheard parts of our exchange, judging by his concerned tone.

“Don't worry about it. I never intended to play nice with my former classmates to begin with,” I replied. “More importantly, now that you’ve seen the members, what's your assessment of our group's lineup?”

“Hm? Oh, well,” Yoshida looked over the gathered group. “I’d say we got off pretty easy. Katsuragi is going to be a pain since he knows us well, but the rest of Class B's members are pretty minor players. Class A is a mixed bag: a weird, mismatched combination of top-tier and bottom-tier students. As for Class D, they're well-balanced, and they seem capable enough, but they aren't exactly intimidating, you know?”

Having visualized the upcoming battles, Yoshida offered this straightforward evaluation.

“This setup should make things pretty easy for you to maneuver too, right?” he asked.

"If we're only talking about Group Three, then that assessment is correct." I looked over the assembled students once more. "However, when it comes to the key leaders, figures like Ryūen, Horikita, and Ichinose, it would have been best to have them all placed in the same group as me. Especially Ryūen."

"...*Ryūen?"* Yoshida's face twisted at the thought, as if he had just bitten into something bitter. "I'd absolutely hate being stuck in the same group as him."

From a short distance away, Sanada, who had been listening to us, slowly approached.

"The more troublesome the opponent, the more useful it is to keep them close. In this special exam, that makes them easier to control. That's what you're thinking, isn't it, Ayanokōji-kun?"

"Exactly. Regardless of who I'm up against, my commitment to doing whatever it takes to protect the class and secure a win remains unchanged. But given the structure of this exam, it's going to be impossible to manage everything happening out of my sight."

Sanada nodded, picking up the exam materials and flipping to the page detailing the penalties.

"To a certain extent, I can maneuver things to ensure our classmates don't finish dead last in token counts, or prevent anyone from failing to reach the goal," I said. "However, the penalty stating that the first student whose tokens drop to zero will face immediate expulsion, that is something I have absolutely no control over."

Yoshida seemed to understand what I meant. His mouth bent into a hard, uneasy line, and after a moment he nodded.

"Yeah, you've got a point... If the guys grouped with Ryūen fall for one of his underhanded tricks and hit zero tokens, they'd be instantly expelled on the spot. When you put it like that, it's actually pretty terrifying."

"Of all the penalties outlined in the rules, I feel that's the only one I can't actively counter," I added.

In reality, under a specific set of conditions, there was a chance that an entirely different penalty could bare its fangs and prove even more devastating. However, there was no point in bringing that up right now, so I let the thought pass.

“Isn't it pointless to worry too much about it?” Sanada interjected. “I imagine the school has designed the tasks so that tokens won’t drop to zero that easily.”

“Sanada's right,” Yoshida agreed. “As long as someone doesn't do something incredibly stupid and walk right into a trap, they'll be fine. Besides, even if we do worry about it, there's no way to prevent it, right?”

“For now, let's prioritize figuring out how our own group is going to maneuver,” Sanada said.

I gave a single nod in agreement.

From here on out, my process would be the same as always. I needed to gather all the scattered building blocks of practical strategies before me and begin sorting through them based on what was efficient and what wasn’t.

I had already eliminated many unnecessary possibilities from consideration, but I still lacked the information necessary to map out the hidden motives of the class leaders: Horikita, Ichinose, and Ryūen.

More time was needed before I could fully analyze the finer details of the rules.

In the meantime, with our faculty supervisor still nowhere to be seen, I let my gaze drift around the area.

Naturally, the entirety of the third-year student body, along with numerous adult staff members, were hurriedly gathering nearby.

That said, I wasn't scanning the crowd to figure out the composition of all ten groups, nor was I trying to map out who belonged where. While I could roughly identify some of it just by observing the crowd here, without any way to guarantee complete accuracy, there was little value in trying to memorize it all.

My true objective was simpler than that.

I was looking for one particular person.

And sure enough, I eventually spotted Hiyori in the distance, chatting happily while surrounded by her classmates. If she had been closer, I might have been able to call out to her, but the physical distance made that completely impossible.

It seemed I really was fated to have no meaningful interaction with her during this Uninhabited Island Exam.

But there was no need to rush.

Once we returned to the cruise ship, there would inevitably be time to talk.

"..."

Suddenly, a strange sense of dissonance crept into my thoughts.

That's right. There was no need to rush.

And thinking I was 'fated to have no connection' with her was logically incorrect, too.

It was true that we hadn't spoken for a few days, not since we first boarded the cruise ship. But a few days wasn't nearly long enough to warrant such a dramatic conclusion. In fact, looking back, there had been plenty of times where we had gone much longer without interacting at all.

So why was I suddenly overwhelmed by the sensation that it had been an eternity since we last spoke?

No...

Was the very fact that I was questioning the reason already proof that I had entered unfamiliar territory?

Was this the effect of realizing I might have feelings for Hiyori, the change it had brought about in my heart?

Given the current lack of concrete exam details, Hiyori, who belonged to a different class and a completely different group, was nothing but static noise. Her existence factored nowhere into the strategic framework I was currently constructing.

And still, my eyes followed her.

Unconsciously, they traced the distant outline of her profile.

Even after I realized what I was doing, nothing changed.

The action was pointless. The time spent on it served no practical purpose. Even so, somewhere within that uselessness, there was a faint stirring of exhilaration.

If this feeling really was romantic affection, then had Karuizawa once looked at me in the same way? Had she felt something similar when her eyes followed me?

Romance was a textbook I had failed to comprehend on my first read-through. But by reviewing the material, I was gradually beginning to notice all the subtle details I had missed the first time around.

What sort of emotion was born when speaking to the person one liked?

What arose when touching them?

My curiosity wasn't limited to purely positive feelings, either.

What sort of emotions would be born within me if I were to be hated by that same person, or if I were to lose them entirely?

I wanted to experience both ends of it: the warmth of affection, and the coldness of rejection. Love and hate alike.

Yet perhaps it was foolish to wish for both at the same time.

Perhaps it was important not to be greedy. Perhaps one should not try to learn everything from a single romance.

If attaining both was impossible, then experiencing either one would suffice...

“What's wrong, Ayanokōji? Something bothering you?”

Yoshida, who had been speaking with Sanada only moments before, turned his attention toward me.

“No, not particularly,” I replied. “Why do you ask?”

“Well, it’s not exactly why……” He glanced in the direction I had been looking, then back at me. “You were staring off into the distance. I thought maybe you’d noticed something we should be worried about.”

“We just finished the Survival Game Special Exam, after all,” I replied smoothly. “I suppose I'm just a little worn out. But considering Shiraishi and Yamamura are still giving it their all, I can't exactly be the first one to throw in the towel.”

Taking a brief pause, I decided to steer the conversation and add a bit more context.

“Right now, we don't have the full picture. We don't know the exact number of tasks, nor how many tokens we'll actually be able to acquire. Whatever happens, please do not leak any information regarding your token counts to anyone outside.”

“Not even to our allies, right? I heard that from Hashimoto,” Yoshida said.

“Right. And for now, I’d also like to avoid unnecessary conflict with the other classes. If we’re going to aim for first place in this group, like you’re hoping, then cooperation with students from the other classes will be unavoidable.”

“I suppose that's true,” Sanada chimed in. “But I wonder how the other side feels about that. I'm sure they want the Private Points, but they probably don't want our class to win, either. They might end up slacking off on purpose.”

“Even if they do, the leaders of the other three classes are facing the exact same dilemma. The underlying motive of not wanting to hand another class a victory will always be a factor.”

Sanada and Yoshida exchanged a brief glance, quickly understanding the logic behind my words.

“I get what you're saying,” Yoshida said. “Anyway, just give us the word whenever you need us.”

I gave a single nod, letting my demeanor convey my gratitude.

Satisfied with my convenient excuse, Yoshida gave me a light pat on the back.

“Don't hesitate to reach out if you need a hand.”

“Yeah, I will.”

With that response, I finally tore my lingering gaze away from Hiyori.

For the time being, all I needed to focus on was getting through this Special Exam. Everything beyond that could wait.

Part 2

Right around the time Ayanokōji was making his first contact with Group 3, Horikita, assigned elsewhere to Group 8, was experiencing a face-to-face encounter of her own.

A gentle sea breeze playfully tossed the long, pink hair of the student standing before her. A warm smile graced the girl's lips as she spoke.

“I look forward to working with you, Horikita-san.”

“I knew there was a decent chance that class leaders might end up in the same group, but to think I'd be paired with you of all people, Ichinose-san.”

Inwardly, Horikita breathed a sigh of relief. Out of the three rival leaders, Ichinose was by far the easiest to manage. It wasn't a question of her being a weak opponent, but rather a certainty: *having Ichinose Honami as an ally would bring an immense sense of stability to their group.*

This special exam certainly contained the element of competition between classes. However, it also placed heavy importance on the results achieved by each group as a whole. In that regard, Ichinose’s presence was almost guaranteed to steer them in a positive direction.

“If this were a purely class-based competition, it might have been a bit troublesome,” Ichinose said. “But looking at the rules, cooperating as a group clearly leads to mutual benefit, so it's a rather good setup. If you and I pool our strengths, Horikita-san, we might just be able to guide our group to a safe and steady victory.”

It seemed Ichinose had been harboring the exact same thoughts.

Yet, looking at the girl standing before her, Horikita sensed a quiet, powerful intensity that hadn't been there before. As an enemy, this newfound strength would be a nightmare to deal with. But as an ally? It made her incredibly reliable.

“True enough,” Horikita replied. “As leaders, our group is expected to secure a win. Under normal circumstances, we'd be probing each other for ulterior motives, but instead, we will cooperate and aim for the highest rank possible... I take it we're in agreement on that?”

Whether they chose to cooperate or oppose would determine everything. It was possible to send tokens to other groups, deliberately weakening their own side in order to prevent another class from profiting. Depending on the policy they adopted, the total number of tokens their group could secure would change dramatically.

“Of course,” Ichinose replied brightly. “If our group takes first place, we'll each be rewarded with one hundred Class Points. It's the ideal outcome for both of us. And it won't just be me, if necessary, I'll firmly request the full cooperation of everyone in Class D. Does that work for you?”

“I'll gladly accept your offer,” Horikita said smoothly. “On our end, I also intend to unite my classmates under a policy of securely maximizing our group's total tokens. Though, naturally, that will heavily depend on the moves made by Class B and Class C, whose hands we've yet to see.”

Students from the other classes began to appear one by one, but there was no sign of Ayanokōji or Ryūen among them.

Hypothetically, if all four class leaders had ended up in the same group, cooperating to maximize their total token yield would have been a simple affair. However, such an arrangement offered little benefit to anyone aside from the front-running Class A.

A precious Special Exam like this was a rare opportunity to widen the gap between classes; but if every leader simply worked together in the same group, that precious chance would be dulled from the outset.

"It seems reaching a mutual understanding and aiming for first place will go smoother than expected," Horikita noted. "However, there is one critical issue that both you and I must treat with the utmost importance."

"How to handle the expulsions... right?"

Their eyes met, and Horikita gave a firm nod.

It had already been established that this Special Exam would result in expulsions. Worse still, one of those was a mandatory penalty that *someone* absolutely had to shoulder. The only ways to prevent a student from being sent home were if the target conveniently held a Protection Point, or if someone paid the exorbitant fee of 20 million Private Points.

"Horikita-san," Ichinose said, her tone resolute. "I absolutely will not allow a single one of my classmates to be expelled. If securing first place in total tokens requires sacrificing a peer, then I will choose to save my ally without a second thought."

The unspoken message from Ichinose was clearly hanging in the air: *If you have a problem with that, speak up now.*

Taking the declaration in stride, Horikita drew a quiet breath before responding. "I agree. I have no intention of sacrificing my classmates either."

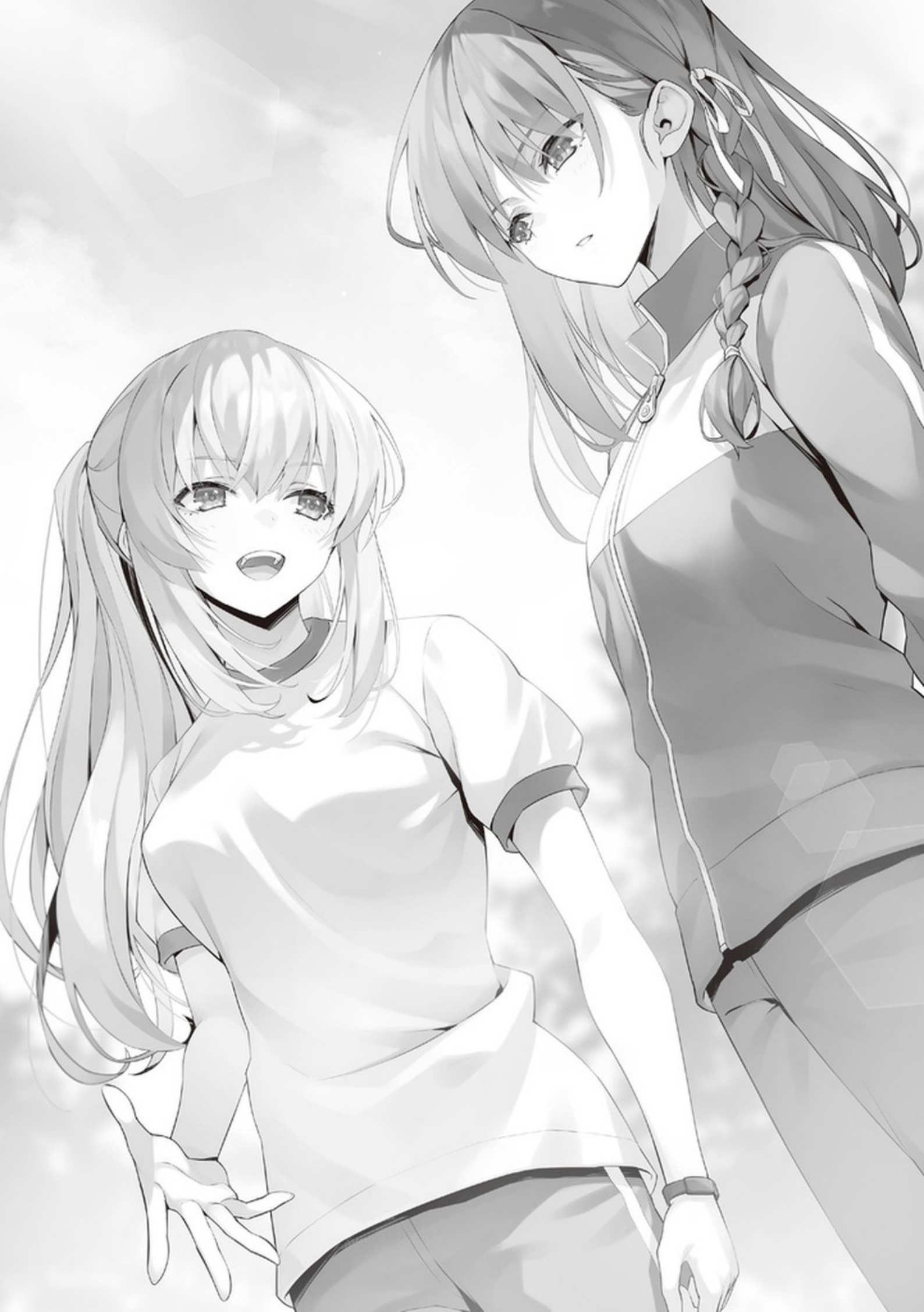
"Then I suppose that makes us allies who can join hands and face the same direction, right?"

"...Assuming you're willing to trust me, that is."

Horikita was well aware that she hadn't garnered nearly as much goodwill and trust as Ichinose had. She knew her standing. Right now, she was the one who needed to prove she was worthy of being trusted.

“Then it looks like we won't have any problems!”

Breaking into a bright, unwavering smile, Ichinose extended her hand.



Seeing her unhesitating demeanor, Horikita couldn't help but let out an inward sigh of admiration.

Over the past two years, Ichinose had weathered countless storms through the sheer power of trust, a track record that spoke volumes. Horikita had felt it indirectly on several occasions, but standing beside her in the same group brought that strength into incredibly sharp, reassuring focus. Under normal circumstances, one should never easily trust a rival. Yet, Horikita found her mind effortlessly jumping to the conclusion that Ichinose was safe to believe in.

Of course, that trust was not absolute. The possibility of betrayal, however remote, could never truly be erased.

But the mere fact that Ichinose could subconsciously instill such an unwavering mindset in someone: making them feel that *if I am betrayed by Ichinose, then so be it,* was a profoundly impressive feat in itself.

“Before I take your hand, there is one more thing…”

Staring down at Ichinose's slender, elegant fingers, Horikita pressed further, delving into the crux of the matter.

“Sacrifices are practically unavoidable in this exam. However, we are agreeing that neither of our classes will produce any expulsions, and we will maneuver with everything we have to ensure that. Maintaining this policy means, by process of elimination, cornering someone from either Ryūen-kun's or Ayanokōji-kun's class for expulsion instead. Are you prepared for that?”

At the sharp question, Ichinose closed her eyes for a moment, letting out a soft, breathy laugh.

“It's true that the old me probably wouldn't have agreed so easily,” she admitted. “But I don't hesitate anymore. You can rest assured, Horikita-san, I have no intention of holding back against rival classes if it means protecting my friends.”

Horikita met that open, unwavering gaze head-on.

“I see. It seems you've grown far more than I realized while I wasn't looking, Ichinose-san.”

Horikita had always recognized her as a formidable opponent. Yet, somewhere deep down, she had still been underestimating the student known as Ichinose Honami.

Being a genuinely good person usually meant harboring inherent weaknesses beneath the surface. Protecting an entire class was no easy feat; Horikita and Hirata had both tried countless times, only to fall short of that ideal. Yet, despite her bitter struggles, Ichinose had continued to protect her classmates to this very day, refusing to lose a single one.

“I feel the exact same way about you, Horikita-san,” Ichinose replied softly. “You're much more formidable now than when we first enrolled.”

“I wonder about that. Personally, I feel it's only become harder to maneuver now that I have more things to protect…” Horikita trailed off before continuing. “But more importantly, there is something that's been bothering me since we heard the explanation for this Special Exam. Ensuring our allies' tokens don't drop to zero will require a certain element of luck. What are your thoughts on that?”

“Have you noticed the correlation between the number of starting tokens and the Survival Game Special Exam?”

“Yes,” Horikita answered. “Students who remained in the previous exam for a longer time seem to have received more tokens. Of course, I haven’t confirmed it with every classmate, so I can’t say for certain…”

She added, after a moment, that this was based only on what she had heard from several students whose elimination times had differed.

“That is my assessment as well,” Ichinose said. “In other words, you could say we have a slight advantage over Ayanokōji-kun's and Ryūen-kun's classes, since both suffered a high number of early eliminations.”

“Your class even had students who remained until the very end. If that conclusion can be drawn from the highest number of tokens among them, then you’re probably right. However, simply having a high total token pool as a class doesn't necessarily mean things will proceed to our advantage.”

Ultimately, because the students had been distributed randomly, a high class total would only create variance between the different groups, or at best, provide an edge in individual battles.

“But holding a large number of tokens as a class does mean a massive difference in how often we can transmit information over the radios,” Ichinose countered. “If you and I cooperate to meticulously manage our tokens, Horikita-san, we can constantly keep track of any students whose counts drop dangerously low. Excluding Group 10, which doesn’t have full sixteen members, we’d have eight people in each group who could transfer tokens and cover for one another.”

“I see... You're suggesting that everyone outside of our Group 8, which will strictly aim for first place, maneuvers solely to prevent casualties? Transferred tokens are flipped Back-side, meaning they lose their value for individual rewards. But from our group's perspective, it also means the rival groups we need to defeat will naturally fall behind.”

Under normal circumstances, coordinating two separate classes with such a unified strategy was no simple task. First and foremost, it required forcing the students assigned to the other nine groups to completely abandon any hope of acquiring the Special Reward. While the monolithically united Ichinose Class might accept such terms, convincing every single one of Horikita's classmates to swallow that pill would be practically impossible.

“It's an interesting idea,” Horikita said, “but it means forcing students in other groups who might be perfectly capable of pulling off a massive upset to sacrifice their chances. If anything, wouldn't the groups completely free of Ryūen-kun and Ayanokōji-kun's influence be the ones harboring the best chance for a surprise victory?”

This exchange perfectly highlighted their fundamental difference in approach. Ichinose wanted to fight with a heavily defensive focus, prioritizing collective survival, while Horikita wanted to maintain a certain degree of offensive awareness, seeking out opportunities to win.

Even with their agreement to cooperate, Horikita couldn't shake the strong premonition that this Special Exam was going to be fraught with difficulties.

“You're right,” Ichinose agreed softly. “I'm sure we won't always see eye to eye. But this Special Exam lasts for four days and three nights. Let's discuss things thoroughly and decide our course as we go, Horikita-san.”

“True. We still don't know what the specific tasks entail or how the tokens will flow in practice. There's no point in rushing things.”

“Alright then. I’ll go speak to everyone in the group.”

With a polite bow, Ichinose excused herself and stepped away.

Standing alone at a slight distance, Horikita watched as Ichinose cheerfully exchanged greetings with students from other classes.

“I know there's no need to rush, but…” she murmured to herself.

Her mind drifted back to a troubling exchange she’d had with Sudō immediately following the Survival Game Special Exam.

“There might be a traitor in our class.”

He had told her how, during Class A's battle, the opposing students had completely bypassed him, despite the massive physical threat he posed on the battlefield, to aggressively target Satō, their VIP.

If Horikita had been the enemy commander, she would have undoubtedly prioritized taking Sudō off the board first. If the opposition had instead focused all their fire on Satō... and if someone had been pulling the strings from the shadows to orchestrate that...

“Is someone in our class really leaking information...?”

Her gaze drifted, eventually landing on Ayanokōji's figure in the distance. Gathered with him were four students from Class A: Wang, Shinohara, Ike, and Kushida.

Before the first semester had even come to an end, the four classes had already settled in a tense state of equilibrium.

If all of their internal affairs were truly leaking out, then the strategies or information Horikita relayed to her classmates would inevitably find their way to Ayanokōji.

Should that come to pass, they would be forced into a grueling, uphill battle in this Special Exam as well.

And so, like a quiet, stubborn ember, that dark anxiety continued to smolder within her chest.

Part 3

Before the exhaustion from the Survival Game Special Exam could even fade, a new Special Exam was already upon them. As Mashima outlined the rules, Ryūen was already turning over several strategies in his mind.

Ever since enrolling at this school, he had tackled every obstacle with absolute, unshakable confidence in his own judgment. Yet lately, no matter the time or situation, the phantom image of Ayanokōji seemed to constantly flicker at the back of his mind.

Orthodox tactics, unconventional schemes, or even outright lawlessness that shattered the rules themselves, Ayanokōji would see right through all of it and still come out on top.

Ryūen caught himself preemptively conceding defeat for a future that had yet to even unfold.

If this were a mere battle of wits, he would have countless ways to counterattack. But Ayanokōji also possessed monstrous physical prowess. The memory of their shootout with paint guns flashed behind his eyes, prompting Ryūen to let out a quiet, sharp click of his tongue.

“Is something the matter, Ryūen-shi? Did something displease you?”

Having been placed in the same group, Kaneda seemed to have noticed that small sound. He called out to Ryūen, his gaze shifting toward the other members who were starting to gather.

“I was just thinkin' about that bastard Ayanokōji. Don't sweat it.”

“...So it has to do with Ayanokōji-shi. I see.”

If Ayanokōji were left to his own devices, his group would easily secure first place in total tokens. Between that and the Special Reward for individual performance, Class C stood to gain a massive haul of up to 200 Class Points. On top of that, the influx of Private Points would grant them an even more dangerous degree of freedom.

The comfortable advantage Ryūen's class had maintained up until now had completely vapourised during the first half of the uninhabited island exam. Even if official class demotions wouldn't take effect until the following month, they had already bled enough Class Points to provisionally plummet from Class B down to Class C. Worse yet, the gap between them and Ayanokōji's last-place class was now razor-thin.

Simply put, it was a battle they absolutely could not afford to lose. Then again... the exact same thing could have been said about the last Special Exam.

Just how is he supposed to outmaneuver Ayanokōji?

Ayanokōji would undoubtedly rake in a massive haul of Front-side tokens. The real question was whether Ryūen could actually surpass that total. If outscoring him directly proved impossible, then beating him in the group rankings to secure the token multiplier was an absolute must. It was the bare minimum requirement for Ryūen to secure a victory.

Then there was the expulsion penalty, triggered the moment a student's token count hit zero.

No matter how monstrous Ayanokōji might be, he couldn't protect all his classmates twenty-four hours a day. If Ryūen could seize total control of their group, eliminating a single student from Class C would be entirely within his grasp.

Letting his gaze drift across the area, Ryūen spotted Ayanokōji a short distance away. Yoshida was standing right beside him, chattering about something, but the boy didn't even register in Ryūen's field of vision.

Ayanokōji was staring off in another direction, his eyes characteristically listless.

“What the hell is that bastard staring at—”

Just because Ayanokōji’s thoughts and emotions were hidden behind an impenetrable wall didn't mean Ryūen was going to give up trying to read him. To find a breakthrough, he had no choice but to strike like a serpent, sinking his fangs into even the most trivial of clues.

And so, Ryūen traced the line of Ayanokōji's gaze.

Normally, pinpointing exactly what someone was looking at from a distance was nearly impossible, especially with so many students clustered tightly together.

Yet, Ryūen realized it instantly.

Standing at the very end of Ayanokōji's unblinking gaze was the figure of Shiina Hiyori.

“Ryūen-kun, it looks like we're in the same group.”

A voice shattered his concentration just as he was trying to dissect Ayanokōji's thoughts.

“What the hell do you want?”

Whipping his sharp glare toward the intruder, Ryūen found Hirata Yōsuke standing right in front of him.

“I'd like to make a request right off the bat,” Hirata said. “I don't want anyone in this group to be expelled.”

“Hah, you've got a damn sharp nose,” Ryūen scoffed. “But that's one wish I ain't granting, Hirata. This is the perfect chance to kick someone out of your precious Class A, after all. Don't go thinkin' you're the only one sitting safe and sound.”

“If you want to target me, I don't intend to stop you,” Hirata replied evenly. “But if you plan on expelling any other student from Class A... or from Class C, for that matter, then I'll have to make you listen.”

Hirata had accurately read the atmosphere. He knew from Ryūen's gaze alone that Class A wasn't even on his radar; Ryūen was actively scouting for prey in Class C. That was exactly why Hirata's statement carried such a pointed implication.

“I ain't got any reason to take orders on who I target,” Ryūen sneered. “Or what? You got something to offer in exchange for me lettin' the small fry off the hook?”

“Well, I suppose I could become proactive about cooperating across class lines. You're a class leader, Ryūen-kun, which means a victory for our group is also a victory for Class B.”

“I can't think of a single damn reason why a Class A guy like you would lend me a hand.”

“It's simple, really. We can avoid producing any pointless expulsions. To me, that is the greatest merit.”

“Seems like you've got the same pain-in-the-ass personality as Ichinose.”

“I don't mind what you think of me. I just want to settle things peacefully.”

Rather than jumping to a hasty conclusion, Ryūen paused to weigh the credibility of Hirata's words and demeanor, carefully considering which path would best serve his goals.

Even if he did drain someone's tokens to zero and force an expulsion from Class C, it would amount to little more than petty harassment directed at Ayanokōji. It wouldn't directly impact his own class's standing or net them any points. Furthermore, one could argue that any student careless enough to let their tokens hit zero was just dead weight anyway. Going out of his way to eliminate them, especially at the cost of making an enemy out of Hirata, held very little strategic value.

On the other hand, if Hirata's offer to cooperate was genuine, it would be a distinct advantage.

Gazing at the other students gathering for their group, Hirata continued.

“Given the severe penalties in this Special Exam, I know it wouldn't be impossible for you to set a trap and expel someone from Class C, Ryūen-kun. However, the only reason you're keeping the option to target a lower-ranked class open is to inflict damage on Ayanokōji-kun. But even if you could freely pick off one of the four people in our group... or rather, one person from Class C, it wouldn't actually affect him. You wouldn't be scoring a real point against him, would you?”

It was a simple truth. If Ayanokōji were in the same group and Ryūen managed to crush his strategy in a direct confrontation before expelling a Class C student, it would undoubtedly be a massive victory. But under the current rules, there were inevitable blind spots where they couldn't observe one another. Scoring a cheap hit while the demon was away was nothing to brag about.

“If anything, it might just prove that you're a small fry,” Hirata added.

“Don't make me laugh.” Opting to put his final decision on hold, Ryūen threw the threat back at him. “You want to protect this makeshift group so badly you'd go out of your way to provoke me? Then you're gonna have to show it with your actions first.”

He calculated that if Hirata could actually operate as an ally rather than an enemy in this Special Exam, his utility value would be immense.

As if anticipating this demand from the very beginning, Hirata gave a single, firm nod.

“I know.”

From the corner of his eye, Ryūen caught sight of Hirata’s rigid expression— so unlike the image he had held of him until now that, for the first time, he sensed within him a faint trace of murderous intent.

Chapter 2: From a Subtle Rift

❖

It was already past five in the evening.

Even with the late midsummer sunset, there was no denying that dusk was beginning to settle over the island.

Yet, far from recovering from the fatigue of the Survival Game, some students stepped directly into another special exam, still carrying all of their accumulated exhaustion.

As the time to begin the exam drew near, the supervisors finally made their appearance.

“My name is Urushihara,” one of the adults announced calmly as he stepped forward. “I will be serving as the supervisor for Group 3. I look forward to working with all of you.”

He was a man I had never seen before. After introducing himself, he immediately began checking attendance with efficient professionalism.

Out of the ten groups, four had apparently been assigned third-year homeroom teachers as supervisors.

Urushihara belonged to the remaining six.

Once he confirmed that everyone was present, he continued without delay.

“In this special exam, you will challenge a variety of tasks in order to acquire tokens. These tasks are divided into three separate categories, so please listen carefully while I explain. The three categories are: *Individual, Group,* and *Team.*

"*Individual* category is the simplest to understand. These are assignments issued to students on a one-on-one basis. You may compete individually against someone from your own group, or against a student from another group.

"Next is the *Group* category. These involve all sixteen members currently assembled here working together to complete tasks issued by the school, or competing directly against other groups.

"And finally, *Team*. This category further divides the group according to class affiliation. In other words, students from the same class within the group will form smaller units. Since these tasks contain more specialized rules, detailed explanations will be given at the time those assignments are actually conducted."

After confirming everyone was following along without issue, the supervisor, Urushihara continued.

"Now then, next I'd like to explain how tokens will be awarded. However, before we proceed, each class within the group must first select one 'representative.'"

Up until now, neither Mashima-sensei's explanation nor the written materials had mentioned anything about a representative.

Hearing this unfamiliar role for the first time, the students exchanged puzzled glances.

"Does becoming the representative come with any benefits?" Sonoda asked cautiously. "Actually… if there are disadvantages too, I'd rather hear about those now."

Though conscious of the students around him, Sonoda took the initiative and asked the question.

"No," Urushihara replied calmly. "There are no particular advantages or disadvantages attached to the role itself. However, the system has been designed so that any tokens earned by a class are awarded in bulk to that class's representative."

A ripple of confusion spread through the group.

"This will become relevant during the *Group* and *Team* categories," he continued. "For example, let's say Class A earns ten tokens through a Group or Team assignment. If Ike-kun has been selected as Class A's representative, then all ten of those tokens will first be awarded directly to him."

Up until that moment, every student there, including me, had naturally assumed that any tokens earned would be distributed directly to the individuals who participated.

That fundamental assumption had just been overturned completely.

Whether tokens were granted individually or concentrated in the hands of a representative was an enormous difference.

"Hah? What the hell is that supposed to mean?" Ibuki snapped immediately, realizing how abnormal this system was, she glared suspiciously at Urushihara. "So if they wanted to, the representative could just pocket all the tokens for themselves?"

"The school has no intention of encouraging such behavior," Urushihara answered evenly. "However, under the rules, it is technically possible. Contribution levels during assignments may vary depending on the task, after all, so classes may need to discuss internally how tokens should be distributed afterward. In that sense, the representative role may require a certain level of integrity."

The supervisor gave a seemingly reasonable explanation, but this setup had caused the risks to skyrocket.

Exactly as Ibuki feared, placing all token management in the hands of a representative meant there was no guarantee that tokens would ever actually reach the students who earned them.

Only the *Individual* category seemed exempt from this structure.

But assuming the rewards across all three categories were distributed relatively evenly, then that meant a student could directly control only about one-third of the tokens tied to their own survival.

"However, there is one important point you all need to understand regarding front-side and back-side tokens," Urushihara continued.

"Any token earned through the *Individual* category will, without exception, count as a front-side token. But tokens earned through the *Group* and *Team* categories work differently. The total number of tokens earned in a given assignment will first be divided according to the number of participants involved. For instance, let's say a Group-category assignment awards forty-eight tokens. Since there are four classes represented within the group, each class representative would temporarily receive twelve tokens. But since the group itself contains sixteen students, only three of those twelve tokens per student would qualify as legitimate front-side tokens. That number becomes the upper limit recognized as a properly earned individual contribution. If a student were to receive four tokens in that situation, then one of those tokens would automatically become a back-side token. The right to possess front-side tokens does not expire and continues accumulating over time. As such, there is no disadvantage regarding *when* representatives choose to distribute tokens."

Putting it simply, the rules worked like this:

❂ Token Distribution Rules

Categories of Assignments: Individual, Group & Team

Individual Assignments:

- All tokens earned personally are treated as front-side tokens.

Group / Team Assignments:

- All earned tokens are first funneled through the class representative.
- The maximum number of front-side tokens that may be distributed is determined by:
  - Total Tokens Earned ÷ Number of Participants
  - Any tokens distributed beyond that limit automatically become back-side tokens

Front-Side Token Rights:

- Front-side eligibility accumulates over time.
- Representatives are free to choose the timing of distribution.

"This rule seriously sucks." Ibuki muttered under her breath.

The distinction between front-side and back-side tokens likely existed to prevent representatives from simply monopolizing all earned tokens and charging toward the Special Reward themselves.

But even with that safeguard in place, the privileges granted to representatives were enormous, far greater than what Urushihara's casual tone implied.

They controlled the distribution of tokens tied to Private Point rewards, and could potentially even avoid expulsion from finishing last.

Urushihara also clarified that indivisible remainders created during division would simply be ignored.

So even if 41 tokens were earned, dividing them among four people would still only create a front-side limit of 10 per class student. The extra one token wouldn't increase the cap at all.

"Now then," Urushihara said, "please discuss among yourselves and decide who will act as representative for each class. If a decision cannot be reached within the allotted time, a vote will be held among the relevant team members."

"So they're intentionally concentrating token control into one person's hands," Sanada said grimly. "From the students' perspective, this rule feels almost entirely disadvantageous."

"Feels like they're trying to provoke infighting," Yoshida added.

In truth, that was likely the case.

At its core, the exam was testing whether classmates could trust one another. And whether the person receiving that trust could actually live up to it.

"I don't know who's going to become the representative," Ibuki said, narrowing her eyes, "but you'd better make sure you hand over my tokens properly."

The rule had already planted distrust in her. Without bothering to hide it, she turned that suspicion directly toward her own Class B teammates.

Katsuragi answered her in his usual calm manner.

"Generally speaking, it shouldn't become a situation where someone tries to bring down another person. And to make sure we don't choose that kind of person as representative, we should decide through a fair method."

In other words, a simple majority vote.

It was the most straightforward and acceptable selection method.

Meanwhile, other classes had begun moving in their own ways.

“I’m thinking I’ll become the representative,” said a sharp, intimidating voice from within the Class A team. “That’s fine, right, Mii-chan?”

The voice belonged to Shinohara.

“A-Y-Yes, I don't mind that, but…”

Mii-chan nodded, looking slightly bewildered, but not particularly inclined to reject Shinohara’s candidacy. She was not the type who liked standing out in front of others. If someone else was willing to take on the role, then perhaps she thought it was better to simply let them do it.

“Mii-chan says she’s fine with it too,” Shinohara said, a confident smile appearing on her face. “So it looks like there’s no problem.”

She acted as though one hesitant opinion had already secured the position for her.

“Um,” Mii-chan said, instinctively speaking up as she realized her single vote was about to be treated as final, “shouldn’t we check with Ike-kun and Kushida-san too—”

But Shinohara paid her no mind.

In this special exam, falling to the bottom in token count was directly tied to expulsion. When one thought several moves ahead, there was still reason to question whether Shinohara or Ike, for that matter, should be chosen so easily as representative.

Kushida likely understood that as well. Precisely because she did, she must have recognized that allowing herself to be swept along like Mii-chan would be nothing short of risky.

The brief silence that fell over Class A was heavy and delicately long, one that couldn't easily blend into the surrounding conversations from the other classes.

Before anyone could even voice opposition, the atmosphere had already shifted.

Mii-chan glanced once between Kushida and Shinohara before quickly lowering her eyes again.

Maybe she simply wasn't used to being put in a position where her judgment mattered.

Or maybe she understood exactly how much weight a single opinion carried right now.

Either way, she showed no sign of answering decisively.

Shinohara, meanwhile, didn't miss even that tiny hesitation.

Even before the discussion had properly concluded, she prioritized steering the momentum toward herself.

She held her gaze without wavering, applying quiet pressure that left little room to escape.

Riding that wave of momentum she shifted her attention to Kushida without hesitation.

"So what is it, Kushida-san?" Shinohara asked. "You don't want me as the representative? Would it be inconvenient for you if I took the role?"

It was phrased like a question, but in reality the range of acceptable answers had already been narrowed down.

If Kushida answered yes, friction would immediately erupt.

If she answered no, then she would effectively be conceding the position.

By forcing that binary choice onto her, Shinohara was clearly trying to seize control of the conversation from the get go.

"Um… well… it's not that there'd be any inconvenience or anything," Kushida replied carefully, "but actually, I was thinking about volunteering too…"

She asserted her intentions in a modest, yet firm manner.

However, upon hearing those words, Shinohara's expression stiffened in apparent dissatisfaction.

“Why?” she asked. “Is it because you don’t trust me?”

“No, it’s not like that,” Kushida answered without missing a beat. “ I just intended to run from the very beginning."

“Hmm?” Shinohara let out a small laugh. “Because honestly, it kinda feels like I’m not being trusted here.”

Kushida faltered for only a moment beneath the pressure.

Even so, she still pushed back.

“But if you put it that way…” she answered carefully, “doesn’t that also mean *you* don’t trust *me*, Shinohara-san?”

Though Kushida seemed somewhat bewildered and overwhelmed by her intensity, she still didn't stop arguing back.

“Ehh? It’s not like that though—”

Shinohara smiled faintly, almost amused.

Then her voice rose slightly.

“But Kushida-san… do you seriously think people can trust you unconditionally?”

The surrounding groups had not started paying attention yet.

But if the conversation escalated any further, it would inevitably draw eyes and ears from nearby.

“I… I do try my best to earn people’s trust,” Kushida answered. “That’s exactly why I thought it’d be better not to place an unnecessary burden on you, Shinohara-san.”

With other classes in the mix, Kushida had no choice but to continue playing the role of the usual cheerful, considerate Kushida.

And Shinohara understood that perfectly.

Which was exactly why she could afford to press forward so aggressively.

“Burden? What do you mean by that?”

“Managing all the tokens sounds like a hassle,” Kushida explained gently. “Even if it’s called a representative, it’s basically just becoming the class errand runner. I thought it might be better if I handled it instead.”

“It’s not a hassle at all,” Shinohara shot back immediately. “So don’t worry about me, Kushida-san. Just leave it to me.”

Then Kushida turned slightly.

“Mii-chan… what do you think?”

The question sounded almost like a plea for help.

But before Mii-chan, caught painfully between the two of them, could even open her mouth, Shinohara’s expression darkened with irritation.

“You heard her agree to leave it to me, didn’t you?” Shinohara pressed immediately. “So why are you asking again? You really *don’t* trust me after all, do you?”

“No, that’s not it,” Kushida answered gently. “I just wanted to properly confirm everyone’s opinion…”

“Then why don’t you ask Kanji too?”

Shinohara gave a small snort as she turned toward Ike, utterly convinced he would side with her.

“Mm… Ike-kun, what do you think?”

Closing the distance slightly, Kushida looked up at him with an almost pleading gaze.

“Huh? Well, I mean…”

The moment Kushida turned those eyes on him, Ike’s composure vanished. Even though everyone in the class had seen her true nature, Kushida was still an angel on the surface. When she looked at him as though she were relying on him, his cheeks reddened almost instantly.

“Well, Kikyō-cha—uh, I mean Kushida wouldn’t be bad at all either, yeah.”

“Hey, Kanji…?”

Shinohara’s mood soured at once. Apparently displeased by his unexpected reaction, she grabbed his left ear and pulled hard.

"Ow, ow-ow-ow! That hurts, Satsuki!"

“Tell me honestly.” Shinohara’s voice was sweet only in shape. “Between me and Kushida-san, who is better suited to be representative?”

“Of course, of course!”

Still crying out in pain, Ike hurriedly corrected course.

"I-It's safe to just leave it to Satsuki!"

Subjected to Shinohara’s openly suspicious stare, Ike chose the answer that let him escape with the least damage.

“So there you have it,” Shinohara said, turning back to Kushida with a satisfied look. “That’s fine, right, Kushida-san?”

“Understood,” Kushida said after a small pause. “Yeah. If everyone is fine with that, then I’m fine with it too.”

She likely harboured immense dissatisfaction.

But Shinohara and Ike already controlled two votes. Even if Kushida persisted and somehow managed to pull Mii-chan to her side, the result would only be a split vote, and the representative still would not be decided. Worse, after rejecting Shinohara this strongly, provoking her any further would be a poor move.

Kushida had no choice but to step back.

Of course, at this point, neither Shinohara nor Ike were likely planning to cheat Kushida or Mii-chan through token management. Their intentions were probably still ordinary enough.

But that was only because they had not yet been pushed into a corner.

If, from here on, they failed to increase their tokens as planned, or if they began losing them, then the authority Shinohara held as representative could grow stronger, and more difficult to control.

Once again, it became clear just how important the role of representative truly was.

There were probably almost no current third-years who could not see at least that much.

And that was precisely why Kushida, more than anyone, would have to move with extreme caution from this point forward.

"Looks like they ended up choosing Shinohara over there," Yoshida murmured after quietly listening in on the exchange. "Well, if you're someone at risk of expulsion, wanting to become the representative is only natural. On the other hand, for someone like Wang or Kushida, this has to be a headache."

His analysis was calm and matter-of-fact.

"So what should *we* do for now?" Yoshida continued, stepping closer and lowering his voice. "We're making you the representative, right?"

"You're willing to follow my lead?"

“Of course.” Yoshida answered without hesitation. “I was sweating a little during the Survival Game Special Exam when it looked like we might lose, but in the end we finished exactly where you planned, second place. Hard to complain about that.”

He shrugged lightly.

“And besides, you’re the leader for this exam. Ideally we want this group taking first place.”

Standing beside him, Sanada nodded immediately in agreement.

“Then I presume that makes me the Representative, yes?” Morishita concluded.

“You can ignore this one,” Yoshida said bluntly, jerking a thumb toward her. “She’s not the type to step forward anyway.”

Morishita stood with her arms folded, nodding repeatedly to herself as though she alone had reached some profound conclusion.

“I believe Morishita-san understands as well,” Sanada added, smoothing over the moment with calm politeness, “that among us, entrusting this to Ayanokōji-kun is the best option.”

It felt like they were deliberately putting me on a pedestal, but I didn't pay it much mind.

“One final confirmation,” I said. “You’re really fine with leaving this to me? Once I become the representative, I’ll be able to distribute the tokens we earn however I like. I might act to protect myself.”

Yoshida looked at me as if the answer was obvious.

“You're the weirdo who willingly dropped down from Class A, right, Ayanokōji? If you pull a stunt like betraying us just to save yourself, you wouldn't be able to stay as the class leader anymore, at the very least. That's why we trust you, or rather, your position which won't allow for such selfishness.”

That was Yoshida's reasoning for accepting me as representative.

Sanada nodded again, showing that he agreed.

Their attitude did not come from blind faith. They had already resolved themselves to the fact that if they could not place complete trust in me, the class would never rise again.

"I, for one, certainly do not trust you," Morishita declared. "But very well, let us treat this as a test to see if you are truly fit to reign over our class."

"Understood," I said. "If Yoshida and Sanada are willing to place that responsibility in my hands, then I'll fulfill the role properly."

I informed Urushihara that I would be serving as Class C's representative, then waited for the remaining teams to finish making their decisions.

In the end, Class A selected Shinohara as representative.

Class B settled on Katsuragi. Ibuki looked far from pleased with the result, but since the remaining two supported him, the decision was effectively made.

As for Class D, Amikura assumed the representative role without the slightest dispute.

Compared to the distorted power balance festering inside Class A, the other selections were probably more or less reasonable.

"So you *are* going to divide the tokens fairly, right?" Ibuki demanded immediately, glaring at Katsuragi.

"Of course," Katsuragi replied calmly. "Although I cannot guarantee that my definition of fairness matches yours."

"Hah? What's *that* supposed to mean?"

"This is still a special exam," he answered evenly. "I am merely the one entrusted with managing the class's collective tokens. I intend to distribute them fairly according to contribution. Those who produce results will receive rewards appropriate to their efforts. Those who hold the group back will receive only the minimum necessary."

He held Ibuki's gaze without flinching.

"If you want enough tokens to avoid expulsion, then contribute to the class."

"Tch... fine."

A very Katsuragi-like policy.

His equality was not equal shares for all. It was fairness measured by evaluation, with token distribution tied directly to contribution. Whether one liked it or not, the logic was consistent.

Amikura, on the other hand, seemed to be taking the opposite approach.

For her team, performance was irrelevant. Any tokens earned by the four of them would be divided evenly among the four.

That, too, was a form of equality.

Because there was already trust between them, and because each student's abilities were relatively well balanced, there was likely no room for conflict to arise.

Then there was Shinohara, the representative of Class A.

On the surface, her stance was the same as Amikura's: equal distribution among all members. But the conditions beneath that statement were entirely different. In terms of ability, Kushida and Mii-chan clearly held a far greater advantage over Shinohara.

In other words, Shinohara was using the authority of the representative role to create a version of equality that favored her own side.

Part 1

With the representatives from all four classes assembled, the supervisor stepped forward to address us.

“Now then, without further ado, we will have you begin the individual category tasks,” he announced. “You have a maximum of sixty minutes to deliberate and decide by majority vote where this group will travel first, choosing from a list of candidate locations. Once everyone agrees to proceed, you will cast your vote via your smartwatches and then head out to the winning destination,” he paused.

“As for the rewards: any student who votes for the destination with the most votes will receive one token. If the vote is unanimous, everyone will receive two. Those who vote for a location other than the majority will receive three tokens. Finally, in the event that a destination receives exactly one vote, that lone voter will be rewarded with five tokens.”

So, our first task was simply to decide Group 3’s destination.

“A word of warning before you begin your discussions,” the supervisor continued. “If there is a tie for the most votes, meaning multiple locations receive the highest number of votes, the students who voted for those tied locations will receive zero tokens. In such a scenario, we will randomly select your destination from among the tied options.”

In short, it was a system that guaranteed a payout of tokens for everyone, provided there wasn't a tie for first place.

“We will not disclose who voted for which location under any circumstances. Furthermore, showing your watch’s screen to others while voting is strictly prohibited. Please be aware that any such violations will incur a separate penalty resulting in the loss of tokens.”

If we knew who was voting for what in real time, coordinating our choices would be far too easy. This strict anonymity was likely a necessary measure to prevent exactly that.

Having briskly wrapped up his explanation, Urushihara, our assigned supervisor, read the list of candidate destinations aloud.

“There are five candidate locations for your first destination: B9, E12, F14, I10, and I13. Regardless of which area you choose, the contents of your upcoming tasks will remain exactly the same. However, any time spent traveling to your next destination is simply time wasted, so please keep that in mind.”

Sanada unfolded the map provided with our materials, immediately checking the coordinates.

The available options were scattered across the grid, ranging from relatively close spots to those a fair distance away. Some even looked like they would require considerable effort to reach.

“I will now start the timer,” Urushihara said, checking his smartwatch without a moment’s delay. “You are free to begin your discussion.”

Reacting naturally, our group of sixteen shifted into a circle so that we could all see each other’s faces.

“It's obvious a nearby place is best for this. The tasks won't change, either,” Sonoda from Class B muttered, sounding more like he was thinking out loud than asking a question.

Catching his words, Ike immediately agreed. “True. Even the teacher—er, the supervisor, just said that travel time is a waste.”

The assertion that closer meant easier was typical of Ike, who despised anything troublesome.

“So we all just vote for the closest area and call it a day? It'd be a quick discussion, and we'd all get two tokens,” Minamikata chimed in.

A unanimous vote for the closest location. It was the first and most obvious choice that came to mind.

While the guarantee that the upcoming task wouldn't change was certainly a solid deciding factor, if we chose a nearby destination based on that alone, there would be no need for this discussion at all.

The school had gone out of its way to give us a lengthy sixty-minute deliberation period. There had to be a meaning behind it, or rather, making us *think* there was a deeper meaning was likely exactly what the school was aiming for.

“Isn't blindly voting for the closest area a bit too simplistic?” Yoshida argued. “There's probably more to this than meets the eye.”

If travel distance was the only difference between the options, no one would ever vote for a faraway spot. Suspecting a trap lay hidden behind such an obvious answer, Yoshida spoke up to rein them in.

“I have to agree,” Katsuragi said, casting a brief glance at Ike and Sonoda. “We should thoroughly examine the other areas first.”

“But... Urushihara-san said the destination and the tasks aren't connected...” Morofuji muttered from her spot beside Katsuragi.

“In that case, we may need to consider factors outside of the tasks themselves,” Katsuragi replied. “We cannot blindly proceed without first verifying which destination will provide the greatest benefit to our group.”

“Isn't that just a waste of time?” Sumida retorted. “This task is centered around the exchange of tokens. I think ‘closer is better’ is a perfectly fine answer.”

It seemed the discussion was already beginning to fray.

It was supposed to be a simple vote to decide our next destination, yet reaching a consensus wasn't going to be easy.

"The supervisor called this an individual battle, didn't he? Does that mean we're supposed to outmaneuver each other through the voting process?"

Sanada turned to me as he asked the question.

"That's undoubtedly one of the core mechanics, yeah," I replied.

"A unanimous vote yields a solid reward of two tokens, but it's certainly not the highest payout," Sanada noted.

It was a natural progression for the majority of the students to favor a nearby location as their destination. Consequently, the votes were bound to concentrate there. While a unanimous choice would distribute tokens equally among all sixteen participants, a calculated betrayal guaranteed a far more lucrative payout for the defector. To make matters worse, such a betrayal would slash the payout of the majority voters down to a single token. And if multiple defectors emerged, it opened the door for opportunists to secure three or five tokens under the safety of complete anonymity.

"It's a simple but troublesome task," Sonoda muttered again, several students nodding in agreement. "Our overall motives align, but the reward system actively discourages us from cooperating."

The optimal strategy was to avoid voting for the desired destination yourself, while persuading others into voting for it instead.

"Wait, isn't this impossible?" someone argued. "Nobody is going to want to waste their vote on the closest place."

Exactly. Everyone agreed that a shorter distance was better. But if prioritizing that convenience meant settling for just one token, people would inevitably be tempted to secure three or five tokens instead, not caring if they had to walk further as a result.

"But... if everyone thinks like that, all the votes will end up going to the distant places instead, right?" Mii-chan pointed out, having apparently foreseen the logical conclusion of that train of thought.

“If we all avoid the shortest route and vote for the distant ones, then a distant location will get the most votes? Man, that won't work either.”

In a space where friend and foe were jumbled together, the students exchanged probing glances, sizing each other up.

An uncomfortable silence fell over the group. Ten or twenty seconds passed, and just as it seemed the heavy atmosphere would drag on, Katsuragi quietly broke the silence.

“Engaging in a clumsy battle of wits will only breed suspicion,” he said calmly. “If we end up casting our votes blindly, then just as Wang pointed out, we run the risk of earning no tokens while being forced to march a long distance. The simplest way to handle this is to keep our discussion to a minimum, prioritize cooperation above all else, and unanimously vote for the closest area. We might not maximize our token earnings, but it guarantees an outcome, and a travel distance, that everyone can be satisfied with.”

Naturally, the majority of the group wasn’t going to just nod along and agree to Katsuragi’s proposal immediately. Katsuragi himself was fully aware of that, of course. It was safe to say he had simply offered a baseline argument to kickstart the real discussion.

“That might be true, but in order to guarantee the most votes, we need at least nine people to vote for the same spot,” Ike argued. “Are you seriously suggesting we just hand over three or five tokens to the remaining seven people?”

“Tokens can be transferred,” Katsuragi countered calmly. “We could agree to pool our winnings and distribute them evenly afterward.”

“You’ve gotta be kidding me,” Ike shot back. “If tokens end up with someone from another class, there’s zero guarantee they’ll actually hand them over. The voting is strictly anonymous, which means someone is definitely going to pull a fast one on us. Take Ayanokōji, for example... Yeah, someone exactly like Ayanokōji!” he continued, turning his gaze toward me. “You’re absolutely gunning for the five-token payout, aren’t you?”

Just as Katsuragi had predicted, his proposal acted as the spark that ignited a flurry of opposition, with Ike fiercely leading the charge.

Since he was glaring in my direction and calling me out by name, I met his gaze, if only to acknowledge him.

“Seems like your attitude has gotten even worse since you betrayed our class,” Ike sneered. “I mean, anyone who transfers from Class A to a lower class just because they think they’re a little smart is crazy to begin with.”

Ever since our groups merged, Ike hadn’t stopped complaining about my attitude. I was perfectly fine letting it slide without offering a rebuttal, but Katsuragi stepped in to answer on my behalf.

“You are free to think whatever you want about transferring to a lower class,” Katsuragi said, crossing his arms and narrowing his eyes sharply. “But if stepping down to a lower class makes someone crazy, then I suppose I am crazy as well.”

Realizing he had just caught Katsuragi in the crossfire, Ike awkwardly averted his gaze.

The fallout from this exchange didn't stop at just the two of them; it cast a faintly heavy atmosphere over the students from Class C. Yoshida and the others used to be Katsuragi's allies, and now that he was their enemy after a long series of twists and turns, they likely harbored some complicated feelings about the matter.

Unable to bear the suddenly tense mood, Moriyama from Class D stepped in to mediate. “Let's all calm down for a second. I think cooperating like Katsuragi suggested is a valid option. It's the most straightforward approach, right?”

“But isn't the whole problem that we *can't* do that?” Shinohara retorted. “Neither Kanji nor I want to throw our votes away on the most popular choice.”

“Yeah, exactly!” Ike chimed in, vehemently backing up her protest.

“Of course, anyone would feel that way,” Sumida reasoned. “But if we just dig our heels in, we'll get nowhere. We need to figure out where we can compromise and find a balanced voting strategy first. There might be a solution we can all accept.”

“Sumida's right,” another agreed. “The total number of tokens we get as a group undoubtedly changes depending on how we vote. The real question is, what kind of voting patterns are actually on the table?”

Assuming we could control everyone's votes, the group was starting to realize that the distribution method directly impacted our total payout. Seeing this, I lightly raised my hand before speaking up.

“A simple, unanimous vote yields two tokens each,” I explained. “That’s a total payout of 32 tokens. However, if we intentionally scatter our votes, there are six different patterns that yield the absolute maximum payout of 40 tokens. For example, Pattern 1 would be 7 votes, 6 votes, and three 1-vote destinations. Pattern 2 would be 6 votes, 5 votes, 3 votes, and two 1-vote destinations, and so on. Regardless of which of the six patterns we use, the maximum yield remains capped at 40.”

I paused for a moment before delivering the optimal strategy. “Out of all six patterns, the easiest one to coordinate is a 4-3-3-3-3 split. We send exactly one person from each of the four classes to vote for the top destination, giving it a winning total of 4 votes. The remaining twelve people divide into groups of three and vote for the other four destinations.”

That would yield eight more tokens than a unanimous vote, which wasn't a bad deal for any of the classes involved.

“The only drawback,” I continued, “is that dividing 40 tokens by 16 people equals 2.5, meaning an even distribution on an individual level is impossible. However, we *can* divide the class cuts equally, giving each of the four classes exactly 10 tokens to distribute amongst themselves.”

Purely in terms of efficiency, this was the absolute optimal solution. Of course, regardless of the pattern, the hurdle of actually pulling it off was anything but low.

“You're incredibly fast at calculating all that, Ayanokōji,” Katsuragi said, clearly impressed. A few other students agreed, clapping their hands in an exaggerated show of admiration.

“You didn't have to go out of your way to explain every little detail. I could've figured out the patterns right away,” Ike muttered defensively. “No need to act so smug just because you can do a little math in your head. I mean, are you even sure that's right? Are you really that confident?”

“Yeah. The math is correct,” I said flatly.

“...Listen to him, so completely sure of himself. It'll be damn embarrassing if you're wrong after all that.” Ike clearly wanted me to be wrong. He started counting on his fingers, but almost immediately abandoned the effort.

"Honestly, you *do* sound pretty arrogant, Ayanokōji-kun," Shinohara chimed in, rushing to defend Ike. Her tone shifted from angry to exasperated. "You never used to give off this kind of impression. You always just seemed... harmless. Did becoming a leader change you, or did you just stop hiding your true colors?"

The rest of the group looked back and forth between me and Shinohara's clique.

The old me would've preferred not to rock the boat; I would have likely just ignored her remarks and let it slide. But this time, I decided to take the bait.

"Maybe so," I said flatly. "My previous class was quite uncomfortable, after all."

"Wow, he actually just said that out loud. You really do have a terrible attitude," Shinohara scoffed, her face twisting in disgust.

Faced with my unyielding, unapologetic stance, it wasn't just Mii-chan and Kushida who looked rattled; even my new classmates, like Yoshida, showed obvious signs of agitation.

"Hey, shouldn't you dial it back a little?" Yoshida whispered, his face twitching slightly.

"There's no need to worry. I'm just speaking my mind."

"No, man, that's exactly the problem..." he trailed off.

The hostile atmosphere lingered in the air, thick and unresolved. But Katsuragi, who had likely been quietly verifying my math in his head the entire time, gave a deep nod and stepped back into the conversation.

“It seems his calculations are indeed correct,” Katsuragi announced. “Splitting the five destinations into a 4-3-3-3-3 pattern is a solid strategy. We cannot avoid competing within the group eventually, but if there's a way for everyone to earn tokens at maximum efficiency right now, I see great merit in taking advantage of it. The most important thing is for each of us to increase our token count and avoid dropping to the bottom of the school year.”

Katsuragi had fully understood the core policy of ‘earn while you can’ and actively embraced it.

“I guess I agree too,” Sonoda said. “The only reason someone would break ranks and try to outsmart everyone else is to squeeze out an extra token or two, right? But honestly, I don’t think the risk is worth it. Splitting the votes would only increase the chances of a tie. Once you realize that, even someone planning to defect would understand that securing a reliable ten tokens for the class is the smarter choice, wouldn’t they?”

Clearly eager to maintain harmony, Sonoda once again expressed his support for cooperation. The true brilliance of this 4-3-3-3-3 strategy lay in the fact that votes would be cast for every single destination. Because every location would receive a minimum of three votes, even if one person decided to play the traitor, it would be mathematically impossible for them to snatch up the five-token reward reserved for a solo vote. And even if a group of traitors wanted to coordinate an ambush, pulling off a flawless conspiracy using nothing but eye contact in this mixed group would be a Herculean task.

“I still don't like it,” Ike grumbled. “Just going along with a plan pushed by Ayanokōji rubs me the wrong way.”

“There is no need for baseless suspicion,” Katsuragi replied firmly. “I ran the numbers several times myself, and Ayanokōji's pattern and projected results are entirely correct. Rather than complain, you should look at the bright side: by providing us with a conclusion faster, he has saved us valuable time that we can now allocate to discussing the actual execution.”

The realization that this distribution method offered the highest efficiency had finally sunk in for everyone. However, understanding the logic and agreeing to execute it were two different things.

“Yeah, I fundamentally agree. Don't you?”

“It's a hundred times better than voting blindly without a plan. I'm in.”

As expected, Class D was straightforward; they weren't the type to oppose a proposal that clearly benefited the majority.

Seizing the moment, I turned my gaze toward Yoshida and Sanada. “Now that you've heard the discussion so far, have you made up your minds?”

“If I had to choose, I'm in favor of the four classes getting ten tokens each,” Yoshida replied. “If our opinions split, we risk getting zero tokens in the worst-case scenario. Plus, this setup seems like a solid deterrent against betrayal, right?”

Following Yoshida's lead, the two of them offered no resistance, clearly leaning toward the most efficient strategy. Curiously, Morishita, who was usually loud enough to be a nuisance, remained completely silent.

Having secured Class C's agreement with a light nod, Katsuragi next turned to his own Class B to solicit their opinions.

“I-I feel like it's better than aiming for an uncertain unanimous vote...”

“As long as it guarantees me tokens, I'm fine with it,” Ibuki added bluntly.

While perhaps not as enthusiastic as Class D or C, Ibuki and the others expressed a relatively agreeable stance.

Now, the only ones left were Class A, which included Ike and Shinohara, who had been the most vocal in their opposition.

“I’d like to hear Kushida and Mii-chan’s opinions on the matter, too,” I said.

“H-hey, hold on a second,” Ike stammered, stepping forward. “Between you ignoring our greetings earlier and now this, you’re purposely leaving Satsuki and me out of the loop, aren’t you?”

“It’s for the exact same reason I didn't greet you,” I replied flatly. “My bad, but I have no desire to seek opinions from either of you.”

“Are you seriously saying that right now, Ayanokōji?” Ike snapped. “You know this is a group task, right? Stop doing things that are just gonna cause a split among us! Weren't we just talking about everyone cooperating?”

It was a perfectly sound argument that left little room for rebuttal, and the rest of the group began to show obvious sympathy for Ike's position.

Seeing Ike clench his fists in agitation, Shinohara gently grasped his hand, mindful of the stares from the rest of the group.

“Kanji, let's be the adults here,” she urged softly. “I was definitely hurt when he ignored us earlier, but you said it yourself: this is a group battle, right? Fighting over pointless things will only drag us down.”

“But still...!”

“I got a little worked up too, but wasn't it partly your fault, Kanji? You were the one provoking Ayanokōji-kun, saying he couldn't be trusted. Am I wrong?”

“...Well... I guess...”

Though his anger hadn't completely subsided, Ike's resentment softened slightly at Shinohara's gentle reprimand.

“...Yeah, you're right. ...I get it.”

Forcing himself to swallow his pride by saying it aloud, Ike slowly unclenched his fists. He gave a stiff, slight bow of his head and desperately pasted a bright expression onto his face.

“Earlier, how should I put it... look, my bad for saying things that made it sound like I doubted you. Of course you'd get mad over that... For now, I agree that making sure all the classes get an equal share of tokens is the way to go. So, as a way to test our trust in each other, let's just try to get along this once.”

Having regained his composure, Ike extended an olive branch. Shinohara nodded, clearly ready to second his attempt at making peace.

Looking back to when we first enrolled, it was clear that Ike and Shinohara had grown mentally, albeit unsteadily. I had noticed it even during the greeting stage. To think they would brush off my blatant rudeness and actively try to compromise with me again. Moreover, it wasn't just surface-level posturing; even if they had to force it, they genuinely seemed to be convincing themselves to let bygones be bygones for the sake of the group.

I could sense a palpable wave of welcome relief from Yoshida and my other classmates standing beside me.

I turned my gaze toward Ike and Shinohara to give them my answer.

“I agree with aligning our voting intentions,” I said coldly. “But unfortunately, I simply cannot trust either of you.”

Without a shred of hesitation, I shattered the fragile peace their goodwill had just created, freezing the atmosphere instantly.

“Wha—”

Before Ike even had a chance to react, the tentative smile on Shinohara's face hardened into a mask of shock. The rest of the group stared at me, their initial astonishment quickly morphing into blatant dissatisfaction at my unapologetic hostility.

“Ayanokōji, I feel that is going a bit too far,” Katsuragi interjected. “I don't know what happened between you as former classmates, but there is absolutely no merit in making an enemy of Class A here.”

“He's right, Ayanokōji,” another student agreed. “No matter how you look at it, you're the one in the wrong here. It's just plain immature.”

“I have no intention of making enemies of them,” I replied calmly. “However, if we want this discussion to proceed smoothly, it's meaningless unless the right people step forward. As long as Shinohara and Ike uselessly intrude as the representatives of Class A, any discussion we hold is just a waste of time. For a task focused on dialogue, the natural choice is to have Kushida lead the talks, with Mii-chan advising her as an assistant. If we take that approach, we can trust each other and progress smoothly.”

My implication was clear: those two needed to know their place and step back like the supporting characters they were.

“You... are seriously pissing me off, Ayanokōji!”

Ike once again clenched his fists, ready to lunge forward, but Shinohara tightly grabbed his shoulder to hold him back.

Unlike earlier, however, Shinohara looked as though she had reached the absolute limit of her patience.

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?” she demanded, her voice trembling. “Are you saying we shouldn't even be allowed to speak? Isn't that completely unfair? Did we say something so horrible that you have to treat us like this?”

“I... well, I also think Ayanokōji-kun's remarks were entirely out of line,” said Sanada, stepping in front of me, with a grim expression on his face.

“All sixteen of us have an equal right to speak, and just as Shinohara-san said, I don't think there was any particular problem with the two of them. Isn't this completely uncharacteristic behavior for you, Ayanokōji-kun?”

“I have to agree. I can't defend you on this one,” Yoshida added, shaking his head.

It seemed all of my new Class C peers were harboring the exact same negative feelings toward me.

“Honestly, this whole thing makes me anxious,” Shinohara said, staring at me. “Even when we tried to compromise, you threw that attitude in our faces. If you keep creating this toxic environment, there’s no guarantee your plan will actually work out. The upcoming vote is strictly anonymous, meaning if someone actually does betray us, we won’t be able to pinpoint who it was. Doesn't this whole strategy fall apart if there are people from other classes we can't trust?”

Her eyes were faintly moist, and despite her defiant glare, it was as if she was trying to hide how deeply my words had hurt her.

“I don't think I'm making a difficult demand,” I replied. “If you just let Kushida and Mii-chan take the lead, things will proceed smoothly.”

No matter how much it worsened their impression of me, I reiterated my stance.

“You just pick on us out of nowhere and make whatever demands you want... Isn't that a waste of time too!?” Ike shouted.

“Ah... I see. So that's how it is. Fine, I get it,” Shinohara scoffed. “Let's just do what he wants, Kanji. Kushida-san is definitely a good girl, after all. She's a great talker, and she's cute.”

Throwing in the towel, Shinohara gave up, deciding I was no longer worth arguing with.

“Anyway, we'll leave this task to you. Can we count on you, Kushida-san?”

“M-Me...?” Kushida blinked.

“Well, it's what Ayanokōji-kun wants. Apparently, we aren't capable of moving the discussion forward ourselves.”

“Y-Yeah, I'm fine with taking the lead, but... Ayanokōji-kun, I think you should apologize to those two first. I want us all to cooperate on good terms, you know—”

Kushida was making it clear that cooperation would be difficult if I maintained the hostile attitude I'd used to force Ike and Shinohara to back down. For the sake of proceeding smoothly, this was probably the right time to pull back.

“Understood. It's true that I went a little too far. Kushida is right.”

“What the hell? When Kushida-san tells you to, you just apologize, just like that?” Shinohara snapped.

“That's not it. Looking back on it, she simply made me realize my mistake.”

“...I highly doubt that. It didn't look that way to me...” Shinohara muttered. “Well, fine. Whatever.”

Rather than forgiving me, she replied coldly out of pure exasperation, clearly done talking to me.

“My bad,” I added.

At my brief apology, Shinohara merely snorted. She grabbed Ike by the arm and pulled him a step back, distancing themselves slightly from the circle.

“So, we've accepted Ayanokōji-kun's *heartfelt* apology. Kanji and I will step back now. Though, of course, if we have something to say later, we'll still say it.”

“Sorry, Kikyō-chan. We're leaving this to you,” Ike added.

“No, don't worry about it at all. I'm not sure how reliable I'll be, but I'll do my best,” Kushida replied with a cute smile.

Seeing her gentle demeanor, Ike's angry expression finally softened a little.

“Oh, right! Why don't you suggest a good idea, Kushida-san?” Shinohara prompted. “It'd be best if we had some sort of risk management method to prevent betrayers from popping up, right?”

It was a pointed remark from Shinohara. Was that jab aimed at me, the person who had been grating on her nerves this whole time? Or was it aimed at Kushida, my former class's *other* traitor? Either way, the group's gaze naturally gathered on Kushida. Looking slightly troubled, she began to think.

“Let's see...” Kushida started. “We can't prevent betrayal completely, but we can lower the risk by making sure we can narrow down exactly *who* betrayed us. If we publicly announce and assign exactly who will vote for which destination in advance, we'll be able to narrow down the suspects if a discrepancy occurs in the final results.”

Kushida explained that, for example, if we agreed on a 4-3-3-3-3 split but the actual result came out as 4-2-3-3-4, it would definitively prove that one of the three students assigned to the second destination had betrayed the group.

“Umm, something like that anyway. I hope my logic is right, but... I don't really have a lot of confidence in it,” she added, looking perplexed as she lightly scratched her cheek with her index finger.

“For a spur-of-the-moment idea, I'd say it's not bad,” I noted. “What do you think of Kushida's proposal, Katsuragi?”

By passing the conversational baton to Katsuragi, I forcefully shifted the dynamic away from the 'Ayanokōji vs. Class A' narrative that had been dominating the air.

“I agree as well,” Katsuragi replied. “It is certainly a measure we should implement. Though, of course, it cannot be said to be foolproof.”

Although Kushida had likely just come up with the idea on the spot, she didn't say anything to undermine it, obediently nodding along instead. After all, there was no point in obsessing over catching a betrayer with absolute certainty. As long as the voting remained anonymous, finding a workable compromise within those constraints was far more important.

“Just the fact that it increases our chances of narrowing down a betrayer serves as a massive deterrent,” Katsuragi concluded.

“Hey,” Ibuki interjected, her brows furrowing slightly. “With the plan you just laid out, there are definitely going to be four people forced to vote for the most popular destination, right?”

“That's what it comes down to, yes,” Katsuragi replied immediately. “They'll be allocated evenly, one per class. By sending exactly one person from each class to the four-vote destination, the burden remains equal. That way, the loss isn't being pushed onto any single group.”

“You say ‘equal,’ but the guys voting for the top destination are only going to receive one token. That means they're temporarily taking a loss, right?” Ibuki challenged. “Assuming this plan even works, is there actually a guarantee that the tokens will be split with them later?”

“Of course,” Katsuragi nodded. “However, as we've already established, each class will earn a total of ten tokens. Even if you distribute them evenly, giving two to each of the four members in your class, that leaves two tokens left over. How to handle those leftovers will be up to each individual class to decide.”

Hearing Katsuragi's explanation, Ibuki paused for a beat.

“Whatever. But just so we're clear, I'm voting for one of the places that pays out three tokens.”

She made her stance clear, lightly sweeping her gaze to the side.

It was true. If all the classes kept in step with the plan, one out of the four people from each class would have to cast their vote for the most popular destination, meaning that at the moment of the vote, they would only receive one token. Her blunt remark meant that if there was no hard guarantee the tokens would actually be shared later, she wanted to be on the side obtaining three tokens from the very start.

Hating the idea of taking on a risky role, Ibuki had clearly stated her refusal.

“Ah, then I call dibs on one of the three-token spots, too,” Ike quickly jumped in, still standing toward the back. “I trust my friends and all, but I don't want to get wrapped up in any trouble. No point taking on unnecessary risks, right?”

Piggybacking off Ibuki's declaration, Ike made it clear that he had no intention of falling on his sword for the top destination either.

The atmosphere of the place shifted, just slightly.

“Since we won't know who voted for what, someone could easily play dumb and keep their extra tokens later,” Shinohara continued, crossing her arms. “Even if you argue it's fine because the class as a whole still gets ten tokens, there's obviously going to be a difference on an individual level. Whether or not someone actually compensates you for taking that loss is a separate issue, isn't it?”

Though she framed it as a general observation, her gaze was faintly sharp.

Katsuragi shot a brief glance in Shinohara's direction.

“Ibuki and Shinohara are exactly right,” Katsuragi declared, jumping in without missing a beat. “This task is premised on the results at the class level. Since there is no mechanism to guarantee perfect fairness between individuals, a guarantee of trust is absolutely necessary. Any student who feels anxious about getting properly compensated should take the initiative, self-declare their intent, and secure one of the spots paying out three tokens. I will take on the burden of voting for the most popular destination for Class B.”

We only needed one person from each class to shoulder the risk, allowing the other three to safely secure at least two tokens. Acting decisively, Katsuragi stepped forward to be the first volunteer.

“I'll do it for Class C,” I said, turning to Yoshida and the others as the second volunteer. Amikura from Class D immediately followed suit.

Now, only Class A remained. With Ike having already explicitly refused the role, all eyes naturally fell on the other three members.

“If possible, I recommend having Ike or Shinohara take on the role,” I added casually.

Hearing my unnecessary remark, Shinohara furrowed her brows. Our dispute had supposedly been put to rest after my earlier apology, but my words threatened to reignite the issue.

Seeing this, Yoshida stepped in. “Hey, what Class A does is for Class A to decide.”

“You're right,” I replied. “Just ignore what I said.”

“No, I can't just 'ignore it,'” Shinohara snapped. “You've been spouting baseless claims that we can't be trusted, talking down to us as if we don't even belong in a discussion! What on earth is your deal? Did we do something to you, Ayanokōji-kun?”

“I'm not targeting you two specifically,” I replied smoothly. “I simply believe that people who lack the trust of the group should take the initiative to act in a way that *earns* that trust.”

“Then let me ask you this: what about Ibuki-san?” Shinohara shot back, pointing an accusatory finger. “Ibuki-san explicitly refused to take on the role, yet you completely ignored that! Shouldn't you be forcing her to vote for the top spot instead of Katsuragi-kun?”

Unexpectedly dragged into the crossfire, Ibuki glared at Shinohara, making no effort to hide her irritation.

“Class B's internal dynamics are slightly complicated,” I explained calmly. “While I believe Katsuragi is a highly trustworthy individual, from Class B's perspective, he is still a transfer student who joined their ranks midway. Stepping up of his own volition to build up trust with his new classmates isn't a bad move on his part.”

“I still don't buy it...” Shinohara muttered.

“To begin with, the situation is entirely different from Class A's. If I were still a student in that class, voting for the primary destination and walking away with a single token wouldn't cause me a moment's hesitation. The reason is simple: as long as Kushida is an ally, I would have an absolute guarantee that she would distribute tokens to cover the deficit afterward. Even if I were intent on securing three tokens, should Kushida fail to provide two, I could simply request them from Mii-chan. In short, there would be absolutely no reason to fear being shortchanged.”

The only people who couldn't be trusted were Ike and Shinohara, the very two who were explicitly scheming to snatch up three tokens for themselves if given the chance.

“Conversely,” I concluded, “not assigning Ike or Shinohara to the top destination is a clear detriment to the group.”

“...Hah. So the reason you're doubting Kanji and me so much is because you care so deeply about Kushida-san and Mii-chan?” Shinohara asked, narrowing her eyes in suspicion.

“They are precious group members,” I replied flatly. “Naturally, I want to cooperate with them in any way I can.”

“I thought this earlier, too, but you are awfully trusting of Kushida-san, aren't you?”

“I am simply stating the facts. If you refuse to accept my assessment, you are free to ask Katsuragi, Sonoda, or anyone else from the other classes. Ask them who they think is more trustworthy: the duo of Shinohara and Ike, or Kushida and Mii-chan.”

“Twenty minutes have passed. Forty minutes remaining.”

The supervisor, who hadn't uttered a single word until now, muttered the time check, a stark reminder that the clock was steadily ticking down.

“We stand to gain very little by succumbing to paranoia right now,” Katsuragi stated firmly, cutting through the tension. “Since the transfer of tokens is allowed, any final adjustments and compensations can be handled after the exam. The problem at hand is making sure our strategy doesn't collapse before we even reach that stage.”

Katsuragi was making it clear: prioritize solving the group's problem first, and handle internal class disputes on your own time.

“I agree. It's better to leave some time on the clock for the actual tasks,” Sumida said with a shrug, showing no hesitation.

Moriyama took a short breath and immediately backed him up. “Likewise. I don't see any point in dragging out useless bargaining right now.”

The members of Class D were practically unanimous. Because the four of them fully trusted one another, this entire debate was likely nothing but a waste of time from their perspective.

“I think it’s about time we moved on,” Sanada said, glancing around the circle before focusing on the final group. “As for the remaining Class A...”

“I am absolutely not doing it,” Shinohara stated flatly.

“I’ll take it on,” Kushida volunteered.

The resolute rejection from Shinohara and the self-sacrificing offer from Kushida overlapped perfectly. At the sheer contrast between their 180-degree different answers, Shinohara shot Kushida a mild glare.

“I just don't want to see everyone arguing anymore...” Kushida added with a reserved smile, officially putting herself forward. “If I can be of use to the group right now, this is the least I can do.”

“Is this acceptable to you, Ayanokōji-kun?” she asked.

“If that's what you want, I won't stop you. Once the tokens are distributed, it becomes an internal class issue,” I replied, reiterating the risk one last time. “Just remember that I won't lift a finger to help when you inevitably argue over the payouts.”

“Tch,” Ike clicked his tongue softly, clearly annoyed by my relentless warnings. “Don't worry, Kikyō-chan. Unlike a certain someone who betrayed his class, I'll absolutely share my tokens with you.”

“Yeah, I completely trust you, Ike-kun. And Shinohara-san and Mii-chan, too, of course.”

The students outside of Class A silently praised Kushida for taking the initiative and shouldering the risk. She seemed entirely genuine when she said she didn't doubt a single person in her class.

Logic and emotion. The gap between the two could never be perfectly bridged. Still, the group managed to move on to the next stage, leaving behind only the faintest lingering friction.

Our next order of business was deciding which of the candidate locations we would actually crown with the most votes and travel to.

“Just to be absolutely clear: the contents of our upcoming tasks are not linked to our destination, correct?” Sanada asked, turning his head toward the supervisor.

Naturally, the supervisor gave no reply. The silence itself was the only confirmation we needed.

“In that case, I believe it's best to consolidate our votes on the closest destination to minimize our stamina consumption,” Sanada proposed to the group. “But if anyone has objections, I'd like to hear them.”

Prompted by Sanada's logic, several students looked back down at the map. There were five candidate destinations, each presenting a distinct set of pros and cons.

Should we choose the closest location? Or should we swallow the travel cost and hike to a further point? At this stage, there simply wasn't enough information to determine a definitively ‘correct’ answer. As a result, each student's personality and thought process bled directly into their opinions.

“I'm good with Sanada's plan,” Sonoda was the first to speak up. Staring down at the map, he offered a frank, pragmatic take, wanting no part in unnecessary fatigue. “This exam is four days and three nights, right? It's obvious we're going to be exhausted by tomorrow. Besides, if we don't even know what the next task is, we should save every bit of stamina we can.”

His words were unvarnished, but they perfectly captured the unspoken feelings of many students present. Setting aside those who had retired early, the sheer fatigue and exhaustion everyone had accumulated from the recent Survival Game Special Exam was no small matter. A distance that looked like a trivial gap on paper could hardly be ignored when actually hiking it on foot.

“I agree, too...” Mii-chan nodded gently. Tracing a spot on the map with her fingertip, she quietly explained her reasoning. “Based purely on the information we currently have, there's very little reason to throw away the obvious advantage of a shorter distance. That holds especially true if the explanation about the destinations not affecting future tasks is accurate.”

Her tone was soft as always, but her stance firmly supported taking the nearest route. She eliminated unnecessary speculation, drawing a logical conclusion based solely on the conditions presented to us. In that regard, her thought process was very similar to Sanada's and Moriyama's.

On the other hand, there were naturally those who refused to simply follow the flow.

“But that's assuming we take the supervisor's words at face value, right?” Sumida said, lifting his gaze from the map. Rather than outright opposition, his voice oozed with caution. “He said the *contents* of the tasks wouldn't change, but he never said the ease of travel or future developments wouldn't be indirectly affected. Isn't it just as dangerous to pick a spot simply because it's close?”

It was a highly plausible point. In fact, during these special exams, looking for loopholes in the rules and doubting the exact wording used by the school was practically second nature. The moment someone voiced that suspicion out loud, the seed of doubt, *the what if,* took root in the group's mind.

“He's right. That sounds exactly like something this school would pull, just like they always do.”

Ike immediately bit onto the idea. Still dragging along some of his lingering hostility from earlier, he quickly hopped onto an argument that suited his sensibilities.

“Going with the closest spot just 'cause it's the normal thing to do is *too* normal, you know? In exams like this, there's always a pattern where the guys who pick the ‘normal’ option end up getting screwed over.”

He didn't have any concrete basis for the claim. However, it was incredibly easy to intuitively agree with him. After all, trying to read between the lines to uncover a hidden trap felt much more fitting for a special exam than simply choosing the most obvious, optimal route.

Katsuragi crossed his arms, dropping his gaze as he pondered the point. “It’s true that we cannot completely rule out a trap. Given the nature of our past special exams, it is perfectly natural to try and read into the rules that aren't explicitly stated.”

It wasn't quite an agreement; it was more like he was leaving the possibility open. Yet, just having one vague affirmation of Ike's paranoia was enough to thin out the prevailing ‘nearest spot only’ atmosphere.

Sumida slid his gaze back to the map. “Be that as it may, if we overthink this, the discussion is going to spiral out of control. As long as distance is the only metric we actually have to compare, any other theory is purely speculation, right?”

Several students nodded silently in agreement with his sharp, dividing logic. It was easy to doubt the rules, but once you started doubting, there was no end to the rabbit hole. What the group needed right now wasn't necessarily the ‘correct’ answer, but a unified standard they could base their votes on.

In that sense, Sumida's words had pulled the group slightly back to reality.

“I...” Kushida spoke up, her voice soft.

She interjected so naturally that it didn't disrupt the flow of the conversation, yet her words carried an undeniable weight.

“I feel like we won't find an answer even if we keep agonizing over things we simply don't know right now. Of course, being cautious is important, but the fact that a closer destination reduces our physical burden is indisputable. If saving stamina gives us more leeway for whatever comes next, I personally think we should prioritize that.”

It was a gentle, tactful way of speaking that rubbed no one the wrong way. She hadn't shut down anyone else's opinion, yet she smoothly steered the conclusion back toward supporting the nearest destination. Her ability to navigate these kinds of social situations was as masterful as ever.

“Well, if Kikyō-chan says so, maybe that's the way to go,” Ike said, his expression immediately softening as he effortlessly abandoned his previous stance.

Shinohara shot him a side-eye but remained silent. No, it was more accurate to say she actively swallowed her words. The look on her face made it clear she didn't want to ruin the mood over something trivial.

Ibuki had been watching the entire exchange with profound boredom, but eventually, she sighed in annoyance and spoke up. “At the end of the day, no one here can actually name a single real benefit to hiking all the way to a distant spot right now, can they? If that's the case, then going to a closer place is fine. If it turns out to be a trap, I'll be pissed, but for now, I'd rather just walk a shorter distance.”

Her argument was rough around the edges, but it was rare for Ibuki to reach a conclusion so quickly. She was clearly exhausted and had zero patience for pointless deliberation.

Sonoda nodded in agreement. “Right. At the very least, using distance as our core metric is the easiest way to move the discussion forward. Even if we can't get everyone to completely agree on the ‘why,’ using the closest spot as our baseline makes it much easier to reach a consensus.”

With that, support for prioritizing a nearby location had grown significantly. Even if it wasn't a flawless, unanimous agreement, the momentum was strong enough to adopt it as our guiding principle.

Of course, the matter wasn't quite simple enough to end there.

Which of the ‘nearby’ places should we choose? And exactly how far were we willing to hike before a location was no longer considered ‘close’? In reality, executing the 4-3-3-3-3 voting distribution across those locations was going to be the real problem.

Taking stock of the room's atmosphere, Yoshida once again pointed to the candidates on the map. “I'm going to sound like a broken record, but are we *really* sure it's that simple? Unlike the Uninhabited Island exam where we were free to roam, there's absolutely no guarantee we'll be allowed to move around freely this time. What if positioning ourselves as close to the center of the island as possible gives us a massive advantage later on?”

“Isn't there also a chance that the further we travel, the better our rewards will be?” Shinohara chimed in.

Everyone wanted to earn tokens efficiently, and they all understood the voting distribution required to make that happen. But as long as the lingering possibility remained that our destination might impact the rest of the special exam, it was only natural for the group's opinions to remain divided.

“I understand the concerns raised by Yoshida and Shinohara,” Katsuragi countered calmly. “However, those concerns are entirely based on unsupported speculation. Whether we head toward the center of the island or hike to its outer edges, we haven't been given a single clue about what lies ahead in this task. The only concrete, undeniable difference is the travel distance. Thinking rationally, selecting a nearby location is the absolute optimal choice.”

“You know, you’re pretty damn stubborn, Katsuragi,” Yoshida scoffed. “Have you already forgotten that that exact rigid way of thinking is the reason you got booted from our class in the first place?”

“Let’s drop it, Yoshida-kun. That was uncalled for,” Sanada reprimanded.

Ever since transferring, I felt I had come to understand my new classmates to a certain degree. Unlike me, Katsuragi hadn't willingly betrayed his class; he had been the one forced out. Yet, the hostility directed at him was surprisingly intense. I could easily imagine him repeatedly clashing with his old classmates whenever opinions were divided over class policies.

“I'm casting my vote with Katsuragi,” Ike declared, watching the two glare at each other as if the conflict had nothing to do with him. “Like the man said, it doesn't matter where we go, since we have no idea what's coming next anyway.”

Despite the various opinions presented so far, it was painfully obvious that our group was not in step. If we proceeded to the vote right now, there was a high chance things wouldn't go according to our initially solid strategy. It would only take one person changing their destination on a whim to cause the entire 4-3-3-3-3 structure to collapse.

Letting their imaginations run wild, these students were desperately trying to convince themselves that reading into the exam's nonexistent subtext was the ‘correct’ choice.

It was the epitome of confirmation bias.

Opting for the closest destination was a perfectly sound, logical choice. Yet, people couldn't help but prioritize narrative over simple probability and efficiency. They wondered if heading further away might yield a hidden reward, or if choosing a spot nobody else would pick might somehow be to their advantage. They were being drawn in by the allure of an uncertain gamble.

Of course, we simply didn't know if our choice of destination would influence the rest of the task or not. The only thing I knew for certain was that we were actively losing a precious resource with every passing second.

“Personally, I'd like to value our time,” I interjected. “We were thrust into this Special Exam immediately after the Survival Game Special Exam, without even being given a proper chance to rest. I would highly appreciate it if we could move on to the voting sooner rather than later.”

Precisely because it truly didn't matter which of the five options we chose, I considered this entire discussion a monumental waste of time.

“Heh, if that's the case, maybe it's actually in our best interest to drag this out as long as possible,” Ike laughed, clearly still annoyed by my earlier cold shoulder.

“This is a group battle, Ike,” Katsuragi warned him. “There is absolutely nothing to be gained from pointless bickering.”

“Ayanokōji's the one who's been picking a fight with me this whole time!” Ike shot back. He looked like he was about to keep arguing, but instead, he just scratched the back of his head and sighed. “Ah, whatever. This is probably useless anyway. Let's quit talking and just get to the voting.”

Following Katsuragi's lead, we finalized our class-based adjustments and cast our votes.

“Since everyone has finished voting, I will announce the results,” the supervisor stated. “The final tally is: 3 votes for B9, 4 votes for E12, 3 votes for F14, 3 votes for I10, and 3 votes for I13. From here, Group 3 will proceed to E12. We will now distribute tokens to each student in accordance with these results.”

“It seems safe to assume that everyone played their part perfectly,” Katsuragi noted.

Our group had managed a safe start, perfectly executing the split. Every class walked away with ten tokens, and no difference was created whatsoever.

Satisfied with the result, Katsuragi gave a deep nod of approval. Despite their various dissatisfactions, the other students had ultimately prioritized securing the guaranteed tokens dangling right in front of them.

“None of the betrayers you were so worried about showed up. Good for you, Ike,” Katsuragi said.

“Well... yeah, but that's because the idea to prevent betrayals came from *my* class, right?” Ike argued. “Before you start complaining to me, you should thank Kikyō-chan. Thanks, by the way.”

While pushing back against Katsuragi, Ike forcefully asserted that their success was entirely thanks to Kushida.

“No, not at all,” Kushida replied, maintaining her flawless, gentle smile amidst the mixed group of classmates and outsiders. “I really wasn't confident in the idea, but I'm just happy I was able to be of use to everyone.” She played the part of the slightly embarrassed, humble girl to perfection.

“Yeah, yeah. Kushida-san really did think of a great way to prevent betrayals, didn't she? I guess the way she sees things is just... completely different from the rest of us,” Shinohara remarked.

It was a stinging, pointed jab delivered in a way that only the members of Horikita's class would understand. Was it simply because she harbored lingering resentment toward Kushida, or was she annoyed that Ike was so openly praising her?

Either way, Kushida didn't let her mask slip in the slightest, effortlessly letting the comment slide.

Part 2

By the time we finished our trek, it was already past 6:00 p.m.

Following the supervisor's instructions, we decided to pitch our tents here for the night. The students set about erecting tents and installing temporary toilets with practiced efficiency, naturally segregating the living areas by class.

Within the main campsite, the territory was loosely partitioned into four distinct sections, one for each class.

However, the moment Ike spotted me, he shot me a glare and immediately started in on me.

“I'm only gonna say this once, Ayanokōji: don't come anywhere near our tent without permission. And about what happened earlier too—”

“I have no intention of making enemies out of you outside of the exam tasks.”

“Like anyone would believe that. If you think you're gonna get me expelled, you've got another thing coming.”

“I suppose telling you I have absolutely no intention of doing that wouldn't convince you.”

“No shit! Even the way you were acting today—”

Unable to just sit there and listen to Ike's rising hostility, Katsuragi stopped what he was doing and rose to his feet.

“Need I remind you that, for the time being, we are allies in the same group?”

Katsuragi delivered his warning firmly. Still, having felt repeatedly made a fool of, Ike’s anger wasn't going to cool down that easily.

“Look, I am calm. But there's no way I can see him as an ally. Ayanokōji is a traitor to the class, and he treats us like idiots. You can't let your guard down around him. Who knows when he might try to slit our throats in our sleep?” Ike turned to me before continuing. “Anyway, sorry, but just keep away from us unless it's absolutely necessary.”

“If one of the sixteen people in this group was guaranteed to be expelled, I might understand your hostility, but…”

“It's fine, Katsuragi. What Ike is saying is fundamentally correct.”

After that, I grabbed my bags and ducked into our newly assembled three-person tent. A moment later, Yoshida followed me inside.

“Still, Ayanokōji... Do you have some kind of grudge against Class A? Or rather, against Ike and Shinohara?”

“I don't hold any grudges. Though, considering the circumstances, they have plenty of reasons to hold one against me.”

“Well, yeah, I guess that's true. But if that's the case, what was up with your attitude during the task earlier? You went a bit far, and some of the things you said didn't even make logical sense. Are you dealing with some kind of issue or special circumstance you can't easily talk about?”

Even though I had answered him honestly, Yoshida didn't seem entirely convinced.

“I mean, going out of your way to leave Class A is pretty bizarre in itself.”

I paused my unpacking and looked over at Yoshida. He met my gaze with a serious expression and continued.

“How do I put this... watching you just made me wonder if you really made the right call. With your abilities, you could've comfortably graduated as a member of Class A.”

“Being in Class A doesn't mean much to me. Even without using class privileges, there are plenty of alumni who have successfully made it into university.”

“Sure, someone like you could probably pass the entrance exams for a top-tier college on your own. Still... after enrolling in a tough school like this, don't you think you might as well take advantage of the Class A privileges while you're at it?”

“Fair point. I won't deny that.”

“You're not even gonna deny it?!” Yoshida laughed, landing a playful smack on my shoulder.

“I'm sure the other guys have already grilled you about this, but have you decided where you're going after graduation?”

“I'll be going to university. I just haven't decided exactly where yet.”

Even though I knew university life was completely irrelevant to my future, I had done a fair bit of research on the subject just so I wouldn't slip up and expose my ignorance.

For a third-year high school student, summer was the crucial period to narrow down their top-choice schools. From what I’d read, it was standard practice to have those choices locked in by November at the latest.

“Have you finalized your choice yet, Yoshida? You mentioned before that any decent university would be fine.”

“Nah, nothing's changed. If I had to pick, I'd say I kinda want to stay in Tokyo. That being said, if I can't graduate from Class A, worst-case scenario is I end up at some local college back home.”

Unlike regular high schools, this school offers a unique perk: the Class A graduation privilege.

Yoshida's case, for example. His plan was to take the entrance exams for a local college and try to get in on his own merit first. I didn't know if this had always been the rule, but under the school's current system, the final Class A standings are locked in on March 1st, right before graduation. If a student chooses to exercise their privilege at that point, they bypass the standard admission process entirely and are accepted into their university of choice under a special quota.

Naturally, entering a university that far exceeds your actual academic level comes with serious drawbacks. You'd be playing catch-up against fast-paced lectures, the higher comprehension levels of your peers, and your own lack of prerequisite knowledge. There would be no shortage of hurdles requiring immense effort to overcome. But ultimately, surviving that environment simply comes down to how hard you're willing to work once you're in.

Under normal circumstances, high schools and universities have strict enrollment caps, meaning the number of accepted applicants is ruthlessly narrowed down. Add in the pressure of make-or-break entrance exams and the fact that the higher a university's prestige, the fiercer the competition, and the barriers to entry become incredibly steep. But if you can skip all those hurdles and guarantee your enrollment, all you have to do is push forward with everything you have.

Granted, this strategy wouldn't work for every academic path. Forcing your way into medical school or certain highly specialized majors without the necessary foundation might not lead to a very bright future. For students lacking confidence in their academics, rather than half-heartedly using the Class A privilege to struggle through college, it would be far more valuable to use it to secure a job at a major corporation straight out of high school.

"Well, before we start talking about our dreams, we actually have to win this special exam first," Yoshida sighed, flopping down onto his side in our relatively spacious tent.

I immediately told him to get up, prompting him to lift his upper torso back off the floor.

“What is it?”

“You're right. Winning this exam is crucial,” I said, holding out my smartwatch for him to see. “Fortunately, the other classes are tucked away in their own tents right now. There are a few things I want to test out while we have the chance, so keep me company for a bit.”

“I don't really get it, but I'm guessing you've thought of something? Alright, let's do this.”

Pushing past his exhaustion, Yoshida sat up across from me as we spent the next little while running through my tests.

Part 3

By 7:00 p.m., it was time for dinner. Rations in hand, I headed over to the girls' side of the camp and called out to Kushida, who was mid-conversation with Amikura.

“Would you like to eat together?”

Amikura's smile seemed to stiffen for a fraction of a second.

Perhaps the invitation had brought someone else to mind?

Yet she quickly smoothed over her expression and urged Kushida to go ahead.

Looking suitably bewildered, Kushida grabbed her meal and followed me. We walked until we were safely out of earshot, at which point she stopped, keeping a deliberate distance of about a meter between us.

“What are you trying to pull, Ayanokōji-kun?”

“Didn't you say you wanted to discuss our plans for tomorrow?”

“I never said that. Besides, it's not like you actually need my help, right? Honestly, you're just being a massive pain.”

“Is that so? I figured that giving you a chance to prove your worth to the group would satisfy your need for approval. I thought you'd be happy.”

“Don't make me laugh. If it were just you, Ayanokōji-kun, that’d be one thing, but do you have any idea how agonizing it is to be put on a pedestal in front of Shinohara and the others when they already know my true nature? They're just messing with me for their own amusement.”

She punctuated her rant by narrowing her eyes into a vicious glare.

“Though, I suppose I understand that you can't exactly rely on Shinohara or Ike…” she muttered with an exasperated sigh, grudgingly accepting that she had been chosen by process of elimination. “Putting that aside, it looks like you're adjusting quite nicely to your new class.”

“With Sakayanagi gone, they lost their safety net. They probably would’ve rallied around anyone in that position, wouldn’t they?”

“You don't say,” she scoffed.

Her response was brief, followed by a fleeting moment of hesitation.



Yet, just as quickly as her guard had wavered, her usual composure returned.

“If there's something you want to ask, go ahead.”

“It's nothing in particular,” she fired back instantly. But sensing that I'd already caught her hesitation, she let out a quiet sigh. “It's just... the rumors about you right now are endless. I don't believe all of them, obviously, but I've been hearing plenty of things from Class D as well.”

She shifted her gaze toward Amikura and the rest of Ichinose's class as she spoke.

“Still—” Her expression shifted as she deliberately changed the subject. “Having my true nature exposed has been almost entirely a nightmare... but having moments like this where I can just drop the act and speak my mind might be the only salvation."

Forcibly ending the conversation there, she took a step back. She still hadn't touched a single bite of her dinner.

“Sorry, but I'm heading back. I really don't want to draw any more unnecessary heat from Shinohara and the others.”

“Your double life sounds exhausting.”

“It's a little late for that.”

With that, Kushida turned on her heel and headed back to Amikura's group.

It was true that Shinohara was partly using Kushida as an outlet for the frustration she felt toward me. Kushida obviously wouldn't enjoy being collateral damage in that conflict.

Still, that didn't mean I was going to leave her out of things from tomorrow onward. This special exam carried a guaranteed penalty: someone was going to be expelled.

Normally, the strategy would be to hunker down, protect everyone in your own group, and just pray that the last-place student comes from a different group or class. But I had no intention of playing it that way.

It was far more rational to take control and select the expulsion target myself from among the fifteen other students in my group. I wouldn't neglect laying the groundwork so that anyone could be chosen, depending on how the situation unfolded.

While her priority was low, Kushida was naturally one of those candidates. That was just the reality of the situation.

Part 4

As we finished our dinner, the supervisor approached our group, tablet in hand.

“Seeing as you've all finished your meals, we will now have you take on a new individual category task,” the supervisor announced. “Since you will continue to work together as a group to tackle tasks from tomorrow onward, I would like you to officially elect a ‘Popular Person’ and an ‘Unpopular Person.’ Each of you will cast one vote for the Popular Person and one vote for the Unpopular Person. The student crowned the Popular Person will be happily rewarded with five tokens upon the task's completion. Conversely, the student chosen as the Unpopular Person will, unfortunately, lose half of their current tokens. As a relief measure, anyone holding only a single token will not lose anything. However, if the unfortunate student possesses an odd number of three or more, any fractions of their remaining tokens will be rounded down, meaning they could potentially lose more than half their stash. Finally, any student who votes for the overall Popular Person will be awarded two tokens.”

A task to decide the most and least popular among us. Naturally, the eyes of the students from the other classes gravitated toward Kushida. Meanwhile, Ike, Shinohara, and Ibuki all shot me meaningful glances.

“If there is a tie for the Popular Person, no tokens will be awarded,” the supervisor continued. “Conversely, should there be a tie for the Unpopular Person, all tied individuals will have their tokens halved. You will have thirty minutes for discussion, and the voting method will remain the same as before. Furthermore, whoever secures the title of Popular Person will be exempt from being designated as the Unpopular Person. In such a scenario, the Unpopular penalty will automatically cascade to the individual with the next highest vote count. You may now begin.”

Between the previous task and this one, a sense of déjà vu drifted over the group.

“We've done a special exam like this before, haven't we?” Yoshida, who was seated next to me, muttered under his breath to Sanada.

“Yes, it's extremely similar,” Sanada replied softly. “It's possible that this entire special exam is designed to mirror the special exams we've faced in the past. If you think about it, the format of this mixed four-class group is quite close to the Mixed Training Camp, so it makes sense.”

It was still too early to draw any definitive conclusions, but the plausibility of that was steadily increasing.

If that really was the case, then from tomorrow onward, we might be hit with tasks mirroring the rules of the Paper Shuffle, the Event Selection Exam, or the Cooperative Comprehensive Written Test, albeit on a much smaller scale.

Regardless, speculating about the future wouldn't help us right now. We needed to focus on the task directly in front of us, the one where the Popular Person raked in tokens.

Unlike the previous task, which had been structured so that everyone could easily reap the benefits, only a single person would walk away with these five tokens. The reward couldn't be split among the fifteen of us. Given that reality, everyone naturally wanted to be voted the Popular Person.

However, the reality was that very few students possessed the confidence to brazenly assert their own popularity.

More often than not, those who loudly declared themselves popular were the very ones who ended up ostracized.

Even Ike, despite his obvious urge to speak up, chose to keep his hand down. He was well aware that the Popular Person title was entirely out of his reach. More than that, he was terrified that drawing attention to himself would backfire, turning him into a prime candidate for the Unpopular Person votes.

“This task is going to be a headache,” someone muttered. “If we all coordinate and vote for the same Popular Person, we each get two tokens, but the winner walks away with five. Reaching an agreement on who gets the lion's share won't be easy.”

“If we're going to struggle to reach a consensus, wouldn't voting for Kushida be the safest bet, assuming we're basing this strictly on popularity?” I interjected, hoping to cut down on a drawn-out discussion.

“M-Me?” Kushida blinked, feigning surprise.

Actually, she might have been genuinely surprised. After all, every single student in Horikita's class had already witnessed the real Kushida. While she likely interpreted my suggestion as a surface-level endorsement of her ‘sweet’ persona, the raw surprise in her eyes suggested she was frantically trying to deduce my underlying motive.

At the same time, Yoshida and my classmates were visibly taken aback. Recommending a student from a rival class essentially meant willingly handing over the biggest payout.

While Kushida directed a suspicious gaze at me, I also felt the inward pressure of her asking *What are you plotting?* It might just be my imagination, so I ignored it and continued speaking.

“Of course, this is just a suggestion. If anyone has a more suitable candidate in mind, I have no objections.” By framing it this way, I made it seem as though I wasn't forcing the issue. Even so, the first idea tossed into the ring inherently sets the baseline for the rest of the debate.

“No, you're definitely right!” Ike immediately latched onto the idea. “Kikyō-chan is super popular. She gets along with everyone and never gets involved in unnecessary drama.”

Glossing over the fact that it was my suggestion, he cheerfully voiced his support.

Kushida possessed two faces. Even though everyone in her class knew about her true nature, as long as the other classes remained in the dark, her public persona was an asset that could be exploited. Ike understood that much perfectly well. Furthermore, his inherently high affection for Kushida was likely fueling his eagerness.

“You... think so? I'm not really sure,” she murmured.

“Nah, out of everyone here, it absolutely has to be you, Kikyō-chan. No question about it!” Ike nodded along enthusiastically, his face lit up with a wide grin.

When Kushida responded with a bashful, sheepish smile of her own, Ike’s expression melted even further, his eyes crinkling with sheer delight as a goofy smile spread across his face.

While Ike's endorsement was unmistakably providing tactical covering fire for the class, from the perspective of his girlfriend, Shinohara, there was absolutely nothing amusing about it.

It was painfully obvious that her frustration was spiking at the sight of her boyfriend fawning over another girl. Under normal circumstances, she probably would have dragged him off by the ear and hurled a few insults his way. However, securing the Popular Person spot for Kushida directly benefited their own class.

“Well... yeah,” Shinohara sighed, unable to keep a hint of sourness out of her voice. “It'd be a different story if someone like Ichinose-san were here, but out of this group, isn't Kushida-san the safest choice?” Swallowing her personal irritation, she opted to back up Ike's proposal.

Naturally, this momentum didn't sit well with anyone outside of Class A. Pushback began almost instantly.

“Hold on a second. I get why you'd say Kushida is popular, and I'm not denying that, but just handing her our votes like this is a bit...” Yoshida trailed off, his hesitation clear as he struggled to voice a solid counterargument.

“Then who else are you gonna vote for?” Ike challenged. “Name one person here who's more popular than Kikyō-chan. Go on, I'll wait.”

“That's…” Yoshida scanned the circle. He was looking for someone who could rival, or perhaps even surpass, Kushida's widespread appeal. But even if he tried to bluff, no such student existed in our current lineup.

“See? No matter how you slice it, there aren't any other candidates. So it's decided, decided!”

“I'm really not all that great, though…” Kushida offered another modest smile, but her denial was flimsy. Her demeanor clearly left the door wide open for her to accept the nomination.

And that very vulnerability gave Ike and the rest of Class A all the more reason to keep pushing for her.

“I get where you're coming from, Yoshida, but realistically, there's no better candidate than Kushida.” I offered this dry defense for the benefit of Class A, though I was ultimately just stating the facts.

“If only Shiraishi were here…” Yoshida muttered under his breath, his quiet frustration slipping past the others' notice.

I wouldn't go so far as to say Shiraishi was unpopular, but Yoshida's imaginary vote was fueled entirely by his own personal bias.

“...I see.” Katsuragi, who had been quietly observing the exchange, finally spoke up. He stood with his arms crossed, his sharp gaze fixed directly on me. “Your logic certainly holds up. However, there is one glaring flaw in this discussion.”

As expected, it seemed Katsuragi was the first to notice.

“We are letting ourselves be misled by the words ‘Popular’ and ‘Unpopular,’ completely blinding ourselves to the conflicting interests of our respective classes.” His voice was quiet, yet the sheer weight of his words anchored the room. “This group is a mixture of all four classes. Naturally, depending on the outcome, some classes will profit while others will suffer losses.”

“Well, that can't be helped, right? Kikyō-chan *is* actually popular —”

“That's exactly my point. Her actual popularity is entirely irrelevant.” Katsuragi cut Ike off without hesitation. “True, the exam tasks us with electing a ‘Popular Person,’ but there is absolutely no rule stating the nominee must actually fit that description.”

“Huh...? But the supervisor literally said we had to properly decide so we could tackle the task.”

“So what? That was merely an instruction to complete the objective. I didn't interpret that statement as anything more or less than what it was, did you?”

He had hit the nail on the head. This wasn't a genuine popularity contest. At its core, it was simply a contest over who could hoard tokens and who would be stripped of them. As long as we remained distracted by the superficial wording, we would never have a meaningful discussion.

“Voting for Kushida simply benefits Class A.” Katsuragi's gaze sharpened slightly. It was more of a check than a mere point out.

“Oh, so that's how it is...” someone murmured as the realization set in. “Right. Whether they're actually popular or not doesn't matter at all.”

“Then the idea is rejected. Rejected,” Ibuki spat, not wasting a single second. But simply shooting it down wasn't enough for her. “Seriously, why the hell should we go out of our way to hand tokens over to Kushida, to a rival class? Are you guys actually idiots for almost getting swept along by that?”

It was a blatant, visceral rejection now that the illusion was shattered. She wasn't arguing with logic anymore; it was pure, unadulterated emotion.

But that was fine. If anything, that raw emotion was exactly what I needed to shift the dynamic.

While things were playing out exactly as I intended, Katsuragi's intense focus shifted back to me.

“There is no way Ayanokōji wouldn't realize something of this level. Am I the only one who thinks so?” He fired the accusation point-blank, questioning exactly why I had nominated Kushida in the first place.

"You aren't secretly colluding with Kushida-san behind our backs, are you, Ayanokōji-kun?" Shinohara, who had been nominally on Kushida's side as a fellow classmate until now, suddenly pivoted, aiming her suspicion straight at me.

“Eh, w-what do you mean, Shinohara-san?” Seeing the crosshairs drift her way, Kushida immediately cranked up her performance of flustered bewilderment.

But Shinohara ignored the act entirely. “I meant exactly what I said. Well, I suppose there's no way Kushida-san would actually stoop to something like that.”

“Of course not, We had no way of knowing what kind of tasks were coming up in the first place.”

“Yeah, Satsuki, you're taking it a bit too far.”

“And why exactly are you taking Kushida-san's side?!” Shinohara snapped.

“Whoa, hey, wait a sec! There's no need to get so combative, right? I mean, I was thinking the same thing as Ayanokōji, so maybe he really was just trying to pick the safest option?”

“I highly doubt that. Don't think I haven't noticed you doing nothing but staring at Kushida-san this whole time, Kanji!”

“T-That's not true at all! I swear, seriously, I swear!”

As the atmosphere rapidly deteriorated into a petty lovers' quarrel that threatened to derail the discussion, Ibuki snapped and kicked the ground in aggravation.

“Whatever, the point is, I absolutely refuse to hand tokens over to Class A.”

“Agreed. We're against it too,”

One after another, the members of Class B voiced their dissent, and the remaining classes quickly followed suit. They showed no signs of backing down.

“Man, come on... this is still better than getting into some weird, messy conflict, right?” Turning his back to actively dodge Shinohara's terrifying glare, Ike desperately tried to placate the group. “What's the point of jumping straight at each other's throats right from the start? For one thing, we'll never reach an agreement like this.”

“Then we should just stop talking in circles,” Ibuki declared bluntly, having zero patience for drawn-out discussions. “Let's just pick whoever we actually want to vote for and be done with it.”

If talking it out couldn't yield a favorable outcome, she preferred to level the playing field. To her, a straightforward clash was the simplest path forward and offered the cleanest chance of winning.

Katsuragi quietly processed her suggestion. “Simply nominating whoever we please might actually be the safest option.”

“I mean, if the whole point is that the Popular Person gets tokens, then voting normally makes the most sense. Not that I care how the results shake out,” Ibuki agreed with a casual nod, treating it as the most natural conclusion.

“However, taking that route practically guarantees that each class will just consolidate their votes,” Sanada pointed out. “Even if we don't say a single word, it's easy enough to coordinate our votes through eye contact alone.”

He was right. If we divided along class lines, it would only result in up to four ‘Popular People’ receiving three votes each. A multi-way tie meant zero tokens awarded across the board.

“Yeah, exactly!” Ike seized the opening. “If we do that, the votes will just split, and nobody gets anything. In that case, it's absolutely better to pool our tokens on Kikyō-chan and boost the group's overall total! This special exam isn't just about individuals hoarding tokens, right? It's about helping each other out!”

“You have a point, Ike,” Sonoda from Class B interjected. “I get what you're trying to say. But if pooling points is the goal, then someone from Class B... hell, even *I* would be fine. The total number goes up either way, so it's the exact same thing.”

“Uh, that's actually a little different, Sonoda-kun,” Shinohara shot back. “Helping each other out means trusting that the person will actually lend a hand when someone is in trouble. No offense, Sonoda-kun, but you aren't exactly trustworthy. Kushida-san, on the other hand, is. Isn't that right, Ayanokōji-kun?”

She was smoothly weaponizing the exact logic I had laid out earlier regarding Kushida's reliability, turning it directly back on Sonoda.

“Yeah, that logic holds up,” I agreed.

If Kushida was crowned the Popular Person, she would gain five tokens. While those tokens would ostensibly belong to Class A, if Sonoda or anyone else were to fall into a desperate situation later on, Kushida possessed the reputation of someone who would return the favor and bail them out. It served as a form of insurance for the future.

“Sure, maybe it means our class gets a few more tokens right now,” Shinohara continued, pressing her advantage. “But you can think of it as a value of trust. Right, Kushida-san?”

“I... I really don't know if I'm suited to be the Popular Person,” Kushida replied, her voice soft and earnest. “But if anyone ever found themselves in trouble, I would absolutely want to help them.”

A heavy silence fell over the area, the sheer weight of their competing arguments lingering in the air.

Those were the words of arguably the most trustworthy person in the entire group. Yet, despite that, the other classes couldn't bring themselves to simply nod in agreement.

The core issue was the inevitable disparity in tokens. Handing Kushida the win meant willingly allowing a gap to form between the classes within our group, a scenario they desperately wanted to avoid. Even if it meant forfeiting the reward entirely by forcing a tie, stalling the creation of a clear hierarchy felt safer. The debate had shifted entirely from *‘who is popular’* to *‘are we fine letting Class A take the lead?’*

“What do we do, Ayanokōji?” Yoshida whispered under his breath, leaning in so the others wouldn't hear. “Do you have some kind of plan?”

I didn’t answer. I merely let my gaze drift sideways, observing the distance between Ike, Shinohara, and Kushida, who remained just beyond them.

A very slight, yet undeniable gap had formed among the three, a subtle rift that hadn't been there moments before. For the purposes of this task, that alone was sufficient.

It was nothing more than a tiny seed of discomfort right now, but given enough time and the right circumstances, it would inevitably blossom into something far more tangible.

With no clear compromise in sight, the clock continued to tick down. One minute passed, then two.

“Seriously, what are we doing here? We can't move forward if we don't actually decide on something,” Ike finally snapped, his patience wearing thin.

However, the edge in his voice wasn't fueled by genuine anger. Rather, it was a desperate impatience to just get it over with, proof that he couldn't stomach the suffocating tension in the room for another second.

“Regarding the Popular Person, it really feels like that's our only viable option,” Shinohara added, her gaze flicking up slightly.

Naturally, a few sets of eyes immediately gravitated toward her. A clear sense of caution still lingered in those looks, but for the time being, that was fine.

“Basing the vote solely on Kushida's personal trustworthiness, you say…” Katsuragi mused, his arms still crossed. “True, if you frame it strictly from that angle, the logic is sound, but…” His eyes remained narrowed, silently probing my intentions. It was obvious he still wasn't entirely sold on the idea.

“I don't care if the class votes end up splitting or whatever. It just means we're stuck picking randomly in the end anyway, right?” Ibuki scoffed. “So why are we still rambling in circles? This is so stupid.”

“Right? We basically just have to decide what's better: letting the votes split so nobody in the group gets any tokens, or giving the win to Class A so the group's overall total goes up,” Ike said, offering a quick shrug. “Trying to pull off some weird mind game and completely whiffing it is way worse.”

“Besides, if the group is bringing in tokens, we should normally be grateful for it,” Shinohara chimed in with a small nod of agreement. Her comment sounded casual, but it carried exactly enough weight to decisively tip the scales.

By shifting the focus to a simple, easily digestible matter of total profit, the resistance from the other classes weakened considerably.

"...I can't say my objections have completely vanished," Katsuragi finally conceded. "But seeing as there is no clear counter-proposal on the table at this moment... I am willing to tentatively accept this."

"Alright, then— are we officially good with Kikyō-chan as the Popular Person?"

When no one voiced a direct objection to Ike's confirmation, a few seconds of heavy silence ticked by before it was quietly processed as unanimous approval.

With that, the first major hurdle was cleared.

"I guess that's fine," Ibuki said suddenly, leaning forward. "But by the way, what exactly are we doing about the Unpopular Person?"

The atmosphere changed instantly, the air around us growing noticeably heavier.

If anything, one could argue that *this* was the true crux of the matter for Ibuki.

Unlike with the Popular Person, no one dared to casually open their mouths this time.

And naturally so. This wasn't about uplifting someone; this was a discussion about tearing someone down. There was no way this could end peacefully, which was precisely why everyone knew they had to tread carefully.

"A debate where we just try to forcefully shove the penalty onto someone else will only end in a fruitless, ugly conflict. The simplest resolution is for someone willing to take the loss to step forward," Katsuragi stated, deliberately cutting to the chase in an effort to prevent the atmosphere from turning hostile.

"...Well, I suppose that's true," a Class C student muttered, and the rest of his classmates mirrored his complicated, uneasy expression.

"Locking in the Popular Person during this discussion is enough," Katsuragi added after a brief pause. "As for the Unpopular Person vote, we simply need to let everyone judge the situation for themselves and cast their votes however they see fit."

"So it's a 'no hard feelings' kind of deal, right?" Shinohara confirmed, though a slight edge of irritation bled into her voice. She wasn't dumb; she knew perfectly well that if she voiced a strongly negative opinion right now, she would instantly paint a target on her own back.

Ibuki, who had been the one to bring the issue up in the first place, also kept her mouth shut after that. Unlike Kushida, who had cleanly secured the Popular Person spot, Ibuki was exactly the type of student who was at high risk of gathering the Unpopular votes.

"That's what it comes down to," Katsuragi confirmed.

"I see…" Sanada murmured, summarizing the strategy aloud. "By choosing not to unify our votes, we are conversely leaving room for mind games." He gave a small nod, looking thoroughly convinced.

He was right. If we forcefully nominated a single sacrifice right now, the thought process for everyone would remain simple and straightforward.

But by dispersing the target, we were forcing everyone to read between the lines.

And those readings… would inevitably become distorted.

Ike relaxed his shoulders, and Shinohara mirrored him with a small sigh of relief. They exchanged a brief look. It was a perfect display of silent communication, a phenomenon the other classes were now unconsciously beginning to mimic.

Claiming we would leave the unfortunate role up to luck without singling anyone out was nothing but a convenient facade.

In reality, coordinated voting blocs form just as easily for negative penalties as they do for positive rewards. In fact, the psychological mechanics behind a negative vote drive an even stronger need for collusion. ‘Voting as you please’ sounded perfectly fair on paper, but in practice, it immediately sparked a web of mind games. Predictions are made, and people naturally piggyback on those predictions to protect themselves. If that bandwagon effect is left unchecked, it inevitably converges on a single point: the absolute safest, most convenient target.

There was no need to wonder who that unlucky target would be.

Ike and Shinohara were going to vote for me with one hundred percent certainty. Ibuki would read that and cast a third vote my way.

Furthermore, astute students like Katsuragi would anticipate this exact flow and steer their own votes to push me securely into the Unpopular spot.

This silent consensus was already spreading rapidly among the students outside of Class C. It was no wonder Sanada looked a bit anxious as he sensed the current solidifying against us, but he couldn't raise an objection. Since we had ostensibly agreed to leave the vote up to individual discretion, he had no grounds to stop it.

“Well then, since that's settled, let's just get to voting,” Ike prompted.

Short murmurs of agreement echoed around the circle, and the momentum of the room shifted entirely toward executing the vote. Kushida for the Popular Person, and individual discretion for the Unpopular Person.

As a discussion, it was over. At least on the surface. Not everyone was entirely satisfied, but digging any deeper would inevitably expose the ugly reality that someone was about to be deliberately sacrificed. Given that fact, it was only natural that the group wanted to slap a lid on the debate while things were still relatively peaceful.

In truth, cutting the conversation short here was the correct move for the majority. Probing too deeply could cause the wind to shift in an unpredictable direction. Precisely because they had just openly colluded to concentrate their Popular votes onto a single person, no one wanted to touch the Unpopular vote with a ten-foot pole. The superficial declaration of 'not deciding' was functioning perfectly as a collective safety measure.

However, naturally, for me who was being targeted, I had no intention of letting the discussion end here.

"I'd like to confirm one last thing before we proceed," I spoke up, cutting through the final moments before the vote. "If we actually leave this up to individual discretion, the Unpopular votes will split. That means multiple students could end up having their tokens halved. Isn't that the absolute worst-case scenario?"

"What gives? You're still dragging this out?" Ike groaned. "Enough already. It's not like we've decided the Unpopular Person is gonna be someone from Class C or anything."

His words were laden with thinly veiled subtext. What he was really saying was: *You're going to be the Unpopular Person, so a split vote isn't going to happen anyway.*

"I really don't wish to dig this back up either," Sanada interjected, likely sensing this was his only window of opportunity. "But... in that case, what do you believe is the correct course of action, Ayanokōji-kun?"

You could practically feel the irritation rolling off the other classes. This was a topic they desperately wanted to sweep under the rug.

"It's a difficult problem," I answered without missing a beat. "The reality is, being chosen as the Unpopular Person carries nothing but severe demerits."

"Which is precisely why we are conducting an equal, open vote," Katsuragi stated. "If that results in a tie and multiple people take the penalty, then it simply cannot be helped."

Katsuragi's sharp gaze locked onto mine. His words carried an unmistakable, silent challenge: *Show me how you plan to maneuver out of this situation. Let's see how you turn the tide.*

“We concentrate our votes on Kushida, who naturally draws the fewest objections as the ‘Popular Person’ in both name and reality. That guarantees two tokens for all fifteen of us. Up to that point, there’s no problem,” I began, first laying out the premise.

“The issue lies with the remaining Unpopular vote. If the votes split apart, there’s a real chance that two or three students could each lose half their tokens instead. To avoid that, we need to predetermine a single Unpopular Person from the very beginning, just as we did for the Popular vote.”

“Huh? We're only having this conversation because we *can't* do that,” Ike scoffed. “What are you—”

“I'm not finished,” I cut him off, turning back toward the group. “Therefore, our class will willingly take on the role of the Unpopular Person.”

Rather than trusting our fate to some superficial illusion of equality, I was deliberately reaching out to claim the penalty. By doing so, I could steer the situation toward a conclusion that appeared similar, but was fundamentally different.

“By accepting the Unpopular penalty in advance, we can establish a framework where the other classes are absolutely guaranteed to suffer zero casualties,” I explained.

“Well, yeah. I agree, I totally agree! Right, Satsuki?”

“Yeah, I think it's fine. If Class C is willingly volunteering for it, I don't have any complaints.”

Since Ike and Shinohara had already internally cast their Unpopular votes for me anyway, neither of them raised a single objection.

“However, in exchange for taking the hit, I want Kushida to transfer two tokens to our side after the task ends,” I added. “She will gain five as the Popular Person. Even if she hands over two, she still walks away with three, meaning her individual cut will still be the largest among everyone here.”

“Well, if Class C is taking the penalty, I don't mind that condition at all, but…” Kushida began, showing her intent to consent, only for Ike to immediately interrupt.

“Hold on, why does Kikyō-chan have to bear the burden for that? That's totally messed up!”

“It's not messed up in the slightest,” I countered smoothly. “We are sacrificing ourselves to ensure that multiple Unpopular penalties aren't triggered. I am merely asking her for a slight compensation to mitigate our damage.”

Since my role as the Unpopular Person was already locked inside Ike's head, it was no wonder he perceived the tax on Kushida as an utterly meaningless burden.

“The logic appears sound,” Katsuragi mused. “In reality, even if Class C receives two compensatory tokens, they won't end up with a net positive. The number of tokens each student possesses at the start differs, but even assuming all four of them started with the bare minimum of two, combined with the earlier reward, their current stash would be three or more. The moment that count is halved, they will lose a minimum of two tokens. The net balance is zero. And if their starting count was any higher, the tokens they lose will only increase.”

Because none of the sharper students had started this special exam with the bare minimum of two tokens, it likely hadn't even crossed their minds that someone could mathematically manipulate the penalty to result in a net balance of zero.

“But something about this is weird! It might be a trap!” Ike protested.

“I don't mind if you doubt my intentions,” I replied. “But if you don't like the proposal, Ike, then *you* are more than welcome to step up and take on the role of the Unpopular Person. Naturally, you would also be entitled to those two extra tokens as compensation.”

“Th-That's... impossible! There's no way I can do that!” Ike immediately backed down, rejecting the offer vehemently.

And rightly so. Ike almost certainly held more tokens than the proposed compensation would cover. If he was going to suffer a net loss of even a single token after having his stash halved and gaining the two extras, there was zero chance he would accept the deal.

During the Survival Game Special Exam, students like Katsuragi and Ike had managed to survive for a decent chunk of time without getting eliminated. Consequently, they had started this current exam with a comfortable cushion of tokens. It was perfectly understandable if the idea of someone having three or fewer tokens at this stage had completely slipped their minds.

Because there wasn't a single student in the other classes who could stomach having their tokens halved, it was practically impossible for them to reject the condition I had proposed.

“I wondered how you were going to resolve this deadlock,” Katsuragi said, a hint of begrudging respect in his voice. “I see. So there was that perspective as well.”

Even if the other classes wanted to complain out of sheer dissatisfaction, they couldn't offer themselves up as substitutes. Nor could they openly assert that I was going to be the Unpopular Person anyway without exposing their blatant collusion. I had completely cut off any avenue for a counterattack.

“Well then, I guess I'll take on the role of the Unpopular Person,” Yoshida announced, raising his hand as if this was exactly the moment he had been waiting for. “Kushida, I'll be counting on those two tokens later.”

At his overly casual volunteer, the atmosphere froze for a split second.

Logically, everyone understood the concept of someone deliberately taking a loss for the group, but it was rare to see someone actually offer it out loud. Much less in a high-stakes situation where the results directly dictated the immediate loss of one's own tokens.

“Hey, if someone has to do it anyway, it's better to just decide quickly and move on,” Yoshida said, looking directly at Ike and Shinohara, who had shown the strongest resistance thus far. “Besides, as far as our class is concerned, it wouldn't be amusing in the slightest if Ayanokōji somehow ended up gathering all the Unpopular votes by some crazy coincidence.”

While volunteering subtly hinted that Yoshida possessed a comfortable amount of tokens to burn, it served as an incredibly strong deterrent.

“...Well, in terms of actually being the ‘Unpopular Person,’ maybe they aren't wrong, right?” Shinohara muttered. “I still think it's way more natural to just leave it up to everyone and let the votes fall where they may.”

Her desire to strike me while the iron was hot was entirely transparent; she wasn't even trying to hide it.

“I thought a group was supposed to cooperate wherever possible, right?” Yoshida challenged lightly, flashing a small shrug. “If we just leave it to ‘chance’ here, and by some crazy coincidence a certain someone ends up gathering twelve whole votes... well, that's gonna look more like an organized vote than a coincidence. And honestly, I'd really hate for our cooperative relationship to completely fall apart moving forward.”

There was no trace of seriousness in Yoshida's attitude. He hadn't been forced into the role; he had perfectly established the outward appearance of a man undertaking the burden entirely of his own volition for the sake of his class.

Since the interests of the four classes would never perfectly align, situations where someone simply had to yield were inevitable. But since someone had stepped up and willingly volunteered to fall on their sword, any remaining justification to drag the discussion out completely evaporated.

“You make a fair point. If that is the arrangement, I have no objections,” Katsuragi said with a quiet nod.

Sonoda, Minamikata, and the rest of the Class B students exchanged looks, but none of them voiced any strong opposition. Even if they weren't entirely satisfied with the outcome, they likely judged that with no better alternatives on the table, they had no choice but to accept the compromise.

Ibuki, too, simply offered a tiny shrug, making no move to interject. She knew perfectly well that pushing the issue any further ran the risk of turning the spearhead back toward herself.

As for Class A, even if Ike and Shinohara stubbornly cast their Unpopular votes for me now, there was no guarantee I would rack up more votes than Yoshida. If a clumsy two or three stray votes landed on me, it would only breed suspicion and ultimately shatter our tenuous cooperative relationship.

“Fine, I get it,” Ike grumbled. “We just have to vote for Yoshida, right?”

And with that, the targets were officially locked in: Kushida, whom the group trusted, and Yoshida, who had stepped up as the sacrificial lamb.

Not everyone was thrilled with the result, but it landed squarely on the minimum acceptable line for all four classes. It was a fragile equilibrium, maintained by the mutual understanding that pushing even an inch further would cause the entire discussion to collapse.

Following the supervisor's instructions, we all dropped our gazes to our smartwatches. The input process was incredibly simple: one vote for the Popular Person, one vote for the Unpopular Person.

In the brief window before the results were finalized, a heavy silence wrapped the space; no one dared to speak.

And so, the task reached its conclusion.

Once the results were confirmed and the suffocating tension finally broke, Yoshida casually flicked his gaze in my direction. Locking eyes with me for just a split second, he offered a quick thumbs-up.

To anyone else watching, it was easily brushed off as the small, self-satisfied gesture of a guy who had just taken a hit to protect his class leader. To the rest of the group, Yoshida's volunteer act looked like a genuine, albeit minor, self-sacrifice. Even if they assumed his token stash was relatively low, they knew he mathematically couldn't profit from the exchange.

But the reality was the exact opposite. Yoshida was actually walking away with a pure profit.

That was because, through a few prior adjustments behind the scenes, I had already lowered Yoshida's token count down to the absolute minimum of one.

According to the rules, anyone holding only a single token was exempt from the halving penalty. Therefore, even after being officially crowned the Unpopular Person, Yoshida lost absolutely nothing. In fact, since he was now guaranteed to receive those two compensatory tokens from Kushida, the entire maneuver carried zero hidden risks.

Shortly before this task began, while we were still inside the tent, Yoshida and I had repeatedly tested the token transfer mechanics. We discovered a few key details. First, the basic condition for a transfer required both parties to operate their smartwatches and physically tap them together, which triggered a default notification sound. However, we realized this chime could be easily muted by simply turning the watch's volume down to zero beforehand.

If transfers could be executed just by brushing two watches together, silencing the notification would be a massive security flaw. But since both parties were required to input their personal PINs to authorize a transaction, there was no risk of tokens being stolen in secret. Thus, the school had made the sound notification entirely optional.

Next, we tested the actual speed and frequency of the transfers. While the system required you to input your PIN again after each completed transaction, there was practically zero lag. Once we got the hang of it, we found we could continuously fire off transfers in about ten seconds flat. You could send tokens one at a time on loop, or dump them all in a single lump sum.

During our testing, we also discovered that the system threw up a severe warning error if you attempted to initiate a transfer when your balance was already down to one token.

The fact that this special exam carries a risk of reducing tokens to zero implies that the rules allow for them to be stripped away during the challenges, not just through peer-to-peer transfers.

However, if a challenge capable of draining three or four tokens were introduced right at the outset, students who started with a baseline of only two would face an immediate checkmate.

My modeling of the school's habits suggested as much. If they intended to inject a negative element this early, they would opt for a mechanism like ‘halving’ to ensure a zero-balance was impossible.

Still, to think I would be able to exploit that exact mechanic this early in the exam... things had worked out almost a little too perfectly.

Part 5

The previous task had barely concluded before the supervisor began tapping away at his tablet, offering no hint of a dismissal.

“I have officially recorded the results and distributed your tokens,” he announced. “Now, we will take a brief five-minute intermission, after which we will commence the final individual task of the day. Thank you for your cooperation.”

“You've gotta be kidding me. There's *another* one?”

Groans of dismay rose from the girls first, who had clearly assumed we would be moving straight into free time before bed. Echoing their sentiment, murmurs of discontent began rippling through the boys as well.

It was a four-day, three-night special exam. Tomorrow would likely be the main event, but even for a day focused mostly on talking, this schedule was relentless.

True to her word, Kushida transferred two tokens to Yoshida. While some students killed the brief intermission by checking their smartwatch balances, it wasn't long before the exam was set in motion once more.

“I will now explain the final task,” the supervisor began. “This one leans closer to a gamble, relying heavily on elements of luck. You can think of it as a simple game. However, because of its nature, I must first confirm whether or not each of you actually wishes to participate. Should you choose to play, you will be required to wager, and potentially lose, two tokens upon defeat.”

“So participation is entirely voluntary... right?” Sanada asked cautiously.

The supervisor gave a curt nod. “Yes. For instance, if you currently hold two or fewer tokens, you may choose to sit this one out. Alternatively, if you simply do not wish to shoulder the risk of losing, you are well within your rights to decline. However, choosing to abstain carries a penalty: you must pay one token as compensation.”

We were faced with a choice: risk losing two tokens for a chance at victory, or pay a flat fee of one token to guarantee your safety.

“I mean, you'd normally just play, right? Isn't it completely stupid to spend a token just to *not* participate?” Ike scoffed.

“I wouldn't be so sure,” Katsuragi countered. “True, if your sole focus is hoarding personal tokens, maximizing your participation is the mathematically correct choice. However, if your absolute priority is avoiding expulsion at all costs, paying one token to sidestep a two-token loss is equally valid.”

It was a running theme today, dilemmas where a single, objective ‘correct answer’ simply didn't exist. Regardless, the harsh reality was that very few students in our group could actually afford to casually bleed a token just to sit on the sidelines. In the end, everyone opted to participate.

The supervisor announced the winner's reward, a handsome five tokens, and the task officially began.

“I hold in my hands sixteen folded slips of paper,” the supervisor said, fanning them out. “There are exactly two slips for each number between one and eight. You will be facing off against the student who draws the same number as you. I will explain the rules shortly, so for now, please come forward and draw your lot. Do not unfold your paper until I give the signal.”

Without any designated order, the students closest to the front stepped up first. I went sixth, drawing a folded slip and returning to my spot.

"You may now check your numbers," the supervisor instructed. "I will collect the slips afterward, so please refrain from tearing or crumpling them."

Bathed in the pale moonlight, the sixteen members of Group 3 simultaneously unfolded their slips. I glanced down at my palm. The number written there was '4'.

"Please sit facing your designated opponent, arranged in numerical order starting from pair number one. I will now collect your slips."

As the supervisor gathered the scrap paper, he distributed a hand of five playing cards to each student. The backs featured a uniform, standard pattern, but the faces were unique: each card bore a single odd number— 1, 3, 5, 7, and 9— arranged sequentially in our hands. Catching a glimpse of the students to my left and right, I confirmed their hands consisted of the exact same 1-through-9 odd-number lineup.

The matchups were as follows: Pair 1 was Katsuragi and Morishita. Pair 2 was Ibuki and Morofuji. Pair 3, Minamikata and Sonoda. Pair 4 was me and Wang. Pair 5, Ike and Kushida. Pair 6, Amikura and Shinohara. Pair 7, Yoshida and Sumida. And rounding it out, Pair 8 was Sanada and Moriyama.

"Umm, Ike-kun and I are both in Class A," Kushida raised her hand tentatively. "Do we still have to play against each other?"

"Yes. Your class affiliations are completely irrelevant for this task," the supervisor replied flatly.

Given the bare-minimum explanation, Kushida blinked in mild bewilderment but obediently nodded her understanding.

“The rules are simple,” the supervisor continued. “In each round, both players will select one card from their hand and place it face down. You will then reveal them simultaneously. The player who plays the higher number wins the round. If the numbers match, the round is a draw. Once a card has been played, it is consumed and cannot be used again. The first student to secure two wins will be declared the overall victor. The winner will acquire five tokens, while the loser will forfeit the two tokens they initially wagered. In the rare event of a complete draw after all five cards are consumed, you will retrieve your hands and play an overtime match until a single win is secured. Excluding the overtime match, please aim to finish within approximately 5 minutes."

By giving a soft five-minute guideline rather than a hard limit, the school was implicitly warning us against deliberately stalling or overthinking. If a match dragged on for seven or eight minutes, it probably wouldn't result in an instant disqualification, but it wouldn't be surprising if a penalty was slapped onto whichever player was burning the clock.

“I-I look forward to our match.” Wearing an incredibly nervous expression, Mii-chan offered a slight bow from across.

She was clutching her five cards tightly to her chest; naturally, from my seated position, the numbers facing her were completely hidden from view.

“Likewise,” I replied evenly.

Then, at the supervisor's signal, the eight matches began simultaneously.

I didn't hesitate. I instantly pulled the ‘7’ from my hand and slapped it face down on the ground.

“Th-That was fast,” Mii-chan stammered, clearly taken aback.

“It's purely a game of luck, anyway. I'm just thinking we should get this over with quickly,” I replied smoothly.

I could hear some of the other students already starting to chatter, trying to engage their opponents in conversational mind games to fish for tells within the allotted time. I had no intention of doing that.

“R-Right... umm, umm, then I'll...”

Based on Mii-chan's personality alone, it was impossible to deduce whether she would open with a weak card or come out swinging with a strong one. There simply wasn't enough data. However, knowing her timid nature, it was incredibly easy to predict exactly how my words and actions would influence her.

By declaring right out of the gate that this was a game of pure luck and actively shutting down any attempt at conversational strategy, I forced her to subconsciously accept that she had to play the same way. Granted, she wasn't the type to excel at that kind of verbal sparring anyway, but my dismissal completely sealed her lips. Furthermore, because her opponent had played a card instantly, she was suddenly hit with a wave of mounting pressure to hurry up and match my pace.

Her fingertips hovered hesitantly over her hand. But she couldn't afford to take her time.

Her hand darted out, grabbing the card perfectly in the center of her fan and placing it face down.

“I'll go with this one...”

“Let's flip them, then.”

“Y-Yes.”

Without even pausing to ask if she wanted to swap her card, we executed our first round. We were the fastest out of all eight pairs by a massive margin. The sheer speed of our match was so jarring that it actually drew the attention of Shinohara and the others sitting nearby.

The cards were revealed. Naturally, mine was the ‘7’. Mii-chan's was a ‘5’.

“Ah—”

“Let's move right to the next one,” I said, cutting off any emotional reaction to the win or loss.

Now, I immediately set my ‘9’ card face down.

Faced with my relentless pace, Mii-chan's thought process clearly short-circuited for a second.

The moment I clinched the opening round by crushing her ‘5’ with my ‘7’, the tide of the entire match swung heavily in my favor. As long as my ‘9’ wasn't canceled out by a tie, my overall victory was mathematically guaranteed.

Looking flustered, Mii-chan gave a small, nervous gulp before decisively slapping her next card face down on the ground.

The moment her hand left the card, I snatched my ‘9’ back up, swapping it for a different card from my hand and setting it face down instead.

“You're... changing it?” she blinked.

“There's no rule saying I can't swap my card before we reveal,” I pointed out. “If you want to change yours, Mii-chan, you're more than welcome to.”

“Eh? Umm... no, I'm fine with this...”

“Let's flip them, then.”

Having obtained mutual consent, we turned the cards over. My number was ‘1’. Mii-chan's was ‘9’.

With that, we were tied at one win apiece. However, because she had just burned her strongest card, my victory was now entirely locked in the moment I played my ‘9’.

“Auu... I lost,” Mii-chan realized, her shoulders slumping.

“Let's just play the final round properly as a formality,” I said.

“...Okay.”

Before a completely frozen Mii-chan, I quickly placed my third card face down.

Naturally, that number was ‘9’. The card Mii-chan despairingly revealed was her ‘7’.

“We're finished,” I reported to the supervisor, my tone flat.

At this point, most of the other pairs were still just finishing up their opening rounds.

Right now, Mii-chan was probably lamenting her terrible luck, convinced that the game had just been an unfortunate turn of events.

But that wasn't true at all.

Precisely because the game was so mind-numbingly simple, it was incredibly easy to overlook a fatal flaw in the initial setup: the default structure of the hand.

When the supervisor dealt the five cards, they were perfectly arranged in numerical order. From the exact second the cards were handed to Mii-chan, I had been watching exactly how she held them. If she had shuffled her hand, or hidden the cards behind her back to reorder them, keeping track of their locations would have become impossible. However, she had gripped the cards in her hand exactly as they were dealt.

Under normal circumstances, once the match officially started, she probably would have unconsciously shuffled her hand out of habit. But by playing my card instantly and aggressively rushing her, I completely deleted the concept of 'shuffling' from her mind. By making her feel like rearranging her hand was pointless since her opponent was already waiting, I crushed her under the pressure to simply play a card *now*.

From there, the rest was practically automatic. Because I knew exactly where every number was in her hand, all I had to do was observe which card she pulled and swap my own card to guarantee the highest possible win rate. If she had managed to shake off the pressure in the second round and scrambled her hand, I would have simply pivoted my strategy to using conversation to fish for tells.

It just so happened that this time, even that wasn't necessary.

Shortly after our match concluded, the other pairs began to settle their games sequentially. While a few cases dragged into overtime, the final victors were Katsuragi, Morofuji, Minamikata, Ike, Amikura, Yoshida, and Sanada.

Chapter 3: The Approaching Tasks

❖

At six-thirty on the second day, the sun crested over the island, signaling the arrival of morning.

The light was still young, pale at the edges, filtering through the fabric of the tent in a muted glow. I woke to the faint sound of footsteps approaching through the quiet morning air, then slowly pushed myself upright.

Beside me, Yoshida and Sanada were still asleep. Their breathing remained calm and even, completely undisturbed by the presence outside.

Peering out of my tent, I found Katsuragi standing nearby.

For a brief moment, a faint look of surprise crossed his face, as though he hadn't expected me to emerge so quickly. But he quickly composed himself and offered a brief greeting.

“Good morning.”

I returned the greeting and stepped out into the morning air.

“Sorry,” Katsuragi said. “Did I wake you up?”

“I was already awake.”

“I see.” He paused briefly before continuing. “I hate to ask this first thing in the morning, but I’d like a little bit of your time. There’s something I want to discuss regarding this special exam before the second day’s assignments begin.”

Whether he had spent the night reaching his own conclusions, or if Ryūen had fed him instructions behind the scenes, I couldn’t tell.

Still, I nodded and quietly followed him. Once we were a safe distance away from the tents, Katsuragi stopped and turned to face me.

“In this special exam, there are several penalties that carry the risk of expulsion,” he began. “Among them, the only one that absolutely cannot be avoided is the expulsion tied to finishing in last place. Even if every student were to tie, it still cannot be bypassed. However, depending on the circumstances, I'm sure you understand that it can be overcome rather easily, don’t you?”

“A student with a Protection Point could become the scapegoat instead,” I said. “Assuming things work out cleanly enough to make that possible.”

“That’s right.” Katsuragi gave a small nod. “If this were only a problem within a single class, self-sacrifice would be a highly viable strategy. But in a competition involving the entire grade, that kind of sacrifice could easily end up benefiting the enemy.”

“If there’s anyone who’d self-sacrifice without caring whether it benefited allies or enemies, it would probably be someone from Ichinose’s class.”

Hearing that, Katsuragi fell silent for a moment.

“...Is there anyone in Ichinose’s class who has a protection point?”

There were certain details that had not been disclosed to the other classes. Katsuragi slipped the question in casually, as though it were nothing more than a natural extension of the conversation.

“Sorry, but I wouldn’t know,” I replied. “And even if I did, I wouldn’t tell you.”

“...Fair enough.”

The internal situation of Ichinose’s class wasn’t something I could casually discuss with a rivalling class.

In truth, I had already confirmed that, at present, no one in Class D possessed a protection point, not even Ichinose. Unfortunately, that meant executing such a strategy was entirely off the table.

"This is just my own speculation," I continued, "but regardless of whether she has a protection point or not, I believe Ichinose will hold off on making a move until the bitter end. While she wouldn't hesitate for a second if it meant protecting her own classmates, the current Ichinose isn't about to extend that same courtesy to the other classes."

"If your prediction holds true," Katsuragi mused, "then unless a student with a Protection Point coincidentally ends up at the bottom, there's a very high chance someone gets expelled the day after tomorrow. And since nobody can see the total token counts across the entire grade, students will naturally focus less on token multipliers and more on simply avoiding last place within their own group."

That alone would become enough of a psychological anchor.

If someone could confirm they possessed even slightly more tokens than another student, it would at least provide temporary reassurance.

Of course, reality was nowhere near that simple.

Unless you physically verified someone's token count, certainty was impossible.

Furthermore, since tokens could be freely transferred twenty-four hours a day, that underlying anxiety surrounding the rankings could never truly be dispelled.

"So, what do you plan to do?" Katsuragi asked.

"That's a rather straightforward question," I replied. "Are you really that curious about my next move?"

"There's only so much I can do," Katsuragi said calmly. "I don't want anyone from Class B getting expelled, but I can't keep track of classmates outside my own group. So at the very least, I want to make sure nobody in the group I'm assigned to gets expelled."

Katsuragi wasn't the only one who felt that way. In fact, the vast majority of the student body likely shared his sentiment.

Allowing an expulsion to emerge from your own group carried a heavy burden of collective responsibility. That's why it was only natural to want to save those within one's reach.

"The way you went after Ike and Shinohara yesterday..." Katsuragi continued. "Wasn't there a reason behind that as well?"

The way Katsuragi framed the question made it clear he didn't believe I had picked a fight for no reason, nor did he think my attitude was born from petty personal grievances.

However, I gave a light shake of my head, brushing off his suspicions.

"If that's what you thought, then I'm afraid you're overestimating me," I said. "Those two and I simply don't get along."

"Are you saying you provoked your own group members based on personal feelings?" Katsuragi frowned slightly. "That seems highly uncharacteristic of you. I always thought you were the calm and quiet type."

"Ike and the others said it too, didn't they?" I replied. "That maybe I revealed my true colours after becoming the class leader."

Katsuragi fell silent for a moment, studying me.

"...I find that rather hard to believe," he said at last. "But fine."

Perhaps sensing that pressing any further wouldn't get him any closer to the truth, Katsuragi steered the conversation forward.

"Whatever your true intentions may be, our fundamental priorities should still align. Neither of us wants to see our classmates expelled. With that as a given, surely there's room for us to cooperate in certain areas?"

“It’s true that as members of the same group, there are areas where we can work together,” I replied. “But on a fundamental level, your way of thinking about the penalties differs greatly from mine. Joining hands might prove difficult.”

“Differs...?”

“Katsuragi, your desire to avoid expulsions stems entirely from the fact that they’re your classmates.”

I paused briefly before continuing.

“But drawing an arbitrary line between your own class and the others misses the point entirely. The real question is whether or not a student actually has the value required to survive this special exam. Whether they’re a member of the same group or the same class is irrelevant. If they don’t measure up to that standard, then their expulsion is simply inevitable.”

Katsuragi listened quietly before responding.

“I won’t deny that logic,” he said. “But treating everyone with perfect objectivity is far easier said than done. Furthermore, prioritizing one’s allies is not wrong. Rather, it’s a completely natural instinct. That isn’t just a rule born of this special exam; if you look back through human history, you’ll find the exact same principle at work.”

Whether they shared the same birthplace. The same race. The same nation.

Humanity has always drawn a line somewhere. Once those boundaries were set, people fought with everything they had to protect those they deemed allies, and struck down those they recognized as enemies.

“I’m not saying that you have to think the same way,” Katsuragi concluded. “But that is what I believe the natural order should be.”

It wasn't about forcing a specific outcome upon anyone.

Rather, within the natural framework of society itself, those destined to receive penalties would emerge on their own, and those unfit to remain would quietly disappear.

“So then, are you saying you would be fine with a student from Class C finishing last and being expelled in this exam?” Katsuragi’s brow furrowed. “If that is the case, then perhaps our views on penalties really are different.”

His voice remained calm.

“But if you truly think that way, I have to say… I’m somewhat disappointed.”

“Eliminating those who lack ability or who disrupt the harmony of the class often triggers a self-purifying effect,” I replied with ease. “Of course, I’m not saying every student expelled so far fell into that category. But at the same time Yamauchi, Sakura, and Maezono disappeared. And though it happened before you transferred, Manabe was cut from Ryūen’s class as well. While losing numbers puts a class at a disadvantage, looking at the bigger picture, it isn't entirely a net loss.”

It wasn’t the kind of logic that would ever resonate with someone like Katsuragi, who sought to protect his comrades. Then again, very few people would ever enjoy hearing something so callous.

“Sorry for taking up your time so early in the morning.”

It was a brief exchange, lasting less than five minutes. Katsuragi gave a single, curt nod, offered a brief apology, and walked back to his tent, making no effort to hide his disappointment in me.

By the time we separated, it was just past seven in the morning.

After waiting a short while, I returned to Class C’s tent. Yoshida was already awake, busying himself outside the tent with breakfast preparations. Sanada was up as well, working on some chores a short distance away.

"Looks like you and Katsuragi were talking for quite a while, huh?" Yoshida remarked.

"You noticed?"

"After you left the tent, I heard Katsuragi's voice for a bit," he said. "I was curious, but I figured it'd be rude to interrupt. Was it about the special exam?"

Since he already knew I had gone outside to talk, there was probably no need to hide it.

"He asked whether we could cooperate to prevent expulsions from our classes."

"So, are you planning to team up with Class B?"

There was no approval or objection in Yoshida's voice. He simply seemed interested in what decision I would make as the leader.

"Unfortunately, the negotiation broke down," I said. "This isn't a problem that can be solved between two classes alone anyway. Still, on this second day, we may start seeing movements in various places as people attempt for that kind of cooperation."

"Then we'd better keep our eyes peeled."

Yoshida's expression hardened as he cast a wary, sweeping glance toward the tents of the other classes.

Part 1

Shortly after finishing breakfast with Yoshida and the others, the supervisor's instructions echoed across the campsite.

"Now then, I would like to announce the first task of the day. You will be taking on a large number of tasks starting this morning, so please remain focused and approach them with care."

Retrieving four tablets, he distributed one to each class representative.

"For this 'Team' task, four classes will compete in a simple academic test, taking turns using a tablet. The order in which the four members of each team take the test is completely random. First place will receive 3 tokens, second place 2 tokens, third place 1 token, and fourth place will receive no reward."

With that preface complete, the supervisor started announcing details.

If all four members of a class won their rounds, the class could earn twelve tokens. On the other hand, if all four finished last, they would walk away with nothing.

There was no direct risk attached to the task. Even so, it was the kind of test that could create subtle disparities in the number of tokens held by each class.

The important thing was the order in which we tackled the test. Rather than having top-tier students clash head-to-head, the ideal scenario was to be paired against opponents you could edge out by a narrow margin. For our Class C lineup, the randomized order fell to Morishita, Sanada, Yoshida, and myself.

True to the supervisor's word, the format was remarkably simple. Each round consisted of ten multiple-choice questions with five possible answers, drawn from a specific subject. If two or more students had the same number of correct answers, their ranking would be decided by the time taken to complete all ten questions.

Morishita placed third in her round, and Sanada took first in his. Yoshida went next, but his opponents were Katsuragi, Mii-chan, and Amikura. With that lineup, he ended in fourth place. Finally, I anchored the group and secured a first-place finish.

In total, Class C walked away with seven tokens. Over in Class A, despite Ike and Shinohara finishing dead last in their respective rounds, Kushida and Mii-chan were blessed with favorable matchups and both secured first place, bringing their total to six tokens. Class B earned five, while Class D matched Class A with six.

All things considered, the opening task had produced almost no significant difference between the classes.

"The gap didn't widen nearly as much as I expected," Yoshida muttered.

He was right. As a single task, the difference amounted to only one or two tokens, well within the margin of error.

However, judging from how smoothly the first task had been carried out, it was unlikely that things would end with just this.

"Now then, we will move on to the next task. The order will once again be randomized."

The supervisor announced that the subject would change, and there on the uninhabited island, we once again turned toward the tablets.

In total, we repeated the same process five times.

At first, the results had been separated by only narrow margins. But as luck and ability began to show their uneven distribution, the scores gradually converged toward what could be called their natural expected values.

From the second round onward, the tasks proceeded without changing format, but their underlying nature had certainly transformed. While the luck of the matchups and coincidence had influenced the results in the first round, as the rounds repeated, those elements were gradually filtered out, allowing each individual's pure academic and processing abilities to manifest directly as their rankings.

The simple structure of ten multiple-choice questions stripped away any room for bluffing.

Since ties in correct answers were decided by time, nearly perfect scores became the standard among the top students. Ultimately, the deciding factor became how efficiently one could process the questions without wasting time.

The lack of hesitation, the speed of grasping the question's intent, and the accuracy in eliminating options. A slight delay in any one of those areas alone was enough to make someone fall one or even two ranks lower.

Among all of them, the two who consistently remained near the top were Sanada and Katsuragi.

Sanada was consistent from beginning to end. No matter what kind of question appeared before him, his judgment never dulled.

The efficiency with which he operated made it seem as though his answer had already been decided the instant he finished reading the question, placing him far above the others in balancing speed and precision.

Katsuragi, meanwhile, approached the competition differently.

Rather than securing a perfect score, he prioritized staying firmly in the upper ranks. By dedicating time only to the necessary portions, he optimized his overall processing. As a result, he displayed great strength in time-based tie-breakers and made remarkably few mistakes.

Just beneath those two, another layer of students gradually began to emerge:

Mii-chan and Kushida.

Neither possessed blistering speed, but they rarely misread a question. Their unshakeable grasp of the fundamentals ensured they never suffered any major collapses.

Kushida finished last in the second round, but from the middle stages onward, she regained her balance. Once her rhythm returned, she began steadily stacking up correct answers, one after another.

Mii-chan, meanwhile, progressed through the problems at the same rhythm throughout, leading to minimal fluctuations in her ranking, fulfilling a role where she steadily picked up 2nd and 3rd place finishes.

In a prolonged competition like this, the existence of students who simply remained consistent and didn't make mistakes translated directly into a steady accumulation of tokens.

Of course, not everyone adapted so smoothly.

As the rounds continued, the faces repeatedly settling near the bottom also became increasingly clear.

Among them, Ibuki's decline stood out the most.

The questions themselves weren't exceptionally difficult.

Even so, Ibuki had a terrible habit of abandoning a problem before fully grasping its intent. The moment her understanding faltered, she'd simply give up and select an answer, practically leaving the outcome to chance.

At first glance, that kind of decision-making might have looked efficient. It certainly allowed her to move quickly. But without any solid reasoning backing her choices, her results were inherently unstable.

While she occasionally managed to scrape together a correct answer by sheer fluke, those fleeting moments of luck didn’t continue. As the rounds piled up, probability smoothed out the fluctuations, and her ranking naturally drifted to the bottom.

It wasn't a temporary stroke of bad luck, but rather the consequence of her deeply flawed approach.

What came as a mild surprise was the performance of Ike and Shinohara, two students who similarly struggled with academics.

Contrary to initial expectations, they didn't throw in the towel on the questions, maintaining their stance of trying to get as close to the correct answer as possible within their limited knowledge. They scrutinized the options one by one, and while hesitating, attached reasoning to narrow down their answers. Their process could by no means be called efficient, and there were many moments where they needed time to make a decision, but at the very least, they did not abandon thinking.

Unfortunately, their earnest effort didn't directly translate into favorable results. They simply couldn't bridge the gap left by their lack of foundational knowledge, which put a hard ceiling on their total correct answers. Furthermore, their extreme caution severely inflated their completion times, putting them at a massive disadvantage whenever a tie-breaker occurred.

Consequently, they remained firmly entrenched in the lower ranks. While they rarely sank to dead last like Ibuki, they could never quite manage to break out of the bottom two or three spots.

By the time all five trials had concluded, a gradual yet undeniable gap in the token counts had emerged between the classes.

In the first round, differences of one or two places had been no more than margins of error. But with each repetition, those small differences accumulated. Eventually, they turned into a gap that could no longer be ignored.

The divide wasn't overwhelmingly dramatic, but that was precisely what made it so difficult to overturn. More than anything, it was a perfectly accurate reflection of genuine ability.

In other words, success here wasn’t determined by one standalone win, but by who could keep performing under pressure and produce results consistently.

It ultimately boiled down to one single metric: the fundamental ability of the students.

And those who failed to meet that standard were quietly and inevitably left behind.

Part 2

Up until now, the uninhabited island exam had been a primarily physical ordeal. Following this abrupt shift to intense mental exertion, the exhausted students simply collapsed right where they stood the moment a break was called.

Unlike the sharp, burning ache of physical fatigue, this prolonged mental strain left a dull, lingering heaviness in the back of their minds. Unable to immediately shift gears and plan their next move, everyone simply surrendered to the brief, heavy silence.

During this respite, the students naturally gravitated toward their own classmates, keeping a wary distance from the other groups. The class representatives then began the meticulous work of distributing the tokens earned from the tasks, adhering to their own pre-established rules.

Our Class C was no exception.

I took our total earnings and divided them by four, handing out the respective shares to Yoshida, Morishita, and Sanada. I intentionally opted for a completely even split, choosing not to stagger the distribution based on individual performance.

“Ike keeps glancing over here,” Yoshida muttered.

“Don’t worry about it,” I replied. “It isn’t just us. He’s curious about all three classes.”

After all, the distribution of tokens was far more than a simple payout of rewards. It was a display of one's contributions laid bare as a numerical value. Naturally, people couldn't help but unconsciously fixate on the shares their peers were taking home.

“It is a battle against the fear of ending up last, after all,” Sanada said.

Perhaps his lenses had become dirty, as he quietly removed his glasses and wiped them with the edge of his shirt.

"I have no idea who's getting how many tokens," Yoshida said after checking the amount he had been given. His eyes drifted, casually toward the other three classes. "Even looking at it by class, it's getting harder to tell how much of a gap has opened up."

Since most of our focus had been devoted entirely to the tests themselves, it wasn't surprising that nobody had perfectly tracked who placed where in every round.

"I'm starting to feel a little anxious myself," Morishita said. "Please give me five extra tokens for emotional stability."

I decided to ignore her unreasonable demand.

More than the rankings themselves, what lingered in everyone's minds were fragmented impressions and half-seen results. People tried piecing those fragments together to grasp the larger picture, but there simply wasn't enough information to arrive at certainty. And that looming ambiguity only fanned the flames of everyone's anxiety.

"Katsuragi-kun, Wang-san, and Kushida-san all seemed to be steadily taking higher places," Sanada said. "So if we look at it by class, there may not actually be as much of a gap as we think."

Sanada, who had a clearer grasp of the situation than Yoshida, answered with calm precision.

His words merely traced the facts. Even so, there was more behind them. On one hand, they carried the reassurance that, at this moment, no decisive gap had yet formed. On the other, they implied that precisely because things remained close, the next move could cause everything to shift at once.

Of course, it was true that the gaps between classes were widening little by little.

But each task offered only a limited number of tokens, so the difference had not yet opened dramatically. That much was also true.

However, that applied only when looking at the whole. When viewing the results by team.

Since each individual's performance appeared directly as numbers, the situation within each class was different. Even among classmates, differences had begun to spread quietly, but surely.

If we turned our attention to the individual level, the gaps were probably reaching the point where they would begin to widen faster than expected.

"Wait a second!" Ibuki's voice suddenly cut through the break. "What do you mean I only get two?!"

Under normal circumstances, the exact number of tokens someone received was not information that should be allowed to leak to other classes. It was strategic data, the kind of thing better kept hidden.

But in a class where distribution itself was based on comparing individual contributions, complete secrecy was rather difficult to maintain. And when the result was one a student could not accept, dissatisfaction had a way of spilling out before anyone could contain it.

Ibuki, furious, seemed to have no thought at all for the information she was exposing. She rounded on Katsuragi and began shouting loudly enough for everyone nearby to hear.

Her emotions had overtaken her. Profit, loss, risk, none of that seemed to matter in the moment. The only thing driving her actions was the fact that she could not accept the result.

"I told you from the very beginning," Katsuragi replied firmly. "Tokens would be distributed fairly, based on your performance. The tasks thus far have centered entirely around academics, which is your weak point, and you significantly dragged us down. You finished last every time. If anything, I could say I judged you leniently by giving you a reward at all."

His words contained no visible emotion. But for that very reason, they allowed no ambiguity. Katsuragi did not try to soften the truth or dress it in comfort. He simply placed the facts before her and, by doing so, closed off any room for rebuttal.

The remaining two members of Class B seemed to have no objection to his reasoning. If anything, they appeared to agree.

As long as the standard for distribution was clear, introducing personal feelings into it would only create the possibility that they themselves might be disadvantaged later. There was no reason for them to deny Katsuragi here.

They had seen it themselves. Ibuki had finished last in every round.

In other words, the number of tokens Ibuki had personally earned was zero. From that perspective, giving her even two tokens could only be described as Katsuragi's generosity.

"Are you trying to make me come in last or something?" Ibuki snapped.

"Don't be ridiculous," Katsuragi replied. "I have not the slightest desire to see anyone from our class expelled. However, if I distributed tokens equally even to a student who dragged us down, I would be causing trouble for Sonoda and Morofuji."

His gaze remained steady.

"This is a special exam where expulsion is at stake. I absolutely cannot endanger those two with an unfair judgement."

For Katsuragi, too, this was a bitter decision. That was the part he emphasized.

To protect someone, another person had to swallow their dissatisfaction.

That structure remained constant throughout the entire exam. This situation was no exception.

"Then..." Ibuki said, her voice lower now, though the anger had not disappeared. "If I actually contribute properly, you'll give me more, right?"

"Of course."

Katsuragi answered without the slightest hesitation.

Ibuki clicked her tongue sharply, then turned and walked away.

Her back showed her dissatisfaction and frustration plainly. But at the same time, she understood the reality in front of her. If she wanted to overturn Katsuragi's judgment, words would not be enough.

She would have to do it by producing results.

Part 3

The sun was already high overhead, and the air across the island was beginning to feel humid.

The clock had only just passed nine in the morning, yet the quiet hours of dawn already felt strangely distant.

A breeze slipped through the gaps between the trees, brushing faintly against our sweat-damp skin. Under normal circumstances, the sensation might have been pleasant. Now, it only seemed like one more thing dulling the mind.

After so many mentally demanding assignments in a row, everyone's concentration had clearly been worn thin. The brief silence before the next physical task felt stretched out far longer than it actually was.

Nobody could fully relax while waiting for the next task, and everyone remained where they were, carrying an awkward lingering tension.

"From this point onward," Urushihara announced, "you will be taking on several physically oriented tasks."

The atmosphere among certain students visibly lightened. After being forced through round after round of mental battles, the prospect of a physical challenge offered relief to those who had been bottling up frustration.

For anyone who had fallen behind in academic contests, this was finally their chance to show what they were truly capable of.

“This will also be a Team task,” Urushihara continued. “Each class will form pairs of two. Just like before, the pairs will be selected randomly by us. This task will test your core strength. The pair that can stand on one leg the longest without putting a foot down will win. The class with the first-place pair will receive ten tokens, second place will receive five, and third place will receive three. The class with the last-place pair will have two tokens withdrawn from their representative.”

The rules were simple enough.

If either member of a pair placed both feet on the ground, that pair lost.

It was classified as a physical challenge, but there was room for strategy. As long as one foot remained raised, students were apparently allowed to hold hands, link shoulders, or use whatever method they preferred. The details were left to each pair.

At a glance, it looked like a straightforward test of physical endurance.

However, it demanded compatibility and coordination between partners.

Individual ability alone wouldn’t be enough. Victory would depend on whether each pair could adjust to the other’s condition and distribute the strain properly.

“Huh? Pairs? Why isn't it individual...?”

For someone as confident in her physical ability as Ibuki, being forced to cooperate with another person was a clear disadvantage.

Depending on her partner, she might end up carrying a heavy burden, or worse, being dragged down entirely.

It was only natural that she wasn’t pleased.

The more confident someone was in winning alone, the more they hated uncertain variables like other people.

For Ibuki, this kind of cooperation was less an advantage than a restriction.

Meanwhile, I was paired with Sanada, and Yoshida ended up with Morishita.

Considering Sanada's build, his higher center of gravity, and the likely limits of his endurance, trying to support each other evenly would be unwise. The most stable approach would be for me to serve as the axis while absorbing as much of the strain as possible.

Ibuki, who had already been muttering complaints, made no attempt to hide her disappointment and anger once she learned that Morofuji would be her partner.

Given Morofuji's temperament, it was obvious that any emotional instability would directly affect her posture.

For Ibuki, it was probably one of the pairings she least wanted to draw.

"So, what would be the optimal approach here?" Sanada asked. "There's a bit of a height difference between us, so linking shoulders seems like it would throw off our balance… Also, to tell you the truth, I'm not very confident."

If the rules allowed one person to drop out while the other continued, then the best strategy would simply be for me to stand alone.

In fact, I'd prefer not to have unnecessary support or cooperation at all.

But if Sanada went down, I'd automatically be eliminated with him.

Since there was no point in only one of us remaining, everything came down to how we designed the load distribution.

"We should avoid clinging too tightly to each other," I said. "That kind of strategy only works when both people are at high risk of falling."

"So you're confident in standing on one leg?"

"More or less."

I shifted my weight lightly.

"Think of me as an object fixed in place, like a tree. Do whatever you need to stay balanced on one leg for even a second longer."

"You mean I can hold on or lean against you however I like… Are you sure?"

"Yeah. As a pair, that's probably the optimal solution available to us."

By taking on Sanada's burden myself, we could extend our total endurance.

It was a setup to prevent a collapse in the long term, rather than seeking short-term stability.

"Now then," Urushihara called. "We will begin the task. Ready—start."

At the supervisor's signal, all sixteen students lifted one foot into the air at once.

While everyone moved at the same time, the real differences wouldn't reveal themselves immediately. The question was how long each pair could hold out.

At the start, there was no major gap between any of the pairs. Some supported each other. Some kept their distance. Some rested their weight against each other's shoulders. Their chosen methods differed, but none of their postures looked fragile enough to fall apart right away.

The real problem lay beyond that. After several dozen seconds, or once the first minute passed, the tiniest distortions in posture would begin to accumulate.

Those distortions wouldn't be large enough to be noticed at a glance, but they would definitely become the seeds leading to a collapse. If they failed to correct their posture in time, a chain reaction would send them tumbling to the ground.

The strain concentrated in the supporting leg increased steadily with every passing second.

The sensation of the sole against the ground began to blur. The ankle, which had been quietly making tiny adjustments, could no longer fully suppress the tremors.

The balance they had initially maintained through conscious effort eventually gave way, plunging them into a desperate, agonizing struggle just to stay upright.

The transition from merely maintaining a pose to desperately enduring it. How quickly a student could adapt to that shift would dictate how long they could survive.

"S-sorry, Kikyō-chan," Ike said, "You know… we kind of ended up pressed close together like this."

Whether it was for the tokens, or because the task had given him a legitimate excuse to press close to her, Ike tried his best to sound calm.

His voice betrayed him anyway. An unmistakable pitch of excitement had already slipped into it.

Under the pretext of maintaining their posture, Ike's shoulder touched Kushida's. It was obvious that he was far too conscious of the sensation carried through that contact, and of the distance, or lack of it, between them. His eyes weren't focused on the task in front of him either. They kept drifting toward Kushida beside him.

The moment his attention had strayed from where it ought to be, the risk had already taken root.

The problem was that Ike himself didn't realize it.

"That bastard Ike…" Yoshida muttered beside me while struggling together with Morishita. "Honestly, I'm kind of jealous…"

Perhaps he had imagined himself paired with Shiraishi, the girl he had his eye on. Or perhaps he simply couldn't stand the fact that Ike had been paired with a cute girl at all.

"You're legally allowed to touch my body right now, you know," Morishita said. "Deep down, you are actually thrilled about it, aren't you?"

"Who the hell would be thrilled, idiot?!"

His denial came out too forcefully.

Whether that brief outburst disrupted his core or threw off his focus, Yoshida's balance faltered. Morishita, dragged along by the movement, ended up putting her foot down as a result.

They were eliminated.

But perhaps realizing that raising their voices might disturb Sanada, who was still fighting to hold on, both of them immediately sealed their mouths shut.

A single reaction from the losers could break the concentration of those still remaining. Their silence came from understanding that much.

Kushida, meanwhile, showed no sign of rejecting Ike's behavior. Nor did she give him any special encouragement.

She simply smiled naturally, treating the closeness as nothing more than part of the cooperation required for the task.

Her sense of distance was exquisite. Not too close and not too far. She maintained a position that allowed the other person to mistake it for permission. He was not being rejected at least. That alone was enough for someone like Ike to interpret the situation positively, and perhaps that thought accelerated his awareness of her even further.

He nearly lost his balance for a moment, but somehow managed to recover.

“Uwooooh! I'm not done yet!”

Shinohara, who was paired with Mii-chan, glared sharply at Ike as he got carried away. But perhaps because she had no room to carelessly call out to him, she remained silent.

Even so, her gaze carried unmistakable emotion.

She was desperately enduring, trying not to lose her balance, yet part of her attention remained fixed on Ike and Kushida. She should not have had any spare room to be distracted by something unnecessary, but the sight in her field of vision was impossible for her to ignore.

As a result, subtle disturbances began creeping into Shinohara’s posture.

She tried to correct it, but Mii-chan was pulled along as well, her own concentration chipped away by the movement. The situation grew increasingly difficult for both of them.

As long as they were a pair, one person’s instability would inevitably spread to the other.

Here too, the very burden they shared became their weakness.

Unaware of the strain those two were suffering through, Ike kept his arm around Kushida’s shoulder and whispered near her ear.

“Heh… Maybe we’re actually more compatible than I thought.”

“Mm, maybe so,” Kushida replied with a soft smile. “You’re really good at this, Ike-kun, so that helps a lot. Let’s keep going as long as we can.”

“O-of course. I’ll keep going… even one second longer…!”

A single compliment was enough to warp his concentration even further.

What he needed to maintain was his posture, but his attention had already been pulled somewhere else entirely.

One minute passed then two.

A one-legged stance that would never last long alone was being prolonged through cooperation between partners.

From this point onward, it was no longer a contest of stamina, but of how long they could postpone collapse.

Still, standing on one leg was never something the human body could maintain indefinitely. Even with mutual support, the time gained wasn’t dramatic. As the three-minute mark approached, one pair fell. Then another.

Limits did not arrive equally for everyone. The moment of collapse in a person came suddenly and often chained down the other one as well.

The next pair to fall was, as expected, Shinohara and Mii-chan.

The instant one of them lost balance, that tremor propagated directly to the partner, and they collapsed in a chain reaction without any room to correct it. The choice to support each other was effective, but at the same time, it carried the risk of falling together.

Conversely, pairs that kept too much distance soon began to drop out as well. Relying on individual stability alone made the opening moments easier, but as time passed, the burden of standing alone accumulated. Once one person reached their limit, if support did not arrive in time, the end came immediately.

The remaining pairs all occupied the space between those extremes.

They didn't completely support each other, nor were they completely independent. They only made contact and distributed the load when necessary. Whether or not they could make those adjustments became the difference here.

“Get it together,” Ibuki snapped. “Don’t you dare put your foot down until I say it’s okay. We’re absolutely winning this!”

In contrast to Ibuki’s fierce determination, Morofuji’s face was already twisted in pain.

“This is… actually really tough…”

Mental pressure and physical exhaustion were hitting her at the same time.

Sanada, who was gripping onto me, was in a similar state. The strain on the sole and ankle of his supporting right foot had clearly become too much to bear, and little by little, more of his weight began shifting onto me.

“Sorry,” Sanada said, his voice strained. “I think this is starting to get a little hard for me too…”

“Just hold out as long as you can.”

“But Ayanokōji-kun…” His small tremors had begun to increase. “Are you still all right?”

I answered only with a slight glance.

Of course, supporting an unstable Sanada meant I could not continue indefinitely either. No matter how steady I kept myself, absorbing another person's shifting weight would eventually consume stamina.

The pairs still holding on were Ibuki and Morofuji, and Amikura and Minamikata.

Third place wouldn't have been a bad result, but this was probably the moment to make a move. If there was a chance to raise our ranking by even one place, it was worth taking.

The question was how to make that happen.

"Morofuji."

I deliberately called out her name.

There was no rule forbidding students from speaking while standing on one leg.

The moment she heard her name, Morofuji's shoulders jolted, and her gaze, until then fixed desperately on her footing, snapped toward me.

All I needed was to divert her attention.

That alone was enough to disrupt balance.

"W-ww-what?"

The fear Morofuji had carried toward me ever since our group first formed was still there.

I said nothing more. Instead, I simply held her gaze and continued staring directly into her eyes.

She seemed to have a strong sense of discomfort around me, that was enough.

Fear, by itself, places a burden on both mind and body.

And what she was supporting now wasn't only physical weight.

"H-hey, Morofuji, you're wobbling!" Ibuki snapped.

Ibuki herself still had some room to spare. But once her partner's core began to collapse, the burden on her increased sharply. A disturbance on one side led directly to collapse.

Meanwhile, Sanada no longer had the room to pay attention to an opponent's movements.

"Why is this so tough...ugh..."

The surrounding noise no longer seemed to reach him. His awareness had turned inward, toward the battle with his own body.

Core strength mattered, but the calves and ankles bore more strain than most people imagined. In an extreme state, outside information was discarded. Only the battle within remained.

Sanada's weight gradually leaned toward me.

Each time it did, I used a small amount of strength to correct it. A slight adjustment of the shoulder. A minor shift through the hip. A quiet compensation through the leg acting as my axis.

None of it was large on its own.

But the accumulation of those small corrections rapidly whittled away at my physical strength. The limit of an individual.

Before long, Sanada reached his limit and put his foot down.

Fortunately, Morofuji had done the same just moments earlier.

Thanks to that, we managed to slip into second place.

Chapter 4: Nanase and Amasawa's Private Pool Time

❖

It was eleven in the morning.

High above the decks of the passenger ship, where the sea breeze softened against glass walls and the sunlight spilled cleanly across the water, lay a completely secluded private pool.

Appearing a little ahead of the appointed time, there was Amasawa Ichika of Class 2-A.

Already changed into her swimsuit, she stepped out into the deserted oasis.

“Being in a private rental really does feel special~” she said, her voice bright and teasing as she glanced around the empty poolside. “You're seriously footing the bill for this, right, Nanase-chan?”

Arriving at the pool just a step behind her was Class 2-D’s Nanase Tsubasa.

“Yes,” Nanase replied with her usual composure. “Since I was the one who selfishly called you out here today, please do not worry about the expense.”

Nanase had booked the private pool for a sixty-minute block. With another student scheduled to take over right at noon, their time here was strictly limited.

“This place was twenty thousand points last year, but now it costs twenty-five thousand, doesn't it? It's hilarious how the rental fee just casually went up. Looks like the wave of inflation has even reached us out here~”

But the clock was ticking, even as they made small talk. Amasawa immediately claimed a lounge chair and snatched up a menu.

"I'm totally ordering something expensive," she hummed, tapping her index finger against the glossy pictures as she pondered her options.

"Please, order whatever you like," Nanase replied. "Though, from the standpoint of preventing food waste, I ask that you try not to leave any leftovers."

"So *that's* what you're worried about. Must mean you have plenty of Private Points saved up, nya?"

"Not necessarily. I am simply a saver by nature," Nanase answered with cool indifference.

Hearing this, Amasawa narrowed her eyes in a sly smile.

"In that case, you must have paid for all this because you decided a little private time with me was worth the splurge."

Keeping her gaze glued strictly to the menu, Amasawa casually guided the conversation forward.

"That is correct." Nanase said. "I intend to make our time together worthwhile."

Intentionally avoiding Nanase's expression, Amasawa gave a small nod and snapped the menu shut with a definitive *thwack*.

"I think I'll go with a melon cream soda! What about you, Nanase-chan?"

She held the menu out to Nanase, who accepted it only to place it back onto the table unopened.

"I am fine, thank you."

"Hmm, really? Well, suit yourself~"

After casually placing the order for her melon cream soda, Amasawa turned her attention back to the girl standing beside her. Slowly, deliberately, she let her eyes roam up and down the length of Nanase's body, her appraising gaze trailing over her as if licking her from head to toe.

Nanase's face remained a completely blank slate. Betraying neither anger nor amusement, she kept her true feelings perfectly concealed behind an emotionless facade.

Driven by an irresistible urge to peel that mask away, Amasawa lowered her gaze.

"But seriously, Nanase-chan, haven't you grown another cup size this past year?" Amasawa teased. "I think I've developed pretty well myself, but... it looks like you've got me beat~"

"That is sexual harassment."

"Oh, come on. It's your fault for having the kind of body that is just asking for it~"

"Under normal circumstances, that would be an unforgivable statement," Nanase replied coldly. "I do not believe I am at fault in the slightest."

An ordinary high school girl would have reacted with intense embarrassment or disgust. Yet, Nanase radiated absolutely nothing. It wasn't that Amasawa thought she was completely devoid of emotion; rather, whenever Nanase flipped a certain internal switch, her mental defenses became impenetrably high.

"That swimsuit is pretty bold, too. Quite the aggressive fashion statement." Fully expecting a reprimand, Amasawa forcefully pressed the attack, desperate to find a crack in the Nanase's armor.

"I merely rented a design that a classmate recommended. Is there a problem with that?"

"Not a *problem,* exactly. I just figured the boys wouldn't know where to look."

“Are you not in the exact same situation, Amasawa-san?”

It was a fair point. Amasawa was wearing a swimsuit a full grade flashier than any of the other girls they’d seen at the pool, proving her tastes were just as daring as Nanase's.

“In my case, it's totally fine, because I'm showing off on purpose!” Amasawa laughed. “The boys stare at me with lust in their eyes, and the girls glare at me with raging jealousy. I love being the center of attention.”

“...Is that so?”

Perhaps unable to process that particular brand of exhibitionism, a slightly troubled frown flickered across Nanase's face. It was the first genuine display of emotion she had shown, but just as quickly as it appeared, her rigid, stoic mask slammed back into place.

“Anyway, to change the subject for a sec...” Amasawa hummed. “I heard someone from Class 2-D was forced to say bye-bye during the Special Exam the other day. Is your class holding up okay, nya?”

The question wasn't born out of genuine interest. Amasawa was simply tossing it out as a way to kill time until her drink arrived.

For a fraction of a second, Nanase’s expression stiffened. Letting out a soft exhale, she averted her eyes and stared off into the distance.

While the third-year students had landed on an uninhabited island to begin their survival exam, the second-years had been locked in a fierce competition of their own through a unique Special Exam. The results had been definitive: Class A secured first place, Class C took second, and Class B came in third. That left Nanase’s Class D sitting dead last.

Up until this point, the dynamic among the second-years had been a slow, steady crawl, with Class A gradually pulling away from the rest of the pack. Now, however, that gap was widening into a chasm. But this latest exam had been more than just a simple defeat for Class D. During the course of the trial, an expulsion had been finalized. They had suffered a casualty.

“The class itself is functioning without issue,” Nanase replied quietly. “However, since the responsibility for his expulsion ultimately lies with me, I am left with mixed feelings on the matter.”

“Wait, it's *your* responsibility, Nanase-chan? Was that how the story went? I thought he broke a rule or something.”

Amasawa hadn't paid much attention to the Special Exam, but she had overheard a few rumors regarding the circumstances of the expulsion.

“In truth,” Nanase said. “another student was supposed to be expelled.”

“That's a pretty provocative way of putting it. Are you saying *you* tried to get someone expelled, Nanase-chan?”

“That is correct.”

It was the kind of statement that would earn a harsh scolding even if said as a joke, yet Nanase affirmed it instantly, without a shred of hesitation.

“However, my target realized my intentions early on and devised countermeasures,” Nanase explained. “Then, as a warning, they cornered a student in Class D who had absolutely nothing to do with the incident. Knowing full well the severe penalty he would face, the expelled student must have been driven into such a mental corner that he felt he had no other choice but to break the rules.”

Having her curiosity slightly piqued, Amasawa sat up from her lounge chair and scrutinized Nanase's face.

While she couldn't detect any hints of guilt or regret in Nanase's eyes, there was an undeniable frustration seeping through her rigid mask.

“Doesn't sound like a very peaceful story.”

“Does that interest you?”

“Eh? Sorry, not really.” Sensing she was about to be dragged into something tedious, Amasawa offered a dismissive reply.

But Nanase had clearly anticipated the evasion and pressed on without hesitation. “You are not entirely divorced from this incident, Amasawa-san. In fact, you already know the details, do you not?”

“My heart belongs solely to Ayanokōji-senpai,” Amasawa answered, her tone dripping with mock devotion. “I couldn't care less about silly squabbles between classmates, y'know?”

Unfazed by the flippant deflection, Nanase continued. “The student I was trying to expel was from Class 2-A.”

“Ah, so *that's* where the ‘not divorced’ part comes in. Sorry to disappoint, but I seriously had no clue. Nor do I care about this even a tiny bit. Still... who were you targeting?”

Amasawa tilted her head, genuinely curious as to who in her class could have possibly provoked Nanase into wanting them expelled.

“Ishigami-kun,” Nanase replied.

“Ishigami?” Amasawa repeated. “The cool, handsome guy? He doesn't exactly seem like the type to make moves out in the open.”

Despite sharing a class with him for over a year, Amasawa had practically zero contact with the boy. In truth, she had absolutely no interest in anyone in her own grade. Because she never bothered interacting with her peers, she barely even knew their basic personalities. It was safe to say the girl standing right in front of her was her one and only object of interest in the entire second year.

As these thoughts drifted casually through Amasawa's mind, she noticed Nanase fixing her with a razor-sharp glare.

“He is far sharper than one might imagine,” Nanase warned.

“Hmm. Well, I know he's essentially in a leader-like position, but Ishigami-kun, huh... So, what made you decide to pick a fight with him? Y'know, just to pry a little.”

“There are... certain circumstances behind it.”

The atmosphere around Nanase underwent a subtle shift. Instantly, Amasawa became absolutely certain that this topic, one she had brought up purely to kill time, was the actual reason she had been summoned here today.

“I'm starting to get the feeling that this little story and my invitation to the pool are connected.”

“Just to be absolutely certain,” Nanase said, her voice dropping a fraction, “you were not involved in this incident, were you, Amasawa-san?”

“Do I really look like a suspect here?” Amasawa asked.

“If you truly mean it when you say you only have eyes for Ayanokōji-senpai... then I concluded your involvement was a distinct possibility.”

Normally, if a girl was strictly interested in Ayanokōji, it would stand to reason that someone like Ishigami wouldn't matter to her in the slightest. Yet, Nanase’s tone implied a completely different, paradoxical logic: *If* you were deeply obsessed with Ayanokōji, *then* you would naturally be deeply concerned with Ishigami.

“Sorry, but I seriously couldn't care less, and I definitely had no part in it.” Flapping her left hand back and forth, Amasawa offered a genuine, outright denial.

“I understand. Regardless, I had fully intended to broach this subject myself.” Dismissing the slight detour in their conversation, Nanase pressed on, firing off her carefully chosen words in rapid succession. “I will speak under the assumption that you truly know nothing. He... Ishigami Kyō is not entirely unconnected to the White Room.”

With that single sentence, Nanase sliced right to the heart of the matter, abruptly dragging the core issue out into the open.

“Ishigami-kun has ties to the White Room? If he’s my age, that would mean he’s a White Room student, but that’s impossible. And Ayanokōji-senpai is the absolute only one in the generation above us... Wait, could he be younger? Hmmm... I think I'd be even *less* interested if he were a junior, though~”

“You are saying that while knowing full well it is not the case, are you not?”

Noting the sharp, unmistakable flicker of anger in Nanase's glare, Amasawa brought her hands together in a playful gesture of apology.

“My bad, my bad. So basically, you're saying he's connected, just not as a student. And since you actively moved to eliminate him, that must mean Ishigami-kun is working for the White Room's side. An assassin sent in to get Ayanokōji-senpai expelled, does that sound about right, nya?”

Even as she voiced the theory, an obvious contradiction sprang to mind. If that were true, wasn't Ishigami leading an awfully leisurely, remarkably ordinary school life?

And that wasn't all. The assassins specifically dispatched under Tsukishiro's orders to expel Ayanokōji were Amasawa and Yagami. If Ishigami was *also* tangled up with the White Room on top of that, things were certainly turning into quite a lively party. A faint smile touched Amasawa's lips at the thought.

However, she was currently taking this entire story with a grain of salt. She wasn't about to swallow the claims at face value. After all, the true allegiances of the girl standing beside her, Nanase Tsubasa, were still steeped in a murky gray area, neither definitively white nor undeniably black.

“The situation has changed drastically since you and Yagami-kun first made your moves shortly after enrolling,” Nanase explained. “The question of whether or not to expel Ayanokōji-senpai is nothing more than a single current in a much larger flow—”

Mid-sentence, Amasawa lightly raised a palm, gesturing for her to stop. Right on cue, the door to the private pool opened, and a female staff member walked in carrying the melon cream soda Amasawa had ordered.

Accepting the drink with a bright, charming smile, Amasawa waited politely for the staff member to leave before taking a generous gulp through her straw.



“Wow, so sweet! But *so* tasty~” Pressing a hand to her cheek, she let out a small, exaggerated shiver, playing the part of an innocently cute girl to perfection.

“May I continue?”

“Go right ahead.”

“Amasawa-san, you were ordered by the White Room side, specifically by Tsukishiro-san, to have Ayanokōji-senpai expelled. That is correct, yes?”

Amasawa nodded encouragingly, urging her to go on.

“From the very beginning, Tsukishiro-san believed the odds of you actually succeeding in expelling him were fifty-fifty.”

“Wait, so he knew right from the start that our abilities were no match for Senpai's?”

“It might be more accurate to say that he simply did not care which outcome came to pass.”

The spoon in Amasawa's hand, which had just scooped up a bite of vanilla ice cream, froze in midair.

When she had been sent to Advanced Nurturing High School, she was ordered to follow Tsukishiro's instructions. Because of that, she had indirectly assumed he was an ally. Was that fundamental premise completely wrong? She turned the thought over in the back of her mind.

“That definitely brings up a lot of things I want to dig into,” Amasawa said slowly, “but can I ask a fundamental question first?"

“What is it?”

“Nanase-chan, at the end of the day... Are you Ayanokōji-senpai's ally? Or are you his enemy?”

Ayanokōji himself had previously asked Amasawa to look into Nanase. Right now, the girl was running around acting like his loyal knight, but there wasn't a single shred of concrete proof to back up her allegiance.

“Yes, you make a fair point. It would probably be best to make my stance explicitly clear, including the matter regarding Tsukishiro-san.”

Nanase pulled a smartphone from her bag, tapped the screen a few times, and held it out.

As Amasawa reached out to take it, her gaze drifted to *another* phone resting innocently on the table.

“For someone playing the honors student, you're actually quite a bad girl, Nanase-chan. Carrying two phones around, and one that looks like a carbon copy of the school-issued models, no less. If you get caught with that, a simple suspension might not cover it.”

Teasing her with a playful lilt, Amasawa finally lowered her eyes to the screen she had been handed.

“To answer one of your earlier questions, Ishigami-kun is not Ayanokōji-senpai's enemy,” Nanase declared. “Putting his own personal feelings aside, his faction is unambiguously the White Room... or, to be entirely precise, Ayanokōji Atsuomi's faction.”

Ayanokōji Atsuomi was Ayanokōji Kiyotaka's biological father and the founder of the White Room. To Amasawa and the other students raised within its walls, he was their absolute ruler.

The phone contained a comprehensive dossier on Ishigami Kyō, detailing everything from his upbringing to the circumstances that led to his enrollment.

During his childhood, he had met Atsuomi and was profoundly inspired by him. Upon entering middle school, Ishigami leveraged his parents' connections to contact Atsuomi independently. He was subsequently highly praised by the man as a brilliant individual with a natural intellect, and ultimately enrolled at Advanced Nurturing High School to act as an observer over Kiyotaka.

Scrolling through the profile, Amasawa's eyes landed on a specific passage. It noted that while Ishigami deeply craved Atsuomi's acknowledgment, he harbored a bitter resentment over the fact that Atsuomi rated his own son much higher.

"I see. It's precisely because he reveres 'Sensei' so much that he's jealous of Senpai, the masterpiece."

For a moment, another figure overlapped faintly with Ishigami in her mind.

Yagami.

Imagining the undeniable parallels between both of them, Amasawa felt a slight, involuntary stir of emotion in her chest.

"That may well be the case," Nanase agreed. "However, unlike you White Room students, he was not ordered to expel Ayanokōji-senpai. His mandate is strictly limited to surveillance."

No matter his personal feelings, Ishigami would never defy Sensei's wishes. If anything, his position was simply to watch over and preserve the masterpiece.

"I was pretty confident in my ability to keep tabs on Ayanokōji-senpai," Amasawa murmured, "but I never once noticed him in the picture."

For over a year, her own monitoring of Ayanokōji had bordered on stalking. Yet, in all that time, she had never caught Ishigami attempting to make contact. Since she couldn't stick to Ayanokōji twenty-four seven, Ishigami might have slipped through the cracks here and there, but if he were making frequent contact, she undoubtedly would have noticed.

“Unless there’s some unexpected development,” Nanase said, “he may believe there is no need for him to interfere.”

“So he does recognize Senpai's abilities." Amasawa let the thought settle before shifting to the next point. “By the way, does Ishigami-kun know about us too?”

“I doubt he knows about me, but I am certain he has received detailed information regarding you and Yagami-kun directly from the White Room.”

“Makes sense. If that's the case, he must be pretty capable.”

Amasawa had never once been approached by him, nor had she ever sensed an unnatural gaze or hostile vibe aimed in her direction. That was exactly why she had paid absolutely zero attention to Ishigami throughout her entire school life.

“I cannot speak to his basic academic metrics, but in terms of deductive reasoning, I would assess him as being at least a step above you and Yagami-kun.”

“Eeeh~?” Amasawa’s voice rose with theatrical disbelief. “Aren't you just underestimating me a little? Or maybe you're overestimating him?”

“It would certainly be helpful for us if that were true,” Nanase said dryly. “Regardless, his current policy seems to be to maintain his surveillance until graduation. But should the tide change, he will likely take immediate action.”

“Meaning Ishigami-kun will make a move to force Ayanokōji-senpai out of the school?”

Even when asked this, Nanase did not affirm. Instead, she briefly averted her gaze, and looked up at the clear blue sky.

“At this point, the word expulsion alone is no longer enough to describe it,” she said. “What matters to Atsuomi is ensuring that Ayanokōji-senpai is brought back into his own hands. If he decides expulsion is necessary for that purpose, Ishigami-kun will follow his orders. If he decides it is best to leave him alone until graduation, then Ishigami-kun will do nothing until the very end. At least, that’s my understanding of the current situation.”

Amasawa stared at her. “For someone who isn't a White Room student, you're vastly more knowledgeable about this whole mess than I am, and I'm the actual assassin sent to get Senpai expelled. You got that phone from Tsukishiro, too, didn't you? Just who are you, Nanase-chan?”

That was the very core of the mystery, the absolute root of Nanase’s guiding principles, and the very thing Ayanokōji himself likely wanted to uncover.

And now, Amasawa was stepping right into it.

“Did you truly think I would just hand over that information so easily?”

“Ah, figured as much. I guess I can't blame you, seeing as I'm a White Room student.”

Thinking she might have probed a bit too deep, Amasawa was surprised when a faint smile graced Nanase's lips.

“I am joking. You respect, no, you revere Ayanokōji-senpai. Because of that absolute devotion, I am completely convinced you would obey his every word. But precisely because the Ayanokōji-senpai you are loyal to belongs to the White Room, there are certain things I cannot share.”

Amasawa understood what Nanase was implying.

If Nanase’s true intentions were brought to light, Ishigami would undoubtedly make his move. That was Nanase's rationale. That was why she had struck first, attempting to get him expelled before he could act.

Inside Amasawa's mind, the puzzle pieces rapidly began falling into place.

“However, I *can* tell you my ultimate objective,” Nanase offered.

“Then give it to me straight. What exactly is your goal, Nanase-chan? Y'know, within the boundaries of what you're actually allowed to say.”

“Initially, my goal was to defeat Ayanokōji-senpai and have him expelled. That was the sole reason I enrolled in this school.”

Seeing Nanase deliver this statement with such a deadpan, serious expression, Amasawa couldn't help but burst into laughter.

“A for effort, but no matter what you do, Nanase-chan, you wouldn’t be able to beat Ayanokōji-senpai.”

Even if Nanase had been hiding her true strength this entire time, that fundamental truth would never waver.

“I am well aware,” Nanase replied calmly. “But do you not think that is only true if I were to fight him head-on?”

Without speaking boastfully, Nanase continued, implying that she had a chance of winning.

“No, no, frontal assault or sneak attack, it doesn't matter. It's totally impossible.”

Ayanokōji simply wasn't the kind of opponent who would fall for conventional tactics, surprise attacks, or underhanded tricks. Amasawa felt a slight wave of disappointment, having assumed Nanase was at least smart enough to understand that much.

However, the next words out of Nanase's mouth were something Amasawa could never have anticipated.

“The enemy I must defeat is no longer Ayanokōji-senpai. It is the man lurking in his shadow: Ayanokōji Atsuomi, the founder of the White Room. And to accomplish this, I must steal Ayanokōji-senpai away, take control of him, and seize the initiative. After all, he is the most vital piece in his father's plans.”

“Hold on, there's no way I can see that actually working.”

“That depends entirely on the method. Ayanokōji-senpai is formidable. As long as I interact with him as an enemy, bringing him under my control is an absolute impossibility. However, if my goal is to induce a change of heart in him, the story changes.”

“...A change of heart?”

“Let me ask you, Amasawa-san. What do you think Ayanokōji-senpai will do once he graduates?”

“What else? Wouldn't he just go back to the White Room? Whether Senpai becomes a new instructor or follows Sensei to accomplish something massive, I wouldn't know.”

“I was told his future would be one of those two options. In other words, if that comes to pass, Atsuomi wins. I intend to prevent that at all costs. Tsukishiro-san said it himself: while Ayanokōji-senpai may have fled the White Room's environment out of intellectual curiosity, he certainly does not hate the place. Nor does he have any real intention of defying them. No, he is fully prepared to willingly return to his origins.”

“Well, I don't know how it looks from your perspective, Nanase-chan, but I don't exactly have a bad image of the White Room either,” Amasawa shrugged. “It's where I've spent every single day since I was born. Simply put, it's my home.”

Having recently lost that very place to return to, one could say Amasawa’s heart carried a quiet, hidden wound.

“That is completely unacceptable,” Nanase replied. “That man is simply biding his time, waiting for the perfect moment to use Ayanokōji-senpai. To send him back to a man like that... I absolutely refuse to let it happen.”

Realizing her hands had unconsciously balled into white-knuckled fists, Nanase forced herself to loosen her grip.

“So, you're going to try your absolute best to stop Ayanokōji-senpai from returning to the White Room, huh? Nanase-chan.”

“Yes.”

“Then what? Are you just gonna bow your head and beg, ‘Please Ayanokōji-senpai, go and live a normal, happy life~’? Come on now~”

“I know it will not be that simple. Ayanokōji-senpai is not going to just nod his head and agree.”

“I don't know if he has any actual interest in a ‘normal life,’ but I definitely think returning to the White Room holds a lot more appeal to him.”

“Indeed. And on the off-chance that he did agree, there is no way Ayanokōji Atsuomi would tolerate such a rebellion.”

“Then how exactly do you plan to change Senpai's heart?”

“To be completely honest, I have not fully pieced together the answer to that yet. But I believe I have found a hint. Before I can put it into action, however, the stage must be perfectly set. Persuading him and tearing him away from the White Room will require careful groundwork. The moment I begin making overt moves toward that answer, Ishigami-kun will undoubtedly notice, and he will come to stop me

“So you tried to strike first and get him expelled to clear the board....I see.” Amasawa murmured.

But now that Nanase's preemptive strike had failed, a dangerous new reality loomed over them. If Ishigami was truly as capable as Nanase claimed, there was a very real chance that he had already sensed the anomaly. In all likelihood, he was investigating who had targeted him, quietly preparing to eliminate the threat.

"Making that move to get Ishigami-kun expelled this time might have been a bit of a blunder on your part, Nanase-chan."

"I will not deny it."

Yet, Nanase didn't seem panicked in the slightest. Watching her, Amasawa deduced that the preemptive strike had likely doubled as a probing attack to test her opponent's strength and gather intelligence. And if Ishigami was truly as sharp as Nanase claimed, then targeting an unrelated student in retaliation was an absolutely brilliant, perfectly calculated move, a flawless warning shot that established dominance without escalating the situation completely out of control.

"Okay, I think I've grasped the general picture," Amasawa said. "Though I have no idea how much of this little story is actually true."

"Of course. I am not asking you to blindly believe every word I say."

Even while taking it all with a grain of salt, Amasawa couldn't detect the faintest scent of falsehood from Nanase. At the very least, Nanase's claims were persuasive enough that Amasawa was willing to treat them as the working truth.

"So, what's my role in all this? It's not like you just want me to play messenger and relay everything to Ayanokōji-senpai, right?"

If that were all Nanase wanted, there would have been no reason to involve Amasawa like this.

"I want you to become my ally."

“Ally? You mean you want me to help induce this ‘change of heart’ in Ayanokōji-senpai?”

“That is certainly part of it. But first and foremost, I would appreciate it if you could act as my backup in the event that I am expelled.”

“Heeh, so you've even factored in the possibility of being taken out by Ishigami-kun.”

“I will do everything in my power to ensure that does not happen, but there is no telling how things will unfold.”

When combining Ishigami's raw capabilities with the classified intelligence provided by the White Room, the threat level skyrocketed. Amasawa deduced that Nanase simply couldn't guarantee her own safety against such overwhelming odds.

“Sorry, but at the end of the day, I'm still a White Room student through and through,” Amasawa sighed, shaking her head. “I've lived my entire life taking pride in that, and I still have lingering attachments to it. I don't dislike you, Nanase-chan, but personally? I want to support whatever future Senpai desires. And beyond that, assisting Sensei is my true, original purpose.”

What Nanase was trying to do was no minor adjustment. It was an attempt to take Ayanokōji’s future and bend it away from its expected course, forcing it from one path onto another.

Whether that intervention was right or wrong, Amasawa could not yet judge. That was precisely why she had no choice but to refuse.

“What is your dream, Amasawa-san?” Nanase asked quietly. “To return to the White Room alongside Ayanokōji-senpai... is that it?”

“So what if it is?” Amasawa replied. “Got a problem with that?”

Of course, she already knew deep down that such a dream would never come true.

The White Room had branded her a failure, and there was no returning from that exile.

Even so, finding solace in the fact that she was still free to dream, Amasawa offered Nanase a bright, unapologetic smile.

“I understand how you feel,” Nanase said. “However, miracles do not happen. That wish of yours is one hundred percent unattainable. No matter what grand achievements you might accomplish, there is no bright future waiting for you.”

“How can you be so sure about that?” Amasawa countered lightly. “For all you know, I might just be on the verge of awakening my true potential, y'know?”

“This is a matter that goes far beyond your individual capabilities. Do you have any idea what your father is currently planning?”

“My father? Sorry, but I have absolutely zero interest in that kind of thing. Doesn't that have exactly nothing to do with me?”

“Your opinion is irrelevant. The simple fact of the matter is that the legal 'ownership' of you, Amasawa-san, lies with your father."

Nanase smoothly took back the smartphone she had handed over and began tapping at the screen.

“Even if some so-called ‘parent’ I've never even met tries to butt in—”

“I am well aware that you are an existence your father cannot control,” Nanase interrupted. “And because he knows this just as well as you do, he has been in close contact with the White Room to advance his preparations.”

As Nanase laid this out with quiet, clinical detachment, the playful smile began to slip from Amasawa's face.

“What is it, re-education? Discipline? Whatever grim future he's planning, bring it on.”

“If you were truly prepared for the reality of it, that would be fine,” Nanase warned. “However, massive fraud has recently been uncovered in his company. Short on funds and backed into a corner, he is desperate. It seems there are certain syndicates overseas willing to pay exorbitant prices for beautiful young women, and he is currently scrambling to secure a buyer for you.”

Nanase handed the phone back. On the screen Amasawa was now scrolling through was the photo and profile of a man presumed to be her biological father.

“So I've outlived my usefulness, and now I'm just going to be sold off to the highest bidder. Hilarious.”

Regardless of whether this was the truth or an elaborate lie, Amasawa cheerfully clapped her hands together and laughed out loud.

But her eyes were completely dead. It was as if the harsh reality had just been violently shoved in her face, the agonizing truth that she didn't even possess the fundamental right to dream of a future.

“If you choose to cooperate with me, I may be able to save you from that fate.”

As Amasawa continued swiping across the screen, the display switched to an English webpage. It detailed exactly which overseas brokers her father was currently in contact with. It also outlined the horrific reality of what awaited her at her destination, a living hell so depraved one would hesitate to even put it into words.

“Oh my, look at that crazy price tag attached to me,” Amasawa giggled. “I could buy anything in the world with this kind of money.”

“From the perspective of an ordinary person, yes,” Nanase replied coldly. “However, given President Amasawa's massive debts, that amount is merely a drop in the bucket.”

Amasawa thought about it over and over again. Her entire life was something she couldn't even verify as truth or lie. However, one thing was absolutely certain: the future she had just been shown held zero salvation.

“Upon successfully inducing Ayanokōji-senpai's change of heart, I will extend ample protection to you after graduation, just as I plan to do for him. If that happens, you will be able to start a life that belongs entirely to you.”

Meaning she would finally be allowed to stand on the starting line as an individual, autonomous human being.

“...Could you really pull something like that off?”

“I can. It is true that Ayanokōji Atsuomi is a man of considerable power with deep connections to the underworld. However, the faction backing me is large enough to easily swallow them whole. Given the circumstances, even you can imagine that much, can you not?”

“Well...” Amasawa said slowly, “assuming you were actually serious about protecting me, maybe so.”

But Amasawa wasn't naive enough to blindly swallow such sweet promises. If she held the same kind of absolute value as Ayanokōji Kiyotaka, then perhaps Nanase's faction genuinely would mobilize to protect her. But there was no guarantee they would afford her that same luxury. After all, she possessed no such value.

“Could you give me a little time to think about it?”

“Of course,” Nanase nodded smoothly. “I will be waiting for a favorable reply.”

Flashing a defiant smirk, Amasawa scooped up a bite of the ice cream, which had now begun to melt.

Chapter 5: The Candidates

❖

Nearly two grueling hours of alternating between academic hurdles and physical exertion had finally come to an end. The supervisor announced a thirty-minute break, bringing the trials for the four teams of Group 3 to a temporary pause.

Some students collapsed right where they stood, while others made a beeline for their backpacks, desperately digging out bottles of mineral water. It was perfectly understandable; the ordeal had felt like taking a comprehensive exam while baking under the blazing sun.

“That really took a toll on me... I don't think I'll be able to manage even a single step for a while.”

Slumped on the ground, Sanada removed his glasses and let out a heavy sigh, voicing his sheer exhaustion. His dirt-streaked jersey was a clear testament to his efforts; anyone looking could see he had given it his all. He was usually the type who kept his composure intact. His cool manner rarely cracked, and he did not often allow fatigue or emotion to show plainly on his face. But under these conditions, even he could not conceal the toll.

“You're seriously insane, you know that? Sweeping every single individual match across both the academic and physical tasks...”

Yoshida wandered over as he spoke, his expression caught somewhere between exasperated disbelief and genuine admiration. Although his tone was casual, a distinct gleam of shock lingered in his eyes. Sanada, twisting the cap off his plastic bottle, too, offered several firm nods of agreement.

A single victory could be brushed off as a fluke or a favorable matchup. But consistently crushing such a diverse range of tasks painted a very different picture. Even to classmates who hadn't known me for very long, it was undeniably clear that this stemmed from true ability.

Wiping the sweat from his brow, Sanada looked at me with an expression of quiet acceptance.

“To be honest, I knew you were capable to some extent, but... this far exceeded my expectations.”

He took a slow sip of water before meeting my gaze once more. Unlike Yoshida's, his words held no trace of exaggeration.

“No, seriously,” Yoshida added. “While we were desperately trying to just survive the tasks, this guy was completely unfazed the whole time. Honestly, I'm just glad he didn't go all out against us back when he was still in Horikita's class.”

When people genuinely acknowledge someone who produces results, and at the same time feel that they belong to that same circle, they become far more honest than one might expect. The tense atmosphere softened slightly, and within this brief period of rest, the outline of Class C was steadily growing firmer, taking shape once more.

“Still,” Sanada said after a moment, glancing around, “I was just thinking it was unusually quiet around here. It turns out Morishita-san isn't with us.”

Catching sight of Morishita resting her back against a distant tree trunk, Yoshida followed up on Sanada's observation.

“Well, she's terrible at anything physical,” he said. “She probably doesn't even have the energy left to open that loud mouth of hers.”

After the two of them had recovered a little, I began handing over the tokens in order. With each transfer, a matching electronic chime rang out from my smartwatch and echoed from Yoshida's and Sanada's as they received them.

I set off toward Morishita to hand her the tokens as well, but no sooner had I started walking than I heard another set of footsteps hurrying toward me.

“U-Um, Ayanokōji-kun…” The voice came from close by, soft enough that it was almost swallowed by the noise of the break. “Do you have a minute?”

Mii-chan stood there looking visibly unsettled. Her eyes did not stay in one place for long, and even before she said another word, it was clear that she had not come to speak casually.

“Um… over here.”

She gestured for me to follow, slipping away from the prying eyes of the other students and moving to a secluded spot where our voices wouldn't carry.

“There's something I want to consult you about,” she began, lowering her voice even further. “I know it's not really my place since we aren't in the same class anymore, but this is something I feel like I can only tell you, Ayanokōji-kun…”

Her restless gaze darted around, and it was plainly obvious who she was looking out for: her own classmates from Class A. Judging by the fact that Ike and the others were currently nowhere to be seen, she had clearly waited for the perfect window to make her move. I stayed silent, gently prompting her to continue.

“It's… about Kushida-san. Since today's tasks started, right up until this break… Shinohara-san hasn't given her a single token. And so…”

“I understand why you wanted to keep this quiet, but that's highly sensitive internal information,” I interrupted. “Are you sure you want to be telling me this?”

“Even though our classes are competing against each other, Ayanokōji-kun,” she replied, hesitating over each word. “we're still allies in the same group right now. Plus, it seemed like you genuinely value Kushida-san's abilities, so…”

Normally, information about who had handed over how many tokens, and to whom, was something that should never be revealed carelessly. But the fact that she was bringing this to me meant that *it* had finally begun.

“Assuming what you're saying is true, you and Ike have still been receiving your shares without any issues right?”

She responded to my question with two small nods. “Yes, we've both... received ours perfectly fine.”

“If Shinohara is keeping hold of all of Kushida’s tokens and refusing to hand over only her share, then that is certainly a problem.”

Even without witnessing the scene firsthand, it was easy to picture the suffocating atmosphere it must have created.

“Shinohara-san was complaining last night,” Mii-chan continued. “She said Ike-kun was constantly staring at Kushida-san. Even during the one-legged balancing task this morning, them being paired up was purely a coincidence, but her mood has been terrible ever since.”

“Knowing Ike, he's always had a soft spot for cute girls. Throw Kushida into the mix, and it's bound to be even worse.”

“B-But Shinohara-san is his girlfriend...” Mii-chan’s voice trembled with an earnest kind of discomfort. “I honestly think Ike-kun is completely at fault here...”

She wasn't wrong. In reality, however, one cannot spend an entire eternity with eyes only for their precious girlfriend. It is often said that as a relationship went on, intimacy deepened while the initial spark inevitably faded. Considering Ike had harbored feelings for Kushida to begin with, a wandering eye was, to some extent, unavoidable.

“I thought that once Ike learned more about Kushida’s true nature, he would put some distance between himself and her,” I said. “But I suppose that hasn’t happened.”

“I suppose not. Lately, Kushida-san has often been isolated in the classroom, and Ike-kun has been going out of his way to talk to her. That's probably been bothering Shinohara-san for a while too.”

“But even taking all of that into account, the root cause of everything goes back to the Unanimous Special Exam... doesn't it?”

Mii-chan closed her eyes tightly, and then nodded deeply.

“In truth, the words that Kushida hurled at Shinohara back then were so intense, they were impossible to forget.”

I remembered it clearly enough.

During the Unanimous Special Exam, Kushida had mocked Shinohara in front of the entire class, casually declaring her to be ‘on the ugly side.’ If Shinohara's boyfriend had then been constantly doting on and acting chummy with the very person who had humiliated her, it was all too easy to imagine the resentment boiling inside her.

Even so, maliciously withholding tokens exclusively from Kushida was a secret she couldn't possibly keep forever.

Up until now, Shinohara had likely bitten her tongue for the sake of the class. She had kept Kushida's toxic nature under wraps, taking a step back to avoid causing any public friction. But now that she had been handed the power of a representative, it seemed her restraints were finally beginning to snap.

“Still, this is surprising,” I noted. “I thought you'd come to hate Kushida too, Mii-chan.”

While it might not have been quite as brutal as insulting Shinohara's physical appearance, Mii-chan had also been a victim; her innocent crush on Hirata had been ruthlessly exposed during the Unanimous Special Exam.

Putting aside the fact that most of our classmates had already noticed her feelings long before the reveal, the humiliation had still driven her into such a deep depression that she temporarily stopped coming to school.

“It's true that Kushida-san... really hurt me,” she admitted softly. “But even so, I feel like if I let myself become a hateful person just like her, it would be wrong.”

She was bringing this delicate issue to me, someone who had essentially betrayed her class by transferring out, despite knowing full well the complex circumstances at play. It was safe to assume her words were grounded in genuine moral conviction, not just surface-level pleasantries.

“From what you've told me, there's no doubt she's abusing her position as representative to harass Kushida,” I said. “But your biggest concern is the worst-case scenario: that Kushida might actually end up in last place. Am I right?”

“Yes...”

If Shinohara monopolized all the tokens and refused to give Kushida a single one, Kushida would be fighting a steeply uphill battle, no matter how many tokens she managed to earn on her own.

This Special Exam was divided into three categories— individual, team, and group— but having the entire class united was an overwhelmingly massive advantage.

If a class treated the trivial Private Points reward as an afterthought and simply distributed their tokens equally, that solidarity alone would act as a tremendous shield against falling into last place. To counter such a strategy, the other classes would be forced to unite as well, ultimately boiling the exam down to a sheer numbers game where the expulsion would fall on the class with the lowest overall total.

However, the logistical hurdles required to reliably execute that kind of strategy were staggering. It demanded trusting unseen classmates, coordinating meetups in the forest, transferring tokens, and meticulously adjusting the totals. The entire plan rested on the fragile premise that no one would betray the group.

“There's no doubt that Shinohara's pent-up frustrations are manifesting in her actions,” I continued. “However, it's highly unlikely she'll withhold Kushida's tokens all the way to the bitter end. If word of this reaches Horikita, Shinohara's own standing within the class would be in serious jeopardy.”

“So... I don't need to worry?”

“For now, it should be fine. Do you honestly think she would go so far as to force Kushida into expulsion over a personal grudge? It's safe to assume this is just her way of exacting petty revenge.”

Driving a classmate to expulsion solely out of personal dislike wasn't a simple line to cross.

When I added that, Mii-chan seemed to relax slightly. A small breath escaped her, as though she had finally been allowed to set down a little of the weight she had been carrying.

“But if you're still worried, just keep a close eye on the situation for me,” I added. “If Kushida still hasn't received any tokens by the end of the third day, or going into the final day, I'll step in and contact Horikita myself. After all, if Shinohara finds out you were the one who tipped her off, she might end up holding a grudge against you instead.”

“...You're really willing to help?”

“If we want Group 3 to take first place, we'll need the cooperation of every class,” I replied. “The order in which we cross the finish line on the final day has a massive impact on our score multiplier. I don't know the precise rules yet, but there's no guarantee we'll win if we're carrying around a powder keg like this.”

When I told her that, Mii-chan bowed her head deeply. “Thank you so much...!”

“More importantly, you should probably head back now,” I cautioned. “It'll be a hassle if Shinohara and the others spot us together.”

Giving a small, earnest nod, Mii-chan hurriedly jogged off. She nearly tripped over her own feet in her haste, but she managed to slip away, successfully putting enough distance between us before Shinohara's group ever noticed she was gone.

“Pray tell, what mysterious matters were you whispering about just now, Ayanokōji Kiyotaka?”

Appearing beside me seemingly out of nowhere, Morishita leaned in with her sudden question.

“Looks like you've recovered your stamina,” I noted.

“Pardon? Whatever do you mean? My boundless energy is simply overflowing in an endless fountain of vitality, you know?”

Perhaps her panting heavily just a few minutes ago had merely been an optical illusion.

I decided not to press the issue any further.

And so, the quiet dissonance brewing within Class A was steadily beginning to take root.

Part 1

After completing several more Individual and Team category tasks, with lunch and a longer break in between, we followed our supervisor's instructions and made our way toward B7.

As we ventured deeper into the forest the dense canopy overhead gradually swallowed the sunlight, casting the area into a dim greenish gloom. Cut off from the breeze, the humidity clinging to our bodies felt even more oppressive.

The ground beneath our feet was soft, mixed with patches of deep mud, giving us the constant, dreadful sensation of our feet sinking into the earth.

Exhausted from the relentless string of tasks, the students' footsteps were heavy and sluggish across the board.

Everyone unconsciously shortened their strides, trying to conserve whatever stamina they had left.

This was especially noticeable with Morishita. Her shoulders drooped as she tried to maintain a steady rhythm, but her breathing had begun to falter slightly.

"What in the world is going on...? Are we seriously still not there yet...?"

"They're literal demons!" Ike groaned, his voice carrying the same exhaustion he was clearly unable to hide. "Do they have any idea how much we've been walking around these past few days?!"

Shinohara glanced sideways at him, offered a few words of comfort, and slowed her pace to match his. She did not say much, but fatigue was clearly visible on her face as well. Even so, she did not stop walking. She was probably conscious of not falling behind the others.

In stark contrast, Katsuragi remained completely unfazed. He walked at a steady, consistent pace, with a perfectly straight posture. It wasn't as though he was free of fatigue, but he didn't show any of it on the surface, simply keeping his eyes fixed dead ahead as he continued walking. His efficient, waste-free movements likely helped suppress unnecessary stamina loss.

Ibuki walked a little behind him, wearing an expression of complete boredom.

Her gaze wasn't fixed on her feet or straight ahead; instead, she seemed to be staring blankly off into space. She walked while occasionally kicking a loose pebble, using the small motion to distract herself from the faint irritation simmering inside her.

A considerable number of assignments had been thrown at us over the course of the day, but to put it plainly, Ibuki’s results had been extremely poor.

At the start, the number of tokens she held had probably been almost the same as mine. Now, though, there was no need to check the exact figures. Within Group 3 as a whole, she was competing with Kushida for last place.

So far, Katsuragi had shown no signs of leniency.

There was probably a deliberate reason for that. By being strict with Ibuki, he may have been trying to force her to produce results. But that was only one side of it. The more immediate reality was that he simply had not secured enough surplus tokens to spare any for her.

When it came to contests of academic ability, the advantage inevitably went to the other classes. No matter how many assignments we cleared, the more we completed, the more the gap between us and them would gradually widen. And even in physical contests, the one area where Ibuki should have had her chance to shine, luck had not been on her side. There had been cases where the teammates she was paired with dragged her down, and other times when she had the misfortune of running into me in succession.

There was no way she could possibly find this situation amusing.

A thin veil of light slipped through the gaps between the trees, faintly illuminating the path ahead. Our destination was still nowhere to be seen. Conversations had dwindled until only the sound of footsteps remained, falling into a steady, almost mechanical rhythm against the damp forest floor.

Each of us continued forward in silence, confronting our own exhaustion in our own way.

What exactly was waiting beyond the forest?

No one had the room to think about it, let alone confirm it. We simply kept moving our feet, one step after another, as though our bodies had been reduced to that single repeated motion.

Suddenly, the supervisor leading the way slowed his pace. He didn't come to a complete stop, but he did glance back over his shoulder, his eyes sweeping across our entire formation.

After a few more steps, he called out in a clipped voice.

“Kushida-san, there's an incoming call for you over the radio. Can you take it?”

Kushida gave a small jolt the moment she was called out by name.

“Me?”

The faint tilt of her head was natural enough, but there was a distinct hint of caution laced in her voice. It was the first external contact we had received since the exam began, so her wariness was perfectly understandable.

The supervisor offered no further explanation, simply gesturing lightly to the device in his hand.

Kushida looked around once, then quickly complied without breaking her pace. She reached out, accepting the radio from the supervisor, and placed the small earpiece into her ear.

Shinohara and the others stared at her intently, wondering what was going on.

After a few moments of nodding to whatever was being said through the earpiece, Kushida exhaled softly and spoke.

“It seems to be Horikita-san.”

With that single sentence, the air around us shifted.

She had kept her voice low, but it was loud enough to be easily heard by anyone standing nearby.

A contact from outside the group, and from Horikita no less, was unlikely to be some mere routine work.

From where we were, there was no point in trying to eavesdrop on the radio itself. Whatever came through the receiver would belong to Kushida alone. Her own voice, however, was another matter. If someone wanted to listen, it would not be impossible to catch what she said.

Because of that, the gazes around her naturally began to gather.

The first to move were the three students from Class A.

As Kushida separated from the supervisor, they adjusted their positions and began walking around her, forming a loose screen. At the same time, they kept watch, making sure no one tried to come too close.

There were no explicit rules stating we couldn't approach, but it was an unspoken agreement. Maintaining our distance now would make it easier to demand that same level of privacy when we inevitably needed it for ourselves.

Katsuragi and I issued quiet instructions almost at the same time and moved toward the front. A moment later, the students from Class D also began putting distance between themselves and Kushida's group.

As I walked ahead, I cast a quick glance over my shoulder.

Shinohara was walking beside Kushida, and the expression on her face held a different shade from before.

The faintest hint of irritation.

The fact that Horikita had called Kushida, not her.

During the Unanimous Special Exam, Kushida had revealed her true nature and placed the class in danger. Her credibility had fallen visibly after that, as had her standing within the class's internal hierarchy.

And yet, despite all of that, Horikita had contacted Kushida first.

For Shinohara, those two facts were becoming a source of invisible stress, quietly eating away at her from within.

On top of that, there was a faint trace of anxiety. If Kushida reported Shinohara's petty behavior as a representative to Horikita, a reprimand would almost certainly follow. While I couldn't be absolutely certain, with Shinohara hovering right over her, Kushida likely wouldn't do that.

After all, in the eyes of those around her, Kushida was not the kind of bad girl who would go around voicing complaints.

Even so, a different kind of silence from the one we had been carrying earlier had undoubtedly fallen over the group.

Part 2

We had crossed into Area C9, our destination finally within reach, when the supervisor stopped in his tracks and turned to face us.

“If we proceed at this pace, I think we'll cross into Area B7 in about fifteen to twenty minutes,” he announced. “We're almost there, so hang in there just a little longer.”

Receiving those words of encouragement, a few students offered weary murmurs of acknowledgment before we resumed our grueling march.

Not long after, a burst of noise reached us from somewhere nearby; voices, footsteps, the faint disorder of another group in motion. A moment later, the first figure to come into view was another sweat-drenched supervisor, walking at the head of the formation. And behind him came Group 6.

The supervisor assigned to Group 6 approached Urushihara almost immediately, and the two exchanged a few brief words.

On the afternoon of the exam's second day, this marked our first genuine encounter with another group.

Among the Class C students assigned to Group 6 were Kitō, Yamamura, Satonaka, and Machida. From the look of them, they had also covered a considerable distance. Fatigue clung visibly to many of the students, weighing down their shoulders and slowing their steps.

While many students likely felt a flicker of relief at seeing fresh faces, a seed of suspicion no doubt took root alongside it.

“Please rest assured, everyone,” Urushihara called out. “We simply happened to cross paths. There are no inter-group tasks scheduled for today.”

With that single announcement, the tension in the air dissipated. The students' underlying suspicions had fortunately been off the mark. With the reassurance that this was nothing more than a chance encounter, they dropped their guard, and tentative smiles slowly began to spread across their faces.

“It appears Group 6 is heading to Area B8, so you're welcome to travel together for the time being,” he continued. “There's no issue with you chatting or exchanging tokens if necessary. Please, feel free to do as you like.”

That permission was all it took.

Students from the other classes began moving toward one another, closing the distance quickly. Questions were exchanged almost at once. *How was your group doing? Were you managing to collect tokens?* A little later, the Class C students; Satonaka, Machida, and Yamamura, also approached us.

“You guys holding up alright with the tasks?” Yoshida asked, casually opening with some small talk.

Machida gave a noncommittal nod. “We're barely scraping by right now. It's hard to tell exactly how much everyone else is earning. Would it be faster if we just showed you our tokens?”

His gaze shifted to me for approval, so I quickly shot the idea down.

“No, that won't be necessary. Right now, instead of worrying about where we stand, it's better to focus entirely on gathering as many tokens as possible, even if it's just one more.”

“You might be right…” Machida admitted. “But honestly, I'd be lying if I said I wasn't anxious.”

“You can rest easy,” I assured him. “I've already decided on a strategy for how we'll survive this Special Exam. Right now, we're just waiting for the right moment to put it into action. I have no intention of letting anyone from Class C get expelled. When the time comes for detailed instructions, I'll definitely contact you over the radio.”

Leaving the rest of the intra-class chatter to Yoshida and Sanada, I shifted my focus beyond our class.

My primary concern right now was Class B's movements. Katsuragi was already at the center of a discussion, where the events and developments within Group 3 over the past day would undoubtedly be shared in meticulous detail.

He would pass on any information he could without relying on the radio, such as exactly how many visible tokens I currently held.

I knew it wouldn't be long before that intel reached Ryūen's ears, prompting him to formulate his countermeasures.

There was no need to rush, I will just proceed with the strategy as planned——

“Hey, Ayanokōji-kun...“

The voice came hesitantly from beside me.

“Do you have a minute?”

It was Hasebe from Class A. When I glanced past her, the other Class A students were gathered a short distance away, smiling and talking with Kushida at the center of the group. Hasebe’s departure from them had not drawn any particular attention. At least for the moment, no one seemed to be watching us closely.

“Let's walk a bit slower,” I suggested.

“Yeah, thanks.”

We hung back to let the other students move ahead, then stepped off the main path toward the nearby beach, staying just close enough to keep the trail in sight. The sound of footsteps and conversation thinned behind us, replaced by the dry rush of wind and the steady breeze of the sea.

Spotting a large rock nearby, I had Hasebe take a seat to keep her from burning through any more of her stamina.

“How are your legs holding up?” I asked. “You must be burning through a lot of energy too with the endless hiking and tasks.”

“Yeah, I'm managing,” she replied. “What about you, Ayanokōji-kun? Are you... actually, never mind. I doubt I need to worry about you.”



“I'm doing well enough in my own way,” I said. “How are things on your end?”

“I'm not really sure. It’s hard to say without knowing how the other groups are doing, but I think we’re holding our own well enough.”

It seemed that, for now at least, neither Hasebe nor the rest of the Class A students were feeling overly anxious.

A stronger sea breeze swept across the shore.

Hasebe narrowed her eyes against it and turned her gaze toward the water, where the sunlight scattered in countless bright fragments across the surface.

“Do you feel guilty?” I asked.

At my question, she turned back to face me, pausing for a moment in quiet contemplation.

“If I said I didn’t feel any guilt at all,” she said at last, “that would be a lie…”

With that preface out of the way, she continued. “But it's better than seeing you get expelled, Ayanokōji-kun. That's what I told myself... so I can honestly say I don't have any regrets. Was my advice helpful?”

“Yeah, pretty much. Thanks to you, I managed to avoid taking the fall and getting expelled.”

“I see. I'm glad.”

It wasn't a forced smile; it was a genuine expression that Hasebe showed from the bottom of her heart.

“Can I... you know, um... go back to calling you Kiyopon...?”

“You really fixate on the strangest things,” I noted. “I don't mind, if that's what you prefer.”

"...I'm glad. For me, using that nickname is kind of like a barometer, I guess? It just makes me feel a certain way... probably. Ugh, I don't know. What am I even saying?"

She let out a self-deprecating laugh, fully aware her words were turning into a jumbled mess.

"Once this uninhabited island exam is over and we're back at school, we should hang out over summer break," she suggested.

"I highly doubt Miyake or Yukimura would welcome that."

"Oh, right. I guess so. Then it can just be the two of us... ah, I mean, just for starters, you know?"

"Alright. Just let me know whenever."

Seeing that I hadn't rejected her, but instead agreed without a second's hesitation, Hasebe broke into a genuinely delighted smile.

Part 3

It was half past six in the evening.

The campsite for the second day had been fixed at B7, and no sooner had the decision been made the students began moving with practiced efficiency. Packs were lowered, tools were brought out, and the quiet rhythm of preparation spread through the site.

Back when we were first-years, pitching a base camp had been an agonizing struggle. Now, regardless of whether they were boys or girls, it was something they had all grown incredibly well-accustomed to.

“Their movements are finally starting to look the part, aren't they?” Morishita said, folding her arms with an air of authority. “If you ask me, they still have a long way to go, but I suppose I should offer some praise for achieving this much as mere high school students.”

A rather bold stance for someone who had done absolutely nothing but watch since day one.

“Ayanokōji-kun, you have an incoming radio call. It's from Nishikawa-san in your class. Can you take it?”

The supervisor walked over relaying the message as he extended a two-way radio in my direction.

I accepted it immediately and slipped the earpiece into place.

“Could it be some sort of trouble?” Morishita mused aloud. “How bothersome.”

“Sorry, but could you get the fire started in my place?” I asked.

“Eeek.”

I engaged the safety lock on the utility lighter and handed it over to Morishita, who had made a small joke (I guess?) with an expressionless face.

“Well, just leave it to me,” Morishita said solemnly. “I'll make sure Ayanokōji Kiyotaka's bed is reduced to ashes.”

“That would almost certainly result in expulsion, so please take this seriously.”

I was slightly concerned, but I couldn't afford to keep Nishikawa waiting. Deciding to put my faith in her, I left the lighter in Morishita's hands.

“Sorry for the wait.”

The moment I responded, Nishikawa launched right in, her tone brimming with her usual energy.

“Yahoo, Ayanokōji-kun. Do you have a second? There's something I wanted to get your advice on.”

Advice? Did something happen?

“What is it?”

“I was just getting a little worried about the token counts for the other groups. Aren't you worried, Ayanokōji-kun?”

“Of course it's on my mind. I'm especially concerned about Shiraishi and the others who ended up in Ryūen's group. Under normal circumstances, I don't think they'd make a mistake that would wipe out their tokens, but in this case, even that isn't a guarantee.”

The possibility that they could fall into some sort of trap and hit zero, even if only for a fleeting moment, couldn't be completely ruled out.

“Even if they haven't hit zero, someone might be struggling because they're dangerously close to it.”

“Is there a specific student you're worried about?”

Her tone practically gave the answer away, but I deliberately feigned ignorance.

“I want to know how Asuka is doing.”

Perhaps sensing I had seen right through her, Nishikawa dropped the pretense and got straight to the point. She must have been harboring the same concerns I had since early on.

To find out a specific person's exact token count, the only surefire methods were to make direct physical contact or call them on the radio. The former relied heavily on luck, while the latter cost precious tokens. Neither was a simple matter.

“Wouldn't calling Shiraishi directly solve your problem?” I asked.

“She's a kind girl. Even if she were in trouble, I feel like she'd hide the truth from me. But since you're the class leader, Ayanokōji-kun, I think she'd answer you honestly.”

“I see. It's true that the only way to confirm her exact tokens without meeting in person is over the radio. Unfortunately, I have no intention of wasting a token just for that. I don't approve of how you're using the radio right now, either.”

“...But what if she really is in trouble?”

I had laced my words with a hint of reprimand, but Nishikawa's voice remained completely unfazed.

“She might be desperately hoping for help,” she added.

“You really don't want to see Shiraishi expelled, do you?”

“Of course I don't. She's a dear friend of mine.”

“That may be true. But plenty of other students share those exact same feelings and relationships. ‘I don't want him to be expelled,’ or ‘I want to protect her’— you aren't the only one who thinks that way, Nishikawa.”

“That's why I came to you for advice,” she said. “Honestly, I'm perfectly willing to use my own tokens to contact her. But it might end up being a waste, and more importantly, I don't want to disrupt the class's harmony. That's why I'm asking.”

“So, if I tell you ‘no’ right now, will you obediently hold back?”

“I wonder about that…”

Perhaps Nishikawa also understood what my answer would be, as she muttered evasively but with a hint of irritation.

“How you use your personal tokens is up to you. If you absolutely must know how Shiraishi is doing, I have no right to stop you. However, confirming her token count now will only buy you a fleeting moment of peace of mind. In fact, if you find out she really is struggling, it will only fuel your anxiety.”

If that happened, she would inevitably use the radio to contact Shiraishi again a few hours later, wasting even more tokens. Her focus on the exam would fracture, leading to a drop in efficiency. Factoring that in, even if Shiraishi were to inflate her token count to reassure her, she certainly wouldn't under-report it.

“Shiraishi is highly capable. Don't you think the odds of her falling to last place are quite low right now?” I asked.

“I won't deny that. But there are no absolute guarantees, right?”

“I suppose it depends on who she's up against.”

“If she only has a few tokens left, I have to do something.”

“Are you prepared to protect her even if it means sacrificing yourself?”

“No way, that's impossible. It wouldn't mean anything if Asuka gets to stay at this school but I get expelled,” Nishikawa answered without hesitation. “However, if it means protecting Asuka, I don't care if someone else has to be the sacrifice.”

“Are you saying that, in a worst-case scenario, I should sacrifice someone other than you or Shiraishi?”

“Exactly. That's precisely why we made you the leader, Ayanokōji-kun. Because I believe you're capable of making ruthless decisions for us.”

It seemed Nishikawa's little ‘consultation’ carried far more weight than I had originally anticipated.

“Sorry, but I have my own way of doing things.”

“Are you saying... you won't help her?”

“My role isn't to decide whether or not to save Shiraishi. It's to ensure we never end up in a situation where we have to make that kind of binary choice in the first place.”

“That's reassuring,” Nishikawa said. “But doesn't that also mean if push comes to shove, we have no idea what kind of decision you'll actually make?”

“If you can't trust me, then you'll just have to handle it yourself. If you manage to earn more tokens than anyone else, there's a chance you could save Shiraishi entirely on your own.”

“Hey, Ayanokōji-kun. You don't actually think our class doesn't matter, do you? Because if you're secretly a spy for Class A, that really wouldn't be funny.”

With a cold, accusatory tone, she mercilessly stabbed the words into me.

“I won't say it's too late to be bringing that up now,” I replied. “I know it will take time to earn everyone's understanding.”

“I guess so. I just can't place my complete trust in you yet. So, if you want me to get to that point, cooperate with me. Contact Asuka.”

“I have no intention of repeating myself.”

“Right... That's a shame, but it looks like we're out of time. I'll hold back for today, but I’ll make no promises about tomorrow.”

Saying that, Nishikawa ended the call.

“Thank you,” I said as I handed the radio back to the supervisor.

I turned my eyes toward Morishita at once, who was supposed to be busy setting up the fire.

“What exactly are you doing?”

“Eeek.”

“No, never mind that.”

Instead of holding the ignition lighter I had just given her, Morishita was crouching on the ground, drawing a picture in the dirt.

“I thought I'd leave behind a dying message,” she said. “It's a sketch of the culprit.”

“I have no idea who that's supposed to be, but more importantly, I’m fairly certain I asked you to start the fire.”

“Oh, details like that hardly matter,” Morishita replied, “It will be all the same if Ayanokōji Kiyotaka does it now. Please, feel free to burn it to your heart’s content.”

Saying that, she lifted her foot, picked up the lighter she had been stepping on, and held it out to me: the nozzle pointed directly at my face. Much like a pair of scissors, common sense dictated handling these tools over in a way that posed no danger to the recipient, but she clearly didn't care. To make matters worse, her finger was resting right on the lever.

Just as I reluctantly reached out to take it, she suddenly squeezed the trigger, attempting to ignite it right in my face.

However, nothing happened..

“A misfire?!” she gasped.

Naturally, it didn't ignite. I had engaged the safety lock before handing it to her.

“You're a dangerous person, you know that?”

“It was a joke, of course,” she replied. “I knew the lock was on; I merely wanted to give you a fright.”

“Knowing the lock is on doesn't excuse trying to ignite a lighter while pointing it at someone.”

“More importantly,” Morishita said, brushing past that point with no sign of reflection, “what were you discussing with Ryōko Nishikawa?”

“She said she was worried about Shiraishi and wanted me to check on her. When I refused, she accused me of being a spy for Class A.”

“Oho. A rather sharp observation, coming from her. I must admit, I was just beginning to harbor that very same suspicion once again myself. The ‘Ayanokōji Kiyotaka is a Class A Spy’ theory.”

“Is that so?”

“Watching you up close these past two days, I can't help but feel like you've been particularly preoccupied with Kushida Kikyō. It certainly seems to go far beyond simply worrying about a former classmate.”

"I see. So it looks that way even from an outside perspective?"

"It certainly does. Or rather, that ‘even’ is practically a confession! You just said, ‘even from the outside.’ I caught that!”

She flashed me a smug little grin, looking exactly like a detective who had just backed a criminal into a corner.

"It's true that Kushida Kikyō appears to be quite capable in her own right," Morishita continued. "But even so, you two have been a bit too close. To the point where I'm honestly startin' to think, 'Are ya actually in love with her or somethin', yo?'"

Why did she suddenly switch to a casual tone? Or rather, why does she sound like a total delinquent now?

"Let me ask you something. Even if that were the case, would it cause any problems?" I asked.

"Let me ask you this in return: do you honestly think it wouldn't?"

"Anyone can see that Kushida is an exceptional student," I said. "Even you can't deny that. Therefore, there's no doubt that she's the most suitable person to keep this group running smoothly. The presence or absence of romantic feelings is completely irrelevant."

"If you desire an exceptional student, why not your classmate Sanada so-and-so, or Katsuragi so-and-so? There's no need to limit it exclusively to Kushida Kikyō, is there?"

"We were in the same class for two years. I have a much clearer understanding of Kushida's capabilities."

"Because she's a former classmate, you say? My, my, how very suspicious. The plot thickens. It almost sounds like you'd swoop in and protect her from Shinohara so-and-so and her friends if push comes to shove. Let me be perfectly clear: I will not give you a single one of my tokens, you thief."

I had already settled today's portion properly, but it seemed likely she would continue pressing me on the details from tomorrow onward.

"Interpret it however you like."

“Well, rest assured, I won't get angry at you for looking at Kushida Kikyō through rose-tinted glasses and playing favorites. Because as long as I am kept safe, I'm perfectly willing to turn a blind eye to it. Therefore, please make absolutely sure to prioritize me over Sanada so-and-so and Yoshida so-and-so.”

So, in the end, all that mattered to Morishita was that her own safety was guaranteed.

“Even so, you sure use ‘so-and-so’ a lot. I've been pondering this for a while now, but if you don't know their given names, there's no need to force yourself to use their full names, is there?”

“Then allow me to ask you this,” Morishita said. “What would you do if there were thirty people in the class with the surname Yamada? If you called out, ‘Hey, you there, Yamada,’ thirty boys and girls would all turn around at once. It would be absolute chaos! Surely it would be more convenient to know whether one meant Yamada Jirō or Yamada Hanako?”

While Yamada is certainly a common surname, it wasn't exactly the most populous in the country. A scenario where thirty people in the same class shared the exact same surname was practically unthinkable anyway.

It had been quite some time since I first met Morishita, but I still couldn't figure her out.

“Ayanokōji, come here a sec.”

Yoshida raised his voice and beckoned me over. A shadow had fallen over his expression, leading me to suspect that, right on the heels of my conversation with Nishikawa, yet another problem had cropped up.

“Let's go, Morishita,” I said.

“No, thank you,” Morishita replied at once. “It may be a troublesome matter, and I would prefer to avoid such things. I shall remain here and light the fire. Please lend that to me.”

With that, she snatched the lighter right out of my hand.

Leaving her in charge of the fire felt incredibly risky, but I decided to put my faith in her just this once. Then I hurried over to Yoshida to hear what was going on.

“I don't really want to stick my nose in other people's business, but Shinohara is seriously crossing a line,” he muttered gesturing vaguely with his chin toward the members of Class A, who were huddled together in a tight group. “It looks like she distributed tokens to Wang and Ike, but Kushida hasn't been given a single one.”

“Kushida hasn't? Why?” I asked.

It appeared that Class A's internal drama, which was supposed to be kept under wraps, had already leaked. Whether Shinohara had let it slip, Kushida had skillfully orchestrated the leak, or it had come from an entirely different source altogether, I couldn't be sure. Regardless, there was no point in trying to track down the culprit now.

A short distance away, Katsuragi and several Class D students who had evidently caught wind of the rumor were already approaching Class A. An argument seemed to be breaking out, and I could already see the anger flashing across Shinohara's face.

“We should probably head over there,” Yoshida said. He broke into a jog, and Sanada and I quickly followed suit.

“You guys are here too? What the hell is going on?” Shinohara immediately directed her frustration at Yoshida before shooting a sharp glare in my direction.

“I heard you aren't giving any tokens to Kushida,” Yoshida said. “Just because you're the representative doesn't mean you get to do whatever you want.”

“...This has nothing to do with you, Yoshida-kun.” Shinohara shot back. “We in Class A have our own strategies we're desperately trying to figure out in order to win. I don't know if you eavesdropped or what, but mind your own business. Don't butt in when you're from another class.”

Her counterargument was perfectly valid; under normal circumstances, this wasn't a matter Yoshida and the others had any right to interfere in.

“But we're in a group together,” Yoshida argued. “Stop disrupting the harmony.”

“Who's the one disrupting things here?” Shinohara demanded. “If we change our strategy because of you and end up losing, are you going to take responsibility for it?”

“That's...”

Faced with her forceful rebuttal, Yoshida faltered and took a step back. I, on the other hand, stepped forward, closing the distance between Shinohara and myself.

“What?” she said, fixing me with a hard, unflinching stare. “Do you have something to complain about too, Ayanokōji-kun?”

Her eyes held a stronger wariness toward me than they had toward Yoshida.

“If Horikita were to find out about this,” I said. “Wouldn't your position be in a bit of jeopardy?”

“Huh? Is that a threat?” She scoffed. “...This has nothing to do with you, Ayanokōji-kun.”

“If this were a strategy meant to secure victory, I could understand it. But what you’re doing is letting your own self-preservation and personal resentment take priority.”

“Satsuki ain't that kind of person! You just don't get her!”

Stepping in to protect his girlfriend, Ike shoved himself right into my face. He was practically seething, radiating an intensity that made it seem like he might grab me by the collar at any second.

Sonoda and Morofuji, who had been watching from farther away, seemed to notice the rising tension as well. Drawn by the commotion, they began moving toward us.

“Perhaps you really are executing this as a legitimate strategy,” I said. “But to the people around you, it certainly doesn't look that way. It looks like you're abusing your authority as the representative to suppress and control someone more capable than yourself. It looks like, in a worst-case scenario, you're planning to save your own skin even if it means kicking Kushida down to do it.”

“Are you kidding me? What's with these baseless accusations!” Shinohara snapped. “I became the representative for the sake of Class A, and I'm managing things so we can win. Stop making up stories based on your own warped speculation!”

Ever since we had formed this group, a lingering grudge had festered between us. Naturally, confronting her with such a harsh rejection of her methods was bound to invite hostility.

At this point, I shifted my gaze toward Katsuragi, who had been observing from the sidelines, and the two Class B students who had hurried over.

“Since we're on the subject,” I continued, “I’ll say this as well. I have some doubts about Class B’s policy too. I’m not saying a performance-based reward system is inherently bad. But when it’s handled too openly, I can’t say I’m impressed.”

Sonoda, clearly not expecting the sparks to fly his way, furrowed his brows in annoyance.

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?” he said. “Another class has no business criticizing our policy. And I hate to put it this way, but especially not you.”

A class traitor. It was obvious they had no intention of taking advice from me, a person already at odds with Class A.

“Yeah, exactly! This ain't something for an outsider to butt into, Ayanokōji!” Seizing the opportunity, Ike quickly sided with Sonoda, attempting to drag their representative into the fray. “Right, Katsuragi?”

“It's true that it's none of his business. But the same goes for you and Class A, Ike,” Katsuragi replied heavily. Unable to stand being lumped into the same category as Shinohara, he made his dissatisfaction clear. “I am making judgments fairly in my own way, and distributing tokens among my three group members accordingly. But as Ayanokōji pointed out, Shinohara is controlling Class A's tokens entirely on a whim. That is not fair.”

“No, no, it's completely different! Satsuki is managing things on our end so we don't lose. The strategy is to properly redistribute them at the right time. Were you even listening to the explanation?” Ike complained, as if to say, *And here I went out of my way to become your ally.*

“If that is truly the case, then you should conduct yourselves in a way that actually convinces Kushida of that.”

At Katsuragi's words, Shinohara let out a mocking laugh.

“Isn't that, like, the exact same for you, Katsuragi-kun? Can you confidently say Ibuki-san is completely convinced by your methods?”

As evidenced by the fact that Ibuki was nowhere to be seen, it was safe to assume she was highly dissatisfied with Katsuragi's policies.

“...Perhaps you are right.”

Receiving Shinohara's unexpected counterattack, Katsuragi averted his gaze, patted Sonoda on the shoulder, and backed away.

“There, see?” Ike said, raising his voice. “The rest of you, back off! Don’t get in our way!”

At his words, the Class D students began to withdraw. Class C quickly followed as well.

Within Group 3, irreversible misalignments in the gears had begun to steadily form due to the clashing policies of the representatives. On one side was Kushida, who was performing well enough but hadn't received a single token due to Shinohara's management. On the other was Ibuki, who was unable to perform as she wished and was thus drip-fed a meager amount of tokens.

Of course, Kushida simply hadn't received her distribution yet, so her situation wasn't completely identical to Ibuki's. However, since her chances of receiving her fair share rested entirely in Shinohara's hands, the two girls were in remarkably similar positions when it came to their underlying anxiety.

Without a doubt, within Group 3, those two were currently the prime candidates for last place.

“What a wonderfully harmonious group we are.”

As I looked over to find the source of the comment, I saw Morishita spectating from afar.

The campfire still had not been lit.

Part 4

After a break filled with unrest, and after dinner had passed in much the same unsettled air, two more tasks were announced, just as they had been the previous day.

The category was ‘Team’.

In these tasks, Class A managed a respectable result of taking second place twice, but naturally, Shinohara showed no sign of handing any tokens over to Kushida.

Though a faint look of anxiety occasionally surfaced on Kushida's face, she outwardly maintained the stance that she had complete faith in Shinohara.

The student known as Kushida Kikyō was the type of person who was kind to everyone, perpetually cheerful, and deeply trusting of others. From the perspective of students in other classes, the impression she gave wasn't vastly different from Ichinose. Because of that carefully crafted image, she couldn't simply air her grievances in public and demand, ‘I can't trust you, Shinohara, so hand over my tokens.’

That was precisely Shinohara's aim, and it seemed Kushida was being successfully taken advantage of.

I walked over to where Class A was huddled together and called out to her.

“I need to talk to you for a second.”

“The hell do you want, Ayanokōji? What're you plotting?”

Ike immediately jumped to his feet, stepping into my path as if to protect Kushida.

More accurately, I figured he was doing it to prevent anyone from interfering with Shinohara's policies as the representative. However, far from pleasing his girlfriend, his aggressive posturing seemed to be having the exact opposite effect as Shinohara looked rather displeased with him.

“I just came to talk to her as a fellow member of Group 3,” I said.

“You think that excuse is gonna fly?” Ike shot back. “Sorry, but we don't trust you.”

“I wasn't asking you, Ike,” I said, before walking past him. “Kushida, there are too many distractions here, so why don't we go somewhere else to talk?”

At my invitation, Kushida slowly rose to her feet.

“You can't go,” Shinohara warned her. “You know it'll look like an act of betrayal, right?”

“It's fine, Satsuki, I won't let her go,” Ike said before turning toward Kushida, his tone softening at once. “Kikyō-chan, we're definitely not gonna treat you badly or anything, so you shouldn't get involved with Ayanokōji. We have no idea what he's scheming.”

“It's okay, Ike-kun.” Kushida looked away from me, turning to offer him a gentle smile. “People have been saying all kinds of things, but I believe in everyone from Class A. I believe in you, Ike-kun.”

Saying that, she shifted her gaze from Ike to Shinohara, then to Mii-chan, before looking back at Ike once more.

“You especially have been looking out for me this whole time. I’m really grateful for that.”

“R-Really?” Ike’s expression loosened. “Well, I mean, it's only natural since we're allies.”

He chuckled, lightly rubbing a finger under his nose in a bashful display. However, upon noticing Shinohara glaring daggers at him, he immediately snapped back into a serious expression.

“So, I'm sorry, but I can't go with you, Ayanokōji-kun,” Kushida said to me.

Mouthing the words *‘Serves you right’* from an angle where Shinohara couldn't see his face, Ike shooed me away.

“Looks like you got rejected pretty harshly,” Yoshida laughed teasingly, having watched the exchange from near the tents.

“It's only natural for Class A to be wary of you, Ayanokōji-kun,” Sanada added. “Even if I were in their position, I imagine I would have handled it similarly. Though, I wouldn't have been so hostile about it, of course.”

“But why are you so concerned about Kushida?” Yoshida asked. “I mean, sure, I feel bad for her, but like they just said, it's not really something another class should be sticking their nose into.”

“I just can't leave her alone,” I replied.

“Wait...” Yoshida’s eyes narrowed slightly. “Don’t tell me...”

“Have you finally noticed?” Morishita chimed in. “It seems our dear Ayanokōji Kiyotaka harbors simply extraordinary feelings for her.”

“Oh, man,” Yoshida said, pressing a hand to his forehead.

Without giving an answer to the two of them as they got worked up over their own assumptions, I stepped away and headed into my tent ahead of them.

Not only Shinohara and Ike, but Yoshida and the others had now thoroughly taken note of my unusual behavior.

That was a major gain for me.

Ibuki and Kushida. The candidates I intended to have expelled from this school.

By the day after tomorrow, their fates would be sealed.

Chapter 6: I'll Do Anything You Want

❖

The morning of the third day dawned. Just as most of us had anticipated, the supervisor explained that today's itinerary would center heavily around the 'Group' category. Our schedule had been pre arranged by the school, pitting us against a gauntlet of rival groups throughout the day.

Victory against an opposing group would yield tokens, which could be distributed through one of two distinct methods. The first was an equal split, awarding a uniform number of tokens to everyone in the victorious group; under this system, no disparity in standing would arise among the members of Group 3. The alternative method rewarded individual merit rather than collective success: regardless of whether the group won or lost overall, the top three performing students would be evaluated and granted a set number of tokens. Yet, no matter which distribution method was applied, the tokens would still be handed over in bulk to the group's representative first.

To make matters worse, shorter Individual and Team tasks were slated to be squeezed into the brief intervals between these larger events. It was guaranteed to be an exhausting day; just as much as the second, if not more so.

That collective sense of dread shared by the students soon proved entirely justified.

The moment we broke camp at eight o'clock, we immediately ran into Group 10, which belonged to Hashimoto. With scarcely a moment to exchange pleasantries, we were thrust right into a unique task that made use of the uninhabited island's terrain.

By the time the hour-long match concluded, there wasn't even a spare second to congratulate one another on a hard-fought battle; we were immediately herded toward the next designated area. After repeating this exhausting cycle of marching and competing against other groups three separate times, our much-needed lunch break finally arrived.

Though this thirty-minute window ostensibly doubled as free time, most students still huddled closely with their respective teams to eat. There were probably various things to discuss, such as checking the tokens acquired in the morning and consulting about the afternoon. Even someone as typically solitary as Ibuki remained close to the Class B encampment.

Amidst all that, Kushida stood out as the sole, glaring exception.

While she was seated nearest to Class A, she maintained a deliberate physical distance, quietly eating her lunch in total isolation.

The rift that had formed between her and Shinohara was painfully obvious, and there was no doubt she was suffering the fallout of that fractured dynamic. It wasn't as if her sudden isolation had gone unnoticed, students like Yoshida and Katsuragi cast concerned glances her way, but given the nature of the exam and the constant friction between teams, no one could afford to carelessly extend a helping hand.

“I can barely stomach watching this,” Yoshida muttered. “They keep hiding behind excuses like ‘strategy’ and ‘team policy,’ but isn't this going a bit too far? Does Shinohara have some kind of vendetta against Kushida?”

“If you observe her boyfriend's attitude, it's not entirely incomprehensible. His eyes are constantly chasing after Kushida Kikyō, after all,” Morishita noted.

“You mean Ike? ...Are you saying he's comparing her to Shinohara or something?” Yoshida shot Morishita a skeptical look, clearly thinking she was reading too much into it.

“Even you would hate it if your girlfriend was mesmerized by another man, right, Yoshida so-and-so? Oh, wait, since you don't have a girlfriend and never will, that might be too hard for you to grasp.”

“Shut up. Don't just casually spit venom at me,” he grumbled. “...Though, if that were true, yeah, I'd definitely hate it.”

Even without a girlfriend of his own, he could easily imagine how much that would sting.

“But it can't really be helped, can it? I mean, between Kushida and Shinohara, they're just on entirely different levels, or rather...”

“That line of thinking makes you absolute trash, Yoshida so-and-so.”

“Stop with the ‘so-and-so’ already. At least call me Kenta. If you're going to use my full name, that is.”

Those two seemed convinced that Shinohara had isolated Kushida, but the reality was likely quite different. It was far more probable that Kushida was intentionally distancing herself, carefully orchestrating her own isolation.

She was playing the tragic heroine to the hilt, monopolizing the sympathetic gazes of everyone around her. Her goal was simple: to firmly establish Shinohara as the villain unless she coughed up some tokens to make amends. It was a brazen, all-or-nothing tactic, and whether it would actually work on Shinohara remained to be seen.

“Ayanokōji-kun. Nishikawa-san is requesting to contact you via the radio,” the supervisor said.

I had been curious to see what Nishikawa would do after I’d given her a day to mull things over. So she was already reaching out again, huh?

I accepted the radio handed to me by the supervisor.

“Is she calling to confirm Shiraishi Asuka's survival again?” Morishita asked.

“Huh? What about Shiraishi?” Yoshida chimed in.

"Please do not butt into the conversation without permission. Having you listen in will only make things unnecessarily complicated, Kenta Yoshida."

“Why is my first name first!?”

Leaving Morishita to handle Yoshida— no, rather, leaving Yoshida to handle Morishita— I stepped a short distance away to take the call.

Ultimately, her questions were identical to the ones she’d asked the other day: she wanted to verify Shiraishi's token count and needed reassurance that the girl was absolutely safe. My answer hadn't changed, but the situation certainly had. I told her over the radio to sit tight just a little longer, assuring her that within a few hours, I would arrange an outcome she would find acceptable.

Part 1

Once everyone had finished their lunch, I returned the radio to the supervisor.

I then made my way back to Class C, who were already packing up.

“That was quite a long talk. Did Nishikawa Ryoko persistently cling to you?” Morishita asked.

“No, I was speaking with someone else about a separate matter.”

“A separate matter? I see, so Ayanokōji Kiyotaka has finally made his move?”

Morishita's gaze sharpened slightly. I had expected her to follow up with one of her usual nonsensical jokes, but it seemed I was mistaken.

“You don't need to hide it,” she continued. “This special exam has felt a bit too ordinary, or rather, devoid of any significant developments. I had a sneaking suspicion you were just biding your time, waiting for the perfect moment to strike.”

For all her eccentricities and goofing around, she truly possessed a sharp mind beneath the surface.

“Yes, I did let an arrow loose,” I admitted.

“Oho-ho-ho, an arrow, you say? And what exactly are we supposed to do from here on out?”

“Instructions haven't changed. As long as the groups are operating separately, your fundamental goal is simply to collect tokens in earnest. Even though there’s no restriction on transferring them, the moment a token changes hands, it’s treated as a back-side token. Therefore, all you need to focus on is tackling the tasks and acquiring as many front-side tokens as possible. That remains the most optimal path toward victory.”

“Indeed. Within Group 3, Ayanokōji Kiyotaka is undoubtedly a head above the rest and currently winning. Even if there's a student in a rival group who has amassed a similar number of front-side tokens, as long as you secure a 100% multiplier on the final day, you'll have a solid chance of clinching the win. Well, I suppose our opponents are banking on that exact same logic.”

“It's not a system that strictly demands overwhelmingly dominant individual scores,” I explained. “If anything, it’s designed so that any well-rounded student can amass a high number of front-side tokens depending on how the match-ups play out.”

Despite the structural elements of teams and groups, the exam was ultimately a framework where individual talent and effort directly translated into results. Overcomplicating the mechanics would only leave you overwhelmed.

“But that’s only if you're solely focused on *winning,”* I added. “The other face of this special exam is the severe weight of its penalties. The real test lies in devising a strategy to reliably avoid them.”

“Ah, so *that's* the kind of arrow you let loose… Well then, how exactly do you intend to avoid it?”

“That is still a secret.”

“Good grief. Do the higher-ups not understand that excessive secrecy only leads to unnecessary casualties?”

With a dismissive shrug, Morishita turned and walked away, looking as though she’d entirely lost interest in the topic.

“She backed down surprisingly easily,” I muttered to myself.

Or perhaps she judged that simply confirming I had set things in motion was enough.

Whether she trusted me or not, she was undeniably a difficult person to read.

Part 2

The trials marched on, though the routine quickly grew monotonous. We were essentially just tackling tasks reminiscent of past special exams, scraping together whatever tokens we could across the three categories.

Naturally, the other students were fighting tooth and nail to secure every last token, but my focus had long since shifted past that stage. The total number of tokens in circulation had been fixed from the very beginning; the only variable was which group, which class, and which specific individuals they would ultimately fall to. To put it bluntly, I had already concluded that winning or losing the exam itself was little more than an added bonus.

The arrow I let loose now sped unerringly toward its destined victim.

Tomorrow, it would find its mark.

Before they even realized it, most of the students had already found their eyes drawn to its flight, quietly predicting how it would all end. Only a select few remained ignorant of what was coming.

If everything proceeded according to plan, the arrow would pierce its intended target, and the masses would emerge unscathed.

Yet there were always exceptions.

With so many eyes following its flight, it wouldn't be surprising if someone tried to snatch the arrow from the air before it struck.

By six o'clock that evening, we reached our final destination for the day and were finally granted a reprieve.

At that moment, Yoshida let out a heavy sigh, exhaling the day's accumulated exhaustion all at once.

“This is the last time we'll have to pitch these tents, isn't it?” Sanada asked.

“Sure feels like the end is finally in sight, but who knows?” Yoshida answered. “Even if this specific special exam wraps up tomorrow, there's always a chance the school keeps us out here on the uninhabited island.”

“I'd really prefer to hope... that isn't the case,” Sanada replied.

As I listened to their exchange, movement caught the corner of my eye. Shinohara was marching off with Kushida in tow, with Ike and Mii-chan trailing slightly behind them. They began setting up their camp a considerable distance away from the rest of us.

Of the four classes in our group, only theirs was isolating itself to such an extreme degree.

“What's with that? What are those guys doing?” Yoshida muttered, following my gaze.

“Perhaps they're dissatisfied with having outsiders meddle in Class A's policies,” Sanada suggested. “If they distance themselves that much, there's no way we can eavesdrop on their conversations.”

He was right. No matter how hard we strained our ears, picking up their voices from here would be impossible. And if anyone tried to close the gap, the attempt to make contact would be instantly obvious to Class A.

“That's definitely Shinohara's doing,” Yoshida concluded. “Let's just leave them be.”

After that, we slowly proceeded with our preparations, and by the time we finished eating dinner, darkness had fully settled over the surrounding area.

Mii-chan, who emerged from the vicinity of Class A's tents, scanned the area before her eyes locked onto mine.

Her gaze sent a clear, desperate signal: *Help*.

“Sorry, but I'll leave the rest of this to you for a bit,” I told Sanada. He willingly agreed, and I briskly made my way over to Mii-chan.

Seeing me approach, she jogged over to meet me halfway.

“This is about Shinohara and the others, isn't it?” I asked.

“...Yes,” she admitted. “Kushida-san begged them to share some tokens with her, but Shinohara-san completely refused to listen... They're arguing about it right now.”

“Understood. I'll go see what's going on.”

“Um, but... that might be a problem...” She stopped me, her expression fraught with guilt, and quietly began to explain why. “I was told to keep watch and make sure no one else comes near them. If anyone tried to approach, I was ordered to stop them at all costs... especially you, Ayanokōji-kun... Those were Shinohara-san's orders.”

Just as I suspected. Shinohara was highly vigilant against Kushida and me making contact. Ever since this special exam began, my stance of consistently evaluating Kushida highly while treating Shinohara and Ike with dismissive indifference had triggered her intense wariness. From her perspective, my motives were an unknown variable, so physically preventing us from interacting was the safest play. Given her limited options, it was probably the best strategy she could muster. Still, if I simply forced my way past here, the chances of Mii-chan becoming their next target weren't zero. I wanted to avoid that outcome.

“But... maybe I should let you go...? I just don't know what to do...”

Although we were technically functioning as a single, unified group, we spent the vast majority of our time segregated by class. It seemed the internal environment within Class A was considerably worse than it appeared on the surface.

Because the entrance to their tent was facing away from us, I couldn't get a read on the three of them from here.

“For now, I'll circle around through the trees and quietly check on the situation. Mii-chan, just stay here and keep playing the lookout.”

I instructed her to return to her post before slipping away into the forest. Moving swiftly through the cover of the trees, I looped around to the front of Shinohara's campsite. The two Class A tents were pitched side by side. I could see Shinohara and Ike standing just outside the one on the right.

Was Kushida... inside the tent?

At a quick glance, I couldn't see her anywhere, so I slowly shifted my angle until I had a clear line of sight into the tent's interior. That was when I realized exactly why I hadn't spotted her right away.

There at the entrance, Kushida was down on the ground in a full dogeza, prostrating herself entirely before Shinohara and Ike.

> **Translator's Note:** Dogeza **(土下座)** is one of the most extreme gestures of apology, supplication, or deference in Japanese culture. By kneeling and bowing until one's head touches the ground, a person demonstrates profound humility and a willingness to cast aside their pride, often in the face of overwhelming remorse, desperation, or earnest pleading.

Looking down at her, Shinohara wore an expression of sheer, unadulterated delight.

I could only imagine the violent vortex of anger currently swirling inside Kushida's heart. But even with their campsite pitched an unusually far distance from the rest of the group, they were still in a shared area. If she carelessly raised her voice, or if her foul-mouthed true nature was exposed to a third party, all the effort she had spent endlessly enduring hardships to maintain her 'good girl' facade would come crumbling down in an instant.

It seemed she was utterly committed to acting the part of the humble, submissive victim from beginning to end, hoping to somehow smooth things over.

Knowing I couldn't carelessly call out to them either, I was trying to figure out my next move when Shinohara's jeers finally reached my ears. Because she was directing her vitriol down toward the tent, the exact words were muffled, but the sheer fury in her tone was unmistakable.

As I observed the situation from the shadows for a moment longer, I noticed another presence approaching the area.

Having grasped the gist of the conflict, I decided it would be best to slip back to the Class C tents before I was discovered.

Part 3

Just shortly before Ayanokōji began circling through the trees, Shinohara's festering suspicions had finally exploded into outright fury. She simply couldn't let go of the incident on the second night, when it became glaringly obvious that their policy of cutting Kushida out of the tokens had been leaked to the other classes.

"You're the one who blabbed to everyone that I wasn't going to give you any tokens, didn't you, Kushida-san?" Shinohara demanded. "Just admit it already."

"I didn't..." Kushida pleaded. "No matter how much I deny it, you still won't believe me, will you...?"

"Then what? If there's someone else, who is it? Are you saying Mii-chan leaked it?"

"I don't know about that, but... it wasn't me. It would have to be either Mii-chan or Ike-kun."

Despite her desperate denials, nothing could shake Shinohara's absolute conviction that Kushida was the prime suspect.

"Satsuki," Ike interjected hesitantly. "it doesn't feel like Kikyō-chan is lying, though..."

"Huh?" Shinohara turned on him at once. "Then who *are* you saying leaked it? It wasn't you, Kanji, was it?"

"Of course it wasn't! There's no way I'd do that!" Ike shook his head quickly, then searched for somewhere else to place the blame. "Look, maybe that Ayanokōji guy spread it around or something... You know he's capable of anything."

"Listen to me," Shinohara said sharply, "Even if that were true, Class A was the one who decided on this policy in the first place, right? Even if Ayanokōji-kun is involved, it still means one of our classmates had to leak the information to him first. Seriously, Kanji, you're such an idiot."

“M-my bad…”

“Mii-chan hates Kushida-san, so she has no reason to leak it,” Shinohara pressed on. “Kushida-san is the only one who stands to benefit from making this public. The culprit was obvious from the very beginning.”

“But still, Kikyō-chan is smart enough to know you'd scold her if she carelessly leaked it, right?” Ike argued.

“She's trying to outsmart us! Kushida-san is supposed to be this brilliant, excellent student, isn't she?”

Unable to look directly at Kushida, who was sitting formally in a seiza position looking apologetic, Ike averted his gaze and squeezed out his voice.

“But you don't have solid proof it was Kikyō-chan, right? In that case—”

“Kikyō this, Kikyō that! that’s all you keep saying!” Shinohara’s anger burst out all at once. “Why are you so comfortable calling only Kushida-san by her first name!?”

“N-no…!”

It was a sudden, violent eruption of emotion. Ike panicked, choking on his words as he scrambled to formulate a defense. Before Shinohara could lay into him again, he forcefully talked over her.

“Even if you say that… I've called her that since way before you and I started dating…”

“Then you should just change it back to her last name starting right now!” Shinohara snapped. “I mean, seriously! Kushida-san is the one who called me ugly right in the middle of the classroom! She said those awful things to your own girlfriend, and you're still acting all buddy-buddy with her? Don't you think that's pathetic? It's embarrassing for me!”

Her eyes red and glaring, Shinohara snapped her gaze away from Ike and back down to Kushida.

“If you don't want to tell the truth, that's fine. I might not have hard proof that you betrayed us, but this relationship of trust is officially broken. Because of that, I can't give you any tokens anymore.”

After delivering that ultimatum, Shinohara forced a venomous smile.

“Or maybe you've already figured out a plan to avoid expulsion?” she continued. “Kushida-san is smart, after all. I wouldn't be surprised if you were out wagging your tail at guys other than Kanji, sweet-talking them into promising you their tokens.”

“I haven't done that…” Kushida whispered. “I haven't even thought about it…”

“This isn't like you, Satsuki… Just stop it already,” Ike pleaded.

“I said shut up! Why… why are you always defending someone like Kushida!?”

Dropping all honorifics, Shinohara dissolved into a hysterical fit. Ike couldn't hide the bewildered, helpless expression on his face.

“We're supposed to be comrades, aren't we?” Ike pressed. “You've been acting really strange ever since this special exam started, you know…”

Ike dropped his voice low, quickly warning her to quiet down. Even with this kind of distance, someone from another class was bound to hear her if she kept yelling.

“I can't help it! Kanji, Yoshida, Ayanokōji— all of you! You guys always just take Kushida's side!”

Rather than calming down at Ike's warning, Shinohara's emotions flared even higher.

"Your voice! You're being too loud!" Ike hissed.

Shinohara's chest heaved with ragged breaths. For several seconds she said nothing, only stood there trying to steady herself, until at last she dragged in a breath and violently brushed her disheveled bangs out of her face.

"Nobody is listening out here," she said, her voice lower now but no less sharp. "so why don't you just show us your true colors, Kushida-san? You might feel a lot better if you do."

"...Even if you tell me to show my true nature, it troubles me. I don't really have any intention of fighting with you, Shinohara-san..."

"Oh, really? Then why are you parading around like some tragic heroine? Making me out to be the villain. Why are you putting on this big show, whining 'I can't get any tokens~' to everyone?"

"That's just..." Kushida faltered, then corrected herself. "I just want you to keep your promise... No, I just want you to properly transfer my share of the tokens up until today. When I think about the fact that I might get expelled, I can't help but feel anxious..."

"Anxious?" Shinohara repeated. "Even though I told you I'd give them to you later? See, you really don't trust me after all."

"...It's not that I don't trust you. But——"

"I've told you over, and over, and *over* again, haven't I?" Shinohara immediately cut her off. "I will definitely give you your tokens before we reach the goal. Until then, I'm just holding onto them for the sake of adjustments. Get that through your head already."

'Adjustments'. It was a highly convenient excuse. She hadn't revealed a single detail about what this supposed strategy was or how it benefited anyone.

Naturally, Kushida understood what was actually happening. Her tokens were being confiscated purely out of spite; they were being held hostage as insurance to guarantee that Shinohara and Ike wouldn't be the ones expelled in a worst-case scenario. Forced to endure this one-sided oppression, Kushida's own frustration had to be boiling over. Yet, she didn't simply explode in a fit of rage like Shinohara. Even though their camp was isolated, they were still relatively close to the others. There was no telling when someone might wander by and see her.

“In the first place,” Shinohara continued, “this is all your fault for insulting me in front of everyone. You're at least aware of that much, aren’t you?” Shinohara demanded.

“...You're right,” Kushida replied. “I'm truly reflecting on my actions regarding that...”

“Hmph. If you're really so sorry, then show me some actual sincerity for starting all this.”

“Sincerity...?” Kushida asked quietly. “Is it enough if I quietly leave the tokens in your care until just before the goal?”

At Kushida's questioning words, Shinohara let out a derisive snort, rejecting the idea entirely before thrusting her true demand forward.

“People might make fun of me for this, and maybe it is a bit unreasonable. But everyone has a line they absolutely will not let someone cross, right? Kushida-san, you crossed that line. I think an appropriate display of submission is necessary.”

With that, Shinohara pointed down at the dirt floor inside the tent.

“Then get down and do a dogeza right here in front of me. As proof that you trust me. Me, of all people.”

It was a demand that truly crossed the line. For a split second, both Kushida's expression and her heart completely froze.

Shocked by the absurdly cruel ultimatum, Ike reached out to touch Shinohara's shoulder to soothe her, but she violently brushed his hand away.

“Can you do it?” Shinohara asked. “Or not?”

It was, in essence, a forceful binary choice: *Do you want your tokens or not?*

For Kushida, there was no room to choose.

“I beg of you... please believe me——”

Placing her hands on the ground, she lowered her head deeply, executing a flawless, beautiful dogeza at Shinohara's feet.



It was a deeply humiliating posture. Yet, far from being satisfied, Shinohara found an unspeakable irritation swelling inside her.

For Shinohara, it was an unbearable reality that even while groveling in the dirt, a posture meant to be ugly and degrading, Kushida still looked infinitely more poised and put-together than she ever could.

"...Somehow, I'm just not feeling any heartfelt sincerity in that. I mean, you have two different faces, right, Kushida-san? You must be so pissed off at me right now you can hardly stand it."

It wasn't as if Kushida's mere existence was causing Shinohara any direct harm. Ike's feelings for Shinohara were genuine, and nothing romantic had ever actually happened between him and Kushida.

Even so, Shinohara was consumed by a suffocating inferiority complex, the inescapable feeling that she was lesser in every conceivable way, from her face and her intelligence to the very curves of her body. It was a merciless reality; even after learning just how rotten Kushida was on the inside, it was no wonder Ike still found himself captivated by her.

Shinohara knew this. She knew that if they competed on an even playing field, she could never win. It was an insurmountable gap in natural-born gifts. Therefore, her only recourse was to leverage her position and power to forcefully grind Kushida down into the dirt.

"That's not true..." Kushida pleaded, still bowing low. "Please, you have to believe me..."

The words repeated themselves. Shinohara knew full well those words were completely hollow. The true, venomous nature Kushida had exposed during the Unanimous Special Exam had been far too intense to ever forget.

But it was also true that she couldn't force her to stay in a dogeza forever. She had to consider when to pull back.

“Aren't you a good girl, groveling so obediently like that?” Shinohara said at last. “...Yeah, I get it. I'll give you the tokens just as promised. But it's going to be right before the goal on the final day. Right before transfers become impossible, that is.”

Within Group 3, the most likely candidates to finish dead last in tokens were Ibuki and Kushida.

From Shinohara's perspective, as long as she crossed the finish line with even a single token more than either of them, she was 100% guaranteed to survive this special exam.

As for Ibuki, Katsuragi was currently clamping down on her for failing to produce results, but there was no telling when or if he might step in to save her at the last minute. Shinohara needed to hoard as much insurance as she possibly could.

“Is this... enough now?” Kushida asked quietly. “Someone might come by...”

“No,” Shinohara ordered. “Stay exactly like that for one more minute. Still, it really is a shame we don't have our phones on us, right, Kanji?”

“N-no... how should I put it,” Ike’s voice faltered. “aren't you going a bit too far? At this point, it's just bullying...”

“Huh?” Shinohara’s anger, which had only barely begun to settle, flared again in an instant. She turned on him with a glare. “What about the humiliation I suffered? That was bullying too, wasn’t it? Why do you keep taking her side?”

“You prefer Kushida over me, don’t you?” Her voice rose, sharp and unstable. “That’s it, isn’t it!?”

“N-No! I'm telling you, it's not like that!”

With his face twitching at her unstoppable rampage, Ike cautiously touched her shoulder again in a desperate bid to calm her down.

“Hey— what kind of sickening game are you guys playing?”

An unusually low, entirely deadpan voice suddenly echoed from the darkness behind them.

Ike panicked, grabbing the hand of Kushida who was still in a dogeza, trying to haul her to her feet, but it was too late. Ibuki, who had circled around to investigate the noise, had a crystal-clear view of Kushida groveling on the floor of the tent.

“...Huh?” Shinohara stammered. “What... what are you talking about, Ibuki-san?”

“About that dogeza.” Ibuki’s gaze remained flat. “You guys are supposed to be allies, aren't you?”

“This was something Kushida-san did voluntarily,” Shinohara said quickly. “Right, Kanji?”

“W-Well, yeah...” Ike answered with lacked conviction. “Something like that... Wait, why the hell are you even here, Ibuki!?”

“What do you mean, ‘what’? I was just taking a walk when I heard all that ‘gyaa gyaa’ yelling, so I came to take a look.”

After saying that, Ibuki added, as though she had suddenly remembered something.

“Oh, by the way, I already know all about Kushida's true nature, so don't sweat it. The girl has a genuinely piss-off personality, so I totally get the urge to make her grovel.”

Hearing her casually touch upon the secret they were most desperate to protect, Shinohara and Ike exchanged terrified glances.

“W-What, you knew...?” Ike asked. “Wait, do the other guys in Class B know, too?”

“Pretty sure they don't,” Ibuki replied. “So that little secret you're trying so hard to protect is safe. However—”

Not breaking her stride, Ibuki looked away from Kushida and stepped right in front of Shinohara.

“What is it?” Shinohara snapped, defensive. “Do you have a problem with me? You just said you understood how I felt, didn't you?”

“Well, yeah. If I made Kushida grovel, I'd probably feel pretty damn good about it, too. But I just realized that watching someone *else* make her do it is incredibly obnoxious. Anyway, why don't you get up already?”

“...Just leave us alone, Ibuki-san,” Kushida finally spoke up, her voice calm. “This is an internal Class A matter. It has nothing to do with you.” Then she turned her words toward Shinohara. “And don't worry, Shinohara-san. Ibuki-san really does know about me, so you don't need to worry.”

Hearing that, Shinohara's resentment cooled slightly, allowing her to regain a measure of composure. The fact that Ibuki had wandered over meant other students might follow soon. If word of this dogeza leaked to the rest of the camp, it would only spell trouble for Shinohara and Ike.

“I’m glad you’re on my side, Kushida-san,” Shinohara said, her voice returning to something closer to calm. “Come on, Kanji. Let’s go back to everyone else.”

“...Y-yeah.”

Still harboring a visible knot of guilt, Ike let Shinohara grab his hand and drag him hurriedly away into the dark.

Ibuki watched them leave, then looked back at Kushida.

“I went out of my way to save your ass, and you tell me to *‘leave you alone’?”* She scoffed at Kushida. “Who the hell do you think you are?”

“I'm just fighting desperately to survive in my own way,” Kushida replied flatly. “As long as Shinohara holds the actual power over the tokens, I have to do whatever it takes, right?”

“And ‘whatever it takes’ means kissing the dirt? Do you have zero pride?”

“I’m fighting because I do have pride. I suppose you wouldn’t understand that, Ibuki-san.” Kushida rose slowly, touching her knees as though soothing the ache left by the position she had been forced to hold. “Sorry, but if something happens from here on, could you not interfere? Even if I look miserable right now, it’s still better than being expelled. If I obey those two, I can get more tokens than you. In that case, something like this isn’t a big deal.”

“I see.” Ibuki’s expression twisted faintly. “Now that you mention it, you were always thick-skinned.”

Kushida stepped out of the tent, then turned her back as if the conversation no longer mattered.

“You should try harder too, Ibuki-san,” she said. “Otherwise you’ll be expelled.”

“Shut up. I know that.”

“Could it be that you've half-given up?”

Ibuki, who had already turned to head back to her own tent, froze mid-step.

“I haven't given up or anyth—”

“That's fine. Honestly, if you end up dropping out, my chances of survival go up by exactly that much.”

With a small, dismissive scoff over her shoulder, Kushida walked away into the night.

“What a total bitch. I never should've called out to her,” Ibuki muttered to herself in the empty clearing.

Even after spitting those words out into the dark, she couldn't bring herself to move from that spot. She was irritated, certainly. But it wasn't just anger.

Shinohara's distorted, petty obsession. The spineless half-measures of Ike, who couldn't bring himself to properly stop her. And that infuriatingly pragmatic attitude of Kushida's.

She despised all of it. Every single part of this situation pissed her off. But what angered her the most right now was her own existence.

If this were a problem she could solve just by punching it, things would be easy. But this special exam... this wasn't something she could just fight her way through. She couldn't subdue it with physical violence, nor could she bulldoze through it with sheer stubborn emotion. It was a deeply frustrating, suffocating school life.

To survive, she had no choice but to think. Yet she never expected the act of thinking itself to be this troublesome and infuriating.

She clicked her tongue once and dropped her gaze to the dirt.

She knew her token count was sinking straight to the bottom of the rankings. But even knowing that, she had no clear idea of what her next move should be.

Should I simply leave things in Katsuragi's hands? When it comes down to it, would he save me in the end, saying it couldn't be helped?

No. She didn't possess that kind of value.

Then should I take matters into my own hands and seize an opportunity myself?

In this exam, someone was absolutely going to be expelled. That harsh reality was why Kushida was fighting so ruthlessly, not even hesitating to do a dogeza.

I couldn't find an answer. Or perhaps—— I already had.

"...There's no point in me clinging to this school if it means obsessing over crap like this," she whispered into the empty air. "I'm just hopelessly unsuited for this place."

Spitting out that quiet realization, Ibuki finally forced her feet to move.

Part 4

Afterward, Shinohara strolled back over to the rest of the group, wearing a perfectly innocent expression as she joined in on the idle chatter. Her expression gave nothing away. She chatted lightly, wearing the same casual face as before, and then confirmed with her own eyes that Ayanokōji was still there, speaking amiably with Yoshida.

A few seconds later, Ike arrived as well.

Unlike Shinohara, he could not quite conceal what had happened. His steps were restless, his movements faintly unsettled, as if some part of him were still caught back at the tent.

“Thanks, Mii-chan. It looks like Ayanokōji-kun didn't make a move after all,” Shinohara whispered.

“Y-yes,” Mii-chan replied hesitantly.

A few minutes later, Kushida emerged from the tent. Having properly dusted herself off and fixed her appearance, she wore her usual, impeccably bright expression.

Are you okay? Mii-chan desperately wanted to ask her that softly, but with Shinohara standing nearby, wearing a smug, triumphant smile as she kept a watchful eye on them, she didn't dare to speak up.

“Shinohara-san, you have an incoming call from Horikita-san,” Urushihara called out, approaching their group.

“From Horikita-san...?” Mii-chan murmured.

“...Looks like it,” Shinohara replied.

During the first radio check-in, Shinohara had been deeply irritated that Horikita had contacted Kushida instead of her. Because of that, she had forced Kushida to tell Horikita to direct all future communications to the actual group representative, meaning her. Seeing that demand finally come to fruition filled her with a petty, lingering sense of joy.

Right before accepting the radio from the supervisor, Shinohara reached out and tightly clamped her hand around Kushida's wrist just as the girl tried to turn away.

“Don't try anything funny that might betray me, okay?” she said in a low voice. “If you do, I'll expose your true colors to everyone here.”

“I know,” Kushida replied softly. “I won't do anything like that.”

Shinohara was actively preempting her, aggressively tying down Kushida's every word and action.

Even if Kushida somehow managed to secretly lay the groundwork to receive token assistance from someone else, the actual transfer of points would require direct physical proximity right in front of the others. Deceiving Shinohara during that critical moment would be a monumental task.

Here, on the night of the third day, Shinohara's resolve hardened. She decided right then and there that she absolutely would not take her eyes off Kushida until the very moment they crossed the final finish line. Whether it was someone from Class A, Ayanokōji, or some random student trying to earn Kushida's favor with an ulterior motive, it didn't matter who it was. The second anyone showed even the slightest sign of transferring tokens to her, Shinohara would intervene and shut it down.

If Kushida suddenly claimed she didn't need any tokens right before the goal, or if she refused to disclose her current count, Shinohara would instantly judge that a secret transfer had taken place. If that happened, she and Ike would simply keep the stockpile of tokens she was supposedly 'managing' for Kushida and split it entirely between the two of them. By doing so, they could completely eliminate their own risk of finishing dead last in the school year.

Without even realizing it, Shinohara's twisted obsession with Kushida had continued to swell, completely eclipsing her concern over Ibuki, the person who was actually heavily favored to finish in last place.

"Sorry, Kanji, but keep a close eye on Kushida-san for a second."

"U-understood."

A moment later, she lifted the radio.

"Hello, Horikita-san? Do you need something?"

Answering the radio in incredibly high spirits, Shinohara broke into a smug grin and walked a short distance away. It was a deliberate, exclusionary display, a physical declaration that she was the one holding the reins of power in their group, and that mere underlings weren't allowed to eavesdrop on her conversation.

"Ike-kun... do you have a minute?" Kushida whispered.

She kept her voice just low enough to avoid arousing Shinohara's suspicion as she spoke to her newly appointed guard.

"Hm? W-what is it."

"Shinohara-san really is going to share the tokens with me before we reach the goal... right?"

"...Of course she is," Ike answered. "Seriously, there's nothing to worry about."

“Yeah, I trust Shinohara-san. I just... I just can't help feeling anxious. It's true that I said some awful things about her, but... I was desperate back then. There were so many things I said that I didn't truly mean.”

As she spoke, Kushida reached out and gently gripped the hem of Ike's jersey between her fingertips.

“K-Kikyō-chan!?” Ike’s voice nearly cracked. “If Satsuki catches us doing this, it'll be really bad...!”

“Don't move,” Kushida whispered. “Shinohara-san can't see us from here.”

It was a veiled threat. If they were caught, Kushida would undoubtedly incur more of Shinohara's wrath, but Ike would find himself equally in the firing line.

“I don’t have anyone else I can rely on anymore,” Kushida said. “It’s only you, Ike-kun...”

“I-It'll be fine,” Ike said quickly. “I promise, there is absolutely no way Satsuki would ever abandon you, Kikyō-chan.”

“Really...?”

“If Satsuki seriously tries to say she won't give you any tokens, I'll step in and set her straight. You can rest easy about that.” His expression tightened with guilt. “I'm sorry... making you grovel in the dirt like that was going way too far, no matter how you look at it...”

“No, it was my fault, too... But still, just hearing you say that... makes me so happy.”

Kushida paused for a brief moment. Then, with glistening, teary eyes, she looked up softly into his.

“If you come through and save me when it really matters, Ike-kun... then when that time comes... I'll do anything you want.”

“Eh——?”

He could feel the sweet warmth of her breath ghosting over his skin. A split second after Ike inhaled her scent, Kushida's fingertips slipped smoothly away from his jersey.

Shortly after, Shinohara returned, radio in hand. Completely oblivious to the exchange, she grabbed the arm of a visibly flustered Ike and practically dragged him briskly toward their tent.

“Listen to this, Kanji. Ayanokōji-kun is plotting something completely unbelievable.”

Hearing Ayanokōji's name leave Shinohara's smugly smiling lips, Ike's eyes went wide.

Part 5

The four students of Class A had initially been huddled together in their own isolated camp, but the moment Shinohara finished her radio transmission, she dragged Ike a short distance away.

After retreating to their tent, the two began discussing something in secret, occasionally shooting glances in my direction. The fact that someone, no, the fact that *Horikita* had directly contacted Shinohara meant she had finally begun making moves as well.

Considering the timing, it was safe to assume Horikita had set this up fully expecting me to catch wind of it.

“She has definitely grown, slowly but surely,” I murmured to myself. “So in the end, she did reach out for the arrow.”

I was genuinely surprised. I had calculated that there was a greater than fifty percent chance she wouldn't attempt to stop the arrow mid flight.

No, it was still too early to tell.

I didn't know yet if Horikita's hand was actually meant to stop the arrow's flight, or if she was merely feigning the attempt. Either way, by making this very visible move, she was probing to see how I would react.

Right now, with Shinohara thoroughly distracted by whatever she'd heard over the radio, making contact with Kushida would be incredibly simple.

“Yoshida, come here for a second,” I called out.

“Hm? Oh, sure.”

Without even asking why I'd called him over, Yoshida pushed himself up and stepped out of our tent.

With him in tow, I walked directly over to Kushida.

“Could you give me just five minutes? There's something I want to ask you,” I said.

Kushida turned to face us. She immediately flashed her perfectly crafted smile and answered without a second's hesitation. “Sure.”

“Sorry Yoshida, but could you head back to the tent?” I said, turning to Yoshida. “I want to talk to Kushida alone.”

“Huh? Wait, then why did you even bring me...?” Yoshida replied, surprised. “Well, whatever.”

He tilted his head in mild confusion, but rather than pressing the issue, he simply turned around and headed back toward the Class C camp.

“That was pretty underhanded, using Yoshida-kun like that,” Kushida remarked quietly once he was out of earshot.

“If I hadn't gone that far, I figured there was a solid chance you wouldn't even entertain the conversation,” I replied.

Because I had approached her with Yoshida present, Kushida, who was always hyper-aware of public perception, had been forced to readily agree to my request to maintain her friendly facade. Now that she had publicly consented, she had no choice but to stand there and listen to what I had to say, whether she liked it or not.

“What is it now?” Kushida asked, her tone shifting to her usual brusque self once we were alone.

“It seems Shinohara still isn't willing to transfer the tokens to you.”

“Looks like she's holding a serious grudge over me calling her ugly, so I guess I can't really blame her. But honestly, part of me wants to say, ‘What's wrong with stating a fact’—— lol, nevermind.”

With a derisive snort, Kushida flicked her gaze over toward Shinohara's camp without turning her head.

The root cause of Shinohara's refusal to hand over the tokens seemed to stem entirely from the grudge she had harbored since the Unanimous Special Exam. Over by their tent, Shinohara, who had been keeping a close eye on our movements, had clearly noticed us talking. Ike tried to head over in our direction, but Shinohara grabbed his arm and stopped him with a laugh.

“The way Ike looks at me... completely unable to hide his gross ulterior motives... makes me sick,” Kushida muttered. “They really are a match made in heaven.”

Perhaps because I was the only one listening, she freely spat out her venom right here in the middle of the campsite.

“If you distance yourself from Ike, won't Shinohara calm down a bit?” I asked.

“Doing that would only buy me more of Shinohara's animosity. Besides, even if I wasn't making eyes at Ike right now, his attitude toward me wouldn't have changed, would it?”

That might be true. The fact that Ike had such a glaring soft spot for Kushida, combined with the fact that I actively valued her while treating Shinohara with dismissive indifference, were likely just acts that added fuel to a fire that had already been smoldering.

“Either way, in the worst-case scenario, I'll be abandoned. To prevent that, I have to think about not only pulling tokens from Shinohara, but from Ike as well. Even if I try relying on Mii-chan, well, since she doesn't like me, it's probably impossible.”

During the Unanimous Special Exam, Mii-chan's private romantic situation had been publicly dragged out into the open as a direct result of Kushida's rampage. Even though Mii-chan interacted with her normally now, it was a humiliating trauma she wouldn't soon forget. Although she suppressed her resentment enough to worry about Kushida, her position meant she likely couldn't transfer any tokens to her anyway. It was certain she couldn't be counted on.

“I know this sounds bitchy,” Kushida continued, “but part of the reason I'm struggling this much right now is because of you, Ayanokōji-kun. You praised me in front of everyone when our groups were first put together, didn't you? It seems like that's what originally lit the fire under her. Is this your way of getting payback because I held a grudge and refused to tell you who the VIP was during the Survival Game Special Exam?”

When I had slipped into the Class A campsite just barely within the time limit back then, I had made a brief contact with Kushida, silently confirming if she would tell me the VIP's identity. She had refused through her attitude alone. It was a silent visual exchange that lasted less than a few seconds. No one could have possibly noticed it.

“I thought you were just hesitating about whose side to take,” I said. “Weren't you afraid I would expose your true nature to the others? If the entire school finds out, you'll have no place left here.”

“It's far too late for that. The people in my class already hold my secret anyway.”

In reality, Kushida had allowed herself to be completely controlled and rendered powerless by someone like Shinohara. But that wasn't the whole story. Clearly, her internal evaluation of Horikita had begun to shift, and her own way of thinking was gradually changing along with it. Not that she would ever admit it if I pointed it out.

“I didn't intend it as payback,” I told her. “What happened with Shinohara was entirely unintentional.”

“Well, if you tell me that I'm the one who sowed the seeds of this mess in the first place, I can't exactly argue back. Anyway, what's clear right now is that neither Shinohara nor Mii-chan are going to take my side. Given that, my only option is to rope in at least Ike and persuade him into transferring his tokens to me.”

There seemed to be an extraordinary resolve and determination in her expression.

“You have a look on your face that says you'll do absolutely anything.”

“Damn right I will,” she said flatly. “I'll even let him grope my breasts if that's what it takes. Even that idiot would hand over some tokens after that, wouldn't he?”

“That would probably be extremely effective.”

If she went that far, wringing out not just one or two, but ten or twenty tokens wouldn't be impossible.

“It seems a trump card like that didn't work on a *certain* someone, though,” she added, shooting me a cold, sideways glare for a fraction of a second.

It felt like a lifetime ago now, but of course, I remembered that incident perfectly well.

Kushida claimed her trump card had no effect, but that was strictly regarding the outcome involving my fingerprints and everything that followed.

If we were purely talking about my state of mind at the time... well, it had certainly been plenty effective for a healthy high school boy.

“If Ike ends up sacrificing his own tokens for my sake, Shinohara won't have a choice but to help him in the end, even if she's pissed about it. Making a move like that might completely cement them as my enemies here and now, but surviving this special exam takes priority. If Ike alone isn't enough, I'll go after Yoshida or Sonoda. In the worst-case scenario, I'll just shift my target to them.”

That meant if push came to shove, she was fully prepared to use the same physical trump card she had planned for Ike on students from entirely different classes. Of course, if she misread her target's personality, it could easily escalate into a serious incident, exponentially inflating the risk.

“I'll ask just in case, but... you have no intention of actually helping me, right, Ayanokōji-kun?”

“In exchange, are you willing to offer me that trump card— your body— again?”

When I asked her back with a completely straight face, Kushida froze for a split second before her jaw dropped.

“H-Hah!? W-What kind of stupid crap are you spouting!? Like hell I would!”

“I thought you were perfectly willing to throw away your dignity if it meant making Ike and the others fall for it?”

“...That's... well, because those guys are practically garbage... and they're incredibly simple-minded? Or rather, you're just messing with me, aren't you? You aren't actually going to help me, Ayanokōji-kun. Right?”

“Unfortunately for you, that's correct. I will produce results for my current class; that remains my absolute highest priority.”

“Then are we done here? I don't want to keep talking to you when you aren't even going to help me, only to gather more pointless hate from Shinohara. Just leave me alone.”

Saying that, Kushida instantly flipped her expression back into a perfectly crafted, bright smile. She offered a cheerful little wave, putting on a friendly show for anyone watching as she naturally distanced herself from me.

Whether things would actually play out as smoothly as she intended remained to be seen.

After all, the other party’s vault was considerably tough to crack.

Chapter 7: Intertwining Strategies

The second and third days of the exam continued with a flurry of tasks. Individually, these trials had yielded small, almost negligible shifts in the overall tokens— hardly enough to warrant concern. But minor gains had a way of compounding. Like drops of water wearing away at a stone, the steady accumulation had subtly reshaped the landscape of the exam. Before long, a handful of students had quietly amassed three-digit fortunes.

It was against this tense, shifting backdrop that the final morning broke. Faint rustling outside her tent pulled Ibuki from her sleep.

For a moment, she lay still inside the tent, listening. The air was quiet in that thin, early-morning way, before the camp had fully begun to stir. She blinked against the gloom, shifting her arm to glance at her smartwatch. The luminous hands pointed just past six o'clock.

Straining her ears, it did not take long for the sound to reveal itself as footsteps. They passed along the side of the tent, then continued on, gradually fading into the distance. Judging by the direction, whoever it was seemed to be heading toward the shore.

It wasn't completely unusual for an early riser to take a morning stroll, and her first instinct was to just ignore it. Yet, for some reason, the footsteps nagged at her.

Careful not to wake Morofuji, Ibuki quietly sat up and peeled back the tent flap just enough to peek outside.

The retreating figure slipping into the forest was none other than Kushida.

“That girl...”

The image of Kushida pressing her forehead to the dirt in a desperate dogeza yesterday flashed through Ibuki's mind; a raw, unforgettable display of her fierce determination to survive at this school.

If the special exam ended right now, there was a very real chance Ibuki would finish in dead last. She had earned so few tokens herself that it was almost laughable.

What would happen to her once the exam concluded today?

Would she be confined to the cruise ship on standby until the others returned, or would they toss her on a small boat and ship her back to the mainland immediately?

Either way, she might never get another chance to speak with Kushida one-on-one.

Unable to suppress her curiosity, Ibuki slipped out of the tent and followed the path she had taken.

Before long, Kushida's back came into view. She was standing barefoot at the water's edge, gazing out across the vast expanse of the ocean.

Kushida was fighting a war inside her own head. A massive, suffocating wave of frustration had been building within her since the very start of the special exam. She was gripped by a powerful urge to scream her lungs out, but she firmly swallowed it down.

Even though she had put some distance between herself and the campsite, a loud shriek might still carry through the morning air.

"This is so damn irritating..." she muttered.

On top of the exhausting effort to constantly maintain her 'good girl' mask, having her true nature exposed to her classmates was a source of immeasurable stress. Shinohara confiscating her tokens. Ike's vulgar, lingering stares. And worst of all, being coerced into a humiliating dogeza; her pride torn to absolute shreds under the threat of exposure to the other classes.

Kushida was harboring a darker, more intense rage than she had ever felt in her entire life.

Even so, the only reason she managed to keep herself from screaming was the bitter lesson she had learned in the past. Ever since she had foolishly let her guard down and allowed Ayanokōji to discover her true self, the gears of her meticulously crafted life had started to slip out of sync. She wouldn't— or rather, *couldn't*— make that same mistake again.

Standing there, she entrusted the sea with the dark emotions swirling inside her, desperate for the tide to wash them away.

She had come here seeking a small, solitary world of her own, a fleeting respite born of sheer desperation, like a drowning girl grasping for air.

Kushida took another step forward. The returning tide washed over her feet, soaking her to the ankles. Narrowing her eyes at the faint, cooling comfort of the water, she steadied her breathing.

“I'll figure something out…” she whispered to the wind. “Even if the absolute worst comes to pass, and I have to go crying to Horikita... I will *definitely* stay here——!?”

Right then, a sudden, heavy impact slammed into her back. Before her brain could even process what was happening, she was sent pitching forward. She instinctively threw her hands out to catch herself, but with nothing to break her fall but the ocean, she plunged face-first into the seawater, getting completely drenched.

Sputtering and completely bewildered, Kushida pushed her upper body off the wet sand and whipped her head around. Standing right behind her, legs planted wide and glaring down sharply, was Ibuki.

“...Huh?”

Kushida stared in sheer disbelief. Her mind couldn't make sense of the situation, but the moment the low sound escaped her lips, her irritation surged forward like a tidal wave.

“Ibuki-san…” she said, her voice darkening. “just what do you think you're doing?”

“What does it look like? A tackle, I guess,” Ibuki replied flatly. “You had your back turned to me, looking completely, stupidly defenseless. I just couldn't help myself.”

“I have absolutely no idea what you mean...! *Why* would you do that?”

“Why?” Ibuki looked down at her without the slightest hint of apology. “Well, a while back, Horikita was moping around with that exact same gloomy aura hanging over her back. I gave her a good kick from behind when she did it, so... I guess I felt a similar urge?”

“No, even with an explanation, I seriously do not get it!” Kushida looked down at herself, drenched by the seawater. “Look at me—what are you going to do about this!?”

Seawater had already seeped all the way through to her underwear. It was a lost cause.

“Serves you right,” Ibuki said.

“I don't see why I have to take that from... Ow...!”

Kushida tried to rise, only for pain to twist across her face. Her strength gave out, and she dropped back into the shallow water with a muted splash.

A small, muffled groan escaped her lips.

She placed one hand near her waist and made no further attempt to stand.

“What,” Ibuki frowned. “Did you actually hurt yourself just from that...?”

Thinking she might have gone a bit too far against an amateur, Ibuki tossed her shoes aside and waded into the water.

“I can't really stand... Pull me up,” Kushida said, reaching out a trembling hand.

Reluctantly, Ibuki took it, only to be violently yanked forward.

“Wha——!?”

Because she had genuinely believed Kushida might actually be hurt, Ibuki's guard had been completely down. With a massive splash, she pitched face-first into the sea, saltwater instantly rushing into her parted lips.

“Ptooh! Ptooh! God, that's salty!”

Right on cue, as if to add insult to injury, Kushida scooped up a double handful of seawater and splashed it directly into Ibuki's face.

“Uwah! What the hell are you doing?!”

“I think that's my line, isn't it?” Kushida shot back, her tone suddenly bright and venomous.

“Faking an injury, you dirty sneak!”

Scrambling to her feet, Ibuki put some distance between them and violently kicked the surface of the water, sending a retaliatory wave crashing back at Kushida. From there, it devolved into a petty, childish brawl, a relentless battle of splashing seawater back and forth.

Whether it lasted one minute or two, in the end, there was no victor. The battle ended in a complete draw, leaving both of them soaked, breathless, and sitting in the water.

“Haa, haa... Why do I have to deal with this first thing in the morning...” Ibuki panted. “you idiot Kushida.”

“Like I said, that's my line...” Kushida replied, also short of breath. “Fufu... You really are an idiot, Ibuki-san...”


Kushida Kikyō
Ibuki Mio

The two of them sat chest-deep in the ocean, glaring at one another. But then, in a sudden, shared moment of clarity, they both burst out laughing at the sheer absurdity of what they were doing.

"...You know," Ibuki muttered once their laughter finally subsided, "maybe you don't need to be that pessimistic about getting expelled."

Kushida looked toward her.

"The initial tokens," Ibuki continued. "They were distributed based on how long students lasted in the survival game special exam, right? You lasted pretty close to the end too, didn't you? Even if Shinohara's managing your tokens, you should still have a bigger safety net than me. I don't think you need to panic over missing out on a few tokens now."

"That's just a margin of error," Kushida dismissed. "More importantly, I don't think Katsuragi-kun would just abandon you like this."

If Katsuragi were to provide her with twenty or thirty tokens, the individual gap between her and the others would easily close.

"So you're saying I'm the prime candidate for last place?" Ibuki sighed. "That guy Katsuragi... he genuinely intends to distribute our tokens equally. He was dead serious about it. Giving preferential treatment to someone like me who can't produce individual results, and potentially sacrificing another hard working classmate in the process, he'd never forgive himself for that. Besides, he was talking with Ryūen on the radio last night. He might have even gotten direct orders to just cut me loose."

It was a strangely un-Ibuki-like thing to say. There was no anger in it. Only a kind of detached resignation. Hearing this, Kushida was completely convinced that the suspicion she had harbored yesterday was spot on.

"I see. It's true that you don't have a single redeeming quality, Ibuki-san, so that's probably the right call," Kushida replied bluntly.

Even though there had been tasks where Ibuki could have shined, she had been forced to compete directly against Ayanokōji at crucial moments. Thanks to a cascading series of bad luck, all her efforts had merely spun their wheels in vain. Despite her fretting over the tasks being systematically checked off by the others, time marched on, refusing to wait for her.

“So, I guess I've just given up…” Ibuki murmured. “I don't know, it's a weird feeling.”

For some reason, Manabe’s face flashed inside her mind, her former classmate who had been expelled.

In Manabe’s case, it had been an instant ‘death’. A surprise attack. Something like being struck down before she even understood the blade had fallen.

This was different.

“How should I put it…” she said. “It feels like I'm slowly ‘dying’ from poison.”

Back when she and Ryūen had challenged Ayanokōji during the survival game and suffered a crushing defeat, she never could have imagined it would come to this. A hollow laugh bubbled up in her throat at the thought of how drastically her environment and position had shifted in just a few short days.

“You don't know that for sure yet,” Kushida said. “You might be close to the bottom, but there are plenty of other groups out there. It's highly unlikely that there are zero other students struggling just as much as you.”

“What's that?” Ibuki asked. “Supposed to be comforting?”

“Not really. I only care about saving myself. It's just reassuring for me to have you down at the bottom.” Kushida replied. “And it would be even *more* reassuring if there was someone lower than you. I just said it because it's what I was thinking.”

It was such a perfectly Kushida-like answer that Ibuki felt, strangely enough, a little relieved.

“Do you really want to graduate from Class A that badly?” Ibuki asked.

“Obviously. I'm an honors student, after all,” Kushida declared as she stood up and began wading toward the shore. “I'm going to graduate from Class A. I'm going to be respected by everyone around me, respected by my parents, and become a member of society that everyone else envies. I will do whatever it takes to make that happen.”

Reaching the wet sand, Kushida glanced back. “There are only a few tasks left now, and I really don't see you making a sudden comeback, Ibuki-san. Still, it wouldn't hurt to hold onto a little hope that someone else might trip up, or that Katsuragi-kun will save you, right?”

“I'm heading back,” she added, leaving those words behind as she returned to the campsite ahead of her.

It was a situation much like yesterday. Yet, despite the looming threat of expulsion, Ibuki's heart felt undeniably lighter than before.

“I'm different from Kushida,” she murmured to the empty beach. “I still don't feel any burning desire to avoid expulsion. But…”

If she were to be expelled just like this…

Thinking about it in those terms, she realized there was exactly one lingering regret left inside her.

Part 1

Our current location was F7.

The clock had just struck 5:00 p.m in the evening when the supervisor called everyone together.

“Thank you for your hard work over this three-night, four-day special exam,” Urushihara said, diving right into his explanation. “I will now announce your final task.”

They could finally return to the ship; that fact slightly, but surely, lightened the hearts of the students.

“Your task is to head to the goal location by 7:00 p.m. The destination is Area F13.”

F13 was almost the same as our starting point.

In other words, we were being told to return to where we had begun, and to do so within the allotted time.

“The other groups will be aiming for the exact same goal,” Urushihara continued. “While their current locations differ, they are starting from roughly the same distance away. You may even spot students from other groups along the route.”

Though the school had tried to distribute everyone fairly, the reality of the island's terrain meant there would inevitably be some groups with a slight advantage or disadvantage in terms of distance.

“Your arrival will be officially recognized thirty seconds after your smartwatches register that you've entered Area F13. Students who reach the goal within the time limit will be awarded three tokens as a reward. Should you fail to arrive on time, Class Points will be deducted in accordance with the rulebook. Furthermore, the penalty for straying too far from your supervisor is nullified from this moment forward. Finally, as I mentioned during the initial briefing, please keep in mind that the moment you cross the finish line, your token count will be permanently locked in. You will absolutely not be able to transfer tokens after that point, so please plan accordingly.”

With that, Urushihara pulled out four cell phones.

“I will now distribute one of these specialized phones to each class representative. Checking the GPS will help you navigate to the goal. Furthermore, these devices function as walkie-talkies. By linking them to your smartwatch and paying a one-token fee, you can contact the phones of other groups or reveal their locations. Feel free to use these features as needed.”

It seemed the communication and tracking functions we’d had access to since the start of the exam were fully integrated into these phones.

“From here on, I will not be able to accompany you. Therefore, any penalties related to my presence will be invalidated,” Urushihara concluded. “Please proceed toward the goal at your own pace. I wish you all the best of luck.”

Basically, it was up to each group to decide whether to run or walk.

The phones were not merely there to keep us from losing sight of the goal, or to prevent members from becoming separated. They were probably also meant to grant us a grace period to transfer tokens as needed before reaching the goal, thereby expanding the range of our strategies.

For the most part, events were unfolding exactly as I'd anticipated. There was no need to alter my plan.

“What's our move, Ayanokōji?” Yoshida asked. “We could head for the goal separately, but having a majority of the group arrive is the absolute minimum requirement. If we fall out of step and get separated, it could create a massive headache later on. We should definitely move together as one.”

“I agree,” I replied. “Does anyone have any objections?”

Figuring that none of the Class D students would raise an issue, I turned my attention to the remaining Class A.

“I'm on board too,” their representative, Shinohara, answered without hesitation. It was the brightest smile she had shown in days. “In the end, we all need to cross the finish line together.”

Part 2

It was just past 5:30 p.m. Group 2 had already set out, determined to be the first to reach the goal.

Given that all the groups had started at roughly the same distance, it was highly unlikely that anyone had crossed the finish line yet.

Hirata marched at a brisk, unrelenting pace, his expression growing grimmer by the minute. The exact same could be said for Ryūen. However, their minds were occupied by vastly different concerns.

Hirata was solely focused on the physical safety of the group and the stability of his class. Ryūen, on the other hand, was entirely consumed by the exam's impending results and the massive shift in class rankings it would trigger.

So far, Ryūen had amassed a total of 110 front-side tokens. He was undoubtedly the top earner in his group, securing what could easily be called a solid result. Reaching the goal would add another three tokens to his count, and if their group finished in first place, they would retain 100% of their tokens through the final multiplier.

It was by no means a bad position. Even so, by his own rough calculations, he had missed out on at least twenty tokens along the way. Knowing Ayanokōji, there was a very high probability that he had secured far more tokens than Ryūen had managed.

Even assuming Ayanokōji only had 130, Ryūen would need a 20% multiplier advantage to beat him. That meant if Group 2 defended first place with their lives, Ayanokōji's group would still need to place fifth or lower.

That was the absolute minimum baseline required to keep any hope of victory alive. It would be easy enough to contact Katsuragi and order him to stall outside the goal area. But since a group's ranking was locked in the moment a simple majority finished, the conditions would still be met even if Katsuragi and all the Class B students in that group resisted. All the sabotage would accomplish was leaving the resisters with a severe penalty for failing to finish.

If Ayanokōji coasted safely to the finish line as things stood, the Class Point gap between them would shrink by 100. And if, by some stroke of luck, his group also took first place? The gap would widen by 200. It would be an undeniable, crushing defeat.

How could he proactively sabotage Ayanokōji and snatch that victory away?

“...Guess I’ve got no choice,” Ryūen muttered.

You had to be willing to let the enemy cut your flesh if you wanted to sever their bones. Without that kind of ruthless resolve, he would never be able to drag Ayanokōji down into the dirt and deal him his first real loss. He couldn't grasp victory without discarding his hesitation and taking a massive risk.

Ever since he had deciphered the hidden mechanics of this special exam, a certain strategy had been smoldering in the back of Ryūen's mind.

Just as he was about to put that plan into action, Hirata made a move.

“Ryūen-kun, do you mind if I confirm something with you?”

Despite their need to hurry, Hirata stopped in his tracks, forcibly dragging Ryūen into a conversation.

“What is it?” Ryūen asked.

“Having come this far, there's no way you haven't realized anything, right?”

Hirata's words were heavy with implication. His gaze bore into Ryūen, sharp and analytical, as if trying to peer straight through into his thoughts.

“No idea what you're talkin' about,” Ryūen replied casually. Then, finding the situation unintentionally amusing, he let out a dark chuckle. “What exactly are you aimin' for, Hirata? Let's hear it.”

“We’ve taken this exam seriously and earned as many tokens as we possibly could,” Hirata began. “And right now, we’re using a single ‘indicator’ to buy ourselves a fleeting sense of safety. But even so, I know there are students here who are still feeling anxious. So, before we go any further, I want anyone who is worried to come forward, regardless of what class you're in. If you check your token count and feel there's even a slight chance you might end up in last place, tell me. I will support you as much as I possibly can.”

He addressed the entire group, his tone implying that even Ryūen was no exception to the offer.



“I thought I had your personality figured out to some extent,” Ryūen scoffed. “But it seems you're an even bigger softhearted idiot than I imagined. Or do you have some ulterior motive?”

“You think I have some ulterior motive?” Hirata's eyes remained perfectly calm, completely unreadable as they locked onto Ryūen. “After spending this entire exam in the same group, I think you already know the answer to that, Ryūen-kun.”

“Hah. Well, do whatever the hell you want,” Ryūen shot back. “As long as the group's total token count doesn't drop, it ain't got a damn thing to do with me.”

Following Hirata's declaration, two students cautiously stepped forward. After confirming their standings, Hirata transferred a few of his own tokens over to them to ensure their safety.

“Alright, we can't afford to fall behind any further,” Hirata announced, turning back toward the trail. “We're almost there. Let's do our best.”

As Hirata resumed his brisk pace, Ryūen followed close behind. But inside his head, the gears of his strategy never stopped turning.

“Ain't no way I'm letting this special exam end just like this,” Ryūen muttered.

“...What do you mean by that?” Hirata asked.

“The token-gathering tasks in this exam were pretty much tailor-made for the highly capable,” Ryūen explained. “A guy with high academic ability could scrape together close to a hundred tokens just off that alone. Throw in being quick on your feet and having good intuition, and you could stack up even more.”

At Ryūen's gesture, Kaneda immediately stepped up beside him.

“Indeed. Unlike the absurd survival test on the uninhabited island, the contents this time constituted a proper academic exam,” Kaneda noted.

“Which begs the question...Just how many tokens do you think that bastard Ayanokōji managed to gather?”

Ryūen turned his gaze to Hirata, former classmate of the subject in question.

“A proportionate amount, I'd imagine,” Hirata replied calmly. “Knowing him, it wouldn't surprise me if he's already exceeded one hundred and thirty, or even one hundred and forty.”

“I share that assessment, Hirata-shi,” Kaneda agreed. “That is precisely why it is paramount we force his reward multiplier down, even if only by a fraction. It is the very reason we are currently rushing to the goal.”

“But even if we knock his multiplier down a peg, it won't mean jack shit if that bastard’s holding enough tokens to blow right past it anyway,” Ryūen shot back.

Ever since the rules of this special exam had been announced, a singular thought had been swirling in the back of Ryūen's mind.

A massive gamble to prevent Ayanokōji from winning.

“There's someone I need to contact right now,” Ryūen declared, his voice rough.

Recalling his decision to show no mercy, he made Kaneda use a token and grasped the cell phone in his hand.

A call to Shiina. After waiting for about 7 rings, the line connected, and Ryūen called out to her.

“Is something the matter, Ryūen-kun?” Shiina's voice crackled through the radio.

Ryūen had fully intended to cut straight to the chase, but for a split second, the words caught in his throat.

“No——”

He was a man entirely accustomed to being called atrocious, a tyrant who reveled in his own cruelty. So why, at the very last second, was he hesitating?

But that tiny gap of silence was more than enough for Shiina to understand exactly why he was calling.

“You're thinking... that if things stay as they are, we will lose, at least in terms of individual token counts. Am I right?”

"According to Katsuragi's report, Ayanokōji's done pretty damn well for himself," Ryūen admitted.

“I see...” she murmured softly. “What should I do? Please, give me your orders.”

“...Right. I'll relay the instructions now.”

As Ryūen coldly outlined the plan, Kaneda, who had been quietly eavesdropping beside him, rapidly turned pale.

And finally, when he was finished, Shiina voiced a single wish.

“Even if I end up being expelled over this... please do not use your Private Points to save me.”

Ryūen had been hoarding Private Points for a long time, desperately saving them up to bring his plan closer to reality. If he coughed them up now, he could invalidate her expulsion. But doing so would cause his entire overarching strategy to collapse. If the opponent knew that saving her using Private Points was the premise, even if he employed similar methods in the future, a reliable effect could not be obtained. It was precisely because he would truly cut her off that it became a meaningful strategy.

“Obviously,” Ryūen replied.

“I'm relieved to hear that. Well then...”

With those soft words, the call abruptly cut off. Ryūen lowered the phone and cast a sideways glance at Kaneda, whose lips were trembling.

Part 3

It was 5:40 p.m. Our group had made good time, advancing just far enough to slip out of Area G11.

Up to this point, our march had gone smoothly, with no one sustaining any major injuries. However, it was also around this time that the creeping anxiety began to take a visible toll on the students.

“Damn it, I wonder how we're holding up right now,” Sonoda muttered restlessly from the middle of the pack. “I can't help but worry about where all the other groups are.”

We *could* use our tokens to verify the positions of the other groups. But spending a token only revealed the location of a single person. To pinpoint the whereabouts of all nine groups currently racing toward the goal, we would need to burn through a minimum of nine tokens.

We had the authority and the means to check, but we simply couldn't afford to pull the trigger. It was like having a terrible itch, scratching it to suppress the urge was easy, but if you wanted the wound to truly heal, you had to endure the agonizing urge to touch it.

As the students continued their march through this frustrating stretch of time, the Class C cell phone in my pocket began to vibrate.

I pulled it out. The screen simply displayed the name ‘Ayanokōji Kiyotaka’, meaning this call was directed specifically at me. Because it didn't show a caller ID, I wouldn't know exactly who was on the other end until I picked it up, but I already had an idea who it could be.

Telling Yoshida and the others to go on ahead, I let myself fall to the very back of the group. Ike and Shinohara were bringing up the rear, walking side-by-side. I gave them a brief gesture with the phone to signal I was taking a call, prompting them to pass me by.

“Looks like you raked it in on those tasks,” Ryūen's voice crackled through the earpiece the instant the line connected. “I already got Katsuragi's report on you.”

“Just decently well.” I replied. “Did you go out of your way to confirm something like that right before the goal?”

“How many tokens did you gather?” Ryūen asked.

“That's quite a straightforward question, but unfortunately, I can't tell you.”

“130? 140? I might not know the exact number, but I can easily guess you earned more than me.”

He knew I had no intention of answering, yet he pressed on anyway.

“If I had to list my one real advantage here, it's just that the goal is right before our eyes.”

Whether he was telling the truth or bluffing, there was only one logical response I could give him.

“Then I recommend you hurry up and reach the goal.”

“Yeah, well, I figured I wouldn't be breakin' a sweat if I could win just on the multiplier alone,” Ryūen said. “You've probably got all the rules memorized anyway, so I'll put it simply. Group 4 is currently in Area H10. And I just ordered one of my classmates in that group to march straight toward K14, completely in the opposite direction of the goal. You understand what that means, right?”

Group 4. One of the groups I hadn't encountered even once during this Special Exam.

And it was the group that Shiina Hiyori from Ryūen's class belonged to.

“And?” I asked.

“Hah, ‘and’ you say.” Ryūen scoffed. “If things go south, Shiina's gonna get expelled.”

I quickly ran the numbers in my head. Assuming it took Hiyori an hour to hike out to Area K14, it would take her at least an hour and a half to double back to the goal at F13. Given her walking speed, it was a mathematical certainty: she absolutely would not make it back in time.

“That doesn't sound like a bad thing to me,” I replied. “But what's the purpose of sending Hiyori off on a solo counter-march? The issue concerning Class B is your problem, not mine.”

“I wonder if you actually mean that, or if you're just putting on a tough front.”

Ryūen, dropping his voice to a low tone, continued further.

“I had her leave just one token on hand and entrust all the rest to her team mates. Then I told her to just wait on standby at K14 until the Special Exam ends——”

“Did you want to choose the student to be expelled yourself?” I interrupted. “If you didn't need the groundwork I laid for you, I would've appreciated being told.”

“To you, Shiina is a person with value,” he replied.

“Using a friend as a decoy is certainly an interesting strategic move,” I conceded, “but since we're in different classes, its effectiveness is incredibly thin. We are friends, nothing more, nothing less. You're calling me under the assumption that I'll abandon my position to go save her. If your expectations are off, this is nothing more than an act of self-destruction.”

Whether Hiyori reached the goal or got expelled had absolutely no bearing on the outcome of this exam. However, the price of losing an excellent student would have a massive negative impact on Class B in the long run.

“You aren't that foolish,” I continued. “Which means there's a very real possibility you're just feeding me a fabricated story.”

Ryūen's lie, concocted with the thought that I, worried about Hiyori's current location, would consume tokens to verify the truth at least a few times from here on out. His aim was to shave off my tokens, even if only slightly.

But ultimately, avoiding that was also easy. I just had to ask Yoshida, Sanada, and the others to consume theirs instead.

“Even if everything you just said is true,” I added, “losing Hiyori is a massive blow to Class B. You'd bail her out even if it cost you twenty million Private Points.”

“Shiina said the exact same thing. That's why she told me absolutely not to save her with points.”

“If you earnestly executed this strategy, then that is the only correct answer. Bait only works when it actually functions as bait. Either way, though, both you and Hiyori made the same miscalculation.”

Staring quietly ahead, I kept my pace steady toward the goal.

“I have acquired as many tokens as possible. Assuming I secure a decent overall rank, there's a very high probability I'll earn a special prize for my individual results. And since we've temporarily dropped down to Class D, earning Class Points here is an absolute must. By any reasonable measure, I am not going to save Hiyori.”

Without waiting for a response, I severed the connection.

Picking up my pace, I quickly caught back up with Yoshida and the rest of the group.

“Who was that on the phone?” Yoshida asked.

“Just a final obstruction from another class,” I replied. “A desperate, futile struggle.”

“Obstruction? ...Is everything okay?”

“Don't worry about it. More importantly, let's pick up the pace and aim for the goal. Our group's ranking is far more crucial right now.”

I hadn't expected any response to the arrow I'd set in motion, let alone an attempt to catch me off guard, but..

“You've played a bold hand, Ryūen.” I muttered softly.

Even knowing there was a very real chance it would amount to nothing, he had gone through with it anyway.

Part 4

Right after the communication with Ayanokōji ended, Kaneda, unable to suppress the emotions he had been enduring, pressed in on Ryūen.

“What exactly are your intentions here... Ryūen-shi...!”

“Hah? What's there to wonder about? It's exactly like you heard,” Ryūen replied callously. “I feel bad for Shiina, but I had her play the bait to lure Ayanokōji out. If that bastard doesn't bite, I'll just have her get expelled right here.”

“T-That's completely absurd! Shiina-shi is an incredibly important student to our class! For you to do something like this...!”

“Ain't it just that you're lettin' your own damn feelings get in the way 'cause you don't want her expelled?”

Like a frog caught in the glare of a snake, Kaneda stiffened, momentarily paralyzed by fear.

However, he immediately shattered that invisible curse through sheer force of will and argued right back.

“No, you are entirely mistaken...! Even *you* should understand that much, Ryūen-shi! It's clearly a foolish plan... No, to call it foolish is far too generous. It's nothing short of barbarism!”

Behind the lenses of his glasses, Kaneda's eyes were blazing with an unprecedented, unconscious intensity.

“I think it's best if you calm down and cool your head, Kaneda-kun,” Hirata interjected softly, trying to defuse the situation.

Having been granted permission to listen to Ryūen's entire conversation, he had heard everything from start to finish.

“I *am* calm,” Kaneda snapped back. “It is precisely because I am calm that I am saying this!”

“It's real simple,” Ryūen said, his voice dropping low. “Just shut your mouth and obey what I decided.”

"I cannot obey... Please lend me the phone. I will contact Shiina-shi and tell her it's unnecessary."

“If you absolutely cannot bring yourself to obey me, then you’ll just have to try making me yield by force,” Ryūen sneered, lazily looking away.

“Tch!”

Utterly infuriated by the blatant disrespect, Kaneda impulsively shot out his right arm, and grabbed Ryūen by his collar.

“You're shaking, Kaneda,” Ryūen mocked softly. “You actually got it in you to hit me?”

“I-if raw force is the only language you'll listen to….even then… I’m prepared to—!”

“Stop it!” Hirata stepped in before the situation could escalate any further, forcefully prying Kaneda's grip off of Ryūen's uniform. “Doing this won't solve anything.”

Kaneda stumbled back, his fingers trembling. “...Excuse me. This is the first time I've ever felt quite like this... But things have certainly become clear. So, this is the emotion known as anger... Ryūen-shi, I don't care what logic you devise, I will absolutely never accept this.”

“It's true that as a strategy, there’s nothing to be praised,” Hirata said, stepping between the two. “I also think you should contact Shiina-san again even now. But let me ask you one thing. Can you declare that this is the absolute best plan to prevent Ayanokōji-kun from winning? I am genuinely curious.”

“I gave the order 'cause that's what I decided,” Ryūen growled, glaring at Hirata. “I ain't got no obligation to sit here and spell it out for you.”

Kaneda had been terrified by that very same glare, but Hirata received it head-on, not shrinking back in the slightest.

"...I see," Hirata murmured. "You truly believe that Shiina-san is someone Ayanokōji-kun would save even at the cost of victory."

Because he was missing context, there were parts of this conflict Hirata didn't fully understand. At the same time, there were parts he found easy enough to accept. It was certainly true that Ayanokōji treated Shiina differently from everyone else. However, he had never imagined her as an existence Ayanokōji would voluntarily abandon victory for, someone he would go so far as to save even at the risk of his own expulsion.

"Seems you got your own thoughts about Ayanokōji too," Ryūen sneered at Hirata. "Well, can't really blame ya."

"I would like to see it," Hirata murmured, his eyes narrowed slightly. "I'd like to see how Ayanokōji-kun actually answers your question."

"Hirata-shi, you are ultimately just a bystander," Kaneda snapped, turning to Hirata. "You can say it so lightly because you aren't a student in our class! And the exact same goes for Ayanokōji-shi! He is in a position where he *must* continue to produce results in order to carry his class to victory. I absolutely refuse to believe he would willingly throw himself into massive risk just to go save Shiina-shi!"

"You can't believe it?" Ryūen taunted. "Or is it just that you don't *wanna* believe it?"

"T-That's not...!"

A vivid memory flashed through Kaneda's mind: an exchange he had witnessed between Ayanokōji and Shiina in the library. The way her expression softened when she spoke to him, a look that seemed identical to her usual smile, yet felt entirely, undeniably special, reserved for Ayanokōji alone.

The realization hit Kaneda like a physical blow. Delight at the sheer purity of her unmasked face clashed instantly with searing, defensive rage. A fierce cocktail of conflicting emotions coursed violently through Kaneda's veins.

"If you wanna stop it that badly, then go pick her up yourself right now," Ryūen provoked him. "But with those slow legs of yours, you'll never make it in time."

"Then I will stop it even if I have to consume my Protection Point. Right now, I will drop my tokens to 0——"

"That's useless, Kaneda-kun," Hirata interrupted gently. "Even if you transfer all your tokens and drop to zero, the penalty you incur for deliberate insolvency is entirely different from finishing in last place. The fact that you didn't even think of that is proof you aren't thinking clearly."

If Kaneda dropped his tokens to zero right now, he would simply be disqualified and forced to wait out the rest of the exam on the ship. It wouldn't offer Shiina any salvation whatsoever.

"Furthermore, even if you ended the exam with exactly one token to tie with Shiina-san, your overall OAA rating is higher," Hirata continued. "The tiebreaker would still dictate that Shiina-san is the one who gets expelled."

In truth, Hirata didn't actually remember Shiina and Kaneda's exact OAA scores. However, he had deduced that if Kaneda could become a substitute using that method, Ryūen would've never let him listen in on the phone call to begin with.

"Guh...!" Kaneda gritted his teeth.

Desperately formulating a counter-plan, he briefly considered lowering Group 2's overall rank to decrease the final token multiplier. However, he immediately realized that if Hiyori only possessed a single token, she wouldn't be affected by the multiplier math anyway. There was nothing the current Kaneda could do to shield her from expulsion.

“The only reliable way to save her is to physically reach Shiina-san before the exam ends and transfer your tokens directly to her,” Hirata explained. “Ryūen-kun waited until this exact moment to bring it up because he knew that.”

“If Ayanokōji goes to save Shiina, he ain't makin' it back to the goal in time, putting his final multiplier at 70%,” Ryūen explained. “And if he transfers his own tokens to her to save her, it'll also drain Group 3's total stash. That’s two birds with one stone.”

The only variable Ryūen couldn't control was whether he could force Ayanokōji to spend his visible ‘front-side’ tokens. There was always a chance Ayanokōji's groupmates had entrusted him with hidden, unrecorded tokens to act as a secret safety net.

“Since when…” Kaneda's voice trembled. “Since when did you decide to use Shiina-shi like this?”

“I ain't answering that.”

This was undeniably a major gamble for Ryūen as well. He may have set it all in motion, but the power to decide the outcome now rested with Ayanokōji.

Either Shiina would be expelled, or Ayanokōji would be defeated. There was no third possibility.

“If, by any chance, Shiina-shi actually ends up getting expelled…” Kaneda spat, his voice laced with venom. “I will never forgive you.”

“Before you start barkin' about forgiveness, first fulfill your own damn responsibility as a member of this group,” Ryūen ordered coldly. “Use those legs to reach the goal as fast as possible to make the class win.”

Ryūen was telling him the hard truth: the only thing Kaneda could do right now was reach the goal. That was it.

“And one more thing— if you wanna punch me, next time grab my collar with your left hand.”

Punching with the dominant arm is what's important, Ryūen declared with a faint smirk playing across his lips.

Chapter 8: A Glimpse of Thought

❖

At 6:07 p.m., with the special exam nearing its end, the dense trees finally began to thin.

Little by little, the world ahead opened up between the trunks and leaves. The oppressive green that had surrounded us for days loosened, allowing faint traces of space and evening light to seep through.

Everyone was exhausted.

It had reached the point where the simple act of walking almost felt like something that stole strength from the body. Breaths came shallow. Sweat had long since dried. In its place, only the rough sensation of salt remained, clinging to skin and clothes alike.

Even so, no one stopped.

After coming this far, the choice to stand still had disappeared from everyone's mind.

We needed to reach the goal as a group as quickly as possible, and preserve our high multiplier. That would lead to a larger reward, and just as importantly, it would help us avoid the penalties waiting for anyone who failed.

One step at a time, the distance continued to shrink.

And then—

The moment finally arrived.

"Whoa, hold up, everyone," Yoshida, who had been walking at the front, halted abruptly as his smartwatch caught the signal. "Looks like this is the goal area."

He stepped back almost immediately, retreating several paces until he was outside the boundary again.

“We're doing a final check of everyone's tokens... right?” he asked.

“Yeah,” I said. “We should confirm everything one last time, just to be safe.”

Once thirty seconds passed inside the goal area, arrival would be confirmed. At that moment, everyone’s tokens would be finalised, and transfers would no longer be possible.

However badly we wanted to finish, this was the one part that had to be handled with care.

Our final scores would decide more than the outcome of the exam. They were an essential step toward preventing expulsion and ensuring that everyone could move on to what came next.

“A final check is great and all, but we don't even know how many we need to be safe,” Sonoda grumbled.

That was where he was mistaken.

Even within this group, more than half the students already had enough information to feel a certain degree of confidence.

To make sure everyone was on the same page, I turned around, swept my gaze over the group, and spoke up.

“The absolute minimum number of tokens we need to secure before crossing is 51. As long as you have that many, you will absolutely not be expelled.”

None of the students from Classes C and D showed a hint of surprise at my assertion. On the other hand, several students, Sonoda included, looked completely bewildered.

“How can you be so sure? Don't just make stuff up, Ayanokōji,” Ike snapped, the first to bite.

“Yeah, where did fifty-one even come from?” Shinohara chimed in immediately.

Yet, beneath their protests, there was a distinct ring of theatricality. Their confusion was an act, rather than genuine bewilderment.

Kushida and Mii-chan, however, were a different story. Unable to follow the logic behind my claim, they stared at me with genuine skepticism.

“No, the number isn't random,” I replied. “The reason I said 51 tokens just now is because it’s been confirmed that the person at the bottom of the group has exactly 50 tokens.”

As I spoke, the eyes of Ike and the rest of the group snapped toward one person: Ibuki Mio.

“...How do you know that? You could be wrong,” she retorted, defensively covering her smartwatch, even though her total wasn't actually displayed on the screen.

“It’s not a particularly difficult calculation,” I said. “For the past four days and three nights, we've moved as a single unit, tackling the exact same tasks. Our initial token counts were also directly linked to our survival time in the previous exam. If you just do some basic addition and subtraction, even an elementary schooler could figure out the total.”

“...But...” Ibuki began, her voice catching on the obvious objection. “what about the tokens Katsuragi gave me? There's no way you'd know exactly how many—”

Halfway through her rebuttal, it finally clicked. Even someone as dense as Ibuki realized why I could state her total with such absolute certainty. The entire thing had been orchestrated from early on.

“You...” Her glare slid away from me and fixed itself on Katsuragi. “Don’t tell me...”

Now that there was no longer any need for secrecy, Katsuragi’s stoic expression softened by a fraction.

“That's right,” he said. “I shared the exact number of tokens I transferred to you with Ayanokōji.”

As Katsuragi laid bare his betrayal, I picked up where he left off, keeping my attention on Ibuki. “In a special exam where someone is guaranteed to be expelled, the tension never truly lets up. But if a losing role is decided in advance, and that information is shared, the others can be freed from the mental pressure of uncertainty—”

Cutting me off, Shinohara stepped forward eagerly, as if she had been waiting for this exact moment.

“It’s pretty pathetic, honestly,” she said. “You were just being used by Ayanokōji-kun from the very beginning, Ibuki-san.”

“...Since when?” Ibuki demanded. “Since when did you decide to cut me off?”

“Probably from the very beginning, don't you think?” Shinohara mocked. “Or maybe right when Katsuragi-kun became the representative. The only reason you didn't get an equal share of tokens is because Ayanokōji-kun already had him in his pocket. Isn't that right?”

“You're surprisingly well-informed, Shinohara,” I noted. “I don't recall ever mentioning my alliance with Katsuragi to you.”

No one else present had realized we were working together. Reveling in the fact that she was the only one who supposedly grasped the situation, Shinohara narrowed her eyes with smug satisfaction.

“You tried your best to keep it a secret, of course.” she said, looking utterly delighted with herself as if she had unraveled the entire plot through her own deductive skills.

“I suppose there's no point in hiding the details anymore,” I said.

Once the clock ran out, the final results would be announced. If Ibuki were expelled without ever learning how the trick was pulled off, she probably wouldn't be able to accept her defeat in peace.

“Katsuragi and I discussed who should serve as the benchmark,” I continued. “In other words, who would be assigned the losing role. In the end, we chose Ibuki. Then, during the lunch break on this final day, I contacted each class by radio and told them the number of tokens they needed to secure. The only people kept in the dark were the four Class A students in Group 3, and the Class B students, with the exception of Katsuragi.”

“...Why didn't you tell us?” Kushida asked, her voice laced with a mixture of anxiety and frustration.

“It's not like all of you are skilled actors,” I explained. “If everyone knew the truth, there would inevitably be an unnatural shift in the group's dynamic. Limiting the informed members to about half ensured that we wouldn't accidentally tip Ibuki off. Besides, last night was the first time this strategy was shared with the rest of the school year.”

Here, I began to explain, recalling the events that led up to the moment I released that arrow, and the circumstances in which I had let it fly.

Part 1

The sequence of events actually began on the night of the third day, shortly after Nishikawa's second transmission came through the radio.

I had requested a connection to Group 8, which Ichinose belonged to.

Sakagami-sensei, acting as their designated supervisor, answered first before promptly handing the receiver over to her.

"Sorry for the wait, Ayanokōji-kun. Did you need something?" Ichinose's voice crackled through the radio, calm but laced with a faint, unmistakable hint of joy.

"The third day will be over soon," I said. "I've decided how this exam should be brought to a conclusion, and where the point of compromise should be. Is Horikita nearby? If you can call her over right away, I want you to let her hear what I'm about to say."

By the rules, radio communications were strictly one-on-one. Switching speakers midway through a call or engaging in a two-way conversation with a third party was strictly prohibited. However, removing the earpiece so that the audio broadcasted to the immediate surroundings wasn't a violation.

"Understood. Just a second," Ichinose readily agreed. Faintly, I heard her call out, "Horikita-san, could you come over here for a moment?"

I waited in silence.

"...Understood, I'll listen in from nearby," Horikita's voice drifted through the channel, tinged with obvious bewilderment. Ichinose was still officially the one on the call, but the mic picked up her surroundings clearly enough.

"I called her over," Ichinose confirmed. "She's listening."

“I'll keep this brief,” I said. “This special exam is designed so that at least one person will inevitably be expelled. While it's technically possible to void the penalty by cashing in a Protection Point or a massive sum of Private Points, the current third-years simply don't have that kind of capital to spare.”

“That's true,” Ichinose murmured. “We've been fighting while constantly worrying about that, too.”

“The most straightforward countermeasure is to meticulously adjust everyone's tokens, ensuring no one from Class A or Class D falls to the bottom of the rankings. But the fatal flaw in that strategy is the lack of a definitive safety line.”

“Because there's always the looming risk of a multi-way tie for last place,” she finished, catching on.

“Exactly,” I said. “So, to completely eliminate that risk, I've decided to pre-designate one student to be the loser.”

“A designated loser...?” Horikita murmured while listening to the radio beside her.

What would she think when she heard those words?

It would not have surprised me if unease stirred within her, her pulse quickening ever so slightly.

“If we lock in the token count and multiplier of the student at the very bottom with one hundred percent certainty,” I explained, “then every other student can guarantee their survival by simply exceeding that score by a single token.”

Upon hearing this proposal, the first thing that would pop into Horikita's mind would probably be the faces of the four Class A students, starting with Kushida.

But at the same time, wouldn’t another kind of unease have risen to the surface?

If he really intended to expel someone from Class A, why would he go out of his way to make sure I heard it?

“Who is it that you're planning to expel, Ayanokōji-kun?” Ichinose asked.

Her voice was perfectly calm; a composed tone I likely never would have heard from her in the past. It perfectly aligned with her new, merciless stance when it came to protecting her own classmates.

“Ibuki,” I answered. “From Class B, she belongs to my Group 3.”

“Ibuki-san…” Ichinose repeated softly. “I see.”

Even if she understood the reasoning, Ichinose was not the sort of person who could rejoice at anyone’s name being chosen. If anything, she likely felt pity and sympathy for Ibuki, who was being steered toward the fate of expulsion.

And what about Horikita? The moment she heard that name, had a wave of relief washed over her, knowing the victim wasn't from her own class? Or were indescribably complex emotions welling up inside her?

Perhaps she was desperately suppressing the urge to ask why it had to be Ibuki.

And then there was Sakagami-sensei, Ibuki's homeroom teacher, who was likely listening to the conversation over the radio.

Naturally, it had to be agonizing to sit there and listen to a plot to expel one of his own students, but even so, homeroom teachers are not permitted to interfere in the special exams.

“I won't ask you why you chose Ibuki-san,” Ichinose said. “If you've decided on her, Ayanokōji-kun, then you must have already judged it to be the absolute best option.”

“Yeah. At this point, my decision is final. If we leave things to chance and an unspecified student gets expelled, we risk losing an excellent student. You could just brush that off as the harsh nature of a special exam, but if the outcome can be controlled, I prefer to eliminate any unforeseen variables.” I continued without changing my tone. “Moving on, I'm going to share the exact number of tokens Ibuki holds with every group right before we cross the finish line. To guarantee everyone's safety, we'll calculate her multiplier at a baseline of 100%. In other words, as long as a student holds even one more token than Ibuki, they are mathematically immune to expulsion.”

“So that's why you wanted Horikita-san to hear this,” Ichinose noted. “But how are you going to explain this to Class B?”

“No explanation is necessary. As long as our three classes share the information, the problem solves itself.”

I briefly clarified that there was no risk involved even if a Class B student scored lower than Ibuki, then pressed on.

“Horikita is fairly close to Ibuki. If she decides to move against me and try to stop this expulsion after hearing this, she's free to try. But if I sense even the slightest hint of interference, I will instantly swap the target, and someone from Class A will be expelled instead. Whether I choose an easy mark like Ike or Shinohara, or someone whose loss would deal a massive blow to the class like Kushida or Mii-chan... that will be for me to decide.”

It was a forceful warning—and a threat—aimed at Horikita, whose expression was likely beginning to stiffen.

“Right now, Ibuki is holding exactly 36 tokens,” I added. “If that number fluctuates tomorrow, I'll contact you again. Her current count is important, but all that truly matters is exactly how many she has the moment we reach the goal area.”

“Yes, understood,” Ichinose answered. “I'll start making preparations to share the information on my end as well.”

After confirming her response, I cut the transmission.

Part 2

“Sakagami-sensei,” Horikita said suddenly. “Please connect me to Ayanokōji-kun immediately.”

“I do not mind doing so, but——”

“Wait, Horikita-san,” Ichinose interjected. “What exactly do you plan to say to Ayanokōji-kun?”

“I cannot simply nod and comply when he resorts to such unilateral threats.”

“I understand how you feel,” Ichinose said gently. “But our primary agreement was to ensure no one from our own classes gets expelled, wasn't it? I was just as surprised by Ayanokōji-kun’s proposal, but strictly in terms of our overall strategy, it doesn't pose a problem.”

“That’s...” Horikita faltered for a moment. “I understand that. But intentionally choosing one specific person to be expelled is...”

“As long as Ayanokōji-kun operates within the boundaries set by the rules, it isn't a violation,” Ichinose said, turning slightly toward the supervisor. “Isn't that right, Sakagami-sensei?”

“Indeed,” Sakagami replied. “It leaves me with rather complicated feelings as well, but what he is attempting does not violate any rules. He will likely continue to maneuver quite cleverly from here on out. If you reject his proposal, he will simply pivot and select his victim from Class A. If you find that unacceptable... What then? Will you choose a different student in his stead and strike back? Doing so would invite a rather glaring contradiction. After all, if you intentionally manipulate the scores so that someone else falls below Ibuki-san, you would be employing the exact same methods as Ayanokōji-kun.”

If Horikita refused to intentionally target someone, her only option was to leave the outcome to chance. Yet, if she clung to randomness, Ayanokōji would still hold the reins, leaving the probability of Ibuki's expulsion incredibly high.

“If you do not wish to dirty your own hands, will you inform Ryūen-kun of this?” Sakagami pressed. “If he learns that one of his classmates is being targeted, he might take action in your stead. Though, speaking frankly as the homeroom teacher of Class B, that would be the most preferable outcome for me.”

Hearing Sakagami speak with such blunt honesty, bordering on a breach of his strict neutrality as an examiner, Horikita bit her lip and swallowed her protests.

“Wanting to protect your friend isn't a bad thing,” Ichinose said softly. “But I think you need to take a step back and carefully assess the situation first. Figure out what you can do, and what Ibuki-san can do for herself. If you need it, I'll help you too.”

“Thank you,” Horikita replied, before walking away from the spot alone.

“I anticipated he would do something,” she murmured. “but Ayanokōji-kun has finally made his move... Must I simply chalk this up to the misfortune of them being placed in the same group? No. Fundamentally, Ibuki-san belongs to a rival class that we are meant to defeat. If I just stand back and let his strategy play out, our class will reap all the benefits without suffering a single drawback...”

Ibuki was not, by any generous standard, an honor student.

But her physical ability made her a troublesome existence. She was also on relatively close terms with Ryūen, Ishizaki, and Albert. If a student like her was expelled, it would do more than remove one troublesome opponent. It would slow the momentum of Class B, a class now pressing closer and closer behind them.

On top of that, no one from Class A would be harmed.

From a purely strategic standpoint, there was no disadvantage in letting the matter pass.

“But—”

Horikita knew she had to cast aside her personal feelings and critically examine the dice Ayanokōji had just rolled.

Were the statements she had been made to hear over the radio entirely true?

What if the entire premise of expelling Ibuki was a lie?

What if he was merely using her name as camouflage to conceal his true target?

Through a simple process of elimination, it was highly unlikely he would eliminate a student from Ichinose's class. There was currently no strategic merit in drawing a bow against them. Of course, if Ayanokōji deemed it necessary, he wouldn't hesitate to show them zero mercy— but even so, this was not the moment. Which meant his target had to be someone else... someone other than Ibuki from Ryūen's class.

How exactly is Ayanokōji planning to fight this?

For a fleeting moment, Horikita felt as though she had caught a glimpse of his true endgame.

Part 3

We stood just before the goal.

No one spoke.

Everyone listened in silence as I finished recounting what I had told Ichinose and Horikita. When the explanation came to an end, I turned my eyes toward Ibuki.

“If you had found out earlier that you were one hundred percent guaranteed to be expelled, there's no telling what kind of sabotage you might have pulled to drag this group down,” I continued. “That's why I decided to wait until the bitter end, the final checkpoint right before we cross the goal line, to tell you.”

“Hah...” Ibuki gave a short, dry laugh. “So that’s how it is, huh.”

Her gaze moved past me.

Behind me, Katsuragi stood with his arms folded, his expression firm. Ibuki glared at him.

“I never thought we were buddy-buddy or anything,” she said. “but I didn't expect to be thrown to the wolves by my own ally.”

“This is a necessary sacrifice,” Katsuragi replied stoically. “We cannot afford to make a tactical error and lose someone valuable.”

“Yeah, maybe you're right.” Ibuki’s voice was cold, but strangely calm, as if some part of her had already accepted it. “Even I know I'm just dead weight.”

Then her eyes returned to me.

“But why reveal it here? You could have just said it after reaching the goal, couldn't you?”

“It's no wonder you think that,” I said. “Shall I tell you the reason?”

“No... whatever. It's not like hearing it is going to magically cancel my expulsion anyway.”

Ibuki shifted her gaze toward Sonoda and Morofuji. Though both looked visibly distressed, neither could meet her eyes. They quickly averted their gazes. The heavy atmosphere hanging over the group spoke volumes: If anyone helped Ibuki now, the target could change at any moment.

By dragging everything into the light, I had effectively paralyzed the entire group.

“The only option left to you,” I said, “is to refuse to enter the goal area until the very end, and hold on to the hope that someone might transfer tokens to you. But you shouldn’t expect too much. Even if some unusually generous person wanted to save you, they would have to consider the distortion that would create. In other words, they would risk causing some unexpected ally to be expelled in your place. No one wants to take responsibility for that.”

The major advantage of this setup was that all the responsibility rested squarely on me, the architect of the plan. Because of that, the rest of the group was spared from the crushing weight of guilt.

“Yeah...” Ibuki said. “I know that much.”

Glaring daggers at me, Ibuki stomped her foot against the dirt and marched straight up to me.

“Fine, I'll accept the expulsion. So let me hit you once before I go.”

I had considered various patterns, but at the very end, a very Ibuki-like demand came out.

“Acts of violence carry a severe penalty. I don't know what will happen if you do it.”

“Don't make me laugh. What do I care about penalties if I'm already getting expelled?” She clearly had no interest in my response. Looking fully prepared to pounce, she reached out with her left hand and forcefully grabbed me by the lapels. This was the raw resolve of someone who had completely accepted their expulsion.



“I’m the one who decided to have you expelled, after all,” Ayanokōji said evenly. “I suppose I can grant you at least that much.”

Perhaps not expecting me to agree, Ibuki was slightly taken aback.

“You’ve got some nerve. Fine, then. Don’t expect me to hold back.”

Releasing my tracksuit, Ibuki turned her back and slowly walked away to put some distance between us.

It seems she is serious.

An entirely unscripted development had just arrived.

Is she really going to punch him?

Everyone's skeptical gazes were glued to the two of us.

Enraptured by the spectacle, the rest of the group subtly shuffled their standing positions, a minor detail no one would notice amidst the mounting tension.

“Alright... here I go.”

“Wait a minute. Are you seriously going to punch me?” I asked.

“Did you think I was joking? I am dead serious. You already agreed to it, so prepare yourself.”

“...I see. Then, let's see——”

I dragged out the time by pretending to hesitate just a little.

Finally, I let out a slow breath and gave her a clear, definitive nod.

“I won't counterattack. It will just be you hitting me one-sidedly, Ibuki.”

Ibuki, who had been bottling up her pent-up frustration for a long time, broke into a savage grin.

“For all the crap you've put me through... Die, Ayanokōji!”

She kicked off the dirt and charged toward me.

And then, she unleashed a clenched right straight punch aimed squarely at my cheek without hesitation.

A dull *smack* echoed through the trees as the impact flared across my left cheek.

“Whoa, she actually hit him!” Ike yelped in shock.

Beside him, Shinohara squeezed her eyes shut with a wince.

Around us, surprise spread in a wave.

Then came silence.

“Normally, an act of violence like this would clearly be subject to penalties,” I stated calmly, breaking the silence. “But fortunately, there's no supervisor around to see it, and I have no intention of reporting it. As far as the school is concerned, nothing happened.”

If Ibuki were expelled for a rule violation, the entire plan of dropping her to last place would be rendered meaningless. Because of that, there was no chance Ike, Shinohara, or anyone else would dare dig deeper into the incident.

“Satisfied now?” I asked.

“At least pretend it hurt a little,” she grumbled.

“I'm just enduring it,” I replied.

“...Hmph.”

Perhaps satisfied with finally landing the one hit she had always wanted, Ibuki stepped back.

“All right,” Katsuragi said. “We should probably head for the goal ourselves soon.”

As he prepared to walk away, abandoning his comrade, Ibuki cast him a brief glance.

“In the end,” she said. “you're really not going to give me a single token, huh.”

“That is the policy I decided on,” Katsuragi replied coldly. “You will exit the stage here.”

“Tch.”

Stripped of any backup from her allies and throwing away her last shred of hope, Ibuki finally forced herself to start walking toward the goal.

Seeing Ibuki like that, Shinohara made her move before Kushida could.

Of course she did. From Shinohara’s point of view, there was no way she could let Ibuki reach the goal as things stood.

“Say, is it just my imagination, or does this whole thing feel totally staged?” Shinohara asked, her gaze sweeping coldly over Ibuki, Katsuragi, and finally, me. “Telling Ibuki-san about the plan right before the goal, letting her punch you... aren't you guys just putting on a show to make it look like she's the one getting expelled?”

“W-what do you mean, Satsuki?” Ike stammered.

“Look, I didn't even tell Kanji this, but Horikita-san warned me,” Shinohara explained. “She told me absolutely not to take this story about expelling Ibuki-san at face value. And if you think about it, she's right. We haven't actually confirmed how many tokens Ibuki-san has. There's no concrete proof anywhere that her count is exactly 50, is there?”

As Ibuki tried to head for the goal, Shinohara approached her, stepping ahead as if to cut her off and block her path.

“If I were really in a pinch,” Shinohara continued. “I would fight tooth and nail to be saved. Nobody just gives up and crosses the goal line like that. Which means there's only one logical answer: you're actually holding more tokens, aren't you?”

Fifty tokens was by no means a large amount. Ibuki had performed poorly in the individual tasks, and during the team and group stages, Katsuragi had only transferred her the bare minimum. To any outside observer, she was clearly dead last in the group. But there remained the suspicion that what they could see was not necessarily the whole picture.

“Talk about completely missing the point,” Ibuki scoffed. “Getting that one hit in was all I needed to give up entirely.”

“Maybe,” Shinohara replied. “But we don't know the truth, right? Everything Ayanokōji-kun just said, and this whole narrative about Katsuragi-kun abandoning you— it could all be fabricated.”

Saying that, Shinohara shot a sharp, fleeting glare at Katsuragi.

As long as token transfers were possible until the very moment before reaching the goal, the possibility that Katsuragi had given Ibuki enough to survive was not zero. Nor was Katsuragi the only candidate. Ichinose’s overly kind class might have helped, or perhaps, Ayanokōji himself, might have orchestrated something behind the scenes. Class D, too, had had the opportunity.

“I haven't gotten anything from anyone,” Ibuki stated flatly.

“Hmm,” Shinohara said. “But hey, even so, you don't have to throw in the towel so quickly, do you?”

“Huh?”

“If we said we were going to save you, Ibuki-san,” Shinohara continued. “the situation might change a little.”

“...Save me?” Ibuki asked, perplexed. “I don't get what you mean.”

“Show me your tokens right here, right now.” Shinohara demanded. “If you let me confirm your count with my own eyes, I'll transfer enough to you so you surpass Kushida-san. That way, you won't be in last place anymore, right?”

“W-what are you saying, Shinohara-san!” Mii-chan cried out, the first to react.

Shocked by a proposal that would seemingly throw a classmate under the bus, she unintentionally raised her voice.

However, Kushida remained perfectly calm, soothing the panicked girl with a hushed voice.

“It's okay,” she said. “That probably... isn't Shinohara-san's true intention. It's definitely a bluff just to confirm how many tokens Ibuki-san actually has.”

“B-but...” Mii-chan trailed off.

Although Ibuki had received an unexpected proposal, she immediately arrived at one answer in her head.

“Look, I'm not stupid,” Ibuki said. “You think I'm gonna fall for something that basic? Even if I show you, there's zero guarantee you'll actually hand over any tokens.”

“But it keeps the possibility alive,” Shinohara countered. “Doesn't it?”

If Ibuki refused to show the number, she would receive nothing. If she showed it, there was a chance, however small, that she might receive some tokens.

Shinohara was dangling that harsh yet tantalizing bait.

“You think I received tokens from someone before coming here?” Ibuki asked. “No way.”

“Of course, as long as I was keeping an eye on you, I didn't see you bumping smartwatches with anyone,” Shinohara explained. “But maybe you got them last night. Or this morning. It's not like we could monitor you twenty-four hours a day, Ibuki-san. A transfer takes barely a second, after all. Tell you what, if you show me your screen, I'll even give you five tokens right away.”

She had begun negotiating, trying by any means necessary to draw out Ibuki’s true count.

“So in the end, this is for your own safety,” Ibuki said. “Even if I get five tokens, my result won’t change.”

“Regardless of what my motives are, isn't it better for you to get your hands on some extra tokens?” Shinohara countered. “I don't think you should throw away even a one percent chance of survival. Who knows, maybe *someone* in another group only has 54 tokens, you know.”

“Sorry, but I have no intention of lifting a finger to buy you the safety you're so desperate for,” Ibuki said, moving again, trying to head for the goal.

Shinohara’s voice followed her, sharper now.

“That’s suspicious. So you did receive tokens from someone after all. Was it Katsuragi-kun, or someone else? Or maybe Ayanokōji-kun?” she said dismissively. “Well, whoever it is doesn't really matter. But at this rate, I suppose I can't afford to give Kushida-san the extra tokens. I’d be worried, you see.”

For Shinohara, visually confirming Ibuki's tokens was the best way to purchase peace of mind. But even if she couldn't verify the number, she still held a powerful trump card: the tokens she had been pooling and withholding from Kushida over the past two and a half days.

“Do whatever you want,” Ibuki said. “Kushida has more tokens than me anyway. But——”

Shooting Shinohara a fierce glare, Ibuki abruptly raised her wrist. She punched in her passcode, bringing her total token count up on the display.

“The only thing I can't stand is being thought of as having been helped by Ayanokōji, even for a millimeter.”

Then she forcefully thrust her wrist right in front of Shinohara's face, presenting undeniable proof that no tokens had been secretly transferred to her.

Looking annoyed, Shinohara pushed that arm away and stared at the display once more.

“It really is... fifty.”

Faced with the simple-minded Ibuki's direct action, Shinohara found herself completely bewildered, unable to hide her confusion.

“...You can't swap smartwatches or... how should I put it, display an old token count, right? Like some sort of loophole...”

Shinohara fell deep into thought, desperately grasping at methods that bordered on the impossible. In reality, the smartwatches could not be removed, and even if someone managed to take one off, doing so would obviously trigger a penalty for violating the rules. Furthermore, there was absolutely no function to falsify the display.

If Ibuki entered the goal area just like this, her tokens would be finalized.

“Thank you, Ibuki-san,” Shinohara said brightly. “Well then, a promise is a promise. I'll send you five right away.”

“I don't need them,” Ibuki spat, immediately turning her back to walk away.

But Shinohara quickly darted around her, blocking her path and flashing her smartwatch. She then had Ibuki, who offered no resistance, switch her watch to receive mode. While forcibly stealing tokens was undeniably a penalty, there were likely no rules against forcefully *giving* someone tokens.

“I'm the type to keep my promises, after all,” Shinohara declared.

Just as she forcefully moved to tap their watches together, Kushida suddenly intervened.

“Wait, Shinohara-san. Aren't those part of the tokens you’re supposed to return to me?” Kushida asked. “You promised to properly hand them over before we crossed the goal line... didn't you?”

“But Kushida-san,” Shinohara replied. “your score is already higher than Ibuki-san's, so there's really no need to worry—”

Seeing Shinohara trying to be stingy, Kushida raised her voice, the carefully crafted facade of the perfect classmate beginning to slip.

“You promised to properly hand them over later, didn't you?” Kushida said, her voice rising slightly. “Mii-chan also wants you to hand over all 34 of my tokens you received. If you're going to give five to Ibuki-san, take them out of your own share.”

It was a fierce assertion. Kushida's tone practically demanded to know if Shinohara intended to renege on their agreement. Given that it was a completely legitimate demand for the return of her own tokens, there was absolutely no logical reason for Shinohara to refuse.

“I said I’ll give them from my own share,” Shinohara replied, irritation creeping into her face. “I just want to give Ibuki-san five first. That should be fine, shouldn’t it? She looks like she’s about to enter the goal anyway.”

“...No,” Kushida said, her eyes sharpened. “I absolutely can't accept that. Because— right now, I only have 54 tokens. I showed you my screen earlier during the final check, so you're well aware of that, aren't you, Shinohara-san?”

Anger openly bleeding into her voice, Kushida firmly rejected the excuse. Faced with such fierce pushback, Shinohara averted her eyes in irritation.

The one most surprised by the exchange was Ibuki, who stood nearest to them.

“You have 54?” she asked.

“Yes,” Kushida answered. “Now you understand what the situation is too, right, Ibuki-san?”

“Shinohara...” Ibuki said, shifting her gaze toward Shinohara “Were you actually planning to save me just to get Kushida expelled?"

If Shinohara had successfully transferred those five tokens to Ibuki, Ibuki's total would have hit 55, dropping Kushida squarely into last place.

Was it merely a coincidence of numbers or something Shinohara had calculated in advance?

“Oh, please,” Shinohara said. “I’m not that mean.”

“Really?” Kushida said. “Then I want you to hand over my tokens right now.”

“...Jeez, I said I understand, Kushida-san,” Shinohara replied with a hint of irritation. “I didn't realize you had such a suspicious personality. Fine, hold out your smartwatch.”

Likely judging that she couldn't argue back any more aggressively with the entire group watching, Shinohara began tapping her smartwatch. A moment later, a sharp chime rang out from both of their watches, signaling a successful transfer.

Right after the transfer went through, Shinohara smiled fearlessly at Kushida, whose expression flickered with momentary confusion.

“Alright, I'm heading to the goal now,” Ibuki announced. “Oh, and by the way, I don't need those five tokens you said you were going to give me.”

Had Ibuki deliberately stood there, delaying her own walk to the goal, just to provide the final push Kushida needed to receive tokens from Shinohara?

Regardless, having seen the transfer through, Ibuki turned and tried to head toward the goal once again.

Seeing that, Katsuragi tried to step forward, but I stopped him with a look.

Immediately after that, Kushida shoved Shinohara out of the way, reached out, and grabbed Ibuki's arm to stop her.

Stumbling and nearly falling over from the unexpected shove, Shinohara glared furiously at Kushida.

“Wait, Ibuki-san,” Kushida called out. “Show me the number of tokens you have right now, too.”

“Huh? I literally just showed Shinohara,” Ibuki protested. “Did anyone even come near me since then?”

Not a single soul had approached Ibuki.

It was a situation where it was 100% impossible for her to receive a token transfer.

“Just show me.”

“...Fine.”

Bowing to the inexplicable, heavy pressure radiating from Kushida, Ibuki typed in her passcode once again. She turned her wrist, proving to Kushida that her total was indeed exactly 50.

“Thank you,” Kushida said. “I just couldn't feel relieved without confirming it with my own eyes. Because——” She paused for one breath. Then turning back to Shinohara with a beaming smile, she continued, “Because I can't trust an *ugly bitch* like you, Shinohara-san, not even for a millimeter, now can I?”

For a split second, everyone present wondered if they had misheard. *Did Kushida just say what they thought she said?*

Even Ibuki was entirely taken aback, her mouth hanging open in a wide, dumbfounded gape.

“W-wait a minute!” Shinohara shouted. “What the hell did you just say to me!? Hey!”

“Couldn't you hear me?” Kushida asked, still smiling. “I called you an ugly bitch. Your face, your personality, and your body too.”

“HAAAAAAH!?”

Completely ignoring the screaming Shinohara, Kushida tightened her grip on the dumbfounded Ibuki's arm and started marching her toward the goal area.

“Sorry, but I'll be crossing the goal together with you just like this, Ibuki-san.”

“W-wait, Kushida——” Katsuragi, unable to restrain himself any longer, called out.

But Kushida turned back to him with a smile.

“I can't wait,” Seeing that Katsuragi couldn’t keep himself from moving, Kushida answered with a smile. “After all, Katsuragi-kun, you look like you want to save Ibuki-san. If you gave her some clumsy sympathy, I might end up in danger again.”

Without waiting for his response, Kushida dragged Ibuki the rest of the way, reaching Yoshida, who was waiting just before the goal.

“We're going to cross the goal first, Yoshida-kun.”

“Eh… ah, y-yeah…”

Still unable to process Kushida’s words or the situation, Yoshida could barely form a coherent sentence.

“Are you... really sure about this?” Ibuki asked.

“It's fine, it's fine,” Kushida said, her expression strangely light. “Honestly, everything has just become so ridiculous to me now. I actually feel pretty refreshed.”

Stepping decisively into the goal area, Kushida raised her smartwatch and began operating it ostentatiously.

“Hey, Ibuki-san,” she said. “I have one last present for you, so just take it.”

“Huh?” Ibuki said, confused. “What do you mean, present?”

“Right up to the very end, Shinohara-san is an ugly bit— no, a cheapskate. Even though I explicitly told her to hand over my thirty-four tokens, she only sent me ten. Isn't she just disgusting to no end?”

“Wha...?”

It seemed Shinohara had decided to harass Kushida until the bitter end, while simultaneously taking out an insurance policy for herself. She had likely calculated exactly how many tokens she needed to hoard so that, even after sharing half of her stash with Ike, she would still barely manage to stay above Kushida in the final rankings.

“Even if I give you half of that, I won’t be expelled,” Kushida said. “So take it.”

“No,” Ibuki pointed out. “Even if I take half, it doesn’t change the fact that I’m getting expelled.”

“That's true. I need you to stay below me until the very end, Ibuki-san,” Kushida explained. “However, Ayanokōji-kun and the others planned to have everyone hold at least fifty-one tokens. What if there's a miscalculation somewhere? Besides, I don't want to hold onto Shinohara-san's disgusting tokens any more than I absolutely have to.”

“...That's just like you, Kushida.”

Ibuki clearly thought the gesture was meaningless.

Even so, she went along with it and placed her smartwatch against Kushida’s.

“W-wait a minute!” Shinohara snapped. “I’ve been listening for a while now, but what the hell is this!?”

Repeatedly being called ugly, Shinohara finally boiled over. Enraged, she charged at Kushida and grabbed her arm to stop her from leaving.

“Everyone heard that, right!? Kushida-san is a wicked woman!” Shinohara said, her voice rising in desperation. “Th-that’s why I was trying to manage the tokens properly for Class A!”

“I won't deny it, you know? It's completely true that my personality is awful,” Kushida replied, completely unfazed. “But hey, your boyfriend seems absolutely obsessed with this wicked woman. When I told him I'd do anything for him if he helped me out, he was drooling all over me. It was honestly disgusting. Why don't you try training your dog properly?”

Before long, a signal indicating the goal was confirmed flowed from Ibuki's, Kushida's, and then Shinohara's smartwatches.

Paying no mind to the confirmation sound, Shinohara whipped around and screamed.

“Kanji!?”

“Huh? N-no, wait, that’s not— I don’t know anything about that! She’s making it up!?”

Ike's eyes darted frantically around the group as he tried to string a coherent excuse together, but the words completely failed him. He wiped a thick bead of sweat from his forehead with a painfully awkward gesture. He had completely lost his composure. Even as he desperately tried to deny the accusation, his voice squeaked slightly, making his sheer panic glaringly obvious.

He turned and bolted after Shinohara, stammering out panicked excuses. Just as Ike's retreating back disappeared into the trees, the heavy vegetation rustled, and Kōenji gallantly strolled out from behind Katsuragi.

“My, my. It appears that troublesome affair has finally come to an end.”

Kōenji’s arrival was unexpected. He appeared just as Katsuragi was about to close in on me.

“You appeared from a rather strange place. Don't tell me you were watching us?” Katsuragi asked, whirling around.

Kōenji casually brushed his golden hair back and flashed a fearless smile. “I simply thought it would be poor manners to interrupt, so I waited.”

“You seem to be alone,” Katsuragi said. “Where are the rest of your group members?”

“I do prefer acting alone, you see,” Kōenji remarked. “I imagine it will still take them a little while to arrive.”

Answering breezily as he glided past Katsuragi, Kōenji moved to stand directly in front of Mii-chan.

“My apologies, but I'd like you to listen to me for a moment. Do you mind?” he asked, gently offering his arm as if escorting her to a ball.

“W-what is it?” Mii-chan stammered.

“This is hardly the proper place. Let us take a short walk, shall we?”

With that, he invited Mii-chan away just as she was about to reach the goal, leading her to a secluded spot slightly away from the rest of the group.

“What's his deal?” Sonoda muttered, tilting his head in complete bewilderment.

Once Kōenji had moved her to a position where they couldn't be overheard, he gently pushed Mii-chan’s back against the trunk of a large tree.



“Show me your smartwatch, if you please.” After shooting a brief, meaningful glance in my direction, Kōenji murmured so.

“Eh, umm? What do you mean?” Mii-chan asked hesitantly.

“The number of tokens you currently possess,” Kōenji replied. “I wish to know exactly how many there are. Though, I suppose it's a different story entirely if you have a reason you cannot show me.”

“No, um, yes... that is fine, but...”

Thoroughly bewildered and unable to comprehend the intent behind Kōenji's actions, Mii-chan nervously operated her smartwatch. She typed in her passcode, bringing up her token count on the display.

“Hmm. It seems you have accumulated a solid number of tokens.” Kōenji said, looking at the smartwatch. “However, it is always best to be absolutely certain. Once we factor in the multiplier, this total still leaves you in the danger zone.”

Then he operated his own smartwatch and made a movement to transfer tokens.

A moment later, a sharp chime rang out simultaneously from both of their devices.

“E-eeeh!? T-this many, eh!?” Mii-chan gasped, shocked.

“It is nothing you need to worry about,” Kōenji said smoothly. “Consider this an insurance policy from me. However, it would be quite problematic for me if you were to hand them over to anyone else, you see.”

With that, he pulled her by the arm and confidently strode straight into the goal area.

Flashing a brilliant, white-toothed smile at the utterly bewildered Wang, Kōenji brought her along, instantly finalizing both of their scores.

"What the heck was that just now?" Yoshida muttered, looking utterly unable to grasp what had just happened.

But there was still the matter of explaining things to Katsuragi—and deciding what to do from here on.

I decided to prioritize those first.

Epilogue: A Special Existence

❖

The Survival Game Special Exam had given way to the Token Collection Special Exam, and at last, the long ordeal of six nights and seven days had come to an end.

A little after eight that evening, after all of the third-year students were informed of the results, we were brought back aboard the ship and gathered almost immediately in the dining hall.

The only exceptions were the students who had been expelled.

They may have already been isolated somewhere, or perhaps sent away on a smaller vessel. Either way, among the students, there was likely no one who knew where they had been taken.

Dinner, delayed slightly by the day's proceedings, was about to begin.

The dining hall was lined with dishes so lavish they seemed almost unreal after our time on the uninhabited island. Platters crowded the tables, leaving barely any empty space between them, each one offering the kind of food we had gone without for the past week. Many of the students waited impatiently for the meal to begin.

But for the class that had produced a victim, even such splendor must have looked faint and colorless. Around them, there was no bright atmosphere.

"Sorry about that, Yoshida," I said. "I put a burden on you right at the very end, but you helped me out."

During this special exam, I had asked Yoshida to take on several important roles. Before anything else, I wanted to express my gratitude for that.

"Nah, it's fine…" Yoshida replied. "That one thing you said to me was too effective, so I couldn't exactly argue back."

He tipped his head back and looked up at the ceiling, letting out a long, heavy sigh.

"If someone says something like that to you, you can't deny it, can you? Well, it was definitely a lot to deal with, though."

Even as he smiled wryly, Yoshida slipped an arm around my shoulder and gave it a light pat.

"You two seem to have gotten pretty close," Hashimoto said from the seat in front of me. His eyes narrowed sharply as he studied my face. "How about letting me in on the story too, Ayanokōji?"

"What do you want to ask?"

"You know what I mean, don't you?" Hashimoto said. "The matter with Shiina— was that really the right way to handle it?"

At those words, Yoshida's expression turned faintly complicated. It was not difficult to read what he was thinking.

'This was neither the time nor the place to bring that up.'

"I don't think I made the wrong decision."

After answering that, I continued.

"Would you have preferred a different outcome, Hashimoto?"

"No…" Hashimoto answered, letting the word trail off for a moment. "I just wanted to ask, that's all. If you're satisfied with it, then I guess that's enough."

Concluding the topic prematurely like that, Hashimoto leaned back and crossed his arms behind his head. His gaze drifted away from me and toward Class A.

"Still," Yoshida said, following Hashimoto's line of sight, "don't you think it's hard to tell whether Class A won or lost?"

His expression turned serious as he gave his honest impression.

“A win is a win,” I replied. “They secured class points, after all.”

Group 8, the group Horikita and Ichinose had belonged to, had finished first at the goal. By making full use of their 100% multiplier, they had also taken first place in the group rankings, earning both Class A and Class D 100 class points each.

On top of that, Horikita’s class had claimed the individual special reward as well, bringing their total gain to 200 class points. It was enough to solidify their position as Class A, one which had been in jeopardy.

In the announced individual token rankings, Ryūen had placed second. The gap between him and first place had been only two tokens. If the order had shifted by even a single rank, the special reward would have gone to Class B instead. For them, that had to be a frustrating result.

Their only consolation was that they had also placed second in the group rankings, which allowed them to acquire 50 class points.

“But we can’t ignore the part where Shinohara was expelled, right? Ike’s mental state looked pretty messed up.”

“Shinohara getting expelled, huh?” Hashimoto said with a sly grin. “Just what the heck did you do, Ayanokōji?”

At those words, I looked around the hall.

Ike was nowhere to be seen. By now, he was probably lying down in the infirmary, trying to rest.

Before long, the buffet-style meal began. At the same time, the third-years were finally permitted to move freely.

Most students naturally gathered with their own classes, forming familiar clusters around the tables. But here and there, students who were close despite belonging to different classes crossed those boundaries, took nearby seats, and began talking animatedly, releasing all the conversations that had gone unspoken over the past several days.

"...Ayanokōji-kun, could you spare a moment?"

The one who approached me empty-handed was Horikita.

During our time on the uninhabited island, we had not spoken directly. Judging from the fact that she had come without taking any food, she probably wanted to organize what had happened during the special exam before beginning her meal.

Since we were allowed to go out onto the deck, we changed locations.

And then—

"Including the matter with Shinohara," I said to Horikita as she stood beside me, "let's align our understanding of the whole sequence of events this time."

With that, I began to explain.

Part 1

Every mechanism behind the plan had been set into motion before the night of the third day, long before I contacted Ichinose.

More specifically, it began on the morning of the second day, during a conversation with Katsuragi that lasted less than five minutes.

“Sorry for bothering you so early in the morning.”

Unable to reach an agreement with me, Katsuragi had given up and started to leave.

I had judged him to be one of the most suitable people to hear this plan.

As I watched his back recede, I decided to throw one idea at him.

“I think Ibuki should be expelled,” I said. “Of course, I don’t expect you to agree.”

Katsuragi stopped only slightly.

“Then why say it?”

“I phrased that poorly.” I corrected myself, “I’m going to get Ibuki expelled in this special exam.”

“...I see.” His voice lowered slightly. “So this is a declaration of war then.”

He probably had not intended to turn around. But once I had stated my intention that plainly, he could no longer ignore it. Katsuragi turned his gaze back toward me.

"Considering the way this school is structured, it may be the natural order of things for students who lack ability to be expelled. Perhaps even deliberately culling such students is not, in itself, evil." His expression did not change, but the weight in his voice deepened. "However, I cannot accept that way of thinking. When I was in conflict with Sakayanagi over the issue of class leadership, Yahiko sided with me. And because of arbitrary selection, he was eliminated. Of course, that happened because I lacked the power to stop it. But precisely because of that, I understand how it feels to be the one who is cut away. I have no intention of saying something naive like I will protect everyone. But I will never act from the beginning on the premise that I should sacrifice one of my comrades."

He had watched a friend who admired him be expelled, and he himself had been driven out of his class.

At the very least, Katsuragi's words carried a definite weight.

"Then can I take that to mean you're capable of fighting without mercy, as long as it's for the sake of protecting your comrades?"

"Of course," Katsuragi replied. "That is my intention."

"In that case, you and I may be able to cooperate."

"...What?"

"A representative can be entrusted with a large number of tokens," I said. "In other words, that representative holds considerable discretion over how those tokens are handled. I want you to use that authority to treat Ibuki as unfavorably as possible."

Katsuragi's eyes sharpened.

I continued. "Naturally, the number of tokens Ibuki can obtain will fall sharply."

"I don't understand what you're saying. I have no intention of getting Ibuki expelled—"

"Think about it objectively," I interrupted. "What happens if you act exactly as I told you?"

Katsuragi fell silent.

I continued, "Ibuki will visibly fall behind in the token competition. Once that happens, the students in Group 3 will begin to think the same thing. *'As long as I have more tokens than that student, I'm safe.'* After that, all you have to do is share Ibuki's token count anonymously and adjust the distribution as needed. If you do that, everyone will be able to remove themselves from the list of expulsion candidates."

"That is an absurd proposal," Katsuragi said. "Do you honestly believe I would take an action so completely disadvantageous to Class B?"

"I'm proposing it because it isn't disadvantageous."

The moment I said that, Katsuragi seemed to notice the truth buried beneath the surface of my suggestion.

His expression shifted slightly.

"...Don't tell me..." he murmured. "You mean she's a decoy?"

"Correct. We use Ibuki only as a target," I said, "someone the others can look at and believe that, as long as they stay ahead of her, they can avoid expulsion. The real targets are the students of Class A."

Katsuragi stared at me.

"Are you serious?" he asked.

"The ultimate goal for the students of this school is to graduate from Class A. If that is what matters most, then the first priority should be weakening the Class A currently standing at the top and knocking them down. If Kushida or Wang can be expelled, it would result in a significant loss of strength. If Ike or Shinohara is expelled, the damage may not stop at a simple couple's breakup. Depending on the situation, the choice of voluntary expulsion to follow their lover might arise, potentially allowing us to eliminate two people at once. For the three classes chasing Class A, they are ideal candidates for expulsion."

"But would it really go that easily?" he asked at last. "Even if I treated Ibuki unfavorably, people normally won't believe that I would cut off a classmate so readily. They'll suspect that I'm only being harsh temporarily, or that I intended to transfer tokens to her later. Naturally, before crossing the goal, they would try to confirm the exact number."

"I don't mind if they notice," I replied. "It's actually more convenient if they become suspicious."

Anticipating how things would develop from there, I explained to Katsuragi the plan I had devised, including the fact that the sound made during a transfer could be silenced.

Part 2

The ship had already pulled away from the uninhabited island and was now sailing across the dark sea.

Beyond the deck, the water stretched endlessly into the night, broken only by the low sound of the vessel cutting through the waves. The island that had held us for the past week was now somewhere behind us.

With the exam over, it was finally time to look back on the chain of events that had led to its conclusion.

By laying the groundwork, we had successfully conditioned the entire group to view Ibuki Mio as the obvious target.

Katsuragi's clinical neglect, executed under the pristine banner of absolute equality, steadily widened the token gap. Meanwhile, driven by a volatile mix of genuine panic and blind indignation, an oblivious Ibuki played her role to perfection.

Watching that raw desperation unfold right before their eyes, Shinohara and Ike had arrived at the exact same conclusion: *As long as we outpace her, our survival is guaranteed.*

What mattered was giving them a reliable benchmark. A number that seemed to guarantee they could avoid expulsion.

But the token count communicated to all the groups was not Ibuki's actual number. Ibuki was only the decoy. The number being used as the benchmark belonged to the real targets: Shinohara and Ike.

"I had a feeling Ibuki-san was earning more tokens than I expected." Horikita said. "There were also students whose actual holdings were lower than the token counts that had been communicated..."

Shinohara and Ike's individual earnings were near the bottom, but they had the pooled portion siphoned from Kushida's share. Even if they were to split it equally in half, it would still end up increasing their overall tokens on top of what they already had.

"You must have had trouble making the adjustments."

While acknowledging her hardships, I told Horikita about what had occurred in the final stages.

On the last day, as the end of the exam drew closer, Shinohara and the others began to imagine a certain possibility.

If it's Ayanokōji, he may already have done something.

Until they reached the goal and token transfers became impossible, they kept watch to prevent Katsuragi and the others from making contact with Ibuki. But even then, their suspicions did not disappear.

Was the number of tokens Ibuki held truly lower than theirs?

They wanted to confirm the true number somehow. The token count displayed on the smartwatch could not be faked. It was the only method that allowed them to see a number that was completely accurate.

That was why we could not transfer tokens to Ibuki until the very last moment.

For Shinohara and the others, they had a two-stage backup structure. Ibuki would be expelled first. And even if something unexpected happened, Kushida would be expelled in her stead.

Under those assumptions, all eyes remained on the Goal as it gradually approached.

Katsuragi and I had both anticipated that the timing required to save Ibuki would be extremely tight.

We had prepared several simulations. Which one unfolded would depend to some extent on how Shinohara and the others chose to act.

The primary plan for that scenario was to have Yoshida, whom we had positioned just before the goal, make contact with Ibuki and secretly transfer the tokens to her. If that proved impossible, we would find some reason to pick a quarrel with Ibuki, prevent her from reaching the goal, and buy time.

Among the possible options, we had also considered using Kushida as a backup plan.

Then, by chance, an incident occurred.

Ibuki insisted that she wanted to punch me.

That unexpected event created an opening. I had Sanada, who had already been given the necessary information in advance, approach Kushida and quickly explain the situation to her. Including the portion meant for Ibuki that we had received from Katsuragi, we transferred enough tokens to ensure she would survive.

“It seems you gave advice to Shinohara and her teammates,” I said, “fully prepared for a counterattack from me."

"Yes...” she said quietly. “I warned them that Ibuki-san being cornered was going exactly according to your plan. And that depending on the situation, the spearhead of that plan might turn towards Shinohara-san and the others――”

“You weren’t wrong to contact Shinohara,” I said. “After all, you saw through the possibility that my attempt to get Ibuki expelled was a bluff.”

“I did feel something was off,” Horikita began. “Even if you told Katsuragi-kun that you were going to have Ibuki-san expelled, I couldn’t imagine him accepting that unconditionally. And he wouldn’t proceed on his own while ignoring Ryūen-kun either. In that case, I thought you might have told them that the real plan was to expel a student from another class. And when I thought about it that way, the target would be our class. That’s why I strongly warned Shinohara-san and the others to keep paying attention to Ibuki-san’s token count, and if possible, to confirm the number for themselves——"

“In practice, I think Shinohara handled it well,” I said. “Forceful as her method may have been, she did manage to confirm the number itself.”

“But…”

Horikita’s voice faltered slightly.

“In the end, I couldn’t protect her. I didn’t want anyone to be expelled. That was what I thought, and yet…” She let out a faint breath. “Things don’t always go the way you hope, do they?”

“It couldn’t be helped. The fact that Ichinose ended up in the same group as you was significant. Being able to build a smooth cooperative structure, then unite everyone around the goal of placing high as a group, was a real strength. On top of that, because the group containing the leader could earn a large reward, those elements created a synergistic effect. However, this Special Exam had a dual nature where crossing the goal early was advantageous for winning, but if you considered what would happen in the event of a loss, crossing the goal late was more advantageous instead. Securing both of those advantages at the same time was never going to be easy.”

Since the goal could be recognized by a majority crossing, Horikita could have stayed behind with the phone instead of finishing with the others. Technically, that option had existed.

But there were limits to what one person could handle alone.

More than anything, she had probably also felt that she did not want to reduce their token count by even one.

"If I had personally guided Shinohara-san and the others to the goal," Horikita said, "the situation might have been different."

"That may be true," I replied. "But in the end, changing who was expelled would not have been simple. If you helped one person, someone else you couldn't see would be pushed down into last place next. From that situation, shifting into a system that could protect both Class A and Class D with absolute certainty was practically impossible."

"...You're right," Horikita said. "Saving Ike-kun and Shinohara-san would inevitably have created a distortion. And once that happened, we wouldn't know which class, or which person, would become the sacrifice instead..."

If there was one fatal point to name, it was probably that Horikita had been made to fight on a stage I had prepared.

By making events revolve around Group 3, physical distance became a heavy shackle, limiting what she could do from outside the center of the conflict.

"Couldn't you have targeted Kushida-san or Wang-san instead?" Horikita asked. "For our class, losing either of them would have meant losing a much greater asset. Why didn't you do that?"

"I simply chose to bring down the easiest target."

That was how I answered.

But the truth was different.

As far as Kushida was concerned, I had only made her look like an expulsion candidate. From the beginning, I had never intended to eliminate her. At the very least, she was incomparably more capable than Shinohara or Ike. Mii-chan, too, was a sufficient asset. On top of that, a new use for her had begun to emerge.

What mattered to me was to nurture Class A as well.

If a plant is allowed to send out too many side shoots, the stock may spread, but the fruit it bears will become smaller. That was precisely why Class A needed to choose, one by one, which stems should be allowed to grow.

“If you’re going to blame someone,” I said, “blame me, not yourself.”

Immediately after I said that, I sensed someone approaching from behind.

“I don’t think that’s quite right. You weren’t the one who decided who would be expelled, Ayanokōji-kun.”

Perhaps she had seen us step out onto the deck. Emerging from a dimly lit corner, Kushida came into view.

I had already noticed that she was eavesdropping, so her appearance did not surprise me.

“I could have taken the tokens Sanada-kun handed me, kept them for myself, and gone straight to the goal,” Kushida said. “If I had done that, Ibuki-san would have been the one to be expelled after all.”

Kushida spoke on her own accord about the backstage events, which I hadn't thought necessary to explain.

“You…” Horikita looked at her. “Did you decide to expel Shinohara-san?”

Kushida ignored the question.

Instead, she voiced what had apparently been on her mind.

“Whether or not I handed those tokens to Ibuki-san was a pretty dangerous gamble, wasn’t it? When I tried to head for the goal, Katsuragi-kun looked seriously panicked.”

“Maybe so.”

I answered as though I were going along with Kushida's interpretation.

But the actual truth was a little different.

I had already judged that it would be safe to entrust her with the crucial core of the plan: the tokens that would decide everything.

A judgment of life and death, placed in the hands of Kushida Kikyō.

All I had to do was make her want to eliminate Shinohara or Ike more than Ibuki.

From the moment this special exam began, I had planted a single seed.

The friction caused by the way I treated Shinohara and Ike. I ignored their greetings. I questioned their abilities. Little by little, resentment accumulated inside them.

At the same time, I valued Kushida highly and treated her carefully, as though she were an exceptional person worth relying on.

My behavior was blatant enough that even my current Class D classmates began to feel distrust. It went beyond the idea that I still had lingering attachment to Horikita's class. They could easily begin to suspect that I trusted the students of Horikita's class more than the classmates beside me now.

It was an unpleasant environment.

And in that environment, the anger that arose would naturally turn toward Kushida, the person Shinohara already resented.

Shinohara's hostility toward her became intense.

She wanted, somehow, to make Kushida suffer.

I had guided things so that such feelings would emerge.

Once that happened, it would also become easier to disturb the discipline of Class A and lead Kushida into isolation within the group.

Everything went according to plan.

An environment of my own making.

“Did you see Ike-kun’s face when the results were announced?” Kushida asked, smiling. “It was amazing, wasn’t it?”

During the result announcement that took place moments ago, the two of them received a shock as if they had been struck by lightning.



Which of them would be expelled was a part that even I didn't know.

“Personally, I would’ve preferred Shinohara-san to be the one who stayed,” Kushida said. “But I suppose that couldn’t be helped.”

Shinohara had apparently never intended to hand over the tokens she had promised Kushida. Early on, she had divided them cleanly and transferred them to Ike instead.

But that became a fatal mistake.

At the very end, left with no choice, Shinohara handed ten tokens to Kushida. Because of that, her own total fell below Ike’s.

Shinohara Satsuki, who fell to last place, was ordered to be expelled and fell into a panic.

Ike, in turn, lost himself. When he began to thrash about, Sudō and the others had struggled to restrain him.

Kushida smiled happily as she remembered the scene.

“I don’t think I did anything wrong,” she said. “If things had gone badly, Shinohara-san could have gotten me expelled. So all I did was pay her back.”

Perhaps that was all she had wanted to say.

Kushida looked satisfied as she lightly turned on her heel.

“And just so you don’t misunderstand, I’ll say this,” she added. “The only reason I let Ibuki-san stay was because I didn’t think she would become a threat. There's no other reason besides that.”

She walked away from the spot, as if to show that a reply was unnecessary.

Horikita may have felt her distrust of Kushida deepen.

My impression, however, was the complete opposite.

There was no doubt that Kushida had shed a layer through this incident. No, it would be more accurate to say she had undergone a major transformation. Once Horikita learned that Kushida had exposed her true nature in front of students from other classes, she would likely come to understand that as well.

"There are still many things I want to ask you," Horikita said. "I'm also curious about your own exam results…"

"Let's leave that for another time," I said. "If necessary, I can set aside time."

"…You're right." Horikita glanced back toward the dining hall. "I'll return to the venue. There are several problems I can't leave unattended."

Even if the class had won, the fact that they had lost a classmate as the price of that victory would not disappear.

They would have to discuss not only how to care for Ike, but also matters going forward.

If I returned with Horikita, I might get dragged into something troublesome. It would be better to go back a little later.

And so, left behind, I stood alone on the deck as the ship continued across the dark sea.

The special exam had been filled with twists and turns.

And yet, what returned to me most vividly was neither Shinohara, nor any of the others involved.

Only one person came to mind.

Shiina Hiyori.

Right now, my thoughts were occupied by her and her alone.

Part 3

After watching Ibuki, Shinohara, and the others reach the goal, I glanced once at my smartwatch.

I calculated backward from the time displayed there. There was no longer any margin to spare.

“Yoshida,” I said. “I’ll leave the rest to you.”

“What do you mean,” Yoshida asked, thrown off by the suddenness. “leave it to me?”

I briefly told him that I had received a message from Ryūen, and that Hiyori was waiting.

“W-wait, what!?” Yoshida’s voice cracked as understanding caught up with him. “If you do that, the tokens will—”

“I know,” I said. “At the very least, our chance at the special reward will disappear completely.”

If I crossed the goal here, there was a strong possibility I would take first place. Throwing that away was no different from dumping one hundred class points straight into the gutter.

“Even so, I'm going to get her.”

Yoshida stared at me, confusion mixing on his face. “Look, if we can help her, then yeah, of course I’d want to. But Shiina’s a Class B student, right? No matter how you look at it, leaving her there would be…”

“She’s special.”

“Huh…?”

“Shiina Hiyori is—— someone special to me.”

“Special? You mean…”

"If Shiraishi were waiting in the same situation," I asked, "could you abandon her?"

"That's..." Yoshida's words caught in his throat. "No, that's..."

At that single statement that required no further explanation, Yoshida clutched his head.

"Damn it... if you put it like that, I can't stop you..."

"That's why I said it."

"Jeez..." He let out a rough sigh, then gave in. "Fine. But can you make it in time? It's a pretty long distance."

"It won't be a problem."

"It won't be a problem, huh?" Yoshida muttered. Then his expression changed as another thought occurred to him. "Ah, wait. What about the tokens you need to give Shiina, and the 70% multiplier? Shiina was only given one token, right?"

"I don't know whether she has one or more than that," I said. "But either way, if she only has one, she won't be able to avoid expulsion. It would also be difficult for us to scrape together twenty million private points on short notice. Right now, the only thing I can do is transfer tokens to her as necessary."

"Worst case, you'll end up in last place..."

"That might happen."

Yoshida stared at me for a moment.

"Wait one minute— no, just thirty seconds."

As soon as he said that, Yoshida turned away and called out to Sanada and Morishita, bringing them over without delay.

"We've got more tokens than the benchmark," Yoshida said. "Take some from us."

Morishita narrowed her eyes. “Who exactly do you think you are, Ayanokōji Kiyotaka, demanding tokens without even telling us the reason?”

“We just need them, Morishita,” Yoshida said. “I’ll explain later.”

“Understood,” Sanada said without hesitation. “Please take them.”

He agreed immediately. Morishita, for her part, looked at Yoshida’s behavior and gave a resigned little mutter.

“I suppose it can’t be helped.”

Then she looked back at me.

“This will be a very large debt,” she said. “I expect repayment at least ten millionfold infinitely, if possible, okay?”

It was a mysterious unit of measurement, one so strange that even a child would probably hesitate to invent it.

Still, despite the absurdity of her words, Morishita extended her smartwatch toward me as well.

Part 4

It was nearly seven in the evening.

Soon, the special exam would come to an end, and somewhere beyond the shoreline, the ship would sound its booming whistle across the island.

The westering sun had begun its slow descent toward the horizon. Above it, the sky was shifting from a soft orange into a deeper crimson, each color bleeding quietly into the next. The sea reflected those colors like a vast mirror, only for the restless waves to break them apart into fragments of light that shifted endlessly with each rise and fall.

At uneven intervals, a salt-laden wind drifted in, sweeping over the stretch of sand that had yet to fully dry.

Amid that quiet scenery, one girl stood alone.

“Hiyori,” I called out softly, doing my best not to startle her.

Perhaps because the yielding sand had muffled my approach, she was a fraction of a second late in noticing my presence. Her shoulders gave the faintest reaction, but she did not turn around immediately.

“I never thought…” she said after a short pause, her voice quiet, “that you'd actually come.”

Her words overlapped gently with the breaking of a wave. The sea was calm, but from this close, each small wave could be heard clearly as it folded over itself and withdrew, repeating the same quiet sound over and over.

I stepped closer.

My feet sank slightly into the sand, the sound arriving a beat late beneath the hush of the shore, stopping just a pace behind her. Then, taking a few more steps forward, I moved to stand by her side. Roughly an arm's length remained between us, an ambiguous distance, not close enough to touch each other, but not far apart either.

“That's strange, then,” I pointed out. “Didn't you agree to go along with Ryūen's strategy because you predicted I'd show up?”

“I had no confidence at all,” Hiyori replied.

Her eyes remained on the horizon. She did not look down, nor did she look at me. She simply gazed toward the line where the sea and sky met, as if following it with her thoughts.

“In the first place,” she continued, “this cannot really be called a strategy. It was only the hopeless ending reached by Class B, after failing to find any certain way to win this special exam.”

As she spoke, her delicate fingertips moved, lightly gripping the hem of her jersey.

“As long as you're in Class B, naturally a fraction of the responsibility falls on you, Hiyori,” I said. “But that burden is meant to be shared by the class as a whole. Or rather, the greater responsibility lies with Ryūen, who serves as the leader. There was no reason for you to take it all upon yourself, was there?”

I turned to look at her profile for the first time.

The fading sunlight cast a soft glow along her features, tracing delicate shadows from her eyelashes across her cheeks. As the sea breeze tossed her hair, I caught fleeting glimpses of her expression.

She showed no sign of relief or joy that I had come to get her.

Instead, she merely stared out at the ocean, a profound sorrow etched into her gaze.



"...I just felt like I had to do something," she whispered. "I thought I needed to do the one thing that only I could do..."

The toe of her shoe shifted against the sand, breaking its surface just slightly.

It was a small gesture. Almost nothing. But it repeated without rhythm, as if her body had been moving that way for a long time before I arrived. That alone told me how long she had been standing here with those thoughts.

"The one thing only you could do, huh."

In that sense, I suppose you could still call this a viable strategy. If it had been anyone else waiting here, I never would have shown up.

A lone seabird cried somewhere in the distance, its voice thin against the evening air. It skimmed low over the water, gliding across the darkening surface before continuing along the crimson light.

"When Ryūen told me, my first instinct was to stay away," I said. "Or more accurately, I instinctively knew that coming here was the wrong move. Showing up is an undeniable net negative for my class. If my only goal was securing a victory for us, coming here holds zero merit. If I abandoned you, I could make Class B lose a valuable asset, and I could practically secure the special reward."

I did not know exactly how the group totals would settle, but my decision to be here would undoubtedly impact the overall rankings.

"Then..." Hiyori asked softly, "why did you come...?"

For the first time, her gaze shifted slightly.

She still did not look directly at me. Instead, her eyes lowered to some uncertain point between the sand at her feet and the sea beyond it.

“Maybe I wanted to surrender myself to something absurd and irrational,” I said. “I was interested in what kind of emotion I would feel after making a mistake—— a choice I would never normally make.”

It was not a lie.

It was the first answer that surfaced in my mind, and I gave it to her as it was.

But as soon as I put it into words, another answer rose up in contradiction.

I was forced to recognize that what I had just said was only a pretext

It was not the truth.

“No, that's not it,” I corrected softly. “The outcome didn’t matter to me. I simply didn't want you to be expelled. I didn’t want to see a future where Ryūen wouldn't save you— a future where you couldn't be saved. I want to share this school life with you for even a single second longer. That's the real reason I came.”

Hiyori remained still beside me.

“I'm not a particularly interesting person,” she replied. “Is there any value in saying such things to someone like me? You have plenty of other friends, Ayanokōji-kun.”

After answering like that, Hiyori continued without turning her eyes from the sea.

“I thought waiting here was cowardly. And then I felt that even thinking of it as cowardly was unfair.”

“Unfair?”

“Because…” Her voice was soft, almost swallowed by the waves. “Isn’t that how it is? To make myself a bait… to actually believe I held enough value to *be* one… What a terrible conceit. After all, there was no logical reason for you to throw away your chances of winning just to come for me.”

Slowly, quietly, Hiyori laid her swirling emotions bare.

As if mirroring her fragile words, her grip on the hem of her jersey loosened, her delicate fingertips slipping away. Then, as the fabric fluttered in the sea breeze, she reached out and gently grasped it once more.

“That’s not fair…” she continued. “Even knowing all that, I couldn't help but harbor a faint sliver of hope. Wondering if you would come see me. Wondering if you would actually… come to save me.”

Two entirely contradictory emotions were violently clashing inside her heart.

“And because you actually came… It made me so happy… but I couldn't bring myself to say it…”

Each time her words trailed off, the soft crashing of the waves filled the silence. Only that rhythmic sound quietly marked the passage of time.

“What…” she whispered, “…should I do?”

I did not know whether I could give her the correct answer.

But there was one thing I could say.

“Right now, I’m fully aware of it,” I told her. “That I am in love with a single person named Shiina Hiyori.”

These were the words that should be spoken.

The words that *had* to be spoken.

Yet, the moment they left my lips, I felt a sudden, faint dryness in my throat.

It wasn't simply a physical thirst from expending the stamina to rush all the way out here. It was the sheer weight of putting those feelings into words. It was the terrifying reality that the answer I'd receive wasn't a hundred percent guaranteed.

Right now, for the first time in my life, I was completely at the mercy of an emotion I had never experienced before.

Hiyori finally turned her face toward me. The sea breeze lifted her flowing hair for a brief instant, and as it settled, her wide eyes locked directly onto mine. A heartbeat later, we were standing there, completely facing one another.

“I'm sorry—” she apologized.

“I'm truly sorry—” she apologized once more.

“I—— I love you too... Ayanokōji-kun. ...I'm so sorry——”

It was an apology for taking advantage of my feelings for her. Having finally spoken the words, she didn't look away. Her tearful gaze remained locked on mine as her chest rose and fell in shallow breaths, trying desperately to steady herself.


Shiina Hiyori

No further words were necessary.

I tapped the screen of my smartwatch, transferring the tokens I had brought with me over to Hiyori. Then, I reached out and took her left hand in my right. Together, we turned to gaze out at the sea.

The instant our skin touched, her fingers squeezed mine with a sudden, desperate strength. She relaxed her grip almost immediately, but the sensation of that fleeting, powerful squeeze lingered unmistakably in my palm.

The ship's booming whistle echoed across the water.

That wasn't a sound signifying the end, but a beginning.

Was I allowed to believe that?

Would I come to know love as an ordinary high school student, and continue to grow from there?

Will I be able to change?

From the pitch-black, murky depths of unseen waters, *something* reared its head.

When I had learned everything there was to learn about this new emotion, perhaps I would let go of the hand I now held without hesitation.

I simply desire it.

Knowledge.

Experience.

Memories.

I wanted to take all of it into myself, to turn it into my own flesh and blood.

Everything is for my own sake.

Every action I take is for me, and me alone.

That is how it has always been, and how it will always be——

That, surely, would never change until the day I die.

> **Translator's Note:** In the sentence - 'From the pitch-black, murky depths of unseen waters, *something* reared its head.' We italicized 'something' because the original uses katakana for 「ナニか」 rather than the standard 「何か」, giving the word an unnatural, ominous emphasis. We've placed this note at the end of the scene so it doesn't interrupt the reading flow.

Part 5

It was 7:30 PM, and the special exam had finally concluded. With the results scheduled to be announced outdoors, we had disembarked from the cruise ship and were waiting on the uninhabited island. We had been given free rein to wait wherever we pleased.

Soon, the small boat dispatched to pick up the students who hadn't reached the goal would return to the dock.

My chest tight with a restless, gnawing anxiety, as I waited for him to step off that boat.

Concealing myself within the nearby treeline, I kept a close watch on the pier.

I should have just walked up and greeted him openly. But I couldn't.

Not after overhearing the unbelievable words Yoshida-kun had said to Hashimoto-kun earlier.

“That guy went to save Shiina, prepared to throw away his own victory. I couldn't stop him.”

Those words clung to the back of my mind, refusing to disappear. They just kept echoing, over and over.

Why?

For what reason?

Just to save Shiina-san?

Why would he do something like that?

I couldn't understand it.

No... maybe I just didn't want to.

I knew, of course, that Ayanokōji-kun and Shiina-san were book buddies. I knew they often met up in the library.

But that fact had never weighed too heavily on my mind.

They were just friends.

I had always assumed they were nothing more and nothing less.

But now, everything felt different.

As the leader of a class that demanded results as early as possible, leaving behind significant results in this Special Exam too should have been one of Ayanokōji-kun's goals.

And yet... he threw all of that away just to save Shiina-san.

It was easy to write it off as simply helping a friend.

Even I would have rushed to help without hesitation if one of my own classmates had been in trouble.

But Ayanokōji-kun isn't like me.

The reason I could think of...

The only reason I could think of is...

...Because she's an exceptional student.

Ayanokōji-kun wants all four classes to compete on equal footing.

That's why Shiina-san is necessary——

I get it, that must be it.

No.

That wasn't it at all.

It meant Shiina-san wasn't just a simple friend to him.

I didn't want to believe it.

But the sight that suddenly leaped into my vision presented a cruel reality.

Ayanokōji-kun was the first to step down from the unsteady footing onto solid ground. Then he turned back and took Shiina-san's hand, gently escorting her off the boat.

Her expression held a faint trace of guilt, but beneath it, she looked undeniably, radiantly happy.

I thought it was Karuizawa-san.

I believed that if I just pushed her out of the picture, I would be the one standing by Ayanokōji-kun's side.

But I was wrong.

The one I truly... had to push aside... was...

It was you, wasn't it...

"Shiina... Hiyori-san."

The name slipped from my lips in a faint mutter.

Heavily.

Darkly.

Deeply.

Like a blade gouging a fresh scar into my heart, I etched her name.

I knew then... there was no way I would be able to control this emotion——



Ichinose SS: Linked Thoughts

❖

Once the groups were announced, I made my way toward Group 8, a faint flicker of hope resting in my chest.

If I happened to be placed in the same group as Ayanokōji-kun...

Then, in this third uninhabited island exam, I would be able to spend three days together with him.

But that hope was quickly dashed. Almost immediately, I caught sight of him heading off toward an entirely different group.

"...It can't be helped, I suppose."

This wasn't something I could control, no matter how much I wished for it. I had to switch gears immediately.

A short while later, I spotted one of the students assigned to my group.

Approaching carefully so as not to startle her, I called out.

"I look forward to working with you, Horikita-san."

She turned to look at me, her lips pressing into a thin line for a brief moment before she met my eyes.

"I knew there was a decent chance that class leaders might end up in the same group, but to think I'd be paired with you of all people, Ichinose-san."

Did she view me as an easy partner to handle, rather than a troublesome opponent?

No, honestly, it works in my favor if she thinks of me that way.

“If this were a purely class-based competition, it might have been a bit troublesome,” I said. “But looking at the rules, cooperating as a group clearly leads to mutual benefit, so it's a rather good setup. If you and I pool our strengths, Horikita-san, we might just be able to guide our group to a safe and steady victory.”

From there, we discussed the importance of working hand in hand as allies rather than fighting as enemies, gradually finding common ground. And naturally, during that process, we arrived at a topic we couldn't avoid—

“It seems reaching a mutual understanding and aiming for first place will go smoother than expected,” Horikita-san noted. “However, there is one critical issue that both you and I must treat with the utmost importance.”

“How to handle the expulsions... right?”

As she nodded, I made it absolutely clear that I would not allow a single expulsion from my class. By drawing that line, I knew she would naturally adopt the exact same stance for her own. But that was exactly why my thoughts were already racing a step ahead. Assuming Class A and Class D joined hands to solidify our defenses, how would Ayanokōji-kun make his move? Once he fully analyzed the rules of this special exam, what kind of strategy would he employ?

I knew, deep down, that deciphering his plan would be the most critical factor in protecting my classmates.

Who would be assigned to Ayanokōji-kun's group?

That detail would undoubtedly be the most important. For him, keeping any potential expulsions strictly within his own reach would be the most reliable, controllable method. If that was the case, then all I had to do was link up my thinking with his, matching his pace as I fought through this exam.

Ayanokōji-kun understands me. And I understand Ayanokōji-kun.

That is everything.

Kushida SS: Suspicious, But...

❖

In order to secure myself a safe, reliable position in Group 3, I wasted no time making my move.

My goal was simple: mingle with the girls from the other classes the way I always did, and quietly deepen those relationships without making a scene.

Dinner on the first day of the special exam was supposed to be the perfect opportunity for that.

But my plan fell apart almost immediately with the arrival of a certain boy.

“Would you like to eat together?”

The person calling out to me was— well, I won't go so far as to say *lo and behold*, but it was none other than Ayanokōji-kun.

A lone guy suddenly diving headfirst into a flock of teenage girls.

Even if there was no hidden message behind it at all. For me, it was still nothing short of a nuisance. Especially with students from Class D around.

The information had already made its way to me, too. Reliable information that Ichinose Honami, the leader of Class D, harboured romantic feelings for Ayanokōji-kun. I had no desire for Amikura, someone close to Ichinose, to start spreading unnecessary speculation because of something she saw here.

Even so, now that he had spoken to me, the good-girl version of me had no choice but to handle it smoothly.

I accepted his invitation with a pleasant smile, and eventually led the conversation away from the other students.

“What are you trying to pull, Ayanokōji-kun?”

I wanted to know why he had approached me so suddenly, so I got straight to the point.

“Didn't you say you wanted to discuss our plans for tomorrow?”

His words were always like that— a mixture of truth and lies, stirred together so smoothly that I could never tell which was which. I couldn’t trust them.

At this point, I wouldn’t even be surprised if he were acting with the intent of ruining all the effort I’d put in.

“I never said that. Besides, it's not like you actually need my help, right? Honestly, you're just being a massive pain.”

“Is that so? I figured that giving you a chance to prove your worth to the group would satisfy your need for approval. I thought you'd be happy.” he replied, his face remaining entirely unreadable and devoid of emotion, as usual.

It was genuinely infuriating. It really pissed me off.

And yet, for some inexplicable reason, I couldn’t bring myself to hate him completely.

This was the exact same person whom I had wanted to murder during the Unanimous Special Exam.

“Don't make me laugh. If it were just you, Ayanokōji-kun, that’d be one thing, but do you have any idea how agonizing it is to be put on a pedestal in front of Shinohara and the others when they already know my true nature? They're just messing with me for their own amusement.”

After watching his attitude this far, I arrived at one answer.

“Though, I suppose I understand that you can't exactly rely on Shinohara or Ike…”

I murmured with a heavy sigh and an air of annoyance, reasoning to myself that being selected through a simple process of elimination was somewhat unavoidable.

“Putting that aside, it looks like you're adjusting quite nicely to your new class.”

“With Sakayanagi gone, they lost their safety net. They probably would’ve rallied around anyone in that position, wouldn’t they?”

“You don't say.”

“If there's something you want to ask, go ahead.”

“It's nothing in particular,”

That was what I thought.

But the moment I said it, one thing that had been bothering me floated up in my mind.

“It's just... the rumors about you right now are endless. I don't believe all of them, obviously, but I've been hearing plenty of things from Class D as well.”

That Ichinose Honami was in love with Ayanokōji.

That something may have happened between them, some event that brought the two of them closer.

Ridiculous.

That was what I told myself.

And yet, ever since I learned about it, an irritation I couldn’t explain had been stirring inside me.

Saying it aloud wouldn't change anything. If anything, it would only make the weight of it feel heavier.

“Anyway—”

Thinking about that any further was unpleasant, so I decided to change the subject.

“Having my true nature exposed has been almost entirely a nightmare... but having moments like this where I can just drop the act and speak my mind might be the only salvation."

And using that as an excuse to escape, I started walking.

“Sorry, but I'm heading back. I really don't want to draw any more unnecessary heat from Shinohara and the others.”

“Your double life sounds exhausting.”

Easy for him to say.

He was an outsider to it, so I didn’t want him tossing those words out so lightly.

“It's a little late for that.”

For my own sake, I have continued to wear this mask.

But lately, I’ve found myself wondering.

How long am I supposed to keep doing this?

Until my student life ends?

Even after I enter the society and become an adult?

Even after I get married?

Even after I grow old?

How long——

Just how long will I have to keep wearing this mask——

Ichika & Nanase SS: Nanase's Love Life

❖

By the time their conversation had run its course, there were still about thirty minutes left before their private pool reservation ended.

Nanase, however, seemed ready to leave first.

Just as she began to excuse herself, Amasawa called out to her.

“We rarely get the chance to talk alone like this,” she said. “Mind if I ask you a little question?”

Nanase stopped.

“What is it?”

She did not believe for a moment that Amasawa would so easily become an ally. Her expression barely changed, but for the briefest instant, she braced herself.

“Nanase-chan, have you ever had a boy confess to you? Or dated anyone?”

A pair of wide eyes and a devilish smirk stared right back at Nanase.

“...Excuse me?”

There were any number of subjects Amasawa could have brought up.

Ayanokōji. Ishigami. The White Room.

Nanase had expected something along those lines. Instead, the question that came flying at her belonged to an entirely different world, so unexpected that she failed to respond at once.

“Well?” Amasawa asked, still smiling. “Have you?”

“I have never dated a man before,” Nanase answered stiffly.

“Wow. So you're a completely pure girl, then.”

“We are second-year high school students,” Nanase replied. “I would imagine those with romantic experience are in the minority.”

“Not at all. I'm no expert, but word is it's around fifty percent. That means one in two people have already experienced it. And if you're cute or pretty, wouldn't the odds be even higher?”

“Around fifty percent...?” Nanse repeated. “Is that true?”

It was not a subject she had ever seriously considered, and because of that, the number itself felt strangely unreal.

“I was in the White Room the whole time,” Amasawa said lightly. “And ever since coming to this school, I’ve only had eyes for Ayanokōji-senpai, so I don’t have any romance stories of my own. But you’re different, aren’t you, Nanase-chan?”

It was the exact sort of idle gossip normal high school girls would share. Yet, beneath the surface, Nanase sensed a faint, lingering incongruity.

“I see,” she said. “As a way of probing into my past, it is a rather good question.”

If Nanase hadn't grown up in a typical family environment, her lack of romantic experience wouldn't be strange at all.

“Ah, you're reading way too much into it,” Amasawa said. “It was just an innocent question, that's all.”

“Well... either way, my answer remains the same.”

“Then do you at least have a crush on anyone?” Amasawa asked. “Don't tell me it's Ayanokōji-senpai.”

A certain someone flashed across her mind for a fleeting moment. But right now, she couldn't even recall his smile.

“There is no one I like,” Nanase replied. “Now, if you'll excuse me.”

Almost as if she were fleeing, Nanase turned and hurried out of the private pool area.

“You've got a much cuter side to you than I thought.”

Nanase had shown only the slightest hint of agitation.

But for Amasawa, that was enough to feel a small flicker of joy.

Kōenji & Mii chan SS: Invisible Thread

❖

Before breaking away from his group, Kōenji had already checked Wang Mei-Yu's location through GPS and moved ahead of her, positioning himself near the goal before she could arrive.

For a good while after, he simply leaned his back against the trunk of a massive tree, resting at his leisure until the echoing chatter of the Group 3 students drifted up to his ears.

Ever since this latest special exam had commenced, a single, specific detail had occupied a corner of Kōenji's mind: the fact that Ayanokōji Kiyotaka and Wang Mei-Yu had been assigned to the exact same group.

Given the cutthroat parameters of this trial, a scenario engineered to force the expulsion of at least one individual, it was only logical that Ayanokōji would select a sacrificial lamb from within his immediate sphere of influence. In other words, from the ranks of Group 3.

Under such conditions, the possibility that one of the Class A students would be chosen could not be dismissed.

No— rather than a possibility, within Kōenji's mind, it was but an absolute, hundred-percent certainty. The only remaining riddle was which of the four individuals would be the one to face the axe.

As he stood in the shadows, listening with nonchalance to the tense friction heating up between Ibuki, Kushida, and Shinohara, Kōenji's grasp of the situation crystallized.

Assessing the chess board, he deduced that the probability of Wang being targeted was remarkably low. By all conventional logic, the safest, most trouble-free course of action would be to slip away undetected into the foliage.

But, this was Kōenji we were talking about.

Guided by an almost predatory instinct, he sensed that this precise moment called for an intentional, grand entrance.

Think of it as a silent, unspoken ultimatum.

If this little incident served as a catalyst for some anonymous player to start spinning malicious schemes, Kōenji would simply deliver a swift and appropriate retribution when the time came. After all, her existence could never truly be twisted into a vulnerability against him.

At the end of the day, everything he did was entirely for his own benefit.

“My, my. It appears that troublesome affair has finally come to an end.”

The moment the uproar simmered down to a quiet hum, Kōenji allowed his suppressed presence to bleed openly into the clearing, stepping forward to materialize directly before the startled members of Group 3.

“You appeared from a rather strange place. Don't tell me you were watching us?” Katsuragi asked, whirling around.

Kōenji casually brushed his golden hair back and flashed a fearless smile. “I simply thought it would be rude to interrupt, so I waited.”

In stark contrast to the suspicious Katsuragi, Ayanokōji's expression remained completely unchanged.

He merely stared at Koenji with cool, dispassionate eyes.

“You seem to be alone,” Katsuragi said. “Where are the rest of your group members?”

“I do prefer acting alone, you see,” Kōenji remarked. “I imagine it will still take them a little while to arrive.”

Concluding that lingering any further with the crowd was a waste of his valuable time, Kōenji marched forward, narrowing his focus entirely on the girl who was the sole purpose of his detour.

“My apologies, but I'd like you to listen to me for a moment. Do you mind?” he asked.

Without hesitation, he boldly took hold of Wang Mei-Yu's arm, guiding her a comfortable distance away.

“W-what is it?” Wang stammered.

“This is hardly the proper place. Let us take a short walk, shall we?”

He spoke with an airy indifference, completely unbothered by the fact that the nearby students could easily catch every word.

“Show me your smartwatch, if you please.” After shooting a brief, meaningful glance in Ayanokoji’s direction, Kōenji murmured so.

“Eh, umm? What do you mean?” Wang asked hesitantly.

“The number of tokens you currently possess,” Kōenji replied. “I wish to know exactly how many there are. Though, I suppose it's a different story entirely if you have a reason you cannot show me.”

“No, um, yes... that is fine, but...”

Thoroughly thrown off balance by his overwhelming rhythm, she complied nonetheless, twisting her wrist to display the glowing interface of her digital display.

“Hmm. It seems you have accumulated a solid number of tokens.” Kōenji said, looking at the smartwatch. “However, it is always best to be absolutely certain. Once we factor in the multiplier, this total still leaves you in the danger zone.”

Kōenji operated his own smartwatch and transferred 30 of the tokens he had earned to her, quickly taking care of what needed to be done.

“E-eeeh!? T-this many, eh!?” Wang gasped, shocked.

“It is nothing you need to worry about. Consider this an insurance policy from me. However, it would be quite problematic for me if you were to hand them over to anyone else, you see.”

Saying so, Koenji casually walked alongside her, crossing the goal to officially log their arrival.

“Umm... w-why did you give those tokens to me?” Wang finally asked. “And so many of them at that...”

“Despite appearances, I'm a man who values the debts he owes. The thread remains connected, you see.”

“A d-debt? ...Thread?” Koenji flashed a broad smirk at Wang, who tilted her head in utter confusion.

Afterword

❖

It has been half a year. This is Kinugasa.

I have continued writing while taking care of my health, and thankfully I am on the road to recovery. I'm finally able to set aside a solid amount of time for work again.

Now then, let me talk a little about the main story.

In the previous two school-year arcs, Volume 4 marked the end of the first semester, and Volume 5 took us into the next stage. That had become something of a tradition. This time, however, in the Third-Year Arc, Volume 5 will begin while everyone is still aboard the ship on the return journey. I expect the story will involve the first- and second-year students as well. The next volume is currently planned for an October release. I'll do my best!

As a bit of behind-the-scenes trivia, deciding which characters would grace the cover of each volume was actually a source of constant agony for me until about midway through the Year 2 arc. Sometimes, the slate would remain completely blank until the absolute last minute. But for this Year 3 arc, the cover characters have actually been mapped out far in advance.

A few volumes from now, some rather unexpected characters are scheduled to appear on the covers. When that moment comes and you find yourself thinking, "Oh?", please remember what I mentioned here.

Also, the anime is currently airing, so please be sure to check it out. Watching it has become a massive driving force for my own writing, and I eagerly look forward to the new episode every single week.

Moving on, I have a rather rare announcement to make today, one completely unrelated to Classroom of the Elite.

A brand-new work of mine is set to be released this September!

Once again, I'll be teaming up with Tomose-san. I treated him properly at an izakaya the other day, so I'm sure he'll put in the effort and give us some wonderful illustrations for this project as well.

Now, to those of you reading this and thinking, "Wait a second, didn't you just say you were in poor health?"

Well, you would be correct. The truth is, I've been quietly chipping away at this new project, little by little, for a very long time. Had things gone according to plan, we would have announced and published it ages ago. Unfortunately, my ongoing health issues dragged the process down, which is why it has taken this long to finally see the light of day.

(If you read carefully through my past afterwords, you might even spot a few hints I dropped along the way!)

This new series is a project that holds a very deep, almost fated personal significance for me. I'm hoping to delve into the circumstances surrounding that history at another time, in another place.

I humbly ask for your continued support.

Well then, let's meet again before the year is over. In the meantime, everyone, please take good care of your health!



Welcome to the Classroom of the Elite: Ichinose Honami Character Book

Set to release on the 25th of September 2026!

Introducing the character book of the most popular student in school, a class leader renowned for her social skills, non-discriminatory attitude towards anyone, and her kindness that extends to everyone— Ichinose Honami.
Full of exclusive content and illustrations, in this book you can take a closer look at the charms of Ichinose Honami!
The cover is a brand new illustration drawn by Tomoseshunsaku!
Also included are behind-the-scenes peeks at the cover's making!
Also includes an all-new original short story written by Shōgo Kinugasa!

This information is current as of May 2026.



Welcome to the Classroom of the Elite 2nd Year finale, 3rd Year start BOX - Tomoseshunsaku Art Works

Set to release on the 23rd of October 2026!

This artbook comes with a bonus novel containing store-exclusive bonuses from the Second-Year Arc, short stories published in magazines that were not included in the light novel volumes, as well as a brand-new original short story written specifically for this artbook.
This volume also includes illustrations from the original novels' Second-Year third semester arc and the Third-Year volumes, illustrations created for Seasons 2 and 3 of the TV anime, and more.
The pin-up is an original by Tomoseshunsaku.
Also included is an interview with Shōgo Kinugasa and Tomose Shunsaku, where the two discuss the Third-Year Arc and their new work!?

Details about the highly anticipated new work by Shōgo Kinugasa and Tomoseshunsaku can be found on the next page!

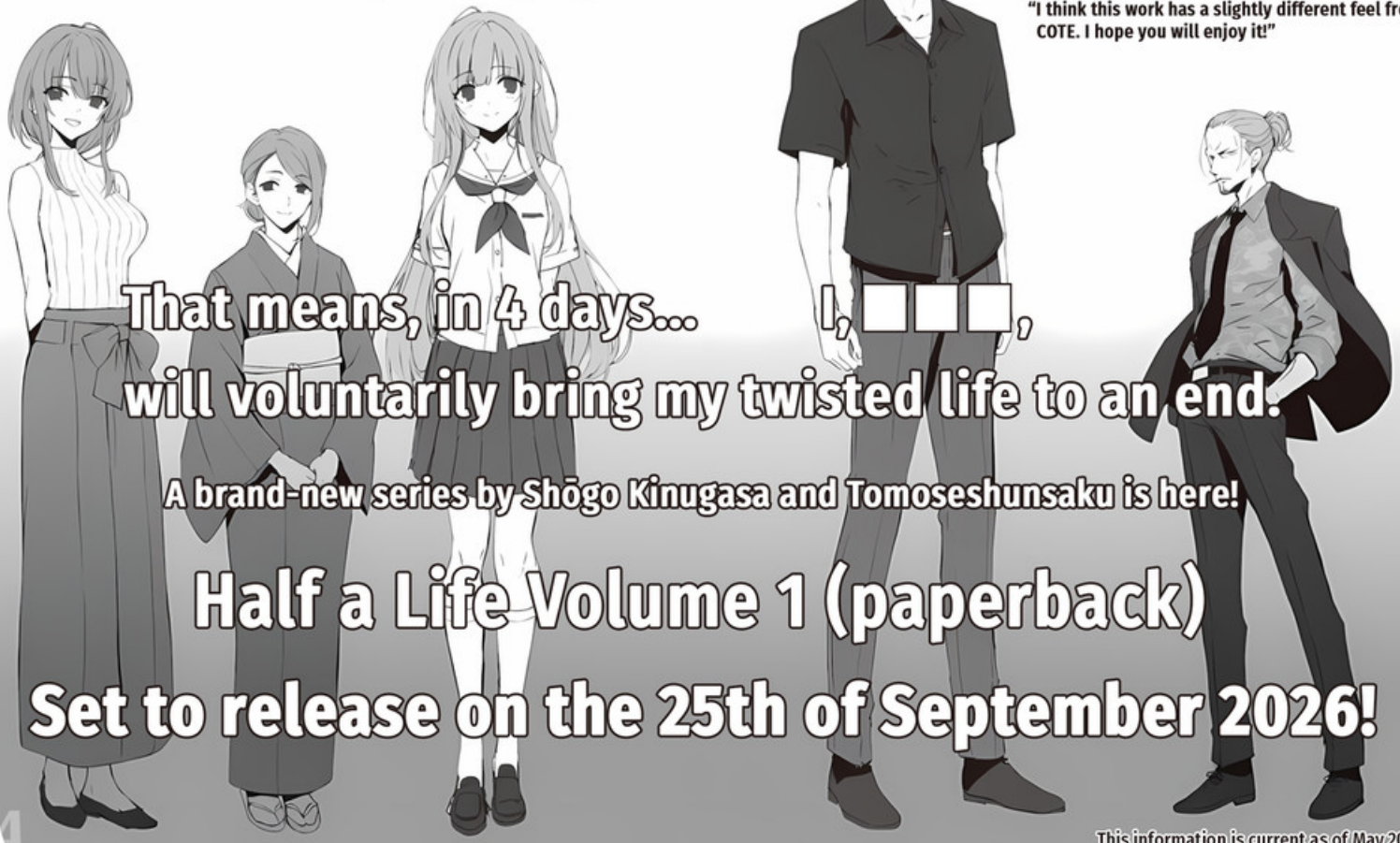
Set in the image of the long standing, historic Hisago hotspring inn,
begins the bizarre tale of a protagonist who wishes for “death”—
Further information about the new work will be released in August.
For updates, check the Youjitsu X, and the official 3rd year website.
An official interview is also scheduled to be published on Mequrimequru !

A comment from Shōgo Kinugasa on his new work

“At last I can share a story with the world I have been cultivating for a very long time.”

A comment from Tomoseshunsaku on the new work

“I think this work has a slightly different feel from COTE. I hope you will enjoy it!”



That means, in 4 days... I, ■■■,
will voluntarily bring my twisted life to an end.

A brand-new series by Shōgo Kinugasa and Tomoseshunsaku is here!

Half a Life Volume 1 (paperback)

Set to release on the 25th of September 2026!

This information is current as of May 2026.

Translation Team's Afterword

From the Translation Team

❖

First and foremost, thank you for taking the time to read our translation. We truly appreciate all of the support and encouragement we have received from the community. It is thanks to your continued support that we are able to keep bringing more Classroom of the Elite content to fans around the world.

With that said, we have a few important announcements we'd like to share with everyone.

First, as many of you may already know, Kinugasa Shōgo and Tomose Shunsaku's brand-new series, **Nibun no Inochi (Half a Life)**, is scheduled for release this September. We are happy to announce that our team plans to pick up the series upon release and provide English translations for it.

Second, as shown in the previous pages, the **Ichinose Honami Character Book** is also set to release in September. We have already reserved our copy and plan to translate any relevant material included in it, such as the newly written short stories and other exclusive content.

Additionally, we are planning to obtain the upcoming **Tomose Shunsaku Art Works / Third-Year Start BOX** as well and translate any relevant materials and exclusive content it contains.

Once again, thanks for your support. Whether you've read our releases, shared them with others, or supported us through our website, every bit of support means a lot and helps us keep going.

You can also join our Discord server to chat about Classroom of the Elite with other fans, share your thoughts, and stay up to date with our latest announcements and releases.

And of course, our journey with Classroom of the Elite continues with Year 3 Volume 5.

Thanks again for all your support. We hope you'll continue following along with us, and we'll see you again when the next volume arrives.

❖

— ANIME ANYWAY Translations —

Our Website animeanyway.com/

Our Discord discord.gg/YNYtBEKJke

Our Subreddit reddit.com/r/AnimeAnyway/

Our Telegram t.me/animeanyway

Credits

Akiso

Lead

Behold! The disciple Kiyotaka has officially graduated from the prestigious Morishita School of Elite Rage Baiting. After months of rigorous training under the great Grandmaster, Her Supreme Majesty Morishita Ai herself, he has finally awakened the forbidden techniques of rage baiting.
Report: The student has surpassed all expectations.

Saku

Editor

I wish Kushida uses her trump card on me.

RI || Great Love

Translator

Yo! RI here!
As always thank you for your audience and support. This volume was truly exciting. I hope you have also enjoyed it just as I did.
See you in the next volume!
For now またね~

NotInvented

Dev

Thank you for reading!

HeliosDrago

Illustration CL/RD

I got it but what cost.. ┻━━┻ (ノ ゜□゜)ノ ⌒ ┻━━┻

Eduardo

Dev

banger volume, did NOT get the ending.

The Real Eduardo

Definitely not akiso

Loved the Ending!

NanotechPikachu

Proofreader

Pretty interesting volume indeed. Though I would have preferred to be Ike if Kushida would do anything for me. Damn.... I can't....
Also, I completed my first year in college! Yaay! I wanna go back to the hostel soon. Life at home is boring....

Meow?

MeiharaFuyu

Translator

I hope you enjoyed this volume as much as ~~they~~ we enjoyed translating it. It was a great special exam with many twists and turns ~~I assume~~. Anyway, here's hoping I'll have more time to contribute to the next volume.

Tommytoothy

Proofreader

Morishita + Lighter = GOAT

Rush

Proofreader

Fire volume. Excited to see what's next!

LVL0

Proofreader

Kiyotaka doesn't fight battles. He arranges the conditions where his opponents arrive at his conclusions on their own.

Ocelot

Proofreader

Arguably the best Year 3 volume so far. Playing a small part in this hardworking team was fulfilling. October can't come quickly enough!!

Infinity

Proofreader

WOW, the volume was sooo good, plus it's one of biggest ones yet, it was extremely fun reading it, hope you guys also have a lot of fun too. Have a gr8 day. Infinity out.

Tr577

Translator

Looking forward to the next one!